ALIENMON

The Kessler Signal

Book One of the Alienmon Chronicles

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Alienmon: The Kessler Signal

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Prologue

The Starfall

Twenty years before this story begins, on a still and moonless night, the sky over the desert world of Dustara caught fire.

It started as one light, low on the horizon, the color of a candle. Then there were ten. Then a hundred. Then the whole sky was raining stars, long glowing streaks of gold and violet and green, falling so slowly they seemed to float. The people of the canyon town of Dustmere came out of their sandstone houses in their nightclothes and stood in the street with their mouths open. Nobody spoke. Nobody could.

The stars did not burn up. They landed. They fell softly into the canyons, into the oceans, into the forests and junkyards and frozen plains of all fourteen worlds of the Kessler system. And when the sun came up, the people found that the stars were not stars at all.

They were seeds. Huge, warm, glowing seedpods, cracked open like eggs. And curled inside each one, blinking at the morning light, was a creature no one had ever seen before.

They came to be called Alienmon.

This is the story of how one boy found out where they came from, and what they were running away from.

Chapter 1

The Night the Bridge Hummed

Rook was standing in a forest made of glass.

The trees were crystal, tall and thin as church spires, and every branch was hung with glittering leaves that chimed when the wind moved them. The ground under his bare feet was warm and soft, like moss, and it glowed faintly blue wherever he stepped. Above him hung a sun that was far too big and far too red. It looked tired, the way a campfire looks tired near the end of the night, when the flames have gone low and orange and the coals just pulse.

The wind blew, and the whole forest sang. It was the saddest song Rook had ever heard. It didn't have words, but it didn't need them. It sounded like someone saying goodbye.

Then, very close to his ear, so close he could almost feel the breath of it, a voice whispered:

"Find the one who listens."

Rook spun around. There was nobody there. Only the crystal trees, and the red sun, and a shadow on the horizon that hadn't been there a moment ago. It was spreading. It was eating the edge of the sky, the way ink spreads through water, and where it went, the stars went out.

"Find the one who listens," the voice said again, fainter now. *"Please."*

Rook opened his mouth to answer, and his head went *BONK* against the underside of the top bunk.

"Ow! Ow, ow, ow."

He lay there rubbing his forehead and blinking at the ceiling. The crystal forest was gone. The red sun was gone. He was in his own little bedroom, in his own little sandstone house, with his own old quilt tangled around his legs and his telescope standing by the round window where it always stood.

And the window was full of sunlight.

Not the pale, pink, early-morning kind of sunlight. The big, gold, fully-awake, middle-of-the-morning kind.

Rook stared at it. His brain was still half in the dream, so it took a second for the important part to arrive. When it did, it arrived all at once, like a bucket of cold water.

"Oh no," he said. "Oh no. Oh no, no, no, NO!"

Today was his thirteenth birthday.

In Dustmere, your thirteenth birthday was the biggest day of your whole life. It was bigger than learning to ride a dust-bike. It was bigger than your first canyon climb. It was the day you walked up the long stone steps to the Observatory, and Dr. Vashti opened her brass cabinet, and you met your very first Alienmon. The partner who would stay by your side, maybe forever.

Rook had been waiting for this day for as long as he could remember. He had a calendar on his wall with every single day crossed off in red marker. He had practiced what he would say. He had practiced how he would stand. He had set three alarms.

He looked at the clock. All three alarms had gone off. He had slept through every single one.

Rook exploded out of bed. He hopped on one foot pulling on his trousers. He hopped on the other foot pulling on a sock. He grabbed his red jacket off the hook, the one with the patched elbows that used to belong to his dad, and shoved his arms into it

on his way out the door. He jammed his yellow cap down over his hair, which was sticking straight up on one side, and checked that the little antenna pin was still clipped to the front. It was. Good. That pin was lucky.

He thundered down the stairs three at a time.

The kitchen smelled like cinnamon and warm butter. Mom was standing at the stove with a spatula, and on the table sat a stack of pancakes so tall it leaned to one side, with a single candle stuck in the top, already lit.

"Happy birthday, sweetheart!" Mom sang. "I made your favorite. Cactus-berry pancakes with—"

"MOM I'M LATE!"

"I know, honey, I called you four times. You were talking in your sleep. Something about trees?"

"No time!" Rook leaned over the stack, blew out the candle in one huge puff, grabbed the top pancake with his bare hand, kissed her cheek, and was already halfway out the door. "Love you! Thank you! Best pancakes ever! Bye!"

"Make a wish!" Mom called after him.

Rook skidded to a stop in the doorway. He looked back at her. She was smiling, with flour on her nose, holding the spatula like a magic wand.

He closed his eyes. *I wish,* he thought, *that my partner likes me.*

Then he ran.

* * *

Dustmere was a canyon town, built right into the red rock where three canyons met. The houses were round sandstone domes, the color of honey, each one with round windows that glowed a soft cyan at night. Purple flags hung from every rooftop, each one stitched with a gold ringed planet, and they snapped and fluttered

in the warm desert wind. Tall lamp posts lined the streets, and brass pipes ran along the walls carrying water from the deep wells, ticking and gurgling as the morning warmed them up.

At this time of day, the whole town was awake.

Rook ran past the bakery, where Mr. Abernathy was sliding loaves onto a cooling rack. He ran past the market, where people were setting out baskets of cactus fruit, strings of dried peppers and glittering canyon crystals. A little girl was riding on the back of a round, sand-colored Alienmon that looked like a rock with legs. It waved at Rook with one stubby foot. Rook waved back without slowing down.

In the middle of the plaza, an old robot was sweeping.

His name was DX-4, and he had been sweeping the plaza since before Rook was born. He was tall and thin and made of brass, with long creaky arms, and he had one round lamp for an eye that blinked when he was thinking. Nobody knew exactly who had built him. He had just always been there.

"GOOD MORNING, ROOK," DX-4 said in his creaky, tinny voice. "HAPPY BIRTHDAY. YOU ARE LATE."

"I KNOW!"

"STATISTICALLY," DX-4 called after him, "RUNNING DOES NOT MAKE YOU LESS LATE. IT ONLY MAKES YOU SWEATIER."

Rook ran anyway.

The Observatory sat at the very top of the town, on the highest point of the canyon rim, where you could see all the way out across the desert to the Starfall Crater, a huge round bowl in the earth, miles away, that glowed faintly purple even in the daytime. The Observatory was a big white dome with a giant brass telescope poking out of the top like a nose. To get there, you had to climb one hundred and twelve stone steps.

Rook had counted them many times. He counted them again now, taking them two at a time, his lungs burning, the half-eaten pancake still clutched in his fist.

One hundred and ten. One hundred and eleven. One hundred and twelve.

The big round door at the top stood open. And from inside, someone was shouting.

"You KNOW something about my dad! You always change the subject!"

Rook stopped dead in the doorway, panting.

The Observatory lab was the most wonderful room in all of Dustmere. The walls were lined from floor to ceiling with bookshelves, crammed with books and scrolls and jars of glowing things. Star charts were pinned everywhere, covered in handwriting and arrows and question marks. Brass gadgets ticked and whirred on every table. And in the middle of the room, under the enormous telescope, a girl was standing in front of Dr. Vashti with her fists clenched.

Rook knew her. Everybody in Dustmere knew her. Her name was Sola Reyes.

She was the same age as Rook, but she somehow always seemed older. She had a long black ponytail and wore purple fingerless gloves, and she was wearing the same thing she always wore: an olive-green jacket that was three sizes too big for her, with the sleeves rolled up four times so her hands could poke out. Everybody knew whose jacket it was. It had belonged to her father, Teo Reyes. Six years ago, Teo Reyes had walked out toward the Starfall Crater one evening, and he had never come back.

The grown-ups said he got lost in a sandstorm. Sola had never believed them.

"Sola, dear," said Dr. Vashti gently. "I've told you everything I can."

Dr. Imogen Vashti was the town scientist, and she was Rook's favorite grown-up in the whole world, after Mom. She had silver hair piled up in a messy bun, with at least three pencils stuck in it, and she wore a long white lab coat with more pockets than seemed possible. Every pocket was full of something: magnifying glasses, tiny screwdrivers, candy, more pencils. Right now her round glasses were pushed up on top of her head, and she had forgotten they were there, because she kept patting her coat as if looking for them.

"Everything you *can*," Sola muttered. "Not everything you *know*."

Dr. Vashti's face did something strange then. Just for a moment, it looked like the face of someone who had been caught. Then it was gone, and she was smiling her usual crinkly smile, because she had spotted Rook in the doorway.

"Ah! There he is! The birthday boy!" She clapped her hands. "Come in, come in, Rook. They've been waiting for you all morning. I think one of them was getting worried you weren't coming."

Sola turned around and looked Rook up and down. She took in his hair sticking up on one side. His mismatched socks. The pancake in his fist, which was dripping syrup onto the floor.

"Wow," she said flatly. "Very impressive."

Rook quickly hid the pancake behind his back. "I overslept."

"I can tell."

"Now, now," said Dr. Vashti, steering them both toward a big brass table by the window. "Today is a happy day. Sola had her thirteenth birthday last week, but she insisted on waiting so she

could choose on the same day as you, Rook. Wasn't that thoughtful?"

"It wasn't thoughtful," Sola said. "I wanted to see which one you picked, so I could pick the one that beats it."

Rook didn't know what to say to that, so he didn't say anything. And then he forgot about Sola completely, because he saw what was on the table.

Three glass capsules sat on velvet cushions in a row. Each capsule was about as big as a beach ball, rimmed with brass, and each one glowed softly from the inside. And inside each one, something was moving.

Rook's breath caught in his throat.

In the first capsule floated a little swirl of living fire, orange and gold, about as big as a pumpkin, and it had one big round eye blinking right in the middle, dark and shiny and curious. Two tiny sparks spun around it in circles, like little moons around a little sun. As Rook leaned closer, the sparks began to spin faster.

In the second capsule wobbled a blob of clear blue jelly, shaped like a dome, with a perfect round bubble glowing in its middle like a heart, and a fringe of curly little tentacles underneath that waved and tasted the air. When Rook looked at it, it jiggled and gave a gurgling giggle.

In the third capsule sat a round, fluffy puffball, cream-colored and soft-looking, wearing a mushroom cap on its head like a hat. The cap was red with white spots. It had two big shy eyes and a tiny mouth. When it saw Rook looking, it squeaked, the white spots on its cap puffed open in a nervous little cloud, and it pulled its mushroom cap down over its eyes.

"Plazmo," said Dr. Vashti softly, touching each capsule in turn. "Gloopa. And Sporix. Plasma, Hydro, and Bio. Fire, water, and

plant." She smiled. "They each came to us from the Starfall. They've been waiting a long time for someone."

"How do I choose?" Rook whispered.

"Not with your head," said Dr. Vashti. "Your head will tell you which one is strongest, or which one has the best type, or which one will win the most battles. Never mind all that. Choose with your heart."

Rook looked at the three of them for a long time.

The jelly was jiggling politely. The puffball was still hiding under its cap. But the little fire ball... the little fire ball was looking right at him. It had floated all the way to the front of its capsule and pressed its eye against the glass, its flames had shot up tall and wild, and its two sparks were spinning so fast now they were just a blur, as if it were so excited it couldn't hold still.

Rook had felt exactly like that this morning, running up all one hundred and twelve stairs.

He didn't need to think about it anymore.

"Plazmo," he said softly. "Want to be my partner, buddy?"

Dr. Vashti pressed a brass button. The capsule went *hisssss*, and its glass lid swung open.

Plazmo shot out like a firework. It zoomed straight up to the ceiling, zoomed straight back down, did three loops around Rook's head so fast that Rook got dizzy watching it, and then stopped right in front of his face, floating there and glowing. Its one big eye was crinkled up in what was very clearly a smile.

Rook held out his hands. Plazmo floated down and settled into them. It was warm, like a mug of hot cocoa, but it didn't burn at all.

"Hi," Rook whispered. "I'm Rook."

Plazmo's eye crinkled up even more. Then its little body scrunched up. Its sparks stopped spinning. It made a tiny sound: *ah... ah... AH...*

"Oh dear," said Dr. Vashti. "Everyone step back—"

AH-CHOOOOO!

Plazmo sneezed. A shower of bright orange sparks sprayed across the table and landed right on top of Dr. Vashti's notes, a whole stack of papers covered in tiny careful handwriting. They caught fire with a *fwoomp.*

"My notes!" Dr. Vashti grabbed a jar off a shelf and dumped it over the papers. It turned out to be full of glowing purple sand, which put the fire out but also covered the papers in glowing purple sand.

There was a long silence.

Then Rook started laughing. He couldn't help it. And Dr. Vashti started laughing too, wiping her eyes with her sleeve, purple sand all over her lab coat. Plazmo, looking very pleased with itself, did another loop.

Only Sola didn't laugh.

She stepped forward, picked up the second capsule, the one with the blue jelly inside, and pressed the button herself. The lid hissed open. The jelly wobbled out into her arms.

"I'll take this one," she said. "Gloopa. Water beats fire." She looked at Rook. "It's the one that beats yours."

Then she tucked Gloopa under her arm, inside the flap of her father's big jacket, turned around, and walked out of the Observatory without saying goodbye.

Rook watched her go. He felt something strange in his stomach, like when you go down a hill too fast. It wasn't anger, exactly. It was more like... he wanted to be friends with her, and

she very clearly didn't want to be friends with him, and he didn't know why.

While Rook was watching Sola, and Dr. Vashti was brushing purple sand off her notes, nobody looked at the third capsule.

Inside it, little Sporix had pushed its mushroom cap back up. It had watched Plazmo get chosen. It had watched Gloopa get chosen. It had waited, and waited, for someone to look at it.

Nobody did.

Sporix's mushroom cap drooped down low over its eyes, until it covered them completely. Very quietly, it pushed open the lid of its capsule with its little head. It climbed out, slid down the leg of the brass table, and tip-tapped across the floor on its tiny feet. It slipped out the door into the sunshine.

Nobody had picked it. Nobody wanted it. Maybe, it thought, nobody ever would.

* * *

That night, Rook lay in his bunk staring at the ceiling, too happy to sleep.

Plazmo was curled up on his pillow, right next to his head, glowing soft and orange like a night-light. Every time Rook turned to look at it, its one big sleepy eye opened a crack and looked back at him. Its sparks were spinning very slowly now, lazy and peaceful, like moons on a quiet night.

"Best birthday ever," Rook whispered.

Plazmo made a tiny happy sound, like a crackle in a fireplace.

Rook was almost asleep, his eyes almost closed, when he heard it.

It was a sound so low and deep that at first he thought it was in his own head. A hum. Like a giant somewhere far away, singing with its mouth closed. He felt it more than heard it. It came up

through the floor, through the bed frame, through his pillow. It made the glass in his round window tremble very slightly in its frame.

Plazmo's eye snapped wide open.

Rook sat up slowly and crept to the window. He pressed his nose against the cool glass.

Far below the town, at the bottom of the deepest canyon, stretched the old stone bridge. Nobody knew who had built it. It was older than Dustmere, older than anybody's grandparents, and it was carved all over with strange swirling marks that nobody could read. Every child in town had dared every other child to walk across it at night, and every child had chickened out.

And right now, the old stone bridge was humming.

All along its length, one by one, the strange carved marks were beginning to glow. A bright, electric, beautiful blue. They lit up from one end to the other, like someone was walking across it lighting candles, until the whole bridge was a ribbon of blue light glowing in the bottom of the dark canyon.

The hum grew louder.

It sounded, Rook thought, almost like the song from his dream.

It sounded like someone calling.

Chapter 2

Zib

Rook stood at the window for a long time, watching the bridge glow.

The hum went on and on. It rose and fell, like breathing. Every so often the blue light along the bridge pulsed brighter, and when it did, the hum got a little louder, and Plazmo's sparks spun a little faster.

"Plazmo," Rook whispered. "Are you thinking what I'm thinking?"

Plazmo's sparks went *whirrrrr*. That was definitely a yes.

Rook knew all the rules. Don't leave the house after dark. Don't go down into the canyon alone. And never, ever go near the old bridge at night. Every kid in Dustmere knew those rules. Every kid in Dustmere also knew that rules like that were basically an invitation.

He pulled his jacket on over his pajamas. He stuffed his feet into his boots without socks. He grabbed his flashlight from under the bed, even though he didn't really need it, because Plazmo was brighter than any flashlight. Then he eased open his bedroom door and listened.

From down the hall came the sound of Mom snoring. It was a small, polite snore, like a kettle that hadn't quite decided to boil yet.

Rook tiptoed past her door. He skipped the fourth stair from the bottom, the one that squeaked. He eased open the front door,

slipped through, and closed it behind him so gently that the latch barely clicked.

Then he was outside, in the night.

The desert at night was a completely different world from the desert in the day. The heat was gone. The air was cool and sharp and smelled like sage and dust. The town was silent, and all the round windows glowed soft cyan, like rows of sleepy eyes. And above it all, the sky was full of stars. Not a few stars. Not a lot of stars. *All* the stars, so many and so thick that the sky looked like someone had spilled sugar across black velvet. Across the middle of it all, a wide glowing band of purple and gold stretched from one horizon to the other.

Rook had seen the night sky a thousand times. It still took his breath away every time.

"Come on," he whispered to Plazmo. "This way."

The path down into the canyon started behind the bakery. It was narrow and twisty, cut right into the red rock, with a rope railing on one side and a long drop on the other. In the daytime it was easy. At night, with only Plazmo's glow to see by, every shadow looked like something waiting to grab his ankle.

Halfway down, one of the shadows moved.

Rook yelped and nearly jumped out of his boots. Plazmo flared up bright as a bonfire. And standing in the middle of the path, blinking its single lamp-eye in the sudden light, was DX-4.

"DX-4!" Rook clutched his chest. "You scared me half to death!"

"APOLOGIES," said DX-4. "I AM UNABLE TO SCARE ANYONE HALF TO DEATH. I CAN ONLY SCARE THEM SOME OF THE WAY. IT IS NOT A PRECISE MEASUREMENT."

"What are you doing down here?"

"I COULD ASK YOU THE SAME QUESTION," said DX-4. "BUT I ALREADY KNOW THE ANSWER. YOU ARE GOING TO THE BRIDGE." His lamp-eye blinked slowly, which meant he was thinking. "I HAVE BEEN MONITORING IT SINCE 9:42 P.M. AT 9:42 P.M., MY SENSORS DETECTED AN UNKNOWN FREQUENCY."

"An unknown frequency?" Rook leaned closer. "What does that mean?"

"IT MEANS SOMETHING IS SENDING A SIGNAL. I DO NOT KNOW WHAT. I DO NOT KNOW WHERE IT IS COMING FROM. I DO NOT KNOW WHAT IT IS SAYING." DX-4 paused. "BUT I HAVE CLASSIFIED THE FREQUENCY TYPE."

"And?"

"FREQUENCY TYPE: FRIENDLY."

Rook let out a breath he hadn't known he was holding. "Friendly. Okay. Friendly is good. Right?"

DX-4's lamp-eye blinked, and blinked, and blinked again.

"PROBABLY," he said.

That was not as comforting as Rook had hoped. But he had come this far, and the hum was louder now, so loud he could feel it buzzing in his teeth. He squared his shoulders.

"I'm going to go look," he said.

"I WILL STAY HERE," said DX-4, "AND MONITOR THE SITUATION. IF YOU DO NOT RETURN IN THIRTY MINUTES, I WILL WAKE YOUR MOTHER."

"Please don't wake my mother."

"THEN I SUGGEST YOU RETURN IN TWENTY-NINE MINUTES."

* * *

The bridge was bigger up close than Rook had ever imagined.

It stretched across the bottom of the canyon in one long, graceful arch, made of huge blocks of pale stone fitted together so perfectly that you couldn't fit a fingernail between them. It had no railings. It didn't need any. It was wide enough to drive a wagon across. And every single stone was carved, all over, with those strange swirling marks, curling and looping like writing in a language from a dream.

Right now, every mark was glowing. Blue light poured out of the carvings and lit up the canyon walls on both sides, so that the whole bottom of the canyon was filled with a cool, shimmering glow, like being underwater.

Rook stood at the very edge of the first stone.

The hum came up through his boots. It went into his knees, into his stomach, into his chest, until it felt like his own heart was humming along with it.

"Okay," he whispered. "Okay. Here goes."

He stepped onto the bridge.

Nothing happened. He took another step. Still nothing. He walked slowly out toward the middle, Plazmo floating beside his shoulder, the blue light glowing up all around them, and the hum got louder and louder and louder until he could barely think—

And then, all at once, it stopped.

The silence was so sudden and so complete that Rook's ears rang. Every glowing mark on the bridge went still. Not dark, just still, glowing a steady, quiet blue, like the bridge was holding its breath.

Rook held his breath too.

Something was falling out of the sky.

It came down slowly, the way a feather falls, tipping a little from side to side. At first it was just a tiny point of light, moving

against the stars. Then it got bigger. Then Rook could see it had a shape: round and flat, like a little plate, with tiny lights blinking all the way around its edge in different colors. Red, then blue, then green, then gold.

It wobbled. It dipped. It nearly crashed into the canyon wall, swerved at the last second, made a tiny noise that sounded a lot like *"eep!"*, and then straightened out again.

And then it was right in front of him, floating at the height of his nose.

It was the smallest, strangest, most wonderful thing he had ever seen. It was about the size of his hand. It was made of something silvery and smooth, like a seashell or a pearl. Its lights were blinking slowly all around its rim. And right in the middle of its top, where a saucer would have a cockpit, it had a clear glass dome. Inside the dome sat a little round body, and that little round body had one huge round eye.

The eye was enormous compared to the rest of it. It was dark and deep and shiny, and in the middle of it was a little ring of light, like a star reflected in a pond. It blinked. It looked at Rook. It looked at Plazmo. It looked back at Rook again.

Then it began to move.

It circled around Rook's head, slowly, once.

It circled around him again, a little closer.

It circled around him a third time, so close that he could feel a faint warmth coming off it, and hear a soft whirring from somewhere inside it, like a very small, very happy engine.

And then it landed, as gently as a falling leaf, right on top of his shoulder.

"Bip!" it said.

Rook did not move. He did not breathe. He was afraid that if he did anything at all, even blinked, it would fly away and he would wake up in his bunk with a bump on his head.

"Um," he said finally, very quietly. "Hi."

"Bip-bip!"

"I'm Rook."

The little saucer's lights flashed gold, all the way around, three times. It sounded, if a light can sound like anything, like it was saying *I know.*

Plazmo, meanwhile, had been watching all of this with its one big eye getting wider and wider. Now it floated a little closer to the newcomer, curious. It wanted to say hello. It leaned in, very close, to get a good look at this strange new friend.

And then Plazmo's little body began to scrunch up.

The saucer's eye went very wide.

Ah... went Plazmo. *Ah... AH...*

"Bip?" said the saucer nervously. "Bip-bip-bip-BIP!"

It dove off Rook's shoulder and straight down inside the collar of his jacket just as Plazmo exploded with a gigantic *AH-CHOOOOO!* Sparks sprayed out across the bridge like fireworks, bouncing and fizzing on the glowing stones.

Rook started laughing so hard that he had to sit down right there in the middle of the bridge. He laughed until his stomach hurt and tears ran down his cheeks. Plazmo looked a little embarrassed, its eye squinting sideways.

"It's okay," Rook gasped, reaching into his collar. "He does that. He doesn't mean it. You can come out. I promise."

For a moment, nothing happened. Then, very slowly, one huge eye peeked up out of his jacket and looked suspiciously at Plazmo.

"...Bip," it said. It did not sound convinced.

Rook held out his hand, and after a long moment the little saucer floated up out of his collar and settled into his palm. It was warm, just like Plazmo. He could feel that tiny engine whirring inside it, like a heartbeat.

"You need a name," Rook said. He thought about it. The saucer looked at him with its huge eye, waiting. It made a little *zzip* sound as it adjusted its balance on his palm.

"Zib," said Rook. "How about Zib? Is that okay?"

The little saucer went perfectly still. And then every single one of its lights flashed at once, every color all together, red and blue and green and gold and purple, so bright that the bridge lit up all around them like a party. It spun in a happy circle on Rook's palm. It made a long, delighted sound: "Bip-bip-bip-bip-bip-BIIIIP!"

Rook decided that meant yes.

* * *

Rook got home with exactly one minute to spare. DX-4 was waiting at the top of the canyon path, and he watched in silence as Rook crept past with Plazmo glowing on one side and a small silver saucer riding on his shoulder.

"IS THAT," said DX-4, "THE SOURCE OF THE UNKNOWN FREQUENCY?"

"I think so," Rook whispered. "His name's Zib."

DX-4's lamp-eye blinked at Zib for a long time. Zib's big eye blinked back.

"FREQUENCY TYPE," DX-4 said finally. "CONFIRMED. FRIENDLY."

"Bip!" said Zib.

* * *

The next morning, Rook didn't oversleep. He didn't think he had slept at all. The moment the sky turned pink, he was out the door and running up all one hundred and twelve steps to the Observatory, with Plazmo zooming along beside him and Zib clinging to the brim of his cap.

Dr. Vashti was asleep at her desk with her head on a pile of books and a pencil stuck to her cheek. When Rook burst in, she sat up so fast that the pencil flew across the room.

"Wha—? Rook? What time is it? What's—"

Then she saw Zib, and she stopped talking.

She stopped talking for so long that Rook started to get worried. She just sat there, staring at the little saucer. Her face had gone pale. Her hands, Rook noticed, were trembling very slightly.

"Dr. Vashti?" he said. "Are you okay?"

She blinked and seemed to come back from somewhere far away. "Yes. Yes, of course, dear. Just... surprised." She cleared her throat and stood up and started patting her pockets. "Well! Let's, ah, let's have a look at our little visitor, shall we?"

She scanned Zib with every gadget she owned. She had a lot of gadgets. She had a brass tube that went *ping*. She had a pair of goggles with nine different lenses that flipped down one at a time. She had a machine the size of a breadbox that made a noise like a duck when you turned it on. Zib sat patiently on the table through all of it, its big eye following each gadget with interest, and occasionally saying "bip" in a helpful sort of way.

Finally Dr. Vashti typed everything into her big computer, the one with the round green screen. It whirred. It clicked. It beeped seventeen times. Then a big red X appeared on the screen.

NO MATCH FOUND.

"No match," Dr. Vashti said slowly. "It's not in any database. Not one. There are over three hundred known species of Alienmon, Rook, and it isn't any of them."

Rook felt a grin spreading across his whole face. "So he's a mystery!"

"A mystery," Dr. Vashti agreed. She smiled at him. But it was a strange smile, and it didn't quite reach her eyes.

"Well, I think he's the best mystery ever," said Rook, scooping Zib up and setting him back on his cap. "Come on, Zib. Let's go show Mom. She is going to FREAK OUT."

He ran out the door. Plazmo zoomed after him. The sound of his boots went pounding away down all one hundred and twelve steps.

The Observatory went quiet.

Dr. Vashti stood alone in the middle of her lab for a long time. Then she walked slowly over to the giant brass telescope. She did not point it at the sky. She pointed it down, at the bottom of the canyon, at the old stone bridge, which was no longer glowing. It was just a bridge again, pale and silent in the morning sun.

She looked at it for a very long time.

Then she reached into the deepest pocket of her lab coat, the one she never let anybody see inside, and took out an old, faded photograph. It showed four children standing in the desert at night, grinning at the camera, their faces lit by a soft purple glow from something just out of the picture. One of them was a girl with round glasses and a messy bun.

Dr. Vashti touched the photograph very gently with one finger.

"After twenty years," she whispered. "Hello again, little one."

Chapter 3

Canyon Rivals

Mom did freak out. Just not in the way Rook expected.

She screamed when Zib flew in through the kitchen window. Then she screamed again, a different, higher kind of scream, when Zib landed on the rim of her teacup and said "Bip!" Then she sat down very suddenly at the kitchen table, put her hand on her heart, and laughed until she cried.

"Oh, he's darling," she said, wiping her eyes. "Oh, Rook. He's absolutely darling. Your Nana Wren would have loved him."

Zib, who seemed to know when he was being complimented, puffed himself up and flashed his lights pink.

Mom made a second breakfast, because she said a boy with two Alienmon needed twice as many pancakes. Plazmo ate a pancake by floating right on top of it and toasting it until it was crispy. Zib didn't seem to eat at all, but he was very interested in the syrup bottle, and kept flying around it in circles, watching the light shine through the amber.

Rook was on his fourth pancake when someone knocked on the door.

It was a boy from down the street, a little kid called Bram, with a gap where his front teeth used to be. He was out of breath. "Rook! Sola Reyes is at the Trading Post. She says she's waiting for you."

Rook put down his fork. "Waiting for me? For what?"

Bram's eyes were huge. "She says," he whispered, "*for a battle.*"

* * *

The Dustmere Trading Post sat at the very edge of town, where the road came in from the desert. It was a wild, noisy, wonderful jumble of a place: wooden stalls with striped red-and-yellow awnings, tents made of patched canvas, a big corral with a split-rail fence, and a water tower on stilts with a creaky windmill on top. Traders came here from all across Dustara to swap things. Cactus fruit and canyon crystals. Spare robot parts and jars of honey. Old maps, new boots, lucky charms, and strange glowing stones that hummed if you held them to your ear.

When Rook arrived, it seemed like half the town was already there.

News traveled fast in Dustmere, and nothing traveled faster than news of a battle. People had climbed up on crates and barrels to get a better look. Kids were sitting on top of the corral fence. A trader in a big hat was selling roasted cactus nuts in paper cones, shouting, "Battle snacks! Get your battle snacks!"

And in the middle of the corral, leaning against a post with her arms folded, was Sola.

Gloopa sat by her boot, wobbling gently.

When she saw Rook, she pushed herself off the post and walked toward him. The crowd went quiet. She looked at Plazmo. Then her eyes went to Rook's shoulder, where Zib was perched, and they narrowed.

"Heard you found some weird little robot last night," she said.

"He's not a robot," said Rook. "He's Zib."

"Bip," said Zib, a little defensively.

Sola looked at Zib for a long moment. Something flickered across her face. It might have been curiosity. It might have been something else. Then it was gone.

"Whatever," she said. "You and me. Right now. First battle."

"Right now? We only got our partners yesterday!"

"So did I." She tilted her chin up. "Unless you're scared."

The crowd went "Oooooh."

Rook felt his cheeks go hot. He looked at Plazmo. Plazmo's sparks were spinning fast and fierce, and its eye had gone narrow and determined.

"We're not scared," Rook said. "Let's do it."

The crowd cheered.

* * *

An old trader with a white mustache climbed up onto a barrel to be the referee. He held up a red bandanna. "One-on-one! First partner who can't keep going loses! No hitting trainers, no fighting dirty, and no knocking over my lemonade stand AGAIN!" He looked meaningfully at a sheepish-looking kid in the front row. Then he dropped the bandanna.

"BEGIN!"

"Plazmo, go!" Rook shouted.

Plazmo zoomed forward like a rocket, its sparks blazing, leaving a trail of orange light behind it. The kids on the fence ducked as it whooshed past their heads.

"Gloopa," said Sola. She didn't shout. She didn't even raise her voice. Gloopa bounced lazily into the middle of the corral and sat there, wobbling.

"Spark Burst!" Rook yelled.

Plazmo gathered all its fire into one glowing ball, wound up, and hurled it with all its might. It shot across the corral, crackling and fizzing, so hot that Rook felt it go past on his cheeks, straight at Gloopa.

It hit Gloopa right in the middle.

And went *fsssssssst.*

The fireball fizzled out like a match dropped in a puddle. A little puff of steam rose into the air. Gloopa jiggled, completely unbothered.

"Water," said Sola, "beats fire. Everybody knows that." She pointed. "Gloopa. Bubble Wave."

Gloopa's middle swelled up. The bubble in its heart glowed bright blue. Then it flung its curly tentacles forward, and out rolled a wave. A real wave, made of a hundred shining bubbles stuck together, tall as a fence post, sparkling in the sun. It rolled across the dirt of the corral, picking up speed, and crashed right into Plazmo.

SPLOOOOSH.

Plazmo went tumbling backward, end over end, its flame hissing and sputtering, and hit the fence so hard the whole rail jumped. *THWACK.* Two kids on top grabbed each other to keep from falling off. Plazmo dropped into the dirt, and a cloud of white steam boiled up off it, so thick that for one awful second Rook couldn't see it at all.

"Plazmo!" Rook ran a step forward. His heart was banging against his ribs. "Are you okay?"

The steam thinned. Plazmo was lying in a puddle, its flame flattened and shivering, water dripping off its sparks. Then it shook itself, hard, like a wet dog, and its flame crept back up, a little smaller than before, with a dark sooty smudge across one side. Its eye was furious. It zoomed straight back into the fight without being told.

"Wait—" Rook started.

But Plazmo was already throwing another Spark Burst. *Fssssst.* It fizzled. Another Bubble Wave came rolling in, and this time

Plazmo saw it coming. It jinked sideways, quick as a blink, and the wave only clipped the edge of its flame instead of swallowing it whole.

Rook didn't notice. He was too busy being scared. His mouth had gone dry, and everybody was watching, and the only thing in his head was a big loud *DO SOMETHING.*

"Again!" Rook shouted, because he didn't know what else to do. "Again, Plazmo! Harder!"

Plazmo heard him. Plazmo turned straight back in, the way Rook said. And the next wave hit it full in the face. *SPLASH.* It knocked Plazmo spinning into the dirt and rolled right over the top of it, and it came skidding out the other side, smaller still.

Plazmo threw everything it had. Spark Burst after Spark Burst after Spark Burst. *Fsst. Fsst. Fssssst.* Every single one fizzled out against Gloopa's watery body. And every time, Gloopa answered with a wave that knocked Plazmo a little further back and made its flame a little smaller.

SPLOOSH. Plazmo bounced off a barrel.

SPLOOSH. Plazmo skidded through the mud on its side, leaving a long dark trail behind it.

The dirt of the corral had turned to soup. Steam hung over everything like fog. Plazmo's sparks had wobbled right out of their circles, and it was panting, its whole flame going in and out, in and out, ragged at the edges like a candle in a draft. Gloopa hadn't moved an inch. It just sat in the middle of the mud with its bubble heart glowing, and waited.

The crowd had stopped cheering. Somebody near the lemonade stand said, "Oh, the poor little thing."

Plazmo dragged itself up off the ground. It wobbled. It nearly fell. And then it turned around, very slowly, and looked back

across the corral at Rook.

It wasn't asking to stop. Rook could see that. It was waiting. Waiting for him to tell it what to do. Waiting for a plan.

Rook didn't have one. He opened his mouth and nothing came out. His knees felt like water. He wanted to run out there and grab Plazmo and hide it inside his jacket. He wanted to shout *Stop!* But his voice wouldn't work, and the only word that finally squeezed out was the same word as before.

"...Again."

And Plazmo went. Because Rook asked. It gathered up every last spark it had left, every scrap of fire, until it was blazing brighter than it had all day, and it flew straight at Gloopa with everything it had.

Sola watched it come. "Gloopa," she said quietly. "All of it."

Gloopa swelled up bigger than Rook had ever seen it, so big its jelly went thin and shiny, and it let out the biggest Bubble Wave of all. It was taller than the fence. It was taller than the trader on his barrel. It rose up over Plazmo's tiny burning shape like a cliff made of glass.

It was over in less than a minute.

The last Bubble Wave crashed down. *KER-SPLOOOOSH.* The ground shook. A sheet of muddy water flew up over the fence and soaked the whole front row. And then there was nothing but hissing.

When it cleared, Plazmo was lying on the ground in a patch of wet dirt. Its flame had shrunk down to the size of a candle. Then smaller. A tiny blue-edged flicker, sputtering in the mud. Its sparks had stopped spinning. Its one big eye was closed.

Across the corral, Gloopa sagged down into a puddle of its own, wobbling and out of breath, its bubble heart glowing dimmer than

before.

The old trader raised his hand. "Gloopa wins!"

Some people cheered. Some people just went "aww." Rook didn't hear any of it. He was already running across the corral, slipping and sliding. He dropped to his knees in the mud and scooped Plazmo up in both hands, very gently, the way you'd pick up a baby bird.

Plazmo was so small now. It was barely warm. Little wisps of steam curled up off it into the air, and it was shivering.

"I'm sorry, buddy," Rook whispered. His voice wobbled. "I'm so sorry. That was my fault. That was all my fault."

Plazmo's eye opened a tiny crack. It looked up at him. And then, very weakly, it nuzzled its little flame against his thumb, as if to say, *It's okay. We'll get her next time.*

That made it worse, somehow. Rook's eyes stung. Plazmo had done every single thing he'd asked. It had gotten up every single time. And all he had given it to do was the one thing that didn't work.

A shadow fell across him. He looked up.

Sola was standing over him. Gloopa sat by her boot, wobbling, looking pleased with itself. For a second, Rook thought Sola was going to say something nice. Her face had gone soft around the edges. She opened her mouth.

Then she closed it again. And when she opened it the second time, the softness was gone.

"My dad," she said, "would've laughed at you."

Then she scooped up Gloopa, turned around, and walked out of the corral. The crowd parted to let her through. Nobody said anything.

Rook watched her go.

And as she turned away, just for a second, he saw her face. Her jaw was clenched tight, and her eyes were shining, bright and wet. She wiped them fast with the sleeve of her father's jacket, so fast that nobody else in the whole crowd noticed.

But Rook noticed.

She wasn't angry, he realized. Not really. She was sad. She was so sad that it was spilling over, and she was holding it in so hard that it came out as mean instead.

He sat there in the mud for a long time after everyone had gone, holding Plazmo against his chest to keep it warm, thinking about that.

* * *

That afternoon, Rook took Plazmo to the Dustmere Recovery Bay, a round white dome in the middle of town with a glowing blue cross over the door. Inside, a nurse with kind eyes laid Plazmo in a machine that looked like a giant glass seashell. It hummed and glowed soft gold. When it opened again a few minutes later, Plazmo shot out like a firework, completely back to its bright, bouncy, sparky self, as if nothing had happened at all.

But something had happened. Rook knew it, and he could tell Plazmo knew it too.

That night, after dinner, Rook didn't go to bed. He took Plazmo and Zib out behind the house, to the flat dusty patch of ground where Mom hung the laundry. The two moons of Dustara were rising over the canyon, one big and gold, one small and silver, and in their light everything had two shadows.

Rook sat down on an upturned bucket. Plazmo floated in front of him. Zib perched on the clothesline, swaying gently.

"Okay," Rook said. "Let's talk about what went wrong."

Plazmo's sparks drooped.

"No, no, not *you*. Me. What I did." Rook took a deep breath. "I kept yelling the same thing. Spark Burst, Spark Burst, Spark Burst. Over and over. Even after it didn't work the first time. Even after it didn't work the second time. I just kept charging in, harder and harder, like if I yelled loud enough it would suddenly start working." He shook his head. "That's not brave. That's just... not thinking."

Plazmo floated closer and listened.

"Sola didn't do that," Rook went on slowly. "Did you notice? She barely moved. She didn't shout. She just watched what we did, and waited, and then did the thing that would work." He was quiet for a moment. "We have to be like that. We have to think first. Watch what they do. And *then* move."

He picked up a small pebble from the dirt.

"Ready?"

Plazmo's sparks started to spin.

Rook tossed the pebble, gently, right at Plazmo. Plazmo bobbed to the side and the pebble sailed past.

"Good!"

He tossed another one. Plazmo dodged that one too. He tossed two at once, one high and one low. Plazmo dipped under the high one and hopped over the low one.

"Bip! Bip! Bip!" Zib cheered from the clothesline, flashing all his lights. "Bip-bip-BIP!"

They practiced for hours. Rook threw pebbles, and then pinecones, and then, when Plazmo got really good, wadded-up socks from the laundry basket, which were much harder to dodge because they flopped around in the air in unpredictable ways. Plazmo zipped and bobbed and twirled through all of it. And between dodges, Rook made it stop and *look*. Look at where the

sock was going. Look at where it would land. Then move, not before.

When the big gold moon was right overhead, Rook finally lay back on the dusty ground, exhausted, and looked up at the stars. Plazmo settled on his chest like a warm little campfire. Zib floated down and landed on his forehead.

"Think first," Rook said to the sky. He was smiling now. "Then act."

Plazmo crackled happily.

"We'll get her next time," Rook said. "You'll see."

And somewhere, across town, in a little house with a dark window, a girl in a jacket three sizes too big for her was sitting on her bed holding a faded photograph of her father. She was looking out at the same two moons.

She didn't know it yet, but she and Rook were going to see a lot more of each other.

Chapter 4

The Cactus Garden Catch

If you walked out the back of Dustmere, past the last house and the last lamp post and the last purple flag, the path wound down between two big red boulders that everyone called the Gateposts. And on the other side of the Gateposts, spread out across a wide, sunny bowl of land, were the Cactus Gardens.

Rook had been there a hundred times. But he had never been there *with a Linker.*

The Linker was a gift from Dr. Vashti. She had strapped it onto his wrist the morning after the battle, tightening the buckle with her careful fingers. It looked like a big, chunky wristwatch made of brass and glass, with a round screen in the middle and a little lens on the side that glowed faintly cyan.

"Every trainer needs one," she'd said. "It lets you talk to your partners. It keeps them safe when they're tired. And," she added with a twinkle, "if you meet a wild Alienmon who wants to come along with you, it lets you ask them."

Now Rook stood at the top of the path, looking down at the Gardens, with the Linker on his wrist and his heart thumping.

The Cactus Gardens were like a maze that someone had built for giants. Cacti grew everywhere, in every shape you could imagine. Tall skinny ones, taller than houses, with arms reaching up to the sky. Short fat round ones, like green barrels covered in pins. Flat paddle-shaped ones stacked up like pancakes. And on top of nearly every one, a flower: hot pink, sunshine yellow, deep

purple, red as a cherry.

Between the cacti grew patches of golden grass. It was called *drift grass*, and it only grew in places where star-seeds had fallen during the Starfall. When the wind blew through it, the tips of the blades crackled with tiny blue sparks, like static from a sweater. And it rustled. Not like normal grass. It rustled like there were things moving around inside it.

Because there were.

"Wild Alienmon love drift grass," Rook whispered to Plazmo. "Dr. Vashti says it reminds them of home."

"Bip?" said Zib, from the brim of Rook's cap.

"I don't know where their home is," Rook admitted. "Nobody does."

Zib went quiet at that. His lights dimmed a little.

* * *

An Explorer was sitting on a flat rock at the edge of the first drift-grass patch, eating an apple. She was an older woman with skin as brown and wrinkled as a walnut, a wide straw hat with a feather in it, and a vest absolutely covered in patches from different places. Rook could see patches with mountains on them, and waves, and a gear, and a mushroom, and one that just showed a big question mark.

She looked at Rook. She looked at his shiny new Linker. Then she took a big crunchy bite of her apple.

"First catch?" she said, with her mouth full.

Rook blinked. "How did you know?"

"You're wearing it upside down."

Rook looked down at his wrist. The little cyan lens was pointing straight at his own belly button. He went bright red and flipped the Linker around. The Explorer laughed, a big warm

laugh that made the feather on her hat bounce.

"Don't be embarrassed," she said. "I wore mine upside down for a whole week once. Name's Tamsin. I've been exploring the Kessler worlds for forty years." She patted the rock beside her. "Sit. I'll show you how it's done."

Rook sat. Plazmo floated down beside him. Zib hopped onto Tamsin's knee, studied her patches with great interest, and said "Bip" at the question-mark one.

"Ah, you like that one?" Tamsin smiled. "That's from a world I never found. The one they all came from. Someday, maybe."

Then she got serious.

"Rule one," she said, holding up a finger. "A capture isn't taking. It's *asking*. Some trainers forget that. They think the Linker is a net. It isn't. It's a door. You open the door, and the Alienmon decides whether to walk through."

Rook nodded.

"Rule two. Wild Alienmon won't listen to you if they're full of energy and showing off. So first you have a battle. Nothing mean. Just enough to tire them out a little, so they slow down and actually *look* at you. Not hurt. Never hurt. Just tired."

"Like after you run around all day," said Rook, "and you finally sit down."

"Exactly like that." Tamsin held up a third finger. "And rule three. When they're ready, you aim your Linker, and you press the button, and you fire the Transfer Beam. If they want to come, they'll come. If they don't..." She shrugged. "Then they don't. And you let them go, and you say thank you anyway."

She stood up and brushed apple crumbs off her vest. "Go on, then. The grass is waiting."

* * *

Rook's first try went like this:

A chunky brown stone block of an Alienmon called a Pebblet popped up out of the grass, with sleepy eyes and glittering indigo crystals tucked into its cracks. It took one look at Plazmo, tipped itself over, and came rolling straight at it like a bowling ball, no legs needed. *BONK.* Plazmo spun away through the air, its sparks knocked all crooked. The Pebblet rolled around in a circle and came back for more. This time Plazmo was ready. It bobbed aside and bumped the Pebblet with a small spark as it rumbled past. *Pff.* The Pebblet rolled over, dizzy. Rook raised his Linker, squeezed his eyes shut, pressed the button, and fired.

The Transfer Beam shot out. It missed the Pebblet by about six feet and hit a cactus.

The cactus glowed bright cyan for a second. Then it went back to being a cactus. The Pebblet blinked at Rook, rolled its eyes, and rolled away into the grass.

"Keep your eyes open," Tamsin called from her rock.

Rook's second try went like this:

A fuzzy yellow puff of an Alienmon called a Fizzle came zipping through the grass, its huge ears tipped with glowing sparks, crackling and popping like a soda that had been shaken up. Every pop threw off a little zap. *ZAP! ZAP-ZAP!* One of them caught Plazmo right on the tip of its flame, and Plazmo's whole body scrunched up, and *AH-CHOOO!* a shower of sparks set a tuft of drift grass smoking, which Rook had to stamp out with his boot. Then Plazmo chased the Fizzle in circles, zap after zap stinging its flame, until the Fizzle was dizzy and puffing, and so was Plazmo. Rook kept his eyes wide open this time. He aimed very carefully. He fired.

The Fizzle hopped to the side at the last second. The beam went straight past it and zapped the toe of Rook's own boot.

His boot glowed cyan. Then it went back to being a boot. The Fizzle laughed, a sound like popping bubbles, and zipped away.

"Better!" called Tamsin. "At least you hit something of yours that time."

Rook's third try went like this:

He aimed at a Pebblet. He fired. The beam bounced off a shiny flat rock, ricocheted off a second shiny flat rock, and zapped Zib right in the middle of his big round eye.

Zib spun around three times in midair with all his lights flashing red. "BIP!" he said. It was the most offended "bip" Rook had ever heard. "BIP-BIP-BIP! BIP!"

"I'm sorry! I'm sorry!" Rook held up his hands. "It bounced!"

Zib turned his back on Rook and floated over to sit on Tamsin's hat, where he sulked with his lights dimmed down to a grumpy purple.

Rook flopped down in the grass, sweaty and frustrated, and stared up at the sky.

"This is hard," he said.

"The good things usually are," said Tamsin.

* * *

That was when they met the Cactling.

It was sitting in the shade of a big barrel cactus, and at first Rook thought it was just a young cactus. It was stout and round and green, tall enough to come up past Rook's knees, and absolutely covered in short cream-colored spines. Right in the middle of its body bloomed a single creamy flower, and at the very heart of the flower was one green eye. It had two little stubby legs, two round stubby arms, and that one eye wore an expression that

said, very clearly, *Go away.*

Rook crouched down. "Hi there," he said softly.

The Cactling glared at him.

"I'm Rook. This is Plazmo. And that's Zib, up there, but he's not talking to me right now."

The Cactling stomped one stubby foot. It huffed, and every spine on its body bristled. And then it threw a handful of needles straight at Plazmo.

Fwip-fwip-fwip!

"Hey!" Plazmo dodged, just like they had practiced. The needles whizzed past and stuck into the dirt. *Thunk-thunk-thunk.* They went in right up to their ends. Rook stared at them. Those weren't little needles. Those were darts.

The Cactling threw more. Plazmo dodged again. And again. Then the Cactling threw two handfuls at once, one high and one low, exactly like Rook's flopping socks, and Plazmo dipped under the high one and went straight into the low one.

THWIP.

Three needles hit Plazmo square in the flame. Plazmo let out a sharp crackle, like a log popping in a fire, and spun right out of the air and hit the ground. The needles sizzled and burned away to ash. But Plazmo's flame had gone all ragged at the edges, and its sparks were wobbling.

The Cactling didn't wait. It charged, stubby legs pumping, and rammed Plazmo with its spiky shoulder. *WHUMP.* Plazmo went rolling through the drift grass in a shower of crackling blue static and fetched up against a barrel cactus. Then the Cactling planted itself over it, puffed up to twice its size with every spine bristling, and wound up again.

Rook's chest went tight. Every part of him wanted to yell. *Spark Burst! Fight back! Again! Harder!* He could feel the words climbing up his throat. They were the exact same words as the corral. The exact same mud.

Plazmo looked up at him from the grass, its flame flickering. Waiting.

Rook swallowed the words. He made himself stand still, and he just watched. *Think first.* The Cactling was strong, and grumpy, and very good at throwing needles. But every time it threw, it had to stop and wind up first, and for just a second, it was wide open.

"Plazmo," Rook said quietly. "I see it. Get up. Dodge one more. Then, next time it winds up: little spark. Gentle."

Gentle, because Tamsin had said never hurt. Over on her rock, Tamsin had stopped chewing her apple.

Plazmo pushed itself up off the ground. The Cactling flung. This time Plazmo didn't flee backward. It slipped sideways, low and close, so close that the needles hissed right past its flame and singed the grass behind it.

The Cactling wound up. Plazmo zipped in and tapped it with a small, warm spark, right on one round arm. Not hard. Just a tap. *Pip.* The Cactling squeaked in surprise and sat down on its bottom.

It glared at them even harder. Plazmo floated back to Rook's shoulder, panting, its flame still a little crooked, and Rook cupped a hand around it. "That's it," he whispered. "That's exactly it."

Then, high above them, there was a loud CRACK.

Everyone looked up.

At the edge of the Gardens, the canyon wall rose up tall and red. And near the top, right where the sun had been baking it all day, a chunk of rock as big as a watermelon had broken loose. It came tumbling down the cliff face, bouncing off ledges, *BANG,*

BANG, BANG, sending up puffs of red dust, faster and faster.

It was heading straight for Tamsin's rock. Straight for Tamsin's hat. Straight for Zib, who was still sitting up there sulking, with his back turned, not paying attention.

"ZIB!" Rook screamed. "MOVE!"

Zib turned around. His big eye went wide. He froze.

Rook was too far away. Plazmo was too far away. Tamsin was diving to the side, and her hat went flying, and Zib tumbled off it onto the flat top of the rock and just sat there, staring up, his lights blinking white with fear. There was no time.

And then a small green blur shot past Rook's feet.

It was the Cactling. It ran faster than Rook would ever have believed those stubby little legs could run. It leaped up onto Tamsin's rock in one huge jump, threw itself in front of Zib, curled up into a tight spiky ball, and took the falling rock right on its back.

THUNK.

The sound went right through Rook's chest. The rock bounced off the Cactling's tough, spiny body like a ball off a wall, cracked clean in half, and the two pieces rolled away into the drift grass and stopped. The Cactling lay pressed flat against the stone. It didn't move.

For a moment, nobody moved.

"No," Rook heard himself say. "No, no, no." He was running. He didn't remember starting.

The Cactling was still curled up tight. Red dust was settling on it like snow. Rook skidded to his knees in front of the rock, and his hands were shaking so badly he didn't dare touch it.

Then the Cactling slowly uncurled. It took a long time. It shook itself, and a whole little shower of snapped spines fell off its back,

leaving a bare, scuffed patch where the rock had hit. Its creamy flower was squashed crooked, and one petal was gone. It tried to stand, wobbled, sat down hard, and glared at its own legs as if they had betrayed it. Then it tried again, and this time it stayed up.

Zib floated down very slowly until he was right in front of the Cactling's face. He looked at it with his huge round eye. The Cactling looked back at him with its single grumpy green eye.

"...Bip," said Zib softly. It was the gentlest bip Rook had ever heard.

The Cactling's spines went flat, just for a second. It looked away. It huffed. Then it climbed down off the rock, one stiff careful step at a time, limped over to Rook, sat down right in front of his boots, folded its stubby arms, and looked up at him. Its expression had changed. It wasn't saying go away anymore.

It was saying: *Well? Are you going to ask me or not?*

Rook knelt down in the dirt until he was eye to eye with it. Up close, he could see the bare patch on its back and the way it was breathing, slow and careful. The Linker would let it rest, Dr. Vashti had said. It kept them safe when they were tired.

"Thank you," he said. "For protecting my friend. That was the bravest thing I've ever seen." He swallowed. "We're going on an adventure soon. A big one. I don't really know where yet. But I'd really like it if you came with us."

The Cactling studied him for a long, long moment.

Then it nodded, once, very seriously.

Rook raised his Linker. This time his hand didn't shake. His eyes didn't close. He pressed the button.

The Transfer Beam poured out, a stream of soft, glowing cyan light, and it wrapped around the Cactling like a warm blanket. The Cactling began to glow too, brighter and brighter, until it

shimmered and broke apart into a thousand tiny sparkling specks of light, like dust in a sunbeam. The specks swirled up into the air, spinning in a beautiful spiral, and then they flowed into the lens of the Linker with a sound like wind chimes in a summer breeze.

The screen on Rook's Linker lit up. A picture of the Cactling appeared on it, grumpy green eye and crooked flower and all.

CACTLING. PARTNER CONFIRMED.

"Bip-bip-BIIIIP!" Zib shot straight up into the air and spun in circles, every light flashing at once.

Plazmo did loop after loop around Rook's head, trailing sparks.

And Rook just sat there in the drift grass, holding his wrist up, staring at the little picture on his screen, with the biggest grin of his whole life.

"We did it," he breathed. "Our first catch."

Tamsin came over and clapped him on the shoulder. She was dusty from her dive and her hat was crooked, but she was smiling.

"No," she said. "*It* chose *you*. That's the best kind of catch there is."

She picked up her walking stick and looked out across the Gardens toward the far horizon, where the Starfall Crater glowed its faint purple glow.

"Something tells me," she said, "you're going to need all the friends you can get."

Chapter 5

Leaving Dustmere

The message came on the Linker the very next morning. It beeped three times, which meant it was important, and then a tiny picture of Dr. Vashti appeared on the screen. She had a pencil in her mouth and another one behind each ear.

"Rook, dear," she said around the pencil. "Could you come up to the Observatory? Bring Zib. Bring everybody. There's something I think you ought to see."

So for the third time in three days, Rook climbed all one hundred and twelve steps. Plazmo zoomed ahead and zoomed back, ahead and back, like an excited puppy. Zib rode on the brim of his cap. And Cactling, who did not like being inside the Linker very much, stomped up every single step on its own two stubby legs, refusing all help, glaring at each step as if the step had insulted it personally.

By the top, Cactling was puffing. It still refused help.

Dr. Vashti was waiting by the big brass telescope. Spread out across the table in front of her was the biggest map Rook had ever seen. It was so big it hung off all four sides of the table and pooled on the floor like a tablecloth. It showed the sun of the Kessler system in the middle, gold and round, and around it, in big looping circles, all fourteen worlds.

"Do you know what this is?" she asked.

"The Kessler system," said Rook. "We learned it at school. Dustara's the red one. Third ring."

"Very good. Now watch." Dr. Vashti turned a little brass dial on the side of the table. Under the glass, eight tiny lights blinked on, scattered across eight different worlds. "Eight Relay Towers. Nobody knows exactly who built them. Each one has a Keeper who guards it, and a crystal heart at the top. And every trainer who's brave enough, and clever enough, can travel from world to world and challenge the Keepers. Win, and the Keeper gives you a Signal Shard. A little piece of the tower's crystal."

Rook's heart started to thump. He knew about the Keepers. Everybody knew about the Keepers. There were trading cards of them. Kids in Dustmere argued about which Keeper was the toughest the way grown-ups argued about the weather.

"Now here's the strange part." Dr. Vashti picked up her brass tube, the one that went *ping*, and pointed it at Zib. It went *ping*. Then she pointed it at the map, at the eight little lights. It went *ping* again. Exactly the same *ping*. "Zib's frequency and the towers' frequency. They match. Like two notes in the same song."

"Bip?" said Zib.

"So if I want to find out where Zib came from," Rook said slowly, "I should go to the towers."

Dr. Vashti didn't answer right away. She took off her glasses, which she had actually been wearing for once, and cleaned them on her lab coat for a long time, even though they were already clean.

"I think," she said carefully, "that the towers are where the answers are. And I think you are a boy who is going to go looking for answers whether I tell you to or not." She put the glasses back on. "So I'd rather tell you. And I'd rather you went with a map."

She rolled up a smaller copy of the map and handed it to him. It was tied with a purple ribbon.

Rook held it in both hands. His mouth had gone dry.

"Sola left this morning," Dr. Vashti added quietly. "On the dawn freight wagon. Before the sun was even up. She's going to the towers too, I think. Though I don't think it's Signal Shards she's looking for."

Rook thought about the girl in the too-big jacket, wiping her eyes so fast that nobody could see.

"Her dad," he said.

"Her dad," said Dr. Vashti. And for just a second, that strange caught look crossed her face again. Then she clapped her hands, and it was gone. "Well! Go on home and pack, then. You'll want more socks than you think. Everybody always wants more socks than they think."

* * *

The next morning, Rook's backpack sat by the front door, stuffed so full the zipper wouldn't close all the way.

Mom had packed it. Then Rook had unpacked it and packed it his way. Then Mom had unpacked it again and repacked it her way, because his way had been seven comic books, a slingshot, and one sock. Now it held a blanket, a flashlight, a water bottle, a tin of cactus-berry cookies, a first-aid kit, the map with the purple ribbon, and fourteen pairs of socks.

"Fourteen?" said Rook.

"One for every world," said Mom. "And you'll lose some. Boys lose socks the way trees lose leaves."

Then she knelt down in front of him, which she hadn't done since he was small, and took his hand. She pressed something into it.

It was small and warm from her pocket. An old brass badge, shaped like a cross, worn smooth and soft at the edges from years

and years of being touched. In the middle of it, someone had engraved a tiny bird with its wings spread out. And right at its heart, set into the brass, was a small round stone that glowed a soft, steady blue, like a nightlight that never ran out.

"This belonged to your Nana Wren," Mom said. "She was the very first nurse at the Recovery Bay. She healed Alienmon for forty years. Every scraped knee, every singed tail, every scared little thing that came through that door. She'd want you to have it."

Rook turned the badge over in his fingers. On the back, in tiny worn letters, it said: *R.B. No. 1.*

"Recovery Bay, Number One," Mom said. "She was so proud of that badge. She used to say it wasn't a badge at all. It was a promise."

"A promise to do what?"

Mom smiled, and her eyes were shining. "Never give up on anybody."

Rook pinned the badge onto the strap of his satchel, right over his heart. His throat had gone all tight and funny, so tight that no words could squeeze past. So instead of saying anything, he just hugged her. He hugged her for a very long time. Plazmo floated in and hugged too, which mostly meant sitting on top of Mom's head and making her hair warm. Zib landed on her shoulder and flashed his lights soft pink. And Cactling, after a long moment of looking at the ceiling as though hugs were beneath it, shuffled over and leaned its prickly side very, very gently against her ankle.

"Ow," said Mom, laughing and crying at the same time. "Oh, thank you, Cactling. Ow. That's lovely. Ow."

* * *

That evening, the whole town gathered at the Bonfire Ring to say goodbye.

The Bonfire Ring was a circle of flat stones at the edge of the plaza, where the people of Dustmere came together on special nights: birthdays, harvests, Starfall Day, and the night before a young trainer set off on a journey. Somebody brought a guitar. Somebody else brought a pot of spicy bean stew so big it took two people to carry it. Mr. Abernathy from the bakery brought a basket of honey rolls, still warm. The little girl with the rock-shaped Alienmon was there, and Bram with the missing teeth, and the old trader with the white mustache, who shook Rook's hand and told him not to knock over anybody's lemonade stand out there.

DX-4 came too. He stood at the edge of the firelight with his broom, very straight and very still, his lamp-eye glowing.

Rook went over to him. "Hi, DX-4."

"GOOD EVENING, ROOK," said DX-4. "I HAVE BEEN INFORMED THAT YOU ARE LEAVING."

"Just for a while. I'll come back."

DX-4's lamp-eye blinked slowly. Once. Twice. Three times.

"I HAVE CALCULATED," he said, "THAT THE PLAZA WILL BE EIGHTEEN PERCENT QUIETER WITHOUT YOU. THERE WILL BE FEWER SKIDDING NOISES. FEWER SHOUTING NOISES. FEWER SNEEZES THAT SET THINGS ON FIRE."

Plazmo looked sideways, embarrassed.

"I HAD EXPECTED," DX-4 went on, "TO FIND THIS RESTFUL." He paused. His lamp-eye flickered. "I DO NOT. THIS IS NOT A STATISTIC. I DO NOT KNOW WHAT IT IS."

Rook grinned. "I think it means you'll miss me."

DX-4 considered this for a long time.

"PROBABLY," he said.

Then he reached into a little hatch in his brass chest and took out a small round thing, about the size of a coin, with a tiny glass window in it. Inside the window, a needle swung back and forth and then settled.

"A FREQUENCY COMPASS," said DX-4. "I BUILT IT LAST NIGHT. IT POINTS TOWARD ANY SIGNAL THAT MATCHES THE UNKNOWN FREQUENCY." He dropped it into Rook's palm. The needle swung around and pointed straight at Zib, who said "Bip!" in surprise. "IF YOU BECOME LOST, IT WILL NOT HELP YOU AT ALL. BUT IF ZIB BECOMES LOST, IT WILL HELP YOU FIND HIM."

Rook looked at the little compass. Then he looked at the tall old robot who had been sweeping the plaza since before he was born.

"Thank you," he said. "I mean it."

"YOU ARE WELCOME," said DX-4. "PLEASE RETURN IN A REASONABLE AMOUNT OF TIME. I SUGGEST TWENTY-NINE MINUTES."

* * *

When the stew was eaten and the sky had gone fully dark, everybody turned toward the oldest man in Dustmere.

His name was Old Dusty. He had a beard so long and so white that he tucked the end of it into his belt so he wouldn't trip on it. He wore a hat that had once been brown and was now mostly holes. He told the best stories in the whole canyon, and he knew it, and he always waited until everyone was perfectly quiet before he started.

Everyone got perfectly quiet.

Old Dusty poked the fire with a long stick. Sparks went whirling up into the dark, and Plazmo watched them go with great interest, as if he were checking whether any of them were

relatives.

"Twenty years ago," said Old Dusty, in his slow, crackly voice, "stars fell from the sky."

The fire popped. Somebody's baby gurgled. Nobody else made a sound.

"Most of you young ones weren't born yet. But I was there. I stood in that plaza in my nightshirt and watched the sky come down. And the next morning, while all the grown-ups were still scratching their heads, four kids, not much older than you, Rook, packed some sandwiches and walked all the way out to the Starfall Crater."

"By themselves?" squeaked Bram.

"By themselves. And at the bottom of that crater, in the purple glow, they found the very first star-seed. The biggest one of all. Glowing, it was. Warm as a heartbeat. And when they touched it, it cracked open like an egg."

Rook leaned forward. "What was inside?"

Old Dusty's eyes twinkled under his hat. "Well. That depends who you ask. Some folks say there was a little creature inside, sleeping. Some folks say there was nothing at all." He poked the fire again. "And some folks say there was something else in that pod, too. A flat stone. Smooth as glass. With writing on it, in a language nobody had ever seen."

A shiver went right down Rook's back, all the way to his boots.

"What did it say?"

"Couldn't tell you. Never saw it. Nobody did, except those four."

"Who were they?" Rook asked. "The four kids?"

Old Dusty just smiled and stroked his long white beard.

"That," he said, "is a story for another night."

Everybody groaned. Old Dusty always did that. He always stopped right at the best part.

But Rook wasn't looking at Old Dusty anymore. He was looking past the fire, past the circle of faces, to the very edge of the light, where the shadows started. Somebody had been standing there, listening. Somebody with silver hair piled up in a messy bun.

As Rook watched, Dr. Vashti turned around and walked quickly away into the dark, without saying goodbye to anyone.

* * *

The next day, the sun came up big and gold over the canyon rim, and Rook walked out of Dustmere.

He didn't look back until he reached the edge of town. Then he did look back, just once. Mom was standing in the doorway of their little sandstone house, waving a dish towel over her head like a flag. DX-4 was in the middle of the plaza, sweeping, but his lamp-eye was pointed straight at Rook. And way up at the top of the hundred and twelve steps, a tiny figure in a white lab coat was standing in the round door of the Observatory, watching.

Rook waved to all of them. Then he turned around and kept walking.

The road went west, across a flat stretch of red desert, toward a wall of jagged purple mountains called the Sunset Range. There was only one way through them, and every kid in Dustmere knew it: the Sunset Tunnel. It was a long dark passage carved straight through the heart of the mountains, so old that nobody remembered who had dug it. People said it took half a day to walk from one end to the other. People said it was haunted. People said a lot of things.

By noon, they had reached it.

The mouth of the tunnel was a huge round arch in the side of the mountain, and around its edge were carved the same strange swirling marks as the old bridge back home. They weren't glowing. But when Zib floated near them, Rook could have sworn he saw them flicker, just for a second, like an eye opening and closing.

Inside, lanterns hung from iron hooks along the walls, each one burning with a little blue flame. They made pools of light every few steps, with long stretches of shadow in between. The air was cool and damp and smelled like old stone. Their footsteps echoed. *Clomp. Clomp. Clomp.* And behind them, smaller and quicker, *tip-tap-tip-tap*, which was Cactling, who had refused once again to ride inside the Linker.

"This isn't scary," Rook said loudly. His voice bounced off the walls. *Scary, scary, scary.*

"Bip," said Zib, who did not sound sure.

They walked for a long time. Rook ate three cactus-berry cookies and gave half of one to Cactling, who ate it with great dignity. Plazmo floated ahead, lighting up the dark places between the lanterns. Zib hummed a little *bip-bip-bip* tune to himself.

They were maybe halfway through when the lanterns went out.

Not all at once. One at a time. Far ahead of them, the farthest blue flame winked out. Then the next one. Then the next, *fft, fft, fft*, coming closer and closer, like someone walking down the tunnel pinching out candles.

Rook stopped. Plazmo stopped. Cactling's needles stood up all over its body with a soft *shff*.

Rook turned around. Behind them, back the way they had come, the lanterns were going out too.

Fft. Fft. Fft.

And then the only light left in the whole tunnel was Plazmo, glowing orange in the middle of a darkness so thick it felt like it was pressing on Rook's eyes.

"Bip," whispered Zib. His lights had faded to a nervous, washed-out gray.

Something clicked in the dark.

Click-click. Click-click. A thin, dry buzzing, like a wasp in a jar. Then, at the very edge of Plazmo's glow, something floated into view. It was a bug-like flier as big as a small dog, with a hard white shell and two round wings shaped exactly like little satellite dishes. The dishes swiveled. They twitched. They turned, slowly and carefully, until both of them were pointing straight at Zib.

It wasn't looking at him. It was *listening* to him.

"Easy," said a voice. "Nobody needs to move fast."

A light clicked on. A small white headlamp, then a second one, a few steps behind the first. Two people stepped out of a side passage Rook hadn't even noticed, as calmly as if they were walking into a classroom.

They wore white jumpsuits, crisp and clean, with dark visors pulled down over their faces so Rook couldn't see their eyes. On each shoulder was a patch Rook had seen a hundred times, on posters and on the side of the radio mast above Dustmere: an orange ring with a diagonal slash through it.

The one in front was tall and lean and stood very straight. Slung across his chest was a squat white launcher with a wide funnel on the end, and a faint blue crackle ran around the rim of the funnel. He didn't point it at anybody. He didn't need to.

The second one was shorter and broader, and he stayed back by the tunnel wall. He had a launcher too. He held it low.

"Helix Directive," said the tall one. "Field Division." He paused, and when he went on, he said it the way some people say the name of a medal they have won, and the way some people say the name of a place they are trying very hard to leave. "Second Class. My name is Pell. That's Strand."

Strand didn't say anything at all.

"And you're Rook," said Pell. "From Dustmere."

Rook's mouth went dry. "How do you know my name?"

"Your Linker checked in with the Dustmere relay four days ago. Every Linker does. Who do you think built the grid?" Pell tilted his head toward the little white flier, which was still hanging in the air with its dishes locked on Zib. "And your friend there has been singing on a frequency we have been waiting a very long time to hear. You can hide a lot of things in a tunnel, Rook. You can't hide that."

Zib pressed himself flat against the back of Rook's neck. Rook could feel the tiny engine inside him going *whirrrrr-whirrrrr-whirrrrr*, fast as a heartbeat.

"Here's how this goes," said Pell. His voice was perfectly calm and perfectly reasonable, like a teacher explaining the rules of a test. "You hand over the scout. Helix pays well for strays. Enough to get you to every tower in the system and back again. You walk out the far end of this tunnel with your Plasma-type and your cactus, and nobody gets hurt."

"He's not a stray," Rook said. His voice cracked in the middle, and he hated that it did. "He's not a scout. He's my *friend*."

For just a moment, Pell looked almost sorry for him. "Everything's somebody's friend," he said. "That's never stopped anybody yet."

"Pell." It was the first time Strand had spoken. His voice was low and quiet. "He's a kid."

"And that," said Pell, without turning around, "is priority number one for Phase Two. The Director wants it."

"You're not supposed to say Phase Two in front of..."

"He doesn't know what it means. Nobody does." Pell lifted the launcher. "Mark it, Strand."

Strand didn't move.

"*Strand.*"

A long second. Then Strand lifted his launcher too. But Rook noticed, even with his heart going wild, that the funnel wasn't pointed at Zib. It was pointed at the floor, a step to the left of Rook's boot.

Pell fired.

FWUMP.

A white net came blooming out of the funnel, wide as a bedsheet, weights swinging on every corner, crackling with blue light. And Plazmo shot straight up into the path of the net, the way a goalkeeper throws himself in front of a ball.

The net swallowed him whole.

The weights whipped around, *zip-zip-zip*, and the whole bundle hit the floor with a *THUD*. Inside it, Plazmo blazed. But the net didn't burn. Everywhere he pressed against it, it spat cold blue static, *KZZT! KZZT!*, and his flame jerked back like a hand off a hot stove.

"PLAZMO!"

"Static mesh," said Pell, almost kindly. "It doesn't burn. Plasma-types never work that out in time." He pulled a handle on the side of the launcher. *CHUNK-CHUNK.* A fresh net slid into place. "Drone. Take it."

The little white flier dove at Zib.

Cactling didn't wait to be told. It charged at Pell's boots, head down, needles up. Pell didn't yelp. He didn't even look down. He just stepped smoothly to one side, the way you would step around a puddle, and swung the heavy end of the launcher low. *WHUMP.* It caught Cactling right in the middle and sent it spinning across the tunnel. It hit the wall and landed upside down, stubby legs kicking, the creamy flower in the middle of its body bent sideways.

Over by the wall, Rook heard Strand make a small sound, as if he were the one who had been hit. He didn't fire.

Zib zigzagged around Rook's head with the drone right behind him, *click-click, click-click*, its dish wings swiveling to follow every turn. Zib was fast. But the drone didn't need to be faster. It only needed to keep listening, and wait for him to get tired.

Rook's heart was slamming so hard it hurt. He dropped to his knees and grabbed at the knots. They were tight as fists. Inside, Plazmo's flame had gone small and flickery, and every time he pushed, the static bit him, and he came back a little dimmer. "Hang on," Rook gasped. "Hang on, I'll get you out, I'll..."

Plazmo's eye found him through the mesh. It wasn't scared. It was furious. It flicked down to the bottom of the net, where one of the weights had landed crooked and left a gap, then back up to Rook.

Rook grabbed the weight and heaved. Plazmo shot out through the gap in a burst of smoke, singed and spitting mad. Cactling rocked once, twice, flopped onto its feet, and turned around with a glare that could have melted the net all by itself.

And Pell was already swinging the funnel around toward Zib, steady as a rock, his finger resting on the trigger. He wasn't

rushing. He didn't need to.

Rook didn't have time to think first. But he had practiced so much that his body already knew what to do.

"Plazmo! Cactling! Together!"

Plazmo shot forward in a blaze of orange and flung a crackling shower of sparks. At the very same moment, Cactling wound up its stubby arm and hurled a fistful of needles. The sparks and the needles flew side by side, and they hit the launcher at exactly the same moment, right in the mouth of the funnel.

The needles jammed the loaded net in place. The sparks hit the static charge behind it.

KRAKKA-KRAKKA-KZZZT!

The net didn't fire. It burst. It came exploding out of the funnel sideways, half open, spitting blue static in every direction, and it wrapped itself around the launcher and Pell's arm and slammed them both flat against the tunnel wall. The drone, swooping low after Zib, flew straight into the crackling edge of it. *KZZT.* Its dish wings jerked. It dropped out of the air like a stone and lay on the floor, buzzing faintly.

Pell hissed through his teeth. With one hard twist he dragged his arm free of the mesh. The launcher stayed where it was, pinned to the wall, crackling and useless.

For a long moment, nobody moved.

Plazmo hung in the air in front of Rook, blazing as big and bright as he could make himself. Cactling stood by Rook's boot with its flower still bent and every needle pointed straight at Pell. Zib hovered over Rook's head, his lights burning a fierce, steady gold.

Pell looked at them. Rook watched him do it. The dark visor turned slowly from Plazmo, to Cactling, to the launcher on the

wall, to the drone on the floor, to Strand, whose funnel was still pointed a step to the left of Rook's boot. It was like watching someone add up a sum in his head. And Rook knew the exact second Pell got the answer, because his shoulders changed.

"Strand," Pell said quietly. "Get the drone. We're done here."

As Strand passed him, Pell said something else, low, not meant for Rook. "You didn't fire."

"I didn't have a shot."

Pell's visor stayed turned toward his partner for a long moment. "Then that's what goes in the report," he said.

Strand slung his launcher over his back. He knelt and picked up the little white flier. He didn't grab it by a wing. He scooped it up in both hands, carefully, the way Rook's mom picked up a hurt bird, and held it against his chest.

Pell stepped back toward the side passage. His headlamp lit the edge of his visor and the orange ring on his shoulder.

"That was good," he said. "The Plasma-type and the cactus, together. That was really good. Remember it, Rook." His voice didn't get louder. It got quieter. "Because it's the last time it's going to be this easy. Helix doesn't lose things. We just collect them later."

Then he turned and walked away into the dark, without hurrying, without looking back.

Strand went after him. But at the edge of the light he stopped. For a second his visor turned back toward Rook, and Rook thought he was going to say something. Something he wasn't supposed to say.

"Go home, kid," Strand said, so softly it was barely more than a breath. "Please."

Then he was gone too.

One by one, ahead of them and behind them, the blue lanterns flickered back to life.

There was a long, long silence.

Rook's legs gave out, and he sat down hard on the cold tunnel floor. His hands were shaking. Plazmo was smaller than usual and still smoking at the edges. Cactling's flower was still bent, and it slapped Rook's hand away when he tried to fix it. "You jumped right in front of it," Rook whispered to Plazmo. Plazmo puffed up, proud, but his flame was still flickering.

Zib came down off Rook's cap and tucked himself into the crook of Rook's arm. He looked toward the dark side passage where the agents had disappeared. Then he looked at Plazmo and Cactling, a little scorched and a little dented, standing guard on either side of Rook, still facing the dark.

"Bip," said Zib, in a very small voice.

Rook didn't laugh. He wanted to. He wanted it to be the kind of story you could tell at the Bonfire Ring, the kind where everybody cheers at the end. But Pell hadn't run away. He had *decided* to leave. That wasn't the same thing at all.

And Helix. He knew that name. Everybody did. Helix had built the radio masts that carried music and weather reports all the way out to Dustmere. Helix had paid for the new roof on the schoolhouse, and there was a shiny brass plaque by the door that said so, with the orange ring and the slash. Whenever the radio talked about Helix, it said things like *research*, and *the future*, and *for the good of the whole Kessler system*. Grown-ups said the name the way they said *doctor*. Like it meant safe.

And Pell believed every word of it. Rook could tell. He hadn't sounded like a villain from a comic book. He had sounded like somebody doing his job, and proud of it.

That was the scariest part of all.

Rook looked down at the Linker on his wrist. *Your Linker checked in with the Dustmere relay four days ago. Every Linker does.* For the first time, the chunky brass watch felt heavy.

What was Phase Two? Who was the Director? And why, out of all the Alienmon on all fourteen worlds, did they want Zib?

He didn't have answers. He just walked faster.

The tunnel went on and on. Then, finally, far ahead, Rook saw a glow. Not the blue of the lanterns. Not the purple of Dustara. A deep, warm, flickering orange, like the inside of a furnace. The air started getting warmer. He could smell something new: smoke, and salt, and hot stone.

"The end of the tunnel!" he said. "Come on, everybody, we're almost—"

His satchel gave a little wiggle.

Rook stopped walking.

Plazmo was floating right in front of him. Zib was on his cap. Cactling was standing by his boot. All three of them were right where he could see them.

The satchel wiggled again. Something inside it shifted. Something small. Something soft. Something that, very quietly, so quietly he almost didn't hear it, went *squeak*.

Rook looked down at his bag.

Something inside it was moving.

Chapter 6

The Stowaway

Rook set his satchel down on the tunnel floor, very, very slowly, the way you would set down a box that might have a snake in it.

Plazmo floated closer and turned himself up bright, like a lamp. Zib hovered just above Rook's shoulder, his lights flickering a nervous yellow. Cactling planted its stubby feet wide apart and raised a fistful of needles, ready to throw them at whatever came out.

"Cactling," Rook whispered. "No needles. Not yet. Let's see what it is first."

Cactling huffed. But it lowered its arm.

Rook undid the buckle. He lifted the flap. He peered inside.

There was his blanket. There was his flashlight. There was the tin of cactus-berry cookies, which had been opened, and which now had a lot fewer cookies in it than it had that morning. And wedged in the corner, half hidden behind his squashed sandwich, with crumbs all down its front, were two round, shiny, terrified eyes, peeking out from under a red mushroom cap with white spots.

"...Sporix?"

The little puffball squeaked. Then it tried very hard to hide behind the sandwich. Unfortunately, Sporix was bigger than the sandwich, so all this really did was make the sandwich look like it had grown a mushroom.

Rook sat back on his heels. "You followed me? All the way from Dustmere?"

Sporix didn't answer. Its cap drooped lower and lower, until it was covering its eyes completely, like a kid pulling a blanket over its head.

Rook thought about that day in the Observatory. He had been so excited about Plazmo. Sola had been so busy beating him. Dr. Vashti had been so busy putting out the fire. And nobody, not one single person, had looked at the third capsule.

He remembered seeing it empty, later, and thinking nothing of it. He had figured Dr. Vashti had put Sporix away somewhere.

He hadn't thought about it again. Not once.

A hot, heavy feeling crawled up into his chest. It felt a lot like the feeling after the battle with Sola.

Very gently, he reached into the satchel and lifted Sporix out with both hands. It was soft, like holding a warm loaf of bread fresh from the oven, and heavier than it looked. It was trembling all over. Little puffs of pale dust came out of the white spots on its cap every time it shivered.

"Hey," Rook said softly. "Hey. It's okay. Nobody's mad."

Sporix peeked out from under its cap. Just one eye.

"I'm not mad. I promise. I'm just surprised." Rook held it up so they were face to face. "You must have been in there since this morning. Since before the Bonfire, maybe. That's a long time to be squashed next to a sandwich."

Sporix's eye looked at the sandwich, then back at Rook. A small, guilty crumb fell off its chin.

Rook laughed. He couldn't help it. "And you ate my cookies."

Sporix pulled its cap down again, fast.

"No, no, it's fine! You can have the cookies! I've got fourteen pairs of socks, I don't need cookies." That didn't make much sense, but it seemed to help, because Sporix peeked out again. "Why did you come, though? Was it... because nobody picked you?"

Sporix didn't move. But its little body went very still, and very small, and that was answer enough.

Plazmo floated in closer, curious, to say hello.

That was a mistake. As soon as Plazmo's warm orange light fell across it, Sporix let out a squeak like a stepped-on toy, wriggled out of Rook's hands, and dove straight back into the satchel. The bag shook. Something inside it went *thud*. The sandwich came flying out.

Plazmo stopped in midair, his eye wide and confused.

"Oh," said Rook slowly. "Oh, right. You're Bio-type. Plant-type. And Plazmo's fire." He looked at Plazmo, who was floating with his sparks drooping, trying very hard to look small and harmless. "Fire beats plants. You're scared of him."

"Bip," said Zib, with great sympathy. Zib knew a thing or two about being scared of Plazmo.

Rook picked up the sandwich, brushed it off, and set it on a rock. Then he knelt down by the satchel and talked to it, the way you might talk to somebody hiding under a bed.

"Plazmo would never hurt you," he said. "Not on purpose. He sneezes sometimes. That's the only dangerous thing about him. And when he sneezes, Zib hides in my jacket, and you can hide in the bag. Okay? We've got lots of hiding places."

The satchel was quiet for a long moment.

Then, very carefully, a spotted cap rose up out of the opening. And under it, two eyes.

Cactling walked over, looked down into the satchel, and grunted. Then it reached into the cookie tin, took out the very last cookie, broke it carefully in half, and held one half out toward Sporix.

Sporix stared at the cookie. Sporix stared at Cactling.

Cactling stared back, its face saying very clearly: *Take it before I change my mind.*

Sporix took it.

Rook felt something warm swell up in his chest. "Okay," he said, standing up and slinging the satchel very carefully over his shoulder. "Okay, everybody. Let's go see what's at the end of this tunnel."

* * *

What was at the end of the tunnel was the other side of the world.

Rook stepped out of the dark and stopped so suddenly that Cactling walked into the back of his leg.

They were standing on a high black cliff. Below them, all the way to the horizon, stretched the Molten Frontier.

Rivers of lava came pouring down the mountains. Not one or two rivers, but dozens of them, glowing orange and gold and red, twisting down the black rock like ribbons of melted sunset. Where they reached the bottom, they spilled into a sea. And the sea was not gray, or blue, or green. It was the brightest turquoise Rook had ever seen, so bright it almost glowed, like someone had poured a whole jar of crushed gemstones into the water.

And where the lava met the sea, it hissed. Huge clouds of white steam billowed up, thick and soft, rolling across the water like cotton. Inside the steam, Rook could see little islands floating. Round, green, fat little islands, each with a few palm trees leaning over like they were sleepy, and each one covered in big bright red

flowers.

Above it all, the sky was a smoky, glowing pink.

"Whoa," Rook whispered.

"Bip," Zib whispered.

Plazmo didn't whisper anything at all. He just went brighter and brighter, until he was glowing like a little sun, his sparks spinning so fast they whistled. Rook had never seen him so happy. It was as if, after spending his whole life in a desert, he had finally walked into a room full of his cousins.

It was hot here. Much hotter than Dustmere. The air shimmered. Rook's cap was sticking to his forehead within about a minute. Cactling, who came from the desert and loved the heat, closed its one green eye and turned its flower up to the pink sky, petals spread wide, like it was sunbathing.

But inside the satchel, Sporix had gone very quiet.

Rook didn't notice right away. He was too busy staring. He was too busy following a rough path of black stone steps down the cliff, toward the turquoise water, toward the nearest island. It was only when they reached the bottom, and he heard a tiny, raspy little cough, that he looked down.

Sporix had poked its head out of the bag. But something was wrong. Its cap, which had been bright red, had faded to a dull, dusty pink. The white spots had gone gray. Its cream-colored body was dry and wrinkly at the edges, like a leaf at the end of summer. And it was panting, very fast and very shallow.

"Sporix!" Rook dropped to his knees. "What's wrong? What happened?"

Sporix tried to answer. All that came out was a tiny puff of dry dust.

"It's the heat," Rook breathed. "You're Bio-type. You need water and shade, and it's like an oven here, and you've been in that bag all day." He looked around wildly. Lava. Black rock. Steam. Nothing that looked like shade, nothing that looked like help.

Then Zib shot straight up into the air, higher than Rook had ever seen him fly, and spun around, his huge eye searching. He stopped. His lights flashed blue, then blue, then blue again. He zoomed back down and flew in a tight circle around Rook's head, then shot off toward the water, then shot back.

"You found something?"

"BIP!"

Rook followed. On the nearest island, half hidden by palm trees and red flowers, stood a little round hut. It was white, and it had a round door, and over the door hung a sign with a glowing blue cross.

A Recovery Bay.

Between the shore and the island ran a path of flat stepping stones, each one just above the water, warm and wet. Rook ran across them, hopping from stone to stone, holding the satchel against his chest like a football. Plazmo flew ahead, lighting the way through the steam. Cactling leaped from stone to stone behind him, grumbling with every jump, but keeping up.

Rook burst through the round door.

* * *

The inside of the hut was cool and dim and smelled like seawater and lemons. Shells hung from the ceiling on strings, clinking softly. A fan made of woven palm leaves turned slowly overhead. And standing at a long table, sorting little bottles of medicine, was a woman with dark curly hair piled high on her head. Tucked into

her curls were seashells. Dozens of them, white and pink and spiraled, as if her hair were a beach.

She looked up. She took one look at Rook, red-faced and panting. She took one look at the little wilted puffball in his arms.

She didn't ask a single question. She just held out her hands.

"Give him here, love," she said. "Quick now."

Rook gave her Sporix. She laid it in a big open seashell lined with damp moss, poured a little cup of cool water over its cap, and slid the whole shell into a machine against the wall. It looked a lot like the one in Dustmere, a huge glass shell, but this one was green-tinted and dripping with little beads of water, like a window after rain. She pressed a button. The machine hummed. It began to glow soft gold.

Rook stood beside it and didn't breathe.

Inside the glow, Sporix lay very still. Then its cap twitched. Then, slowly, so slowly, the color began to come back into it. First a little pink. Then a little brighter. Then red. The spots went white again. The wrinkles smoothed out. Sporix opened its eyes, blinked, and let out a long, happy sigh that puffed out a little cloud of shiny, healthy spores.

Rook's knees went wobbly. He sat down on the floor right where he was.

"There now," said the nurse, crouching down beside him and patting his shoulder. "There now. He'll be just fine. Bio-types and the Frontier don't mix, I'm afraid. Too hot, too dry. You did right, bringing him straight here." She smiled. She had a lovely smile, with crinkles at the corners of her eyes. "I'm Nurse Coral. And who might you—"

She stopped.

She was looking at his satchel strap. At the little brass cross pinned over his heart, with the tiny bird in the middle, worn soft and smooth.

Nurse Coral's hand went to her mouth.

"That's Nana Wren's badge," she whispered.

Rook blinked. "You knew my Nana?"

"Knew her? Oh, sweetheart." Nurse Coral laughed, and her eyes went wet and shiny. "I was her apprentice. When I was your age, I followed her around that Recovery Bay in Dustmere like a little duckling. Every bandage I ever wrapped, she taught me how." She reached out and touched the badge very gently with one finger. "Recovery Bay, Number One. She never took it off. Not once, not in all the years I knew her."

"My mom gave it to me," said Rook. "Yesterday. Before I left."

"Then you must be Rook." Nurse Coral looked at him properly, up and down, from his cap to his boots. "She used to talk about you, you know. Her grandbaby. She said you had the loudest laugh in the whole canyon." She smiled. "I can see she was right."

Rook didn't know what to say. He had been very small when Nana Wren died. He remembered her a little. He remembered warm hands, and the smell of peppermint, and somebody singing him to sleep. He remembered a laugh. But he didn't remember her talking about him.

It made his chest feel tight and full, like a balloon.

* * *

While Sporix rested, Nurse Coral checked over the rest of the team. She gave Plazmo a thorough look-over and announced that he was the healthiest Plasma-type she had seen in years, at which Plazmo puffed up so proudly that he set a corner of her paper towels on fire. She put it out with a squirt bottle without even

looking up, like this happened every day. (It probably did, on the Molten Frontier.)

She tried to check Cactling. Cactling folded its arms and refused.

"Fair enough," said Nurse Coral. "Most Cactlings are shy little things. You're not shy, though, are you? You're proud." She leaned down and whispered, loud enough for Cactling to hear: "Your flower's a bit crooked, though."

Cactling clapped both stubby hands over its flower, went pink in the cheeks, and stomped off to sulk in the corner. After a minute, Rook saw it secretly checking its reflection in a shiny bottle and trying to straighten its flower.

Then Nurse Coral looked at Zib.

She looked at him for a long time. Zib looked back, his lights blinking a curious blue.

"Well," she said finally. "I've never seen one of you before. And I've seen a lot of Alienmon." She tilted her head, and the shells in her hair clinked. "Though you do remind me of something. Can't think what."

"Bip?"

"Never mind, little one. Old memories. Come on, all of you. Tea."

She made them tea in tiny cups shaped like shells. Rook's was sweet and tasted like honey and oranges. Plazmo heated his own cup by sitting on it. Zib flew around the teapot in circles, fascinated by the steam. And Sporix, now bright red and puffy and perfectly healthy, came out of the healing machine and sat on the table in a little wet patch of moss, carefully not looking at Plazmo.

"Tell me about her," Rook said. "Nana Wren. Please. Mom doesn't talk about her much. I think it makes her sad."

Nurse Coral smiled. She sat back in her chair and wrapped both hands around her cup.

"Your Nana," she said, "was the bravest person I ever knew. And she wasn't brave the loud way. She wasn't brave the way people in stories are brave, charging into battle, waving swords. She was brave the quiet way. The staying-up-all-night way." She took a sip of tea. "Did you know she healed the very first Alienmon that ever fell from the sky?"

Rook shook his head. He was holding his cup so tightly his fingers had gone white.

"Twenty years ago, on the night of the Starfall, everyone was outside looking up. But your Nana was inside the Recovery Bay. And just before dawn, somebody brought her a creature. It had come down hard, they said, not soft like the others. It was hurt. Its light was flickering. And it was scared. Oh, it was so scared. It didn't know where it was or what we were or why everything was so strange."

Outside, the steam rolled over the turquoise water. Somewhere a seabird cried.

"Nobody knew what it was. Nobody knew what it ate, or how to help it, or whether it could be helped at all. Doctors came and looked and shook their heads and went home. But your Nana didn't go home." Nurse Coral's voice went soft. "She sat up with it for three nights. Three whole nights. She held it, and she talked to it, and she sang to it, and she never once let it be alone. And on the fourth morning, its light came back on."

Rook's throat ached.

"What kind was it?" he whispered. "The first one?"

"That's the funny thing," said Nurse Coral. "She never told me. Never told anybody, I think. She wrote it all down, every bit, in a

little blue notebook. But she kept that notebook locked away on that funny old starship of hers."

"Starship?" Rook nearly dropped his cup. "Nana Wren had a STARSHIP?"

"Didn't you know? Oh, she loved that ship. Little round thing, cream and pink, like a cake. She used to fly it all over the system, visiting sick Alienmon on worlds where there were no nurses." Nurse Coral frowned, thinking. "I don't know what became of it after she passed. Somebody's keeping it, I suppose. Somewhere."

Rook's head was spinning. His Nana. His little old Nana with the peppermints and the singing. She had flown a starship.

He looked across the table at Sporix, curled up shyly in its patch of moss, its cap pulled half down, eyes peeking out at the world as if it expected the world to be disappointed in it.

"Sounds like she never gave up on anybody," Rook said quietly.

Nurse Coral followed his gaze. She smiled a small, knowing smile.

"Never," she said. "Not once."

* * *

That night, Nurse Coral let them sleep on the porch of the hut, in hammocks woven from palm fronds, swinging gently in the warm breeze.

Rook couldn't sleep. He lay in his hammock and listened to the hiss of lava meeting the sea, and watched the steam glow orange and pink in the dark. Plazmo was curled up on his stomach. Zib was asleep on the hammock rope, his lights dimmed to a soft, slow blink. Cactling was snoring in a flowerpot.

And Sporix was sitting at the very edge of the porch, alone, looking out at the water.

Rook slid out of his hammock and went and sat beside it. He didn't say anything for a while. Neither did Sporix.

"I'm sorry," Rook said at last. "That nobody looked at you. That day in the Observatory. I should have. I was just so excited. But that's not a good reason."

Sporix's cap tipped a little toward him.

"You don't have to be my partner," Rook went on. "I don't think that's why you came. I think... I think maybe you just didn't want to be left behind. Is that right?"

A very small nod.

"Then you're not left behind. You can come with us. As long as you want. And someday, maybe you'll find the right person. Somebody who looks at you first." He grinned. "And if they don't, Cactling will throw needles at them until they do."

From the flowerpot came a sleepy, grumpy snort that sounded like agreement.

Sporix looked up at Rook. Then, very slowly, it leaned its soft little body against his arm. It was cool and a little damp from the moss. It stayed there.

They sat together and watched the steam.

That was when Rook noticed the compass.

DX-4's little frequency compass was hanging on a string around his neck, where he'd tied it before bed. And the needle, which should have been pointing at Zib, asleep on the hammock rope behind them, wasn't pointing at Zib at all.

It was pointing up. Up at the ridge high above the island, where the black cliffs met the pink sky.

Rook squinted. Up on the ridge, against the glow, he could just make out a shape. A huge round shape, like a giant stone ring standing on its edge.

And as he watched, one tiny mark on the edge of that ring flickered blue.

Just once. Just for a second.

Like something waking up.

Chapter 7

The Gate That Woke

In the morning, Nurse Coral packed them a basket of fruit, filled Rook's water bottle with cool tea, and gave Sporix a present.

It was a tiny glass bottle with a squeezy rubber bulb on top, the kind you might use to spray houseplants. It was full of water that smelled like rain.

"Mist bottle," she said, hanging it around Sporix's middle on a loop of string, like a little backpack. "One squirt on the cap whenever it starts going pink. It'll keep you fresh as a fern, even in this heat."

Sporix gave itself a squirt immediately, just to try it. It shivered happily and puffed out a little cloud of sparkly spores.

Then Nurse Coral hugged Rook. She smelled like lemons and the sea.

"Your Nana would be so proud," she said into his hair. "Now go on. And mind that ridge. The miners up there have been grumpy for weeks."

"Why?"

She pulled back and gave him a funny look. "Because the gate's been humming. And nobody likes a gate that hums."

* * *

The path up the ridge was steep and black and hot, with little rivers of lava trickling down on either side like the mountain was sweating. Plazmo loved it. He kept zooming off to float over the

lava streams and warm his hands, if he had had hands. Cactling marched straight up the middle of the path without stopping once. Zib rode on Rook's cap, his lights turning a cautious yellow every time they passed a bubbling crack in the rock.

Sporix rode in the satchel, with its head poking out of the top and the mist bottle in easy reach. Every few minutes Rook heard a tiny *pssht*, followed by a happy little sigh.

Halfway up, they started passing signs. They were painted on old wooden boards and stuck into the rock with iron spikes.

FORGE MINING CAMP. AUTHORIZED MINERS ONLY.

NO BATTLING NEAR THE LAVA. YES, THIS MEANS YOU.

IF YOU CAN READ THIS SIGN, YOU ARE TOO CLOSE TO THE EDGE.

Rook stepped back from the edge.

At the top, the ridge flattened out into a wide, rocky shelf, and on it sat the Forge Mining Camp. It was a cluster of sturdy little huts made from black stone, with tin roofs and smoking chimneys. Rail tracks ran everywhere, carrying little carts full of glittering rock. There was a clanging of hammers, and a hissing of steam, and somewhere, somebody was singing a work song very badly. Miners in thick leather aprons and helmets with lamps on the front were pushing carts and swinging picks and yelling at each other in friendly ways. And riding on their shoulders, or trundling along beside them, were their Alienmon. Most of them looked like rocks. Big rocks, small rocks, rocks with legs, rocks with faces, one rock with what appeared to be a mustache.

And there, at the very far end of the shelf, on the edge of the cliff, stood the stone ring.

It was enormous. Much bigger than it had looked from the island. It stood on its edge like a giant wheel, taller than a house,

taller than two houses, made of the same pale stone as the old bridge in Dustmere. Every inch of it was carved with those same swirling marks. Through the middle of the ring, Rook could see nothing at all but pink sky.

Around the base of it, someone had built scaffolding. Wooden poles and planks and ladders, all tied together with rope, climbing halfway up the ring. Lanterns hung from the poles. Tools were scattered everywhere.

And right in front of it, sitting on an overturned mine cart with his arms folded, was the biggest man Rook had ever seen.

He had a chest like a barrel and a beard like a bush and a miner's helmet with a lamp on the front, and the lamp was pointing straight at Rook. Beside him sat an Alienmon that looked like a boulder had grown legs and decided it was angry about it. It was gray and lumpy and huge, with two little red eyes deep in the rock, and every time it breathed, gravel trickled off its shoulders.

"Name's Forge Miner Dax," the big man rumbled. "This is Rumbler. And nobody gets near the Forge Gate without beating me first."

Rumbler went *GRRRRRUMMMMMM*, which sounded like a rockslide clearing its throat.

Rook looked up at the giant stone ring. "What's a Forge Gate?"

"It's a big old rock that doesn't do anything," said a voice from behind it.

There was a clatter of tools. A grunt. A bump. A muffled "ow." And then a kid came wriggling out from underneath a stone box at the base of the ring, feet first, on their back, the way a mechanic slides out from under a cart.

They sat up. They were about Rook's age, maybe a little younger, and quite a bit smaller. They had short, messy brown

hair and a big smudge of black oil across their nose. A pair of round brass goggles sat pushed up on their forehead, with about six different colored lenses that could flip down. They wore overalls with the knees patched three times. And around their waist was a toolbelt.

It was the biggest toolbelt Rook had ever seen. It went around them almost twice. It had wrenches and screwdrivers and pliers, a little hammer and a big hammer, rolls of wire, a flashlight, a magnifying glass, a tiny welding torch, a jar of screws, and what looked like half a sandwich in a pocket marked EMERGENCY.

The kid looked at Rook. Then at Plazmo. Then at Cactling. Then their eyes went up, and up, and landed on Zib, sitting on Rook's cap. They stopped.

"Huh," they said. "What's that?"

"This is Zib," said Rook. "I'm Rook."

"Kit," said the kid. "Kit Briggs." They wiped their hand on their overalls, which made it dirtier, and then held it out. Rook shook it anyway. It was rough and warm and covered in little burn marks, like someone who touched hot things on purpose. "I've been trying to fix this console for three weeks." They jerked their thumb at the stone box. "It's dead. Totally, completely dead."

"Kid's been under there every day," said Dax, and he didn't sound annoyed. He sounded a little impressed. "Came in on a cargo freighter from off-world. Walked straight up this ridge with a toolbox and said, 'I'm going to fix your gate.' Hasn't left since."

"Because it's *interesting,*" said Kit. "Look at it! Nobody knows who built it. Nobody knows how it works. There's a panel full of crystal circuits under there that's older than anything I've ever seen, and it's all connected, every bit of it, like it's waiting for something." They kicked the stone box, not hard. "It just won't tell

me what."

"Where are you from?" Rook asked.

Kit's face did something funny. It closed, a little, like a door.

"Nowhere," they said. "A scrap world. Doesn't matter."

* * *

Zib, meanwhile, had gotten bored with the talking.

He lifted off Rook's cap and drifted toward the great stone ring, curious, the way he drifted toward anything shiny or new. His lights blinked a soft, interested blue. He floated past the scaffolding. Past the lanterns. And then, without seeming to think about it, he floated right in front of the ring itself, just about level with the bottom of the circle.

The nearest carved mark lit up blue.

Everybody stopped talking.

Then the next mark lit up. And the next. And the next. One after another, faster and faster, the swirling carvings began to glow, racing up the side of the ring, curving around the top, racing down the other side, until the whole enormous circle was blazing with bright, electric blue light. Exactly like the bridge back home.

The ground began to rumble. Little stones danced on the rock. The scaffolding creaked. All across the mining camp, miners dropped their picks and turned around and stared. One of the rock Alienmon fell over in surprise.

And from deep inside the stone box, the dead console, came a sound like a hundred tiny bells.

Kit's mouth fell open. Their goggles slid down off their forehead and landed on their nose, crooked.

"...Okay," they said faintly. "It's not totally dead."

"Bip!" said Zib, delighted, spinning in a little circle in front of the glowing ring.

Kit dove back under the console so fast they banged their head on the way. "OW. Okay. Okay okay okay." Their voice came out muffled. "The crystals are lighting up! All of them! It's routing power everywhere, it's—Rook! Come look at this! Hurry!"

Rook got down on his stomach and wriggled under the console next to Kit. It was dark and close in there, and it smelled like dust and oil. Above their heads, set into the stone, were rows and rows of tiny crystals, like teeth, all glowing blue now. And carved into the middle of it all, glowing brightest, was a picture.

It was a circle. And around the circle, evenly spaced, were eight smaller circles. Lines ran between them, joining them all together, like the spokes of a wheel, or the points of a star.

"Eight," Kit breathed. "Eight of something. All hooked together." They pulled out a stubby pencil and started copying the drawing onto their arm, since they didn't have any paper. "This gate's not just a gate. It's part of something bigger. Way bigger."

Rook stared up at the eight glowing circles. Something tickled at the back of his brain. Something about a big map on a table, and eight tiny lights.

He was just opening his mouth to say so when, above them, something went *CRACK*.

* * *

It was one of the scaffolding beams.

All that rumbling had shaken it loose. It was a big, heavy iron beam, long as a canoe, and it had been holding up a whole platform of planks and toolboxes. Now one end of it had snapped right off its rope. It swung down, out, and then the other rope went *SNAP* too.

Kit had just wriggled back out from under the console. They were sitting up, looking at the drawing on their arm.

The beam came down. Straight at them.

"KIT!" Rook yelled.

Kit looked up. Their eyes went wide behind the crooked goggles. They didn't move. There wasn't time to move.

And then something small and round shot out of Rook's satchel like a cork out of a bottle.

It was Sporix.

It landed right next to Kit. It planted its tiny feet. It squeezed its whole body tight, so tight it went perfectly round, and its mushroom cap swelled up, bigger and bigger, until it was twice the size it should have been. And then Sporix let go.

FWOOOOMPH.

A huge cloud of spores burst out of every white spot on its cap at once. Not dry, dusty spores. These were thick and fluffy and golden, and they clumped together in the air like whipped cream, like a giant soft pillow, right above Kit's head.

The beam hit the pillow of spores.

It didn't stop. But it slowed. It sank into the golden cloud the way a spoon sinks into pudding, slower, and slower, and slower. And by the time it finally pushed all the way through, Kit had rolled out of the way, and the beam landed on the rock where they had been sitting with a heavy, harmless *thunk*.

Golden spores drifted down over everything like snow.

For a moment, the whole ridge was silent.

Kit sat in the dust, breathing hard, with golden spores all over their hair and their goggles and their oily nose. They stared at the beam. Then they stared at the tiny puffball standing between them and where the beam had landed. Sporix was panting. Its cap had shrunk back down to its normal size. It was shaking all over, little spore-puffs coming out with every shiver.

But it had not run away.

Kit stared at Sporix. Sporix stared back.

Then Sporix did something that surprised everyone. It turned around, toddled over on its little feet, and climbed right up into Kit's lap. It turned around twice, like a puppy getting comfy. Then it sat down, and pushed its cap up so it could see Kit's face, and looked up at them with its big shy eyes.

Kit didn't move. Kit didn't seem to be breathing.

"It..." Kit's voice came out cracked and small. "It picked me?"

Sporix leaned its soft little head against Kit's overalls.

"Nobody's ever picked me first," Kit whispered. "Not for anything. Not for teams. Not for anything." They blinked hard behind the goggles. "I'm always the one standing at the end of the line. Holding a wrench."

Rook knelt down beside them. He looked at Sporix, curled up in Kit's lap, its cap pushed up, not hiding at all for the first time since he had met it. Not one little bit.

He felt a lump in his throat. But it was a good lump.

"Looks like it waited for the right person," he said.

Kit looked at him. Then they looked down at Sporix. Then, slowly, they reached into the toolbelt, past the wrenches and screwdrivers, and took out something wrapped in a rag. They unwrapped it. It was a Linker, or at least something trying very hard to be a Linker. It was made of mismatched brass and copper and a bit of an old clock, held together with wire and tape. Its screen was cracked down the middle.

"Built it myself," Kit mumbled. "Out of junk. Never used it. Never had anybody to use it on." They looked at Sporix. "Do you... want to? You don't have to."

Sporix's cap went *poof* with a little cloud of happy sparkles.

Kit pressed the button. A slightly wobbly cyan beam sputtered out of the homemade Linker, wrapped around Sporix, and turned it into a swirl of glittering dust. The dust spiraled up and poured into the cracked lens with a tinkling sound like wind chimes and one slightly worrying *clunk*.

The cracked screen flickered. A picture of Sporix appeared on it, sideways.

SPORIX. PARTNER CONFIRMED.

Kit let out a breath that seemed to have been waiting there for about a hundred years. Then they let Sporix back out again immediately, as if they couldn't stand for it to be anywhere they couldn't see it, and Sporix popped out right back into Kit's lap.

"Bip-bip-BIIIIP!" Zib zoomed in circles over their heads, flashing every color.

Cactling, standing nearby, watched all of this with its arms folded. Then it gave one short, approving nod, as if to say: *About time somebody noticed.*

* * *

The miners had gathered around now, muttering and pointing at the glowing gate. Forge Miner Dax pushed through them and stood in front of Rook with his hands on his hips.

"Well," he said. "Looks like your little saucer woke up my gate." He scratched his bushy beard. "My granddad used to say these gates were here before the first settlers ever came to the Frontier. Said they were built to keep something out." He paused. "Or keep something in. Never could remember which."

Rook felt that shiver again, the one he'd felt at the Bonfire.

"Can we go through it?"

Dax grinned. Under the bush of his beard, he had a gap in his teeth. "Rules are rules, kid. Nobody gets near the Forge Gate

without beating me first." He jerked his thumb at the huge gray boulder beside him. "Rumbler. Let's see what this one's made of."

Rumbler stomped forward. The ground shook with every step. *Thoom. Thoom. Thoom.* It was so big it blocked out the sun, and its shadow fell over Rook and Plazmo both.

"Rook," said Kit nervously. "That thing's a Magma-type. Rock and lava. Fire just makes it angrier."

Rook looked up at Rumbler. He thought about Sola, and the Bubble Waves, and Plazmo lying in the mud. He thought about the pebbles and the socks under the double moons.

He took a deep breath.

Think first. Then act.

"Plazmo," he said. Not shouting. Just calm. "Don't attack yet. Just dodge."

Rumbler swung one huge stony arm. Plazmo bobbed to the side. The arm hit the ground, *KRASH*, and sent up a cloud of dust.

"Dodge."

Rumbler stomped. Plazmo hopped up and over. The ground cracked where its foot came down, a long jagged crack.

"Dodge."

Rumbler swung again, and again, and again. Plazmo dipped and zipped and twirled, just like he had through the flying socks. And Rook watched. Rumbler was strong. Really strong. But it was slow. Every swing took a long time to wind up. Every stomp left it wobbling. And every time it stomped, it had to stand on one leg for just a second, and its legs... its legs were short and stumpy and holding up an awful lot of rock.

Then Rumbler stopped swinging.

It dug both stony hands into the crack it had made and ripped up a slab of the ridge as big as a kitchen table.

"Oh no," Kit breathed.

Rumbler threw it.

Plazmo dodged the slab. He did. But it hit the rock behind him and burst, *KA-BOOOM*, into a hundred flying chunks, and one of them, a chunk the size of a loaf of bread, caught Plazmo square in the middle.

WHAM.

Plazmo shot backward like a ball off a bat. He smacked into the base of the scaffolding so hard the whole thing swayed and groaned, and he dropped onto the rock in a puff of dust.

And his fire went low.

Not out. But low and flat and flickering, like a match in the wind. He lay there in the dust, a little orange glow no bigger than Rook's thumb, and his sparks weren't spinning at all.

"PLAZMO!"

Rumbler went *GRRRRRUMMMMMM* and started toward him. Slowly. It didn't need to hurry.

"Rook," said Kit, very fast and very high. "He's hurt. *Call him back.*"

Rook's hand was already on the Linker. He had told Plazmo to *wait*, and Plazmo had waited, and now he was lying in the dirt because of it. Maybe waiting was just a slower way to lose.

One button. That was all it would take.

Plazmo lifted himself off the rock.

He wobbled. A few sparks fell off him and fizzled out. But he rose up, inch by inch, and turned his one small eye toward Rook.

It wasn't asking to come back. It was asking, *Are we still doing the plan?*

Rook took his hand off the Linker.

"Yeah," he whispered. Then louder, so Plazmo could hear it: "Yeah. We're still doing the plan."

He made himself look again. Not at Plazmo. At everything. At Rumbler's stumpy legs. At the dust. At the long jagged crack running across the shelf, and the spiderweb of little cracks around it where Rumbler had been stomping and stomping and stomping the whole time. The rock there wasn't solid anymore. It was like a cookie that had been stepped on: still in one piece, but only just.

Rumbler had been breaking its own floor.

Rook's mouth went dry. Because the only way to use it was to get Rumbler to stomp right there, right on the cracks. And the only way to get Rumbler to stomp there was to put Plazmo right underneath its foot.

"Plazmo," he said, and his voice wobbled, and he let it. "Go stand on the crack. Right in the middle. Make it want to squash you. And don't move until I say. No matter how close it gets. Can you do that?"

Plazmo floated out over the spiderweb of cracks. He hung there, small and flickering, right in Rumbler's path. And he blew a tiny, rude raspberry of sparks at it.

Rumbler roared. *THOOM.* The cracks spread. Rumbler reared up and lifted one enormous foot high over Plazmo's head, and the little glow underneath it didn't move, didn't move, didn't move...

Rumbler was puffing now. Gravel was pouring off its shoulders with every breath. Its one standing leg trembled under all that rock.

"NOW, Plazmo! Spark Burst! At its feet!"

Plazmo gathered every bit of fire he had left into one bright ball and flung it, not at Rumbler's big rocky chest, but straight down at the ground under its one standing foot. The Spark Burst

hit the cracked rock with a *BANG* and a bright flash, and the ground under Rumbler's foot cracked and crumbled. The big rock wobbled. It windmilled its stony arms. Its raised foot came down anyway, *WHOOSH*, right where Plazmo had been, and Rook screamed his name, and a little smoking spark shot out sideways from under the heel just in time. Rumbler tipped, and tipped, and tipped.

THOOOOOM.

The whole ridge jumped. Dust went up in a great gray cloud.

When the dust cleared, Rumbler was sitting down hard on its bottom. It blinked its little red eyes. Then it lay back on the rock, spread out its arms, and refused to get up.

Rook was already running. He found Plazmo in the settling dust beside Rumbler's heel, a little glow lying on the cracked rock, and scooped him up in both hands.

He was so dim, his warmth coming and going in Rook's palms in little weak pulses. But Plazmo's eye opened, and looked up at him, and his flame curled itself around Rook's thumb and held on.

Rook's eyes stung. He held Plazmo up against his chest. "You stayed," he whispered. "You stayed right under it. I'm sorry I almost..." He couldn't finish. Plazmo nudged his chin, warm and stubborn, as if to say *I know. I saw. You didn't.*

The miners went quiet. Then one of them started clapping. Then they all were, whooping and banging their helmets with their hammers.

Dax stared at his Alienmon for a long moment. He knocked twice on Rumbler's rocky belly, gently, and Rumbler let out a long, gravelly sigh. Then Dax threw back his head and laughed, a big booming laugh that echoed off the cliffs.

"Fair and square, kid!" He clapped Rook on the back so hard that Rook stumbled forward three steps, holding Plazmo tight. "Fair and square! Didn't even rush it. Most young trainers come up here swinging. You waited." He nodded at the little flicker in Rook's hands, and his big voice went gruff. "And that one waited right along with you. Under Rumbler's foot. Never seen anything do that." He stepped aside, and swept his huge arm toward the great glowing ring. "The Forge Gate's yours."

Rook turned toward it.

The blue lights on the ring had started to move. They were swirling now, around and around the inside of the circle, faster and faster, like water going down a drain. In the middle, the pink sky wobbled. It rippled. And then, with a sound like a deep breath being let out, it vanished. In its place hung a shimmering doorway of blue light, like the surface of a pool seen from underneath.

And through it, wobbly and strange, Rook could see a whole different world. Orange sky. Tall dark shapes. The glint of metal.

He heard a clang. A long, far-off whistle, like a train.

Beside him, Kit had gone very still. They were staring through the doorway with an expression Rook couldn't read at all.

"Kit?" he said. "What's wrong? Do you know where that goes?"

Kit swallowed.

"Yeah," they said quietly. "I know exactly where it goes."

They pulled their goggles down over their eyes, as if they didn't want anybody to see them.

"It goes home."

Chapter 8

The Iron Orphans

Stepping through the Forge Gate felt like jumping into a cold swimming pool, except you didn't get wet.

There was a *whoosh* in Rook's ears. A tingle all over his skin, like pins and needles. A flash of blue so bright he saw spots. His stomach did a flip, then another flip, then a sort of cartwheel. And then his boots hit solid ground with a *clang*, and he stumbled forward three steps and sat down hard on something cold and bumpy.

He opened his eyes.

He was sitting on a pile of bolts.

"Bip," said Zib dizzily, from somewhere near his ear. He had come through upside down and was still spinning slowly, like a coin on a table.

Rook looked up. And up. And up.

Ferrox was a world made of metal.

The ground was metal: old plates and panels riveted together, scratched and dented and patched, stretching off in every direction. The hills were metal: huge heaps of scrap, rusted pipes and twisted girders and broken wheels and bent gears, piled higher than mountains, so high their tops disappeared into the haze. Long iron train tracks wound between the heaps, twisting and looping over each other like spaghetti, and somewhere far off, a train whistle wailed. Huge cranes swung slowly through the sky, each one dangling a crate on a chain. Every so often one of them

would drop a crate onto a heap with a *CLAAAANG* that echoed for miles.

The sky was orange. Not sunset orange. Furnace orange, smoky and hot, with dark clouds drifting through it. Everything smelled like oil and sparks and hot metal, like the inside of a garage on a summer day.

And everywhere, everywhere, there were Alienmon. Little metal birds with wings made of tin flapped between the cranes, cheeping like squeaky hinges. Something round and copper-colored rolled past on a single wheel, beeping to itself. On top of the nearest scrap heap, a big Alienmon that looked like a rusty armadillo was curled up asleep in the sun, snoring with a sound like a slow saw.

Kit came through the gate last. They landed neatly on their feet, the way someone does when they've done something a hundred times. Sporix clung to the front of their overalls like a baby koala. Kit looked around at the heaps and the tracks and the orange sky, and let out a long, long sigh.

"Home sweet home," they said.

It was not the way most people say *home sweet home*.

* * *

They walked along the tracks toward a smudge of chimneys on the horizon, and Kit explained things, because explaining things seemed to make Kit feel better.

"Twenty years ago, during the Starfall, more seeds fell on Ferrox than anywhere else," Kit said, stepping over a rail. "Thousands of them. Big ones. And when the Alienmon hatched out, the shells were left behind. Huge shells, harder than steel. So people started building with them." They knocked on a curved wall of a nearby shed. It rang like a bell. "This whole world's built

out of star-seed shells. The houses. The towers. Half the trains. Pretty much everything."

Rook ran his hand along the shed wall. It was smooth and faintly warm, and when he looked closely, he could see a soft, pearly shimmer under the rust. Just like Zib.

"And the Keeper here," Kit added, a little quieter, "is Hank Briggs."

Rook stopped walking. "Wait. Briggs? Like you?"

"He's my dad."

"Your DAD is a KEEPER?" Rook's voice went up so high that a tin bird on a crane above them squawked and flapped away. "Kit! That's amazing! The Ferrox Keeper! He's on the trading cards! The Iron Wall! Kids in Dustmere fight over his card!"

"Yeah," Kit mumbled. "I know."

"They say he's the toughest battler in the whole Kessler system! They say he once battled for nine hours straight and didn't even sit down! They say he can lift a train car with one hand!"

"Two hands," said Kit. "It was two hands. And it was a small train car." They kicked a loose bolt. It went skittering off down the track. "It's awesome. Really awesome."

Rook looked at Kit. Kit didn't look like it was awesome. Kit looked the way Rook felt when somebody at school asked him what his dad did, and he had to say that his dad had gone away when he was little, and then everybody went quiet and looked at their shoes.

It wasn't the same thing. But it was the same sort of face.

Rook decided not to ask any more questions. Instead, he said, "Want a cactus-berry cookie? Oh. Wait. Sporix ate them all."

Sporix pulled its cap down over its eyes.

Kit laughed. It was a small laugh, but it was a real one.

* * *

The tracks led them onto a long, winding road called the Scrap Route. It ran right between the biggest scrap heaps, so tall on both sides that it felt like walking along the bottom of a metal canyon. Every so often a heap would shift and groan, and a little avalanche of nuts and bolts would come tinkling down.

They had been walking for about an hour when they heard the sound.

It was small. So small that at first Rook thought it was the wind whistling through a pipe. A thin, wobbly, whimpering sound. *Mew. Mew. Meeew.*

Plazmo heard it too. He stopped dead in the air, his sparks going still.

"Bip?" Zib's lights went soft and worried.

The sound was coming from behind a tangle of old pipes at the base of the nearest heap. Rook got down on his hands and knees. Kit got down beside him. Very carefully, they moved one pipe, and then another, and then a big bent sheet of tin.

Underneath, huddled together in a little hollow, was a whole family of Alienmon.

There were five of them. Four were small and round and shaped like gears, with little stubby teeth around their edges and one big blinking eye each, set right in the middle where the hole in a gear would be. They were huddled in a pile, all pressed together, their teeth interlocked as if they were holding hands. They should have been shiny. Rook could tell they should have been shiny. But they were brown and orange and crusty all over with rust, and their eyes were dull and scared.

"Cogglets," Kit whispered. "Alloy-types. They're supposed to be bright silver. These guys have been out here for ages."

The fifth Alienmon was different. It was a little bigger than the Cogglets: a fat little slug wearing a riveted shell of rusty metal, like a tiny dented tin can on its back. Two long eyestalks poked out of the front, each with a round green eye on the tip, and behind it on the metal ground ran a thin trail of glowing lime-green slime. It was sitting in front of the others, as if it were guarding them. And it was trembling so hard that it rattled.

When it saw Rook and Kit, it stretched its eyestalks up as tall as they would go to look as big as it could, and made a tiny, brave, squeaky growl.

"It's okay," Rook said softly. "We're not going to hurt you."

The little rust slug growled again. But its eyestalks were shaking.

Kit wasn't looking at the Alienmon anymore. Kit was looking at something behind them. Half buried in the scrap was an old wooden crate, splintered and broken. Kit reached in and pulled it out, and wiped the dirt off one side with their sleeve.

Stamped on the side, in faded orange paint, was a ring with a diagonal slash through it.

HELIX DIRECTIVE. FIELD TRIAL. PHASE ONE. DISPOSE AFTER USE.

Kit read it out loud. Then they read it again, very quietly, to themselves.

"Helix test crews," they said. Their voice had gone hard and flat, in a way Rook hadn't heard before. "They came through a few years ago. Said they were studying Alienmon. Doing *important research*. Everybody thought it was great." Kit turned the crate around. Inside were scraps of old wire, a broken clipboard, and a

tangle of something that looked like a tiny harness. "They used these guys for experiments. And then when they were done, they just..." Kit's hands tightened on the crate. "They just left them here. Like garbage."

Dispose after use.

Rook stared at the little rusty Cogglets with their interlocked teeth. He thought of the *static net crackling around Plazmo in the dark tunnel. He thought of Pell's calm voice saying Zib was priority number one, as if Zib were something to be stamped and packed in a crat*e.

A cold, heavy feeling settled in his stomach and stayed there.

"Well," he said, and his voice came out louder than he meant it to. "Well, they're not garbage. And they're not going to stay here."

Kit looked at him.

"We'll find them homes," said Rook. "Real homes. Every single one."

* * *

It took them the whole afternoon.

First, they had to get the Alienmon to trust them, which took a long time and most of the fruit from Nurse Coral's basket. The Cogglets liked the oranges best. They rolled the slices around between their teeth like they were tasting them all over. The little slug wouldn't touch the fruit at all. It waited until all four Cogglets had eaten first. Then it nibbled one flake of rust off a pipe, very slowly, without taking its eyes off Rook.

Then they had to clean them up a bit. Kit had a rag and a little can of oil on the toolbelt, and they worked on the Cogglets one by one, rubbing the worst of the rust off their teeth so they could turn properly, oiling the stiff places until they could roll again. It was careful, fiddly work. Kit's fingers were quick and gentle. They

talked to each Cogglet the whole time, in a low, calm, mumbly voice. "Easy, buddy. There we go. Little bit stuck there. Little bit more. There." Rook watched and realized that this was what Kit sounded like when they were fixing a machine, and that it was exactly how Nurse Coral had sounded fixing Sporix.

Then they set off along the Scrap Route, with four Cogglets rolling along behind them in a wobbly line and the little rust slug riding on top of Cactling's head, because it was very, very slow, which Cactling permitted with an expression of enormous patience.

The first Cogglet went to a kind old train driver named Mr. Oduya, who had a white mustache and a cap with a shiny badge and an engine called the Big Bertha that was mostly made of star-seed shell. He was eating his lunch on the steps of his engine when they came by. When he saw the Cogglet, he put down his sandwich and held out his hand, and the Cogglet rolled right up into it.

"Well, now," he said, turning it over gently. "I've been needing a fireman for years. Somebody to watch the gauges while I watch the track." He looked at the Cogglet. "What do you say, little gear? Want to ride the rails?"

The Cogglet's eye lit up, and it spun so fast it whistled.

The second and third Cogglets went to the junk market kids. The junk market was a noisy jumble of stalls built under an old rusted bridge, where people sold everything from broken radios to robot legs to jars of shiny screws sorted by color. A gang of kids ran a stall there selling fixed-up toys, and when they saw the Cogglets, they shrieked so loudly that the whole market turned around. Two of the Cogglets were immediately swarmed, hugged, named (Sprocket and Lady Twinkletooth), and given a job sorting

screws by color, which they turned out to be wonderful at.

The fourth Cogglet went to a tall, quiet lady who ran the water tower at the end of the Scrap Route. Her water tower had a big leak in it, and the leak had been there for six years, and she was very tired of it. The fourth Cogglet rolled right up the side of the tower, wedged itself into the pipe where the leak was, turned a quarter of the way around, and stopped the leak dead. The lady stared at it. Then she burst out laughing and said it could live in her tower forever and she would polish it every Sunday.

By the time they were done, the sun was going down. The orange sky had turned deep red, then purple. The heaps had gone dark, with little lights coming on at their tops, where people had built houses right into the scrap. And there was only one Alienmon left.

The little rust slug.

It had climbed down off Cactling's head by now. It was sitting in the middle of the road, watching the last Cogglet go rolling happily up into the water tower. Its eyestalks had drooped. Its little green eyes were sad.

It had been guarding the Cogglets this whole time, Rook realized. Through all those days out in the scrap. Being brave for them. Being the one who growled. And now they all had homes, and they were all happy, and it was all alone.

Rook knew that feeling. He thought Sporix probably knew it even better. Sporix was peeking out from Kit's overalls, watching the little slug with big, understanding eyes.

"What is it?" Rook asked quietly. "What kind?"

"A Gleamgrub," said Kit. "A rust slug. Toxin and Alloy. They're pretty rare, and super shy. Their slime eats metal, slowly, turns steel to rust. And then they eat the rust." Kit crouched down.

"Scrappers use them to loosen stuck bolts. That's probably why the Cogglets weren't even rustier. It was eating the rust off them to keep them going. Weren't you?"

The Gleamgrub looked up at Kit. Then, very slowly, it slid over, leaving a little glowing lime trail behind it. It looked at Kit's boots. It looked at Kit's patched-up knees. And then it looked at Kit's enormous toolbelt, with all its wrenches and screwdrivers and pliers and hammers, and its eyestalks stretched out very, very long.

The tools were old. Kit had been carrying most of them for years. They were scratched and stained, and more than a few were spotted with rust.

The Gleamgrub slid up onto the toolbelt and pressed itself against the rustiest wrench in the biggest hug a slug could manage.

There was a soft, crunchy, munching sound, like somebody eating cornflakes. And where it was hugging, the rust just... disappeared. Flake by flake, it went into the Gleamgrub, and a fresh orange patch spread across a dent in its riveted shell. Then it reached Kit's old adjustable wrench, the one whose little screw had been rusted solid for as long as Kit could remember. It dabbed a blob of glowing lime slime into the stuck part. The slime fizzed. Something went creak. And the little screw spun free. When the Gleamgrub finally sat back, licking its lips happily, every rust spot on the left side of Kit's belt had been eaten clean away, and every stuck hinge and jaw and screw turned smooth as butter.

Kit looked down at their toolbelt. Kit's mouth opened. Nothing came out.

The Gleamgrub burped, very politely. Then it started on the right side.

Rook laughed out loud. "I think it likes you."

"It likes my *tools*," said Kit, but their voice had gone wobbly.

"Same thing," said Rook. "Kind of. Isn't it?"

Kit thought about that for a while, watching the little Gleamgrub crunch and fizz its way along the toolbelt, freeing every stuck wrench and screwdriver.

Then Kit knelt down on the metal road.

"Hey," they said softly. "Do you want to come with me? You don't have to. I know Sporix already picked me, and that's different. That was Sporix choosing. This is me asking." They swallowed. "I'm asking. If you want."

The Gleamgrub stopped eating. It looked at Kit for a long, long moment, with both eyestalks tipped to one side.

Then it climbed up onto Kit's knee, tucked itself snugly into its rusty shell, and drew its eyestalks down until its green eyes closed.

Kit pulled out the homemade Linker. Their hand only shook a little. A slightly wobbly cyan beam, a swirl of sparkles, a tinkle of wind chimes and one small *clunk*. And the cracked screen flickered.

GLEAMGRUB. PARTNER CONFIRMED.

Sporix had chosen Kit. That was something special, and Kit would never forget it. But this was the first time Kit had done the asking.

Gleamgrub was Kit's first catch.

"Bip-bip-BIIIP!" Zib flew loops around Kit's head.

Kit just sat in the road with the Linker in both hands, staring at the little picture on the screen. They didn't say anything. But they were smiling so hard their goggles were crooked.

* * *

They didn't go to Kit's house that night.

"It's late," Kit said, when Rook asked. "Dad'll be asleep. Or at the tower. He's always at the tower." They said it quickly, without looking at Rook. "I know a better place anyway."

The better place turned out to be an old caboose. A little red train car, the very last car of a train that had stopped running years ago, sitting on a rusty side track at the edge of the Scrap Route. Its paint was peeling, and its wheels were rusted solid, but inside it was cozy. There were two bunks, a little iron stove, and a window with a cracked pane. Somebody had pinned drawings all over the walls. Drawings of engines and gears and gadgets, labeled in a careful, messy hand. Some of them were very old, and some of them looked like they had been drawn by a much smaller kid.

"I used to hide here," Kit said, lighting the stove with a spark from their welder. "When I was little. When people came to see Dad battle and kept asking me when I was going to be a battler like him." They shrugged. "I'm not a battler. I fix stuff. It's not the same."

Rook didn't know what to say to that. So he just said, "These drawings are really good."

Kit's ears went pink.

They ate the last of Nurse Coral's fruit and lay down in the bunks. Plazmo floated by the stove, keeping it warm. Cactling slept in the doorway, guarding it. Sporix and Gleamgrub curled up together in Kit's bunk, one soft and one shelled, like a pillow and a rusty tin can. And Zib settled on the windowsill, his lights going slow and dim.

Through the cracked window, far off across the scrap heaps, Rook could see a tower.

It was the tallest thing on the whole horizon. A great dark spire of riveted metal, wider at the bottom and narrowing to a point,

and at the very tip, a crystal. A huge glowing crystal, the size of a house, blazing bright blue against the purple night.

The Ferrox Relay Tower.

Rook watched it, his eyes getting heavy. And just as they were closing, the crystal flickered.

It went dark, just for a heartbeat. Then it blazed back. Then it stuttered again, dim, bright, dim, bright, like a lightbulb about to go out.

In the other bunk, Kit sat bolt upright.

Rook was almost asleep. He heard Kit whisper something. It sounded like "*No. No, no, no.*" He heard the creak of the bunk. The rustle of the toolbelt being picked up. The soft click of the caboose door.

He meant to sit up and ask what was wrong. He really did. But he was so tired, and the stove was so warm, and his eyes were already closed.

When he woke up, it was the middle of the night, and the caboose was very quiet.

Kit's bunk was empty. Sporix and Gleamgrub were gone. The toolbelt was gone.

And far away across the scrap heaps, at the very top of the Relay Tower, a tiny white light was flickering. Not blue, like the crystal. White. Hot and bright and spitting sparks.

Like someone up there, all alone in the dark, was welding.

Chapter 9

Like Father, Like Kit

When Rook woke up again, the sun was up, the stove was warm, and Kit was asleep in the bunk across from him as if they had never left it.

They were curled up on their side with their goggles still on. Sporix was tucked under their chin. Gleamgrub was snoring in their boot. And there was a smudge of black soot across Kit's cheek that definitely hadn't been there the night before.

Rook sat up and rubbed his eyes. Had he dreamed it? The empty bunk? The little white welding light at the top of the tower?

He looked out the cracked window. Far away across the scrap heaps, the great crystal on top of the Relay Tower was glowing a steady, beautiful blue. Not a flicker. Not a stutter. Perfect.

Kit yawned, stretched, and opened one eye.

"Morning," they mumbled.

"Kit," said Rook slowly, "did you go somewhere last night?"

Kit's other eye opened. For just a second, they looked very awake.

"Couldn't sleep," they said. "Went for a walk." They rolled over and pulled the blanket up. "Five more minutes."

Rook looked at the soot on Kit's cheek. He looked at the tower. He decided not to say anything.

But he wondered.

* * *

Here is what Rook didn't know.

The night before, when the crystal on the Relay Tower had flickered, Kit had known exactly what it meant. Kit had grown up in the shadow of that tower. Kit had fallen asleep every night of their life looking at that blue light through a window. And Kit knew that a crystal that flickered like that had a crack in it somewhere. A bad one. The kind that gets bigger.

So Kit had grabbed the toolbelt and the welder, and woken up Sporix and Gleamgrub, and slipped out of the caboose without a sound. They had run all the way across the scrap heaps in the dark. They had climbed the service ladder on the back of the tower, two hundred and forty rungs, with the wind whistling and the toolbelt clanking. And at the very top, inside the crystal room, they had found it: a crack running right down the middle of the glowing core, thin as a hair and long as an arm, spitting little blue sparks.

It was a strange crack. Kit noticed that. It was too straight. Too neat. Cracks didn't usually look like that. Cracks usually looked like lightning. This one looked like somebody had drawn it with a ruler.

But there wasn't time to think about that.

Kit had worked for two hours. Two hours of very careful, very quiet, very slow work, with goggles down and welder hissing and tongue sticking out of the corner of their mouth. Gleamgrub had eaten the rust off every bolt so they would turn. Sporix had puffed out little clouds of sticky spores to hold the pieces still while the welds cooled. And when the last spark faded, and the crack was sealed, and the core blazed back to life, Kit had sat back on their heels in the blue glow and let out a breath so big it fogged their goggles.

Then they had climbed back down all two hundred and forty rungs, run all the way back across the scrap heaps, and crept into their bunk.

And they hadn't told anyone. Not Rook. Not Sporix, who already knew. And definitely not the person whose tower it was.

* * *

The Ferrox Relay Tower was even bigger up close.

It rose up out of the middle of Ferrox City like a giant iron spear, so tall that Rook had to lean all the way back to see the crystal at the top. Its base was made of huge curved plates of star-seed shell, riveted together with bolts the size of Rook's head, all of it shining with that soft pearly glow under the rust. Wide iron steps led up to an enormous round door. And carved into the stone lintel over the door, so old and worn they were almost gone, were the swirling marks. The same as the bridge. The same as the Forge Gate.

"The tower was here before the city," Kit said quietly. "Before anybody. People came to Ferrox and found it standing here all by itself in the middle of nowhere. They built the city around it."

Inside was an arena. A great round room with metal stands climbing up the walls on every side, packed with people. Miners and train drivers and junk market kids and old folks with blankets on their laps. They were stamping their feet on the metal floor so it rang like a drum. *BOOM. BOOM. BOOM.* Up near the top, Rook spotted the gang of kids from the junk market, with Sprocket and Lady Twinkletooth sitting on their shoulders, waving a hand-painted sign that said GO ROOK! (AND KIT!!!)

Kit went pink and hid behind Rook.

And in the middle of the arena floor, waiting, stood the Keeper.

Hank Briggs was the biggest man Rook had ever seen, and Rook had met Forge Miner Dax only two days ago. Hank was bigger. He was as tall as a door and as wide as two doors. He had a huge red beard that went all the way down his chest, with little brass beads braided into it. He wore a leather apron over a shirt with the sleeves ripped off, and his arms were as thick as tree trunks, covered in old burn scars and faded tattoos of gears. On his head was a welding cap, pushed back, and on his face was the biggest grin Rook had ever seen.

"WELL, NOW!" he boomed. His voice was so loud that the stands shook. "YOU'RE THE KID WHO CAME IN WITH MY KIT?"

Rook swallowed. "Yes, sir."

"HA!" Hank threw back his head and laughed. It sounded exactly like a train horn. *HAW-HAW-HAWWWWW.* "Sir! Hear that, Kit? He called me sir!" He looked past Rook, and his eyes went soft. "Hiya, kiddo. You came home."

"Hi, Dad," said Kit, from behind Rook.

There was a little pause. It was the kind of pause where two people both have a hundred things to say and neither of them knows which one to say first. Rook felt it, and it made his chest ache.

Then Hank clapped his enormous hands together, and the pause broke.

"RIGHT! Let's see what you've got!"

* * *

Hank Briggs had two Alienmon, and both of them were made of iron.

The first one was called a Girderon. It looked like a long iron beam that had grown four short legs and a head like a hammer. It was heavy and slow, and when it charged, it charged in a straight

line, like a train, and if you weren't out of the way, you'd be flat.

"Cactling!" Rook called. "You're up!"

Cactling marched out onto the floor, cracked its stubby knuckles, and glared at the Girderon. The Girderon glared back. It scraped one iron foot across the floor. *Skreeeee.* Sparks jumped. Then it lowered its hammer head and charged.

The floor shook. Rook felt it through his sneakers, THOOM, THOOM, THOOM, faster and faster, a whole iron train coming straight at a cactus that barely came up to Rook's belt.

"Wait for it," said Rook. His mouth had gone dry. "Wait for it. Wait for it... NOW! Sidestep!"

Cactling hopped to the left. The Girderon thundered past, couldn't stop, and slammed head-first into the arena wall with a CLAAAANG that made the whole tower ring like a bell. Dust rained down from the rafters. It staggered back, its hammer head wobbling.

"Needle Spray!"

Cactling flung a whole fistful of needles. They bounced off the Girderon's iron sides with a sound like rain on a tin roof. *Ping-ping-ping-ping.* Not one of them stuck.

The Girderon shook its head, turned around, and charged again. Cactling dodged. It charged again. Cactling dodged again, but closer this time, so close the wind of it spun Cactling around in a circle. Every needle bounced off. And Cactling was panting now, its little green chest going in and out, in and out. The Girderon wasn't panting at all.

On the fifth charge, Cactling's stubby legs were too slow.

The hammer head caught it full in the middle. *WHAM.* Cactling flew. It hit the arena wall so hard that the metal dented, and it dropped to the floor in a heap and lay there, not moving, with half

its cream-colored spines snapped off and the creamy flower in the middle of its body crushed flat.

The whole crowd went "OHHH."

"Cactling!" Rook's voice cracked right down the middle. He was halfway onto the floor before he knew he was moving. "Cactling, that's enough, come back, you don't have to..."

Cactling's arm twitched.

Then, slowly, it planted one stubby fist on the floor. It pushed. It wobbled. It fell over. It pushed again. And Cactling, the grumpiest, bravest, smallest cactus on the whole Molten Frontier, dragged itself back up onto its feet, and turned around, and glared at the Girderon with one squinted, furious eye.

The Girderon was already charging.

Rook didn't think. He just saw it. Every time the Girderon ran, its hammer head swung up, and for one heartbeat there was a gap. A dark little seam, right where the head joined the beam. The only place on the whole thing that wasn't solid iron.

"Cactling! Don't dodge! Stand your ground! When the head comes up, aim for the neck!"

Cactling planted its feet. The Girderon came on like a train. THOOM, THOOM, THOOM. Rook couldn't breathe. The hammer head swung up...

"NOW!"

Cactling threw every needle it had left, all of them at once, straight into the seam.

SHHHK.

They stuck. The Girderon's head jerked sideways with a screech of metal. Its legs tangled. It skidded past Cactling on its side, sparks shrieking up off the floor, and crashed into the wall again, and this time it didn't get up so fast. It stood there,

wheezing steam, its hammer head drooping to one side.

And Cactling, very calmly, sat down.

It didn't fall. It sat. Like it had decided it was done, and it had done enough, and nobody was going to tell it otherwise.

Rook ran out and scooped it up, needles and all. It prickled. He didn't care. "You were *amazing*," he whispered. "You hear me? Amazing." Cactling glared up at him as if to say, *Obviously.* But it leaned its crushed little flower against his thumb before it let him call it back into the Linker.

The crowd went wild. Hank Briggs was laughing his train-horn laugh and clapping his huge hands. "HA! Did you SEE that? Nobody's ever stuck a needle in Girderon! Come on back, old girl. Rest that neck."

Then he stopped laughing. And Rook felt the whole arena change.

"Plazmo," said Rook. "Your turn."

Plazmo shot out onto the floor, sparks crackling. And Hank Briggs reached for his last capsule.

"Anvilox," he said quietly. "Let's go, old friend."

The stands went silent.

The thing that stomped out onto the arena floor was the most famous Alienmon on all of Ferrox. Rook knew it from the trading cards. Everybody did. They called it the Iron Wall. It was a hound, but a hound built like a fortress, nearly as tall as Rook and as heavy as two grown miners, made of thick slabs of dark metal and rock. Glowing orange seams ran between the slabs like lava running through cracks in the ground. Across its brow sat a heavy plate shaped exactly like an anvil. Its paws were armored and clawed, and every step it took made the floor jump, and behind it a tail of flame swished slowly back and forth. It had two small, calm,

glowing eyes under that anvil plate. It didn't growl. It didn't stomp around. It just walked to the middle of the arena, planted its paws, and stood there like a warm metal wall. And somehow that was scarier than any roar.

"Spark Burst!"

Plazmo flung a fireball. It hit Anvilox right in the chest.

And vanished.

It didn't bounce. It didn't even scorch. The fire just sank into Anvilox's armor like water into dry sand, and all along its body the lava seams brightened, glowing a deeper, hotter orange. Its flame tail flared up tall. *It drank it,* Rook thought, his stomach dropping. Then a wave of heat rolled off the Anvil Hound and up into the stands, and a man in the third row had to slap at his hat to keep the brim from catching fire.

"Sorry!" Rook called.

"Happens every battle!" the man called back, patting out the brim.

Then Anvilox moved.

It lifted one enormous armored front paw, claws spread, high, higher, and brought it down. *BOOOOM.* The floor jumped like a trampoline. A ring of force rolled out across the arena, and it hit Plazmo like an ocean wave and threw him backward, tumbling over and over through the air, and smashed him into the far wall.

Plazmo's fire went out.

Not all the way. But almost. For one horrible second, there was nothing on the floor but a little gray wisp of smoke and a tiny red ember, like the very last coal in a campfire.

"PLAZMO!"

The ember flickered. Then it flared, weakly, and Plazmo floated back up, wobbling, half his usual size. He shook himself. A few sad

sparks fell off him.

"Spark Burst! Again!"

Plazmo tried. And again. Spark Burst after Spark Burst. *Fwoomp. Fwoomp. Fwoomp.* Anvilox drank every single one, and every time, its seams burned brighter and its flame tail stood up taller. And every time Plazmo got close enough to throw, Anvilox stamped, *BOOM*, and the shockwave knocked him spinning, and every time he came back a little smaller and a little dimmer and a little slower.

It was just like the battle with Sola, Rook thought, his stomach going cold. Just like the Bubble Waves. Throwing everything you have at something and watching it all fizzle out. Only worse. Because this time every shot was making Anvilox stronger. And Plazmo was getting *hurt*.

BOOM. Plazmo hit the floor and bounced and rolled and lay there, flickering.

Rook's hand went to the Linker on his wrist. One button. That was all. One button, and Plazmo would be safe inside, and it would be over, and everybody would say he did really well for a kid from Dustmere.

Plazmo looked up at him.

He was so small now. He was the size of a candle flame. But his one eye was fixed right on Rook, steady as anything, and it wasn't asking to go back. It was asking something else. It was asking, *What do we do?*

Rook took his hand off the Linker.

He felt the old panic rising up in his chest, the urge to yell *Again! Harder!* He pushed it down.

Think first.

He made himself look. Not at what wasn't working. At everything. At the arena. At those glowing seams. At Anvilox, standing there so calm, drinking up every spark like a cat lapping milk. And then he heard something in his head. Kit's voice, from the walk along the Scrap Route the day before, when they had been talking about how Kit's welder worked.

Dad's Anvilox loves heat. You could pour a whole furnace on him and he'd just drink it up, like soup. But a welder's different. A welder's one tiny point, hotter than any furnace. More heat in one spot than anything can drink. You don't splash it. You focus it.

Rook's eyes went wide.

The problem wasn't that Plazmo's fire wasn't hot. The problem was that it was spread out. A big round fireball, splashing all over everything, like water from a bucket. To Anvilox, a spread-out fire wasn't an attack. It was food. It was the opposite of a welder. A welder was tiny. A welder was one bright, white-hot point, more heat than anything could drink.

But a welder had to *touch* the metal. Plazmo would have to get right up against that anvil plate on its brow. Right under those claws.

Rook's heart was slamming so hard he could hear it.

"Plazmo," he said. His voice shook. He let it. "Stop throwing. Don't spread out. Make it small. Smaller than you've ever made it. One tiny point. Hot as you can. Hotter than any furnace. Like a welder." He made his hand into a fist and then pointed one finger. "And then you go right up to it, and you put it right on that anvil plate, and you *don't let go*. No matter what. Can you do that?"

Plazmo's eye narrowed. His sparks stopped spinning. And then, slowly, his whole flame began to shrink. It shrank from the size of a candle, to the size of a grape, to the size of a pea. And as it

got smaller, it got brighter, and brighter, and whiter, until Rook had to squint. Until it wasn't orange anymore at all. It was a tiny, fierce, blazing white star.

In the stands, Kit had gone perfectly still. They were gripping the railing so hard their knuckles had gone pale.

Plazmo flew.

He went straight at Anvilox, low and fast. Anvilox lifted its foot. *BOOM.* The shockwave came. Plazmo didn't fly over it. He went *through* it, head down, and Rook watched him get battered sideways and keep going, battered again and keep going, and then he was there, right up against the great anvil plate on Anvilox's brow, and he pressed his tiny white-hot flame against the metal. Right in one spot. And held it there.

TSSSSSSSSSS.

Anvilox's calm eyes went wide.

It reared back. It stamped. It slammed its whole body sideways into the arena wall, CRASH, trying to crush the tiny burning thing off its brow. Rook screamed Plazmo's name. The wall buckled. The crowd was on its feet, shrieking.

When Anvilox pulled away from the wall, Plazmo was still there.

The plate under him began to glow. Dull red. Then bright red. Then the lava seams all over Anvilox's body began to change, the orange in them racing to yellow, and from yellow to a hard, blazing white, spreading out from the hot spot like cracks across ice. Anvilox was trying to drink the heat. It couldn't drink fast enough. It bucked and stamped and twisted, and the arena floor cracked under its paws, and still Plazmo held on, a white star burning a hole in the night.

"Hold on," Rook whispered. He didn't even know he was saying it. "Hold on, hold on, hold on..."

Steam was screaming out of every white-hot seam. It was too much heat, far too much, more than even the Anvil Hound could drink. Anvilox's big heavy legs began to wobble. It swayed. It swayed the other way. It took one last step toward Rook, slow and heavy, and Rook saw its calm little eyes looking right at him, and he could have sworn it looked almost proud.

Then the Iron Wall fell.

It went over like a tower coming down, *KER-RASHHH*, and the whole arena jumped, and dust went up in a great gray cloud, and when the cloud cleared, Anvilox was lying on its side on the cracked floor with its eyes closed, its seams cooling back to a soft, sleepy orange, and it did not get up.

There was a moment of complete silence.

Then a tiny spark floated up out of the dust. It drifted toward Rook, slowly, sinking lower and lower, and right before it hit the floor, Rook dove and caught it in both hands.

Plazmo was barely there. He was a flicker. A little warm glow in Rook's cupped palms, so faint that Rook could see his own fingers through it. But his eye opened, just a crack, and looked up at Rook. And Plazmo sneezed.

Pfft. One tiny, happy spark.

Rook laughed. It came out wet. He held Plazmo up against his chest, against his heart, and felt him getting warmer, little by little, like a coal someone was blowing on.

And then the whole tower exploded. People were on their feet, stamping and cheering and banging on the railings. The junk market kids were screaming. Sprocket and Lady Twinkletooth were spinning so fast they were whistling. The man with the

singed hat threw it in the air.

"We did it," Rook breathed into Plazmo's flame. "We beat the IRON WALL."

Hank Briggs walked out to the middle of the arena. He knelt down beside Anvilox and laid his big scarred hand on its warm iron side, and Anvilox opened one eye and made a low, tired rumble, like a cat purring. Hank tapped the anvil plate on its brow, very gently, and it rang like a soft bell. Then he stood up and walked over to Rook. He was not laughing now. But he was smiling, a big, slow, warm smile.

"That," he said, "was smart. And that," he nodded at the flicker in Rook's hands, "was the bravest little fire I've ever seen. Nobody's ever done that to old Anvilox before." His eyes flicked up to the stands, to where Kit was standing. "Where'd you learn that trick, son?"

Rook looked up at Kit, too.

"A friend told me," he said.

* * *

Hank opened one of his huge hands. Sitting in his palm was a crystal. It was small, about as long as Rook's finger, shaped like a little icicle, and it glowed bright blue from the inside. It was humming. Rook could hear it, very softly, if he held his breath. A single, pure note, like someone running a wet finger around the rim of a glass.

"Your first Signal Shard," said Hank. "A little piece of the heart of my tower. You earned it."

Rook took it with both hands. It was warm. He could feel the hum all the way up his arms.

Then Hank turned around. Kit had come down out of the stands. They were standing at the edge of the arena with their

hands stuffed in their pockets and their goggles down over their eyes.

Hank walked over to them. He looked down at his kid for a long moment.

"I went up to check on the core this morning," he said. "It's been flickering for days. I've been worried sick about it. Couldn't figure out how to fix it without shutting the whole tower down." He paused. "Yesterday it was cracked. Today it's perfect. Somebody fixed it." His big voice went quiet. Quieter than Rook would have thought it could go. "Neatest weld I've ever seen. Neater than any I could do." He crouched down, so his face was level with Kit's. "That was you. Wasn't it?"

Kit stared at their boots for a long time.

"...Yeah," they said.

And Hank Briggs pulled his kid into a hug so big and so tight that Kit's goggles fell right off their face and clattered on the floor.

"I'm proud of you, kiddo," Hank said into Kit's hair. His voice had gone all rough and thick. "I'm proud of you. I don't say it enough. I know I don't. I'm always going on about battles and I never say it. But I'm so proud of you I could burst."

Kit didn't say anything. But Kit hugged him back. Hard. Harder than Rook had seen Kit do anything.

Then Hank stood up, with Kit still squashed against his apron, and turned to face the stands. He filled his enormous chest with air.

"HEY! EVERYBODY!" he roared, and the whole tower went quiet. "YOU SEE THIS KID? THIS IS MY KID! KIT BRIGGS! FIXED MY TOWER ALL BY THEMSELF, IN THE MIDDLE OF THE NIGHT! I'M SO PROUD I COULD BURST!"

For one second, nobody made a sound. Then the stands went wild. The miners stamped. The train drivers whistled. The junk market kids screamed "KIT! KIT! KIT!" and waved their sign so hard it ripped in half. Kit buried their bright red face in their dad's apron and groaned. But Rook saw them smiling into it.

Rook looked away to give them a moment, and found that his own eyes were stinging, and decided the arena must be very dusty.

"One more thing," Kit said, when they finally pulled apart and found their goggles. They wiped their nose on their sleeve. "The crack. Dad. It was weird. It was too straight. Like somebody made it."

Hank's face went still. Then it went dark, like a cloud passing over the sun.

"That's what I thought," he said quietly. "Cracks like that don't happen on their own. Somebody's been poking around my tower." He looked out toward the arena doors, toward the orange sky. "And I've got a pretty good idea who."

He didn't say the name. But Rook thought of a crate in the scrap heap, stamped with an orange ring and a diagonal slash.

* * *

That was when Zib floated over.

He had been quiet the whole battle, sitting on Rook's cap with his lights dimmed, watching. But now he drifted down slowly toward the Signal Shard in Rook's hands. His huge eye was fixed on it. He floated closer, and closer, until he was hovering right over the little blue crystal.

The Shard's hum got louder.

And Zib's eye began to glow.

It started as a soft white light, deep inside the eye. Then it got brighter. Then a beam of light shot out of it, straight up into the

air, like a projector at the movies. And in the air above them, made of light, a picture appeared.

It was a planet.

It was floating in the dark of space, all alone, and it was glowing. Not blue or green, like a healthy world. It was glowing a deep, dark, smoldering red, like the last coals of a campfire when the flames have all gone out. Its sun hung beside it, huge and tired and red. Rook knew that sun. He had seen that sun before. In a dream, on the morning of his birthday.

And from the planet, one by one, little lights were rising.

They were seeds. Tiny glowing seeds, gold and violet and green, lifting off from the surface of the red world and shooting away into the stars. One. Then ten. Then a hundred. Like dandelion fluff blown off a stem. Like sparks rising from a fire. All of them flying away, as fast as they could, into the dark.

The whole arena had gone quiet. Everyone was staring up at the picture.

Then it flickered, and faded, and was gone. Zib's eye went dark. His lights went very, very quiet, a faint, slow, sad blue.

Rook cupped his hands around the little saucer.

"Zib?" he whispered. "Was that... was that your home?"

Zib didn't flash any lights. He didn't spin. He just sat there in Rook's palms, very small and very still.

"...Bip," he said.

It was the smallest bip Rook had ever heard.

Nobody said anything for a long time. Then Hank Briggs cleared his throat. He was staring at the place in the air where the picture had been. He had a very strange look on his face.

"Rook," he said. "That brass badge on your strap. Where'd you get it?"

Rook touched the little cross with the bird on it. "My mom gave it to me. It was my Nana Wren's."

Hank closed his eyes for a second. When he opened them, they were wet.

"Thought so," he said quietly. "You've got her chin." He put one enormous hand on Rook's shoulder. "Come by my hangar in the morning. First thing. There's something in there I've been keeping for a very long time."

"What is it?"

Hank smiled a strange, sad, happy smile.

"Your Nana's," he said.

Chapter 10

Launch Clearance

Hank Briggs's hangar was at the far end of Ferrox City, past the train yards and the smelting works, in a part of town where the scrap heaps got quieter and the cranes got older and rustier and more tired-looking. It was a long, low, curved building made of star-seed shell, with a roof like the back of a whale and two enormous sliding doors on the front.

Hank was waiting outside when they got there. He was holding two mugs of something hot and a paper bag that smelled like cinnamon.

"Breakfast," he said, handing the bag to Rook. "Kit's favorite. Gear-buns."

Gear-buns turned out to be sticky cinnamon rolls shaped like gears, with sugar icing on all the little teeth. Kit ate three in a row without stopping to breathe. Rook ate two. Plazmo toasted one until it was crunchy. Cactling ate one very slowly, pretending not to enjoy it, and then quietly stole another when it thought nobody was looking.

Then Hank wiped his hands on his apron, walked over to the big sliding doors, and pulled.

The doors groaned. They screeched. They rumbled open on their old iron wheels, and sunlight came pouring into the hangar.

Inside, it was dim and dusty and full of things. Old engines, coils of cable, shelves of spare parts, a workbench covered in tools. And in the middle of it all, taking up most of the floor, was

something big and round, covered with an enormous gray canvas sheet.

Hank walked over to it. He stood there for a moment with one hand on the canvas. Then he took hold of the edge, and pulled.

The sheet slid off in one long whoosh, and a cloud of dust went billowing up into the sunlight, sparkling like glitter.

Underneath was a starship.

It was not a big starship. It was not sleek, or sharp, or scary-looking, like the ships on the posters in Dustmere. It was small, and round, and sort of plump. Its body was cream-colored, the soft warm cream of fresh butter, and it was smooth and curved all over like an egg lying on its side. On the back were two engines shaped like seashells, painted a cheerful, rosy pink. And on top was a cockpit that was a perfect bubble of clear glass, so you could see all the way around in every direction.

It looked, Rook thought, like a cake. A small, round, friendly cake that wanted to go somewhere.

On its side, painted in curly, old-fashioned letters that someone had done by hand, was a name.

Dandelion.

And underneath the name, very small, was a picture. A tiny bird with its wings spread out. Exactly like the one on the badge.

Rook's breath stopped in his throat.

"This was your Nana Wren's ship," said Hank quietly.

* * *

They all walked around the *Dandelion* in a slow circle. Nobody said anything. Zib flew right up to the bubble cockpit and pressed his whole eye against the glass, his lights flashing a curious, excited blue.

"She flew it all over the system," Hank said. "Every world. Every moon. Anywhere there was a sick Alienmon and no nurse to help it. That's what she did with her holidays. Most folks go to the beach. Wren went to the places nobody else would go."

Rook ran his hand along the side of the ship. It was cool and smooth, with little dings and scratches here and there, like old freckles. He tried to imagine his Nana, with her peppermints and her singing, sitting at the controls of a starship. Zooming through the stars. It was the best thing he had ever tried to imagine.

"How did you know her?" he asked.

Hank leaned against the workbench and folded his huge arms. For once, his big voice was quiet.

"When Anvilox was just a pup," he said, "no bigger than a toolbox, he fell off a crane. Forty feet, onto solid iron. Broke three of his legs." He looked down at his hands. "Every doctor on Ferrox came and looked at him and shook their heads. Said he'd never walk again. Said I ought to... well. They said a lot of things. And I was young and I didn't know what to do, and I just sat there in the mud holding him."

Kit was staring at their dad. Rook could tell Kit had never heard this story.

"And then this little cream-colored ship came down out of the sky," Hank said. "Landed right in the train yard. And out climbs this little old lady with a medical bag twice as big as she was. Didn't ask anybody's permission. Didn't even say hello. Just knelt down in the mud next to me and said, 'Well, let's have a look at him, then.'" Hank laughed, a soft, rumbly laugh. "She stayed three nights. Three whole nights. Sat with him, splinted his legs, sang to him. And on the fourth morning, he stood up."

Three nights. Rook thought of Nurse Coral. *She sat up with it for three nights.*

It seemed like that was just what Nana Wren did.

"Years later," Hank went on, "when she was getting old, and her eyes weren't so good anymore for flying, she brought the *Dandelion* here. Asked me to keep it safe for her. I said, 'Wren, what am I keeping it safe *for*?'" He smiled. "And she said, 'Someday my grandkid is going to need it. You'll know them when you see them, Hank. They'll have my chin.'"

He reached into the pocket of his apron and took out a key. It was small and brass and old-fashioned, on a ring with a little round tag. The tag had the bird on it too.

Hank held it out to Rook.

"You've got launch clearance," he said. "Go see the stars."

Rook took the key. His hand was shaking.

* * *

The inside of the *Dandelion* was the coziest place Rook had ever been in his life.

It was round and warm and smelled faintly of peppermint. The seats were covered in knitted covers, lumpy and colorful, red and yellow and green, obviously made by someone who loved knitting more than they were good at it. A little brass bird hung from the ceiling on a string and swung gently back and forth. There was a tiny kitchen with a kettle and a tin of peppermints that still, impossibly, had peppermints in it. There was a bunk with a patchwork quilt. There was a shelf of old books, their spines cracked from reading. There was a cupboard full of bandages and medicine bottles and a stethoscope.

And at the front, under the big glass bubble, were the controls. A steering wheel shaped like a ship's wheel, with little handles all

around. Rows of switches and buttons and dials, each one labeled in that same curly, careful handwriting. SPEED. HEAT. LIGHTS. TEA. One big red button all by itself in the middle labeled, simply, GO.

"TEA?" said Kit.

"It's my Nana," said Rook. "Of course there's a tea button."

Under the controls, Rook noticed something else. A small drawer, made of dark wood, set right into the panel. It had a keyhole. But the keyhole was a funny shape. It wasn't a normal keyhole at all. It was shaped like a little cross.

Rook tried his key. It didn't fit. He tugged on the drawer. It was locked tight.

"Hank?" he called. "What's in this drawer?"

Hank poked his huge head in through the hatch and looked. Then he shrugged his huge shoulders.

"No idea, son. Never could open it. She never told me." He rubbed his beard. "Some locks are like that. They wait for the right key."

Rook looked at the little cross-shaped keyhole for a long time. Then he looked down at his satchel strap. At the little brass badge pinned over his heart. A cross. With a bird on it.

He reached for it. He started to unpin it.

And from outside the ship, Kit shouted, "ROOK! Dad says the launch window closes in five minutes! If we're going, we have to go NOW!"

Rook's hand stopped. He looked at the drawer. He looked at the badge.

Later, he thought. It had waited this long. It could wait a little longer.

* * *

Kit was standing outside the hatch with their toolbelt on and their goggles down, bouncing on their toes. Hank was standing beside them.

Rook stopped in the doorway. "Kit? Are you... are you coming?"

"Well, somebody's got to," said Kit, very fast, as if they had practiced it. "This ship is like fifty years old. Something's going to fall off. Probably several somethings. You'll need an engineer. A good one. Which is me." They paused. "If that's okay."

Rook grinned so wide his face hurt. "That's MORE than okay."

Then Kit turned to Hank. The grin wobbled.

"Dad. I..."

Hank knelt down in front of his kid, the way Rook's mom had knelt down in front of him. He put both enormous hands on Kit's shoulders.

"Go," he said. "Go see the stars, kiddo. Fix everything that breaks. And come home and tell me about it." He pulled Kit into one more crushing hug. "I'll keep the light on."

He meant the tower. Kit knew it. Rook knew it.

Kit climbed into the *Dandelion* and didn't look back, because if they looked back they would cry, and engineers do not cry during launch procedures. That was a rule. Kit had just made it up.

Rook sat down in the pilot's seat, in the knitted seat cover, which was lumpy and red and perfect. Plazmo floated by the window. Cactling strapped itself into a seat with great seriousness and gripped the armrests. Sporix and Gleamgrub tucked themselves into Kit's toolbelt. And Zib settled right on top of the steering wheel, his huge eye fixed on the hangar doors, his lights flashing every color at once.

Rook put the key in. He turned it.

The *Dandelion* woke up.

It started with a cough and a sputter, like an old dog getting up from a nap. Then a rumble, deep down in the seashell engines. Then a hum. The dials on the panel lit up one by one, in soft green and gold. The little brass bird on its string began to sway. Somewhere in the back, the kettle started to whistle all on its own.

"Is the TEA button on?" Kit yelled over the noise.

"I didn't touch it!"

"Then it's just HAPPY!"

Rook put his hands on the steering wheel. He looked at the big red button marked GO.

He pressed it.

The engines roared. The whole ship shook so hard Rook's teeth rattled. The hangar floor fell away beneath them, and the hangar doors swept past, and Hank, standing in the train yard waving both his huge arms over his head, got smaller and smaller and smaller, and the scrap heaps shrank to little bumps, and the orange sky rushed down around them like water, and then—

WHOOOOOOOSH.

—they burst out of the top of the sky, and everything went quiet.

* * *

Rook had dreamed about space his whole life. He had stared at it through his telescope every night. He had read every book about it in the Dustmere library, even the boring ones with no pictures.

None of it had prepared him for this.

Space was not black. Not really. It was a deep, soft, velvety blue, darker than the darkest night, and it was full of light. Stars everywhere, millions of them, so many and so close and so bright that they didn't twinkle anymore. They just shone, steady and clear, red and white and blue and gold. A great glowing band of

purple and gold stretched across the middle of everything, the same band Rook had seen from the canyon, except now it wasn't up. It was all around them. They were inside it.

A comet went streaking past, close enough to see. Its head was a ball of glittering ice, and its tail stretched out behind it for miles and miles, sparkling and shimmering like a long silk scarf.

And off to one side floated a planet. A huge, round, pale-blue planet, frost-white at the top and bottom, its whole surface crazed with long silver cracks like ice on a winter pond. And around its middle, a set of rings. Wide, flat, glittering rings, tilted at an angle, like the brim of a hat. Up close, Rook could see that the rings were made of millions and millions of little chunks of ice and crystal, all glinting in the sun.

"That's Glacia," Kit breathed, pressing their face against the glass. "The ice world. Fifth ring. It's frozen solid, pole to pole. There are a few towns down there, way out on the far side, tucked under big glass domes. Dad says you can't step outside without six pairs of socks on. And he says there are Alienmon in those rings that swim through space like fish."

Zib was plastered against the front of the bubble with his whole eye pressed to the glass. "Bip," he said. Then, "Bip." Then, faster and faster, as they swooped past the rings, "Bip... bip... BIP! BIP-BIP-BIP-BIIIIIP!"

Plazmo did loops around the cockpit. Cactling let go of its armrests for the first time and stared out the window with its mouth open. Even Sporix pushed its cap all the way up to see.

And Rook just sat there, with his hands on his Nana's steering wheel, and felt something swell up inside him so big that he thought he might burst. He wished Mom could see this. He wished DX-4 could see it, and Dr. Vashti, and Old Dusty, and everybody.

He wished, he realized, a little surprised at himself, that Sola could see it.

And he wished Nana Wren could see him now. Flying her ship.

Maybe, he thought, touching the badge on his strap, she sort of could.

* * *

The radio crackled.

Rook jumped. He hadn't even known there was a radio. It was a little brass speaker shaped like a trumpet, poking out of the panel, and it was hissing and spitting static.

KSSSSHHHH. "...cream-colored vessel, this is Helix Field Division." KSSSHH. The voice was calm and clear and very close. "Cut your engines and open your docking hatch."

Kit and Rook looked at each other.

Rook knew that voice. He had heard it in the dark, in the Sunset Tunnel, telling him that nobody needed to move fast.

He looked in the little round mirror on the side of the bubble. Coming up behind them, fast and smooth and silent, was a white Helix shuttle. It was long and narrow, like a needle, and it was closing the distance the way a hawk closes on a mouse. On its nose was an orange ring with a diagonal slash through it.

"Is that...?" Kit whispered. Rook had told them about the tunnel. All of it.

"Pell," said Rook.

KSSHH. "Hello again, Rook." As if he had heard. Maybe he had. "I told you it wouldn't be that easy twice. You're in a fifty-year-old medical ship with two speeds. I'm in a pursuit shuttle with clearance to bring the scout in. You already know how this ends. Cut your engines, and nobody gets hurt."

"Bip!" Zib dove off the steering wheel and hid behind the tin of peppermints.

Rook gripped the wheel. "Kit. How do we go faster?"

Kit was already flipping switches. "This ship was built to visit sick Alienmon, not win races! It's got two speeds! Gentle and Slightly Less Gentle!"

"Then give me Slightly Less Gentle!"

Kit slammed a lever. The seashell engines roared, and the Dandelion leaped forward, and for one wonderful second the white shuttle shrank in the mirror.

Then it grew again. Slowly. Easily. As if it had only been waiting to see what they would do.

KSSHH. A different voice this time. Lower. Quieter. "Pell. That ship's old. If we lock on at full power, the hull could crack."

A pause.

"Then they'd better hold still," said Pell. "Lock it."

A beam of pale orange light shot out from the nose of the shuttle and hit the back of the Dandelion.

THOOM.

The whole ship jolted like a cart hitting a wall. Rook flew forward against his straps. Cactling's armrests creaked under its grip. The brass bird on its string swung wildly, and the stars outside the bubble, which had been streaming past, slowed. And stopped. And then, horribly, began to slide the *other way*.

They were going backward.

"Tractor beam!" Kit shouted. Every dial on the panel had swung over into the red. "It's got us! It's twice as strong as our engines, Rook, we can't pull out of it!"

The engines screamed. The whole ship shook. Somewhere in the back, the kettle started to whistle, high and thin and

frightened, and it didn't stop. Rook twisted around in his seat and looked out the back of the bubble.

The shuttle was so close now that he could see a hatch on its belly sliding open. Inside, it was bright and white and clean. And all along one wall, in a neat row, were cages. Small metal cages. Empty. Waiting.

Zib saw them too. He made a sound Rook had never heard him make before. Not a bip. Just a thin, tiny whine.

Something inside Rook went very cold and very still.

Think first.

He made himself turn back around. He made himself look. Not at the cages. At everything. Glacia's rings, glittering, far off. A comet, farther still. And just ahead, tumbling slowly end over end through the dark, a giant asteroid. It was huge, as big as a mountain, gray and lumpy and pocked with craters, and it was spinning. Slowly, heavily, like a top that was just about to fall over.

And around it, Rook noticed, little rocks and chunks of ice were floating in circles. Round and round. Caught.

"Kit," he said, and his voice came out strangely calm. "That asteroid. It's pulling stuff in, isn't it? Like a magnet?"

Kit looked. Their eyes went wide behind their goggles. "It's big enough to have gravity. If you get too close, it'll grab you and swing you around and... Rook. *Rook.* What are you thinking?"

"The beam's pulling us back. The asteroid would pull us forward. Our engines plus the rock..." He swallowed. "Is that more than the beam?"

Kit stared at him. Then at the dials. Their lips moved, doing sums. "Maybe," they whispered. "*Maybe.* And the shuttle's locked onto us. Wherever we go, it has to come too. And it's way heavier than we are. If it gets dragged into those rocks..."

"Then it's got bigger problems than us." Rook put both hands on Nana Wren's steering wheel. "Hold on, everybody."

He turned the wheel.

The Dandelion stopped fighting the beam and dove, nose first, straight toward the giant spinning rock.

KSSHH. "What is he doing?" That was Strand.

"Stay on him," said Pell. But for the first time, Rook thought, he didn't sound quite so sure.

The asteroid's pull caught them. Rook felt it, a strange, heavy tug, like the ship was rolling downhill. The stars began to slide forward again. Faster. Faster. The dials crept back out of the red. The asteroid loomed up ahead, bigger and bigger, filling the whole bubble, gray and cratered and turning, until Rook could see every lump and bump on its surface, and the chunks of ice and rock swinging around it like a crowd of tiny moons.

Behind them, the shuttle came too, dragged along on the end of its own beam.

"Now, Kit! Everything we've got!"

Kit slammed every lever on the panel. The seashell engines roared like they had never roared before. And Rook turned the wheel as hard as he could, so the Dandelion skimmed past the edge of the asteroid, so close that they could have reached out and touched it, threading the gap between two tumbling chunks of ice.

The shuttle couldn't thread it. It was too big, too heavy, too fast.

A boulder of ice the size of a house came swinging around the asteroid and passed straight through the orange beam.

SNAP.

The beam broke like a rope cut with scissors. The Dandelion leaped free, curved away and out, and went shooting off into the

dark like a stone from a slingshot.

Behind them, the Helix shuttle tried to make the same turn.

It was a little too close. It was a little too slow. The ice boulder clipped its wing in a silent flash of white, and the asteroid's pull caught it, the way a hand catches a ball. The shuttle lurched sideways into the circling rocks. Its engines flared bright, fighting, and it began to swing around the asteroid in a long, slow, helpless curve.

KSSHH. "...port engine's hit." Strand's voice was tight and fast. "Pell, we're in the debris ring. If we keep chasing, we go in. We have to get clear."

A long silence. The static hissed.

"...Break off," said Pell.

Rook let out a breath he hadn't known he was holding.

Then the radio crackled one last time.

"That was clever, Rook." Pell's voice was perfectly calm again. Not angry. Interested. Which was worse. "Clever gets noticed. Somebody a lot higher up than me is going to hear your name today. I'll make sure of it." A pause. "Enjoy Sporeholm."

The radio clicked off.

For a long moment, nobody in the Dandelion said anything at all. The kettle was still whistling. Kit reached back without looking and switched it off, and their hand was shaking so hard it took two tries.

"They had cages," Kit said quietly. "Rook. In the shuttle. They had *cages*."

"I know."

Zib came out from behind the peppermints. He didn't fly to the back window. He flew to Rook, and pressed himself against Rook's hand on the steering wheel, and stayed there.

Rook looked in the little round mirror. Far behind them, the white shuttle was still crawling around and around the asteroid, slow and crooked, engines sputtering, caught. It was getting smaller. But it wasn't gone.

"Bip," Zib whispered.

Rook kept one hand on the wheel and the other on Zib, and he didn't let go of either one for a long time.

* * *

They flew on through the stars for hours.

Kit fiddled with the engines and found a rattle and fixed it, and then found another rattle and fixed that one too, and was very happy. Plazmo fell asleep on the dashboard. Cactling read one of Nana Wren's old books upside down, very seriously. Rook made tea, and it was terrible, and they drank it anyway.

And then, as the sun of the Kessler system swung around behind them, a new planet rose up ahead.

It was soft and round and glowing, all green and purple, like a giant bruise-colored plum. Thick white mist swirled over its surface in long lazy spirals. And as they got closer, Rook could see that the mist itself was glowing. Little specks of light drifted through it, millions of them, green and gold and violet, like fireflies.

"Sporeholm," said Kit. "The swamp world."

Sporix shot up out of Kit's lap and pressed itself against the glass. Its cap was quivering. Its eyes were enormous. And it was making a sound Rook had never heard it make before. A long, soft, happy, longing hum.

They dipped down into the clouds. The mist closed around them, cool and soft and glowing. Through the vents came a smell, sweet and damp and green, like rain on moss, like honey, like the

inside of a flower.

And over the old trumpet radio, very faint, under the static, came something else.

Singing.

Hundreds of voices, low and soft and swaying, singing a song with no words. It rose and fell like breathing. It sounded like a lullaby. It sounded like someone calling a name into the dark.

It sounded, Rook thought, a lot like someone was looking for somebody who was lost.

Chapter 11

The Spore Choir

Sporeholm was the most beautiful place Rook had ever smelled.

That was the first thing he noticed when he opened the hatch of the *Dandelion* and stuck his head out. Before he even saw anything, the smell came rushing in. It smelled like rain. It smelled like moss after rain, and wet earth, and green leaves crushed between your fingers. And underneath all of that, something sweet. Like honey. Like the inside of a flower on a summer afternoon.

Rook breathed in so deeply that he got dizzy and had to hold onto the door.

Then he looked around, and got dizzy all over again.

They had landed on top of a mushroom.

It was the biggest mushroom in the world, or at least it seemed that way. Its cap was as wide as the whole plaza back in Dustmere, flat and soft and springy, and it glowed. It glowed a gentle, pale green, from somewhere deep inside, like a lamp with a cloth over it. And all around it, rising out of a misty swamp far below, were more mushrooms. Hundreds of them. Tall ones and short ones, fat ones and skinny ones, all of them glowing. Green and violet and soft blue and pale gold. Their stalks were as thick as tree trunks. Some of them were taller than the trees.

There were trees, too, between the mushrooms. Strange, droopy trees with long hanging beards of moss that swayed in the breeze. And down in the swamp, the water was dark and still and

covered in lily pads, and every time something moved near a lily pad, it lit up. *Blip.* Pale pink. *Blip.* Soft yellow. Like someone walking across a floor made of lightbulbs.

And everywhere, drifting through the air, floating on the breeze, were the spores.

Tiny glowing specks, no bigger than grains of sugar. Green and gold and violet. Thousands of them. Millions of them. They floated lazily through the mist like fireflies, like snow falling upwards, like someone had shaken out a blanket full of stars. They landed on Rook's sleeve and sparkled there for a moment before drifting off again.

Sporix came out of the hatch behind him and stopped dead.

For a long moment, it didn't move at all. Its eyes were enormous. Its cap was trembling. Then it took one step, and another, out onto the springy, glowing mushroom. It held its little arms out to the drifting spores, and a few of them settled on its cap, and stayed there, glittering.

And Sporix began to laugh.

Rook had never heard it laugh before. It was the smallest, softest, happiest sound, like bubbles rising in a glass. It turned around and around in a slow circle with its arms out and its eyes closed, while the spores swirled around it, and every time it spun, it puffed out a little cloud of spores of its own, which went drifting off to join the others.

Kit stood in the hatchway watching it. Kit didn't say anything. But they took their goggles off, which Kit almost never did, and wiped their eyes.

"It's like it's home," Kit said quietly. "It's never been here before. But it's like it's home."

* * *

The village of Mirefen was built on top of the mushrooms.

Little round huts made of woven reeds and wood sat on the glowing caps, two or three on each one, like birds' nests. Their roofs were thatched with moss. Their windows were round, and their doors were round, and lanterns hung outside every door. Wobbly rope bridges stretched between the mushrooms, swooping and swaying across the gaps, with planks so far apart that Rook could see the misty swamp far, far below between them. Ladders made of vines ran up and down the stalks. And on the tallest mushroom of all, right in the middle of the village, sat a wide, flat, open platform with no huts on it at all.

The people who lived here were called Sporefolk.

They looked just like the people back in Dustmere, mostly. But they wore long cloaks woven from soft green moss, and wide hats made from upside-down mushroom caps. And across their noses and cheeks, every one of them had freckles that glowed. Faint, soft, golden freckles, like the spores had settled on their faces when they were babies and decided to stay.

A Sporefolk girl came bouncing across the nearest rope bridge to meet them. She was younger than Rook, maybe nine or ten, with wild red hair stuffed under a mushroom hat and so many glowing freckles that her face looked like a starry sky. She didn't hold onto the ropes at all. She just skipped across the planks as if they were solid ground.

"Visitors!" she shouted. "Visitors, visitors! You came in the cake ship!"

"It's not a cake," said Kit. "It's a starship."

"It looks like a cake."

"...Yeah, okay, it kind of looks like a cake."

"I'm Fenna!" the girl said, sticking out her hand. Then she saw Sporix, and gasped so loudly that a nearby tree full of glowing moths all flew off at once. "Oh! Oh, you've got a SPORIX! Hello, Sporix! Hello! You're so little! You're so cute! Look at your little cap! Look at your little FEET!"

Sporix pulled its cap down over its eyes. But Rook could see it was pleased.

Fenna took them on a tour. She took them across bridge after bridge, swaying and bouncing, until Rook stopped looking down and started just holding on and hoping. She showed them the Mirefen market, where people sold glowing berries in woven baskets, and jars of mushroom honey, and cloaks and hats and little carved wooden Alienmon. She showed them the swamp-boats, long and thin and made from hollowed-out mushroom stalks, which the Sporefolk paddled through the misty water below. She introduced them to about a hundred Alienmon. There were little round frogs that glowed green when they croaked. There were moths as big as dinner plates, with wings like stained glass. There was a huge, slow, gentle-looking turtle sunbathing on a lily pad, with a whole tiny garden growing on its shell: ferns and flowers and even a little mushroom.

"That's a Mossback," Fenna said. "They're the oldest Alienmon on Sporeholm. That one's called Grandmother Fern. She's been sleeping on that lily pad since before my mum was born. She only wakes up for festivals."

Grandmother Fern opened one ancient eye, looked at them, and closed it again.

"She likes you," said Fenna.

"How can you tell?"

"She opened her eye. She doesn't do that for just anybody. She didn't do it for the Helix people."

Rook stopped. "Helix people? There are Helix people here?"

Fenna's bouncy smile went away for a second. "Out past the Maze. Weird white tents and big humming machines. They said they were studying the mushrooms." She frowned. "Some of the mushrooms out there are going gray. Mum says not to go near."

Rook and Kit looked at each other.

* * *

As the sun went down, the whole village gathered on the big flat mushroom in the middle.

The sky over Sporeholm didn't go dark like a normal sky. It went purple, then deep violet, then a soft glowing indigo, and as it did, the mushrooms all around them glowed brighter and brighter, until the whole swamp was lit up like a city at night. The spores in the air glowed brighter too. They drifted through the dark like a slow, gentle snowstorm of light.

The Sporefolk sat down in a big circle on the mushroom, in their moss cloaks and mushroom hats, their freckles glowing. Fenna pulled Rook and Kit down to sit with her. Sporix sat in Kit's lap. Plazmo, who Fenna had very politely asked to keep his fire turned down low ("The little ones get scared of flames"), floated beside Rook as dim as a nightlight.

And then, without anyone giving a signal, the Sporefolk began to sing.

It started with one voice. An old woman, somewhere across the circle, humming a single low note. Then another voice joined her, a little higher. Then another, and another, until the whole circle was humming together. It was a song with no words. Just a simple, swaying tune that went up and down and up and down, like

breathing, like a cradle rocking. *Hmm-mm-mmm. Hmm-mm-mmm. Hmm-mm-MMM-mm-mmm.*

The sound rolled out across the swamp. It echoed off the mushrooms. And the spores in the air began to move with it. Rook saw them. He wasn't imagining it. They swirled and swayed in time with the song, gathering into long glowing ribbons that rose and fell with each note.

And out in the swamp, things began to come home.

Little glowing shapes came drifting out of the mist. Baby Alienmon. Tiny green frogs and baby moths and little round puffy things with leaves on their heads. They came floating and hopping and paddling toward the music, out of the dark, toward the light. Their parents were waiting at the edge of the circle. Every time a baby arrived, a parent scooped it up, and the Sporefolk sang a little louder.

"We sing to the sporelings," Fenna whispered to Rook, under the music. "That's what we call the babies. When they're little, they go out wandering in the mist, and they can't always find their way back. The mist is thick. It all looks the same. But they can always hear the song. So every night, we sing, and they follow it home."

Rook watched a tiny green frog hop all the way across the lily pads, *blip, blip, blip*, and leap into the arms of a bigger green frog, who hugged it so tightly it squeaked.

He thought of the picture from Zib's eye. The little glowing seeds, flying away from the red planet into the dark. Flying as fast as they could. With nobody singing to bring them home.

He looked at Zib, sitting on his knee. Zib's lights had gone very soft and very still.

The song went on. One by one, the babies came home.

And then the song began to falter.

It was a deep sound that did it. A long, low, sad call from somewhere out in the swamp, so deep that Rook felt it in his chest. *Hoooooom. Hoooooom.* It sounded like a foghorn. It sounded like someone calling a name over and over.

The singers stopped one by one. The circle went quiet. Everybody turned to look.

Out in the swamp, at the very edge of the light, something huge was moving. It was a Mossback. A great, ancient turtle, even bigger than Grandmother Fern, with a whole forest growing on its shell. It was wading slowly through the dark water, back and forth, back and forth, swinging its big old head from side to side, calling. *Hoooooom.*

"That's Mother Willow," Fenna whispered. Her voice had gone small. "She had a baby this spring. Just one. She's only ever had one." Fenna looked out at the dark mist. "It didn't come home."

* * *

The Sporefolk sent out search boats. They paddled out into the swamp with lanterns, calling and singing. But the mist was thick and the swamp was big and the night was dark, and one by one the boats came back with nothing.

Mother Willow kept calling. *Hoooooom. Hoooooom.*

Rook couldn't stand it.

"We'll find it," he said, standing up.

Everybody looked at him.

"We will," he said. "We've got a Sporix. Sporix can smell other sporelings. Can't you, Sporix?"

Sporix's eyes went wide. Then it looked out at the dark swamp, and at Mother Willow, wading back and forth, calling for her baby.

Sporix hopped down off Kit's lap. It stood very straight. Its cap went up. And it nodded.

* * *

They went down the vine ladder to the swamp, Rook and Kit and all their Alienmon, and Fenna came too, because Fenna said she knew the swamp better than anyone and also that they couldn't stop her, which was true.

At the bottom, they found a trail. A line of small glowing mushrooms, no bigger than thumbs, sprouting out of the mud and moss in a winding path that led away into the mist. Some of them were bent over, as if something small had brushed past them.

Sporix went first. Its cap was held high and wiggling, like a dog's nose sniffing the air. Every so often it would stop, and turn, and its cap would wiggle harder, and then it would set off again in a slightly new direction. Kit walked right behind it, holding up a lantern. Rook came next, with Plazmo turned down so low he was barely a glow. Fenna brought up the rear, humming the song softly under her breath.

The mist closed in around them, cool and wet and thick. It was so thick that Rook could barely see Kit's lantern, just a few steps ahead. Everything was soft and gray and glowing, and every sound was muffled. The squelch of their boots in the mud. The drip of water from the moss. And, far behind them, getting fainter, Mother Willow calling. *Hoooom.*

They walked for a long time. The trail of little mushrooms twisted and turned. Rook stopped being able to tell which way they had come. Everything looked the same.

This was what it was like for the sporelings, he realized. Lost in the mist. Everything looking the same. No way to tell which way was home.

Then Sporix stopped.

Its cap was wiggling so hard it was almost a blur. It turned, very slowly, toward a big, droopy fern at the side of the trail. A fern with leaves as wide as umbrellas, hanging all the way down to the mud.

Kit crouched down and lifted the lantern.

Under the fern, curled up in a ball in the mud, was a baby Mossback.

It was tiny. No bigger than a teacup. Its shell was soft and green, with just one little leaf sprouting out of the top of it, like a flag. Its eyes were squeezed shut. And it was shivering. Shivering so hard that its little leaf was shaking.

"Oh," whispered Fenna. "Oh, little one."

Rook knelt down in the mud. "Hey," he said softly. "Hey, little guy. We're here to take you home. Your mom's looking for you."

The baby Mossback opened its eyes. It saw Rook. And it pulled its head all the way into its shell, so fast that its leaf flopped over.

Kit tried next. Kit held out a hand, slow and gentle, the way they had with the Cogglets. The baby Mossback pulled its little feet into its shell, too.

Fenna tried. She sang the song, soft and sweet. *Hmm-mm-mmm.* But the baby just shivered harder. It was too scared. It had been alone in the mist for too long, and everything was too big and too strange and too dark.

Then Sporix tried. Sporix crept right up to it, so close that their caps were almost touching, and puffed out a tiny cloud of friendly, glittering spores.

The baby Mossback didn't come out. It didn't even peek.

Sporix's cap drooped. It looked back at Kit, its eyes miserable.

Rook sat back in the mud. He didn't know what to do. Out in the mist, far away, Mother Willow called again. *Hoooom.* But the sound was so faint now, so far, and the baby didn't seem to hear it at all.

That was when Zib did something he had never done before.

He lifted off Rook's shoulder. He floated down, slowly, until he was hovering right in front of the baby Mossback's shell. He dimmed all his lights down until they were soft and warm and gold, like a candle.

And then he began to hum.

It wasn't a bip. It wasn't any sound Rook had ever heard Zib make. It was a hum, soft and clear and steady, like a note played on a little glass flute. And it was the song. The Spore Choir's song. The simple, swaying tune they had heard in the village. Zib had only heard it once. But he hummed it perfectly, every note, up and down and up and down, like breathing, like a cradle rocking.

Hmm-mm-mmm. Hmm-mm-mmm. Hmm-mm-MMM-mm-mmm.

Rook held his breath. Kit held their breath. Fenna had both hands over her mouth.

The baby Mossback's shell stopped shaking.

Zib kept humming.

Very, very slowly, a little green head poked out of the front of the shell. Two little eyes blinked up at Zib's warm golden light.

Zib kept humming.

One little foot came out. Then another. Then the baby Mossback was standing up in the mud, wobbling, staring at Zib. And then, very softly, very croakily, it opened its tiny mouth and hummed along.

Hmm-mm-mmm.

It was the most beautiful thing Rook had ever heard.

* * *

They walked back through the mist with Zib leading the way, still humming, and the baby Mossback toddling along right behind him, humming too. Sporix walked beside it, close enough that their shoulders touched. Every few steps, Fenna joined in, and then Kit, a bit off-key, and then Rook, even more off-key, until they were all humming together, walking through the glowing mist like a very small, very muddy choir.

And when they came out of the mist at the bottom of the village, a great dark shape loomed up out of the water ahead of them.

Mother Willow.

She stopped calling. She lowered her enormous old head, slowly, slowly, all the way down to the mud, until her great eye was level with her baby.

The baby Mossback squeaked. It ran forward on its little legs, as fast as it could, and threw itself against its mother's huge face.

Mother Willow closed her eyes. And she made a sound that Rook would remember for the rest of his life. It wasn't a call this time. It was low and soft and rumbly, a long, deep, contented hum, the sound of someone who has been holding their breath for a whole night and can finally let it out.

Above them, on the mushrooms, the whole village of Mirefen began to cheer.

* * *

That night, the Spore Choir sang one more time. They sang for the baby who had come home.

And this time, Zib sang with them. Right in the middle of the circle, floating above the glowing mushroom, his lights pulsing soft gold in time with the song. The Sporefolk didn't seem to think this was strange at all. The old woman who had started the song smiled at him, and nodded, and slowed down a little so he could keep up.

Rook sat at the edge of the circle with Kit, watching. He felt warm all the way through, warmer than a pancake breakfast, warmer than Plazmo on a cold night.

"He's never done that before," he whispered. "The humming."

"Maybe he never had anything to hum," Kit whispered back.

Rook thought about that. Then he looked out across the swamp, past the circle and the glowing mushrooms, toward the misty dark where the Lantern Marsh began. Fenna had told them about it. A part of the swamp where the Sporefolk floated paper lanterns on the water, one for every person they missed.

There were hundreds of lanterns out there tonight. Little floating lights, drifting slowly over the black water like sleepy stars.

And standing alone on a wooden boardwalk among them, so far away she was almost lost in the mist, was a small figure.

Rook sat up straight.

The figure was holding something in its hand. Something small and glowing, like a screen. And it was wearing a jacket. An olive-green jacket, three sizes too big, with the sleeves rolled up four times.

The figure looked up. Straight across the swamp. Straight at him.

Then the mist rolled in, thick and white, and when it rolled away again, the boardwalk was empty.

Chapter 12

Rival in the Lantern Marsh

Rook didn't tell Kit what he had seen on the boardwalk. Not right away. He lay awake half the night in the bunk of the *Dandelion*, staring up at the little brass bird swinging on its string, thinking about an olive-green jacket in the mist.

In the morning, he told Kit.

Kit was sitting on the floor with half the ship's control panel taken apart around them, humming to themselves and holding three screws in their mouth. They spat out the screws. "Sola? Your rival Sola? The water-beats-fire Sola?"

"She's not my rival," said Rook. Then he thought about it. "Okay. She's kind of my rival."

"What's she doing all the way out here?"

"I don't know." Rook pulled on his boots. "That's what I want to find out."

* * *

The Lantern Marsh lay on the far side of Mirefen, where the giant mushrooms thinned out and the swamp opened up into a wide, flat stretch of still black water. Long wooden boardwalks wound across it on stilts, zigzagging from one little island of moss to the next. Reeds grew tall on either side, whispering in the breeze. Frogs croaked. Dragonflies as big as Rook's hand zipped over the water with wings that glowed faintly pink.

And everywhere, floating on the water, drifting in the air, were the lanterns.

They were made of paper. Thin, soft, colored paper, folded into the shapes of flowers and boats and birds and little round moons. Each one had a tiny glowing spore-candle inside it, so they shone soft gold and pink and green. Some floated on the black water like lily pads. Some had been made with little paper sails, and they drifted slowly across the marsh, turning in the breeze. Some had been made to fly, and they bobbed in the misty air above the reeds, rising and falling gently, like sleepy stars that had come down to rest.

There were hundreds of them. Maybe thousands.

And every one, Fenna had told them, had a name written on it.

Rook walked slowly along the boardwalk, reading the names as the lanterns drifted past. *Grandpa Oskar. Bluebell, the best frog. Auntie Mae. Pip. My sister Rosa, who I miss every day.* Each name in different handwriting. Some neat. Some wobbly, like a little kid had written them. Some so old the ink had faded almost to nothing.

One for every person someone missed.

Rook found that he had to stop reading after a while. It was making his chest hurt.

Plazmo floated close beside him, keeping his fire very low and careful near all that paper. Zib rode on his cap, lights dimmed to a quiet blue. Kit walked a few steps behind, with Sporix riding on their shoulders, not saying anything, which was how Rook could tell that Kit's chest hurt too.

At the very end of the longest boardwalk, where it stopped at a little round platform in the middle of the marsh, they found Sola.

She was standing at the edge of the platform with her back to them. Gloopa sat by her boot, wobbling gently. She was staring down at something in her hand, a little glowing screen, like a phone or a pocket computer, and she was so busy staring at it that she didn't hear them coming.

On the water in front of her floated one lantern. It was folded into the shape of a little boat, plain and white, and it hadn't drifted away yet. It was bobbing right there at the edge of the platform, as if it didn't want to leave.

On its side, in neat, careful letters, was a name.

Dad.

Rook stopped. He almost turned around. He almost walked away and left her alone. But Zib let out a small, soft "bip," and Sola spun around.

She saw them. Her face went through about five different things at once. Surprise. Embarrassment. Something that might have been happiness. And then, very quickly, like a door slamming shut, anger.

She shoved the glowing screen into the big pocket of her father's jacket.

"What are you doing here?" she snapped.

"I saw you last night," said Rook. "From Mirefen. On the boardwalk."

"So you followed me."

"No! Well. Kind of. I just wanted to see if you were okay."

"I'm fine." Sola folded her arms. "I'm totally fine. I don't need you checking up on me."

Kit stepped out from behind Rook. "Hi. I'm Kit."

Sola looked at Kit. At the goggles and the oil and the enormous toolbelt. Then at the knee-high mushroom riding on Kit's

shoulders, peering at her from under its cap. Her eyebrows went up.

"That's the Sporix," she said. "From the Observatory. The one nobody picked."

"Somebody picked it," said Kit, a little sharply. "Well. It picked me. Same thing."

Sola opened her mouth, then closed it again. For a second, she looked almost sorry. Then her eyes went to Zib, sitting on Rook's cap, and her face changed again.

"That thing," she said. "Do you know Helix wants it? They want it really, really badly."

Rook's stomach went cold. "How do you know that?"

Sola hesitated. She looked down at the lantern bobbing on the water. Then she pulled the glowing screen back out of her pocket and held it up, just for a second, so they could see. In the corner was a small orange ring with a diagonal slash through it.

"Helix messaged me," she said. "Three days ago. They found me in the Molten Frontier. They know who I am. They know about my dad." Her voice was getting faster now, the words tumbling out, as if she'd been holding them in for days with nobody to tell. "They said he was working on something before he disappeared. Something about a signal. A signal from the Starfall Crater. And they've been tracking it, and they're close. They're really close. They said they're closer to finding him than anyone's ever been." She swallowed. "They said nobody in Dustmere ever even tried."

"Sola," said Rook carefully. "Helix tried to steal Zib with a net gun. In a tunnel. They're not—"

"They told me about your saucer," Sola cut in. "They said it's dangerous. They said nobody knows what it really is, and it might be connected to whatever happened to my dad, and you're just

carrying it around on your hat like a toy."

"BIP!" said Zib, extremely offended.

"He's not dangerous!" Rook said. "He's my friend! He hummed a baby turtle out of a fern last night!"

"I don't care what he hummed!" Sola's voice cracked. She took a deep breath and pushed it back down. When she spoke again, she was calm and cold, the way she had been at the Trading Post. "I don't have time for this. I don't have time for you." She pointed at Rook. "But I'll battle you anyway. Right here. Right now. If I win, you stop following me."

"I'm NOT following you!"

"Gloopa," said Sola. "Go."

* * *

The platform at the end of the boardwalk was small and round, made of old wooden planks, with black water on every side. Lanterns floated all around it, glowing. It was not a good place for a fire-type to battle. Rook knew it the moment he looked around. One wrong spark and the paper lanterns would go up like dry leaves.

And it was a very good place for a water-type. There was water on every side. Water underneath. Water in the air, even, cool and damp, beading up on the rail. Gloopa wouldn't run out of anything here. Plazmo would be fighting with the whole marsh against him.

"Kit," he said quietly. "Can you move the lanterns back?"

Kit was already on it. They knelt at the edge of the platform and blew gently on the water, and Sporix puffed out little breezes of spores, and slowly, carefully, all the floating lanterns drifted back and away, until there was a wide circle of clear black water around the platform. All except one. The little white paper boat with Dad written on its side. That one Kit lifted out of the water

very gently and set down on the boardwalk behind them, safe and dry.

Sola watched Kit do it. She didn't say anything. But her jaw went tight.

Gloopa bounced out to the middle of the platform and sat there, wobbling, its bubble heart glowing blue. Just like at the Trading Post. Calm. Patient. Waiting.

Plazmo floated out to face it. His sparks were spinning fast. He remembered, Rook could tell. He remembered the corral, and the mud, and the wet dirt, and being so small he was barely warm. His eye was fixed on Gloopa and it was blazing.

And Rook did not say anything at all.

He just watched.

His heart was going like a drum. His hands wanted to make fists. Every single part of him wanted to shout *Spark Burst!* and get it over with, the way he always did. He kept his mouth shut. He made himself breathe.

Sola frowned. She had been waiting for him to charge. Everyone in the whole Kessler system knew Rook charged. He was a rush-ahead, shout-first, think-later kind of kid, and everyone in Dustmere had been saying so since he was four years old. She waited.

Rook waited too.

"...Gloopa," Sola said finally. "Bubble Wave."

Gloopa's middle swelled up. Its bubble heart glowed bright. It opened its mouth, and out rolled the wave. A great curling wall of shining bubbles, tall as a fence, sparkling in the lantern light, rolling across the platform straight at Plazmo. The old planks groaned under it. *WHOOOSH.*

"Up," said Rook.

Plazmo shot straight up into the air. The Bubble Wave rolled right under him and smashed off the edge of the platform into the marsh, *KER-SPLOOSH*, throwing black water so high it rained back down on all of them.

Sola's eyes narrowed. "Again."

Another wave. Bigger this time. Faster.

"Left."

Plazmo zipped to the left. The wave missed him by a hair. But only by a hair. The edge of it clipped his flame as it went by, and there was a sharp *TSSST*, and a puff of steam, and Plazmo spun sideways like a top and nearly went into the water.

Rook's stomach dropped right through the planks.

Plazmo caught himself an inch above the surface. He hung there, hissing. A whole side of his flame had gone dark and smoky, like a log somebody had splashed. He shook himself hard, and it crackled back, but thinner.

"Again!" Sola snapped. "Don't let him rest!"

Gloopa didn't. It didn't even close its mouth between waves now. It just poured them out. One, *WHOOSH*, and Plazmo dodged. Two, *WHOOSH*, and he dodged again, slower. The third one caught him low, scooped him up like a leaf in a gutter, and slammed him flat onto the planks. *WHAM.* Water went everywhere. Steam went up in a great white hiss, and for a second Rook couldn't see him at all.

"PLAZMO!"

When the steam blew away, Plazmo was lying in a puddle in the middle of the platform. His flame was flat. Sputtering. Spitting little gray wisps of smoke. He was trying to lift himself up, and every time he did, the water under him hissed and pulled him back down.

It was the Trading Post all over again. Rook could feel it happening. The mud. The fence. The old trader's hand going up. And that awful voice in his head, the one that sounded just like him, yelling *Again! Harder! Just throw everything!* His mouth was already open to shout it.

Plazmo looked up at him.

Soaked, smoking, half his size. But his one eye found Rook's across the wet planks, and held on. It wasn't scared. It wasn't asking to stop. It was asking what it had asked in Hank's tower. *What do we do?*

And Rook realized it was waiting. Plazmo was waiting for *him*. Not for a yell. For an answer.

Rook shut his mouth. He swallowed the yell. It was like swallowing a rock.

Think first.

"I've got you," he said. His voice shook. "Get up, buddy. Just get up. And keep watching her. Not the wave. Her."

Plazmo pushed. The puddle hissed. He pushed again, and dragged himself up out of the water in a cloud of steam, and floated, wobbling, back into the air.

Somebody behind Rook let out a breath. Kit.

"Again!" said Sola.

A third wave, wider than the other two, filling the whole platform from side to side, so there was no left and no right to dodge to.

Rook didn't panic. He had been watching. And he had seen something. Every time Gloopa made a Bubble Wave, it had to open its mouth. And every time it opened its mouth, it had to push all its water forward, out of its body, to make the wave. And for just a second, just one second, the bubble in its middle, its glowing heart,

was right at the front, not protected by any water at all.

But to get there, Plazmo would have to go over the wave. Not around it. Over it. Right through the spray at the top of the curl, where the bubbles fizzed hottest against his fire. One mistake and he'd be under it. And there might not be enough flame left in him to come back up.

"Plazmo," Rook said, very calm, even though he was not calm at all, even though his heart was slamming so hard he could hear it over the water. "Over the top of it. And then, right as it opens its mouth for the next one, Spark Burst. Small. Right at the bubble."

Plazmo didn't wait to be asked twice.

He flew up and over the curl of the third wave, so close the bubbles fizzed against his flame and sent up little puffs of steam, *tsst-tsst-tsst-tsst*, and the top of the wave curled over and smacked down on his back, *SPLASH*, and for one horrible second Rook lost him in the white. Then a ragged little flame came tumbling out the far side. Plazmo landed hard on the planks, skidded, smoked, and stayed up.

Sola's mouth had fallen open.

"G-Gloopa! Again! Bubble—"

Gloopa opened its mouth.

"NOW!"

Plazmo flung a Spark Burst. Not a big one. A small, fast, tight one, bright as a firework. It shot straight across the platform and straight into Gloopa's open mouth, right at the moment its bubble heart glowed at the front, before the water could close back around it.

FSSSSHHHHHHHT!

This time it wasn't a fizzle. It was a burst of steam, a big white puff that shot out of Gloopa like a kettle boiling over. Gloopa

wobbled backward. It jiggled. It slid across the wet planks and bumped against the rail, *thunk*, and made a startled, hiccupping sound. And for the first time ever, it looked hurt.

Plazmo did a loop in the air. A lopsided, wobbly, smoking loop. But a loop.

"We got it!" Kit yelled from the boardwalk. "Rook! You actually got it!"

Rook felt a grin spreading across his face. It had worked. It had actually, really worked. He had watched, and thought, and waited, and it had worked.

Sola was staring at her partner.

"Gloopa," she said. Her voice had gone small. "Gloopa, are you okay?"

Gloopa didn't answer.

Gloopa was glowing.

* * *

It started in the bubble heart. A soft blue light, getting brighter. Then the light spread out, through Gloopa's whole wobbly jelly body, until it was glowing all over like a lamp. Then brighter. Then brighter still, until it was too bright to look at, a blinding blue-white light that lit up the whole marsh. Every lantern. Every reed. Every ripple on the black water. The frogs stopped croaking. The dragonflies froze in the air.

Rook had to shield his eyes with his arm.

Through the light, he could just see Gloopa's shape changing. Stretching. Growing upward, taller and taller, and thinner, and more graceful. Things were unfurling from it, long and soft and flowing, like ribbons. Like streamers. Like someone unrolling silk.

And then the light faded.

Gloopa wasn't a little jelly dome anymore.

Floating in the middle of the platform was something tall and beautiful. It hung in the air beneath a tall, speckled bell, like a living lantern full of seawater, a whole head taller than Rook, and the bell glowed a soft, deep blue from the inside. Under the rim of the bell, a quiet face peeked out. Its bubble heart glowed right in the middle of it, just below that quiet face, bigger and brighter than before. And flowing down from it were long, long tentacle arms, dozens of them, rippling and swaying in the air like silk ribbons in a breeze, trailing little sparkles of water behind them.

It tipped its tall bell and looked down at Sola from under the rim, humming one low, watery note, like the sea inside a shell. Its eyes were gentle and calm and very, very old-looking, like it had just remembered something.

Sola's arms had fallen to her sides.

"Tidaloid," she whispered.

And for just a second, she forgot to look tough. She forgot to look angry. She forgot that Rook was watching, and Kit was watching, and that she was in the middle of a battle. She just looked up at her partner with her mouth open and her eyes shining, and she looked amazed. She looked the way Rook had felt on the bridge the night he met Zib. She looked about seven years old.

Then she remembered. Rook watched it happen. Her face closed up again, like a flower at night.

Rook's mouth had gone completely dry. Plazmo was hovering in front of him, panting little puffs of smoke, smaller than a candle now, and the thing he was facing was taller than Rook.

Plazmo drifted backward, just a little, until his warm, flickering side bumped against Rook's fingers. And stayed there. Not hiding. Leaning. The way you lean on somebody before you go

back out.

Then he floated forward again, all by himself, and faced Tidaloid.

"Okay," he whispered. "Okay. Together. Watch the heart, buddy. It's still the heart."

"Tidaloid," said Sola. "Tidal Whip."

Tidaloid raised one long flowing arm. It drew it back, slow and graceful, the water inside it sparkling, and its speckled bell glowed brighter and brighter as it gathered the attack.

And as it drew back, its bubble heart showed. Right there in the middle of its chest. Glowing. Open.

"Spark Burst! *NOW!*"

Plazmo threw everything he had left. Every last spark, squeezed into one tight, white-hot point, the way he'd learned against Anvilox. It streaked across the platform like a shooting star, straight at the glowing heart, and Rook's whole body leaned after it, and for one breathless moment he really thought...

Three silky arms swept across Tidaloid's chest. *FSSST.* The Spark Burst hit a curtain of water and went out in a puff of steam.

And then Tidaloid swung.

The arm cracked across the platform like a whip made of ocean, faster than Rook could follow, faster than he could even shout. *KRAAACK.* It caught Plazmo right in the middle and sent him spinning off across the marsh in a cloud of steam. He bounced off the water once, twice, like a skipping stone, and landed on a lily pad, which lit up pink.

His flame was down to the size of a candle. Then smaller. A birthday candle. A match. It flickered and leaned over and almost went out.

"Plazmo!" Rook was already running.

It was over. The old trader with the white mustache wasn't there to raise his hand, but nobody needed him to. Sola had won again.

Rook threw himself down flat at the edge of the platform, stretched out his arm as far as it would go over the black water, and scooped Plazmo off the lily pad. He was small and dim and soggy and hissing. He weighed almost nothing. Rook cupped both hands around him and breathed on him, gently, the way you'd breathe on the last coal of a fire.

The little flame shivered. It caught. It held.

And Plazmo's eye opened. It was not sad, like it had been after the Trading Post. It was fierce and bright and almost smiling. It seemed to say: *Did you see that? Did you see how close we got?*

And Rook realized, holding him, that he did not feel the way he had felt at the Trading Post either. He didn't feel like crying. Well. A little like crying. But not because he was ashamed. He didn't feel like it was all his fault. They had gone through every one of those waves together, and they had gotten back up every single time, and Plazmo had never once stopped looking at him.

We lost, he thought. *But we lost close.*

"Yeah, buddy," he whispered. "I saw. Next time."

Plazmo sneezed. *Pfft.* One small, soggy spark, and a puff of steam that smelled like wet campfire. Rook laughed, and his laugh wobbled.

He looked up. Sola was standing over him again, with Tidaloid towering behind her, its silky arms swaying. One of its arms, Rook noticed, was held a little close to its chest, right over its bubble heart, as if it still stung.

She didn't say anything mean this time. She didn't say anything about her dad. She just looked at Plazmo, and at Rook,

and then she said, very quietly, almost as if she didn't want to say it:

"That thing with the bubble. Where you waited." A pause. "That was good."

Then she turned around and walked away down the boardwalk, with Tidaloid gliding behind her.

Rook stared after her with his mouth open.

* * *

Plazmo needed warming up. Kit went off to find some dry wood and a bucket of clean water to make tea, because Kit had decided that tea fixed most things, and if it didn't, a wrench did.

Kit went back down the boardwalk. Past the reeds. Past the floating lanterns. And behind one of the biggest lanterns of all, a huge paper moon that floated on its own little raft at the edge of the marsh, they heard something.

A small sound. A sniffling sound.

Kit stopped. Kit peeked around the paper moon.

Sola was sitting on the edge of the raft, alone, with her knees pulled up to her chin and her arms wrapped around them. Her ponytail had come loose. Tidaloid was gone, back in her Linker. And she was crying. Not loud crying. The quiet kind. The kind where you try so hard to be silent that your whole body shakes with it.

The little white paper boat was in her lap. The one with *Dad* written on it. She must have gone back for it.

Kit stood there for a moment, not sure what to do. Kit was good at fixing machines. Kit was not good at this.

But Kit thought about the caboose. About hiding in the caboose when they were little, all alone, when everyone kept asking about Dad. Kit thought about how much they had wanted someone to

knock on the door. And how nobody ever had.

So Kit stepped out from behind the paper moon.

"Hey," Kit said softly. "Are you okay?"

Sola's head snapped up. She wiped her face with her sleeve, fast, so fast, the way Rook had seen her do at the Trading Post.

"Go away," she said. Her voice was thick and wobbly. "Just leave me alone."

Kit didn't move for a second.

"Okay," Kit said. "I'll go." They took a step back. Then they stopped. "But... Rook told me what you said once. About your dad laughing at him. For what it's worth? I don't think he would have."

Sola stared at them.

Kit went.

But Kit didn't forget. And as Kit walked away, they noticed something lying on the boardwalk, just past the edge of the raft. It must have fallen out of Sola's pocket when she pulled her knees up. A crumpled sheet of paper, folded small.

Kit picked it up. Kit hesitated. Kit knew they shouldn't read it.

Kit read it.

It was a printed Helix notice, with the orange ring and slash at the top. Most of it was boring. Times and numbers and code words Kit didn't understand. But in the middle, in bold letters, there was one line that made Kit's blood go cold.

SPORE HARVEST. MUSHROOM MAZE, SPOREHOLM. ALL UNITS. PHASE TWO PRIORITY. BEGINS TONIGHT.

Chapter 13

Lost in the Mushroom Maze

Kit ran the whole way back down the boardwalk and nearly crashed into Rook, who was sitting at the end of the platform warming Plazmo between his hands.

"Look," Kit panted. "Look at this."

Rook read the crumpled paper. Then he read it again. *Spore Harvest. Mushroom Maze. Phase Two priority. Begins tonight.*

"Phase Two," he said slowly. "That's what Pell said. In the tunnel. He said Zib was priority number one for Phase Two."

"And Fenna said the mushrooms near the Maze are going gray." Kit's face was pale under the oil smudges. "Rook, the spores are what keep everything alive here. The mushrooms glow because of them. The sporelings follow them home. If Helix takes them all..."

They didn't need to finish the sentence. Rook looked out across the marsh, at the hundreds of glowing lanterns, at the spores drifting through the mist like slow golden snow.

He stood up.

"Then we stop them," he said.

* * *

The Mushroom Maze grew in the deepest, oldest part of Sporeholm, a long paddle by swamp-boat from Mirefen. Fenna lent them her boat, a long thin canoe carved from a hollow mushroom stalk, and showed them which way to paddle. She

wanted to come. Her mum said absolutely not. Fenna argued for six minutes straight, and lost, and stood at the edge of the village with her arms folded and her freckles glowing very crossly as they paddled away.

"Be careful in the Maze!" she shouted after them. "It's easy to get lost! The mist comes in all at once! And whatever you do, don't follow the echoes!"

"What does that MEAN?" Rook shouted back.

But they were already too far away to hear the answer.

They paddled through the dark as the sun went down. The swamp got quieter. The mushrooms got bigger. And then, all at once, the trees ended and the Maze began.

It was like paddling into a forest made of giant stalks. Mushroom stems rose up out of the water on every side, thick and smooth and pale, so tall that their caps were lost in the mist far above. You couldn't see the sky. You couldn't see the stars. The caps overlapped high overhead like a roof, and the stems stood so close together that there were only narrow, twisting channels of water in between, winding off in every direction. Left. Right. Left again. Every channel looked exactly like every other channel.

The stalks should have been glowing. Rook could tell. They had the same soft shimmer as the mushrooms in Mirefen, deep under their skin. But here, the glow was faint and flickering. And some of the stalks weren't glowing at all. They were gray. Dull, ashy, sickly gray, like a burned-out candle. Their caps drooped. Their skin was cracked and dry.

Sporix looked at the gray mushrooms and made a tiny, unhappy noise. Its own cap went a shade paler.

Then they heard it. A deep, steady hum, coming from somewhere ahead. *Hmmmmmmmmm.* Not like the Choir's song.

Flat and mechanical and ugly. Like a giant vacuum cleaner.

And voices.

Rook and Kit pulled the canoe up against a stalk and crept forward on foot, along a narrow ledge of moss. They peeked around the edge of a huge gray mushroom.

In a clearing in the middle of the Maze, Helix had set up camp. There were white tents with the orange ring and slash on their sides, and floodlights on poles, glaring and harsh. And everywhere, standing at the bases of the mushrooms, were machines. Big white boxy machines on wheels, each one with a long flexible hose sticking out of it like an elephant's trunk. The ends of the hoses were pressed up against the mushroom caps. And they were sucking. Sucking up the spores. Rook could see them going in, little streams of golden light vanishing into the hoses, *shhhluuuurp*, and the mushroom caps fading to gray behind them.

Thick black cables ran out of the back of every machine, snaking away across the ground and disappearing into the mist.

Helix workers in white jumpsuits were walking between the machines with clipboards, checking dials, writing things down, as calm and busy as people in a factory. Nobody was shouting. Nobody was hurrying. Somehow that was worse. Two Skitterdrones hung in the air above the tents, their dish wings turning slowly, listening to the Maze.

And at the edge of the floodlights, with his visor pushed up and a glowing screen in one hand, stood Pell.

Rook had never seen his face before. He was younger than Rook had expected, with a sharp, narrow face and short, neat hair. He looked tired. Beside him stood Strand, visor still down, holding a clipboard he wasn't reading.

"Sector nine is down to forty percent," Pell said, scrolling. "We're behind."

"Pell." Strand didn't look up. "Look at the stalks."

"I've seen the stalks."

"The ones we did last night. They're not growing back. Nothing's growing back."

Pell's thumb stopped on the screen. "They told us it's temporary."

"Do you believe that?"

For a moment Pell didn't answer. Then he lowered the screen.

"You know what my father did, Strand? Ran a water pump out in the dunes on Dustara. Thirty-one years. Fixed it every time it broke. Nobody ever knew his name. Nobody ever came out to see him." He looked up at the floodlights, at the orange ring on the nearest tent. "Helix came out. Helix put up the masts and the grid and the school roofs, and now there's music in places that never had anything. When the Director says something matters, it's because he can see further than we can. That's what believing in something *means*."

Strand said nothing.

"And when Phase Two is done," Pell went on, more quietly, "the people who did it won't be standing in a swamp at midnight. They'll be on the Station. I'm going to be one of them." He glanced sideways. "You could be too. If you'd stop asking questions out loud."

Strand turned the clipboard over in his hands. "I heard one of the lab people talking," he said, even more quietly. "They said the spores are pulsing. All over Sporeholm. In time with something. Something back at the Starfall Crater. They said they're using them to measure it." He swallowed. "They said it's like a

heartbeat. Getting faster."

Pell didn't say anything.

"They said it's for Phase Three. They said Phase Three is something to do with a door."

Pell went very still. Then he reached up and pulled his visor down, and Rook couldn't see his face anymore.

"Then it's above our clearance," he said. His voice was perfectly level. "And you don't repeat it. Not on the radio. Not in the mess hall. Not even to me. If Admin Vex finds out you've been listening at lab doors..."

Strand's shoulders hunched. "Don't say her name. People say she can hear through walls."

"People say a lot of things," said Pell. But before he walked back toward the machines, Rook saw him glance over his shoulder, into the dark.

Behind the gray mushroom, Rook and Kit looked at each other. Neither of them knew who Admin Vex was. Neither of them liked the sound of her.

"Okay," Rook whispered. "We have to stop those machines. Here's what we—"

And that was when the mist came in.

* * *

Fenna had been right. It came all at once.

One moment, Rook could see the clearing, and the machines, and Kit crouched right beside him. The next moment, there was a soft sighing sound, like the whole Maze breathing out, and a wall of thick, white, glowing mist came rolling through the stalks like a wave. It swallowed the floodlights. It swallowed the tents. It swallowed the gray mushroom they were hiding behind.

It swallowed Kit.

"Kit?" Rook whispered. He reached out to where Kit had been. His hand closed on nothing. "Kit!"

Kit... Kit... Kit... The Maze threw his voice back at him from every direction at once, bouncing off the stalks. *Kit... it... it...*

"KIT!"

KIT! Kit! it... it...

He heard Kit's voice calling back. "ROOK?" But it came from the left. And then from the right. And then from behind him. And then from above. The echoes tangled it all up, like yarn in a cat's paws. *Rook? Rook? ook... ook...*

Don't follow the echoes, Fenna had said.

Rook stood very still in the mist, with his heart pounding, and Plazmo glowing beside him, and Zib clinging tight to his cap. He had no idea which way to go.

* * *

On the other side of the clearing, though neither of them knew it, Kit was standing just as still, with Sporix clutched against their chest.

Kit turned around. Mist. Turned again. Mist. Kit called for Rook until their throat was sore, and every time, a dozen Rooks called back from a dozen directions, and none of them were real.

Kit sat down on a root, very suddenly, because their legs had stopped working.

"I can't do this," Kit whispered. Their hands were shaking. Their whole body was shaking. "I can't. Rook's the brave one. Rook's the one who charges in and has the ideas and battles Keepers. I just fix stuff." They pressed their goggles against their eyes. "I'm just the one standing at the back. Holding a wrench."

The mist pressed in, cold and wet and silent. The ugly hum of the machines went on and on, somewhere out there in the white.

Sporix wriggled.

It wriggled out of Kit's arms, climbed up onto Kit's shoulder, and sat there. And then it leaned over and bumped its soft little mushroom cap against Kit's cheek. Gently. Once. Twice.

Kit lowered their goggles and looked at it.

Sporix bumped them again. Its big shy eyes were looking right into Kit's. And they were not shy at all. They were steady and sure. They seemed to say: *You can.*

Remember the falling beam at the Forge Camp? the eyes seemed to say. *I was scared then, too. I did it anyway. And you were the one who looked at me first.*

Kit took a deep breath. It shook on the way in. They took another one. It shook a little less.

"Okay," Kit whispered. "Okay. Okay okay okay."

They stopped trying to look for Rook. They stopped thinking about the mist and the echoes and how lost they were. Instead, Kit did the thing Kit always did when something was broken and nobody knew how to fix it.

Kit looked at it like a machine.

What do I know? Kit thought. The vacuums are sucking up the spores. The vacuums need power to work. The power comes through the cables. Kit had seen the cables. Thick and black, running out of the back of every machine, all heading the same way.

All heading the same way.

Kit dropped to their hands and knees and felt along the mossy ground in the mist. There. Their fingers closed around something thick and smooth and rubbery, buzzing faintly with electricity. A cable.

And a cable, Kit thought, their heart starting to pound for a different reason now, always leads somewhere.

"Sporix," Kit whispered. "Quiet as mice. Okay?"

Sporix nodded.

They crawled along the cable, through the mist, hand over hand. It led them between the stalks, around a corner, over a root, past a Helix worker who was walking right by them with a clipboard and humming to himself and never even looked down. It joined up with another cable. Then another. Then six more, all twisting together into one big fat black rope as thick as Kit's arm. And it led them, finally, to a big gray metal box sitting all alone in a little clearing, humming loudly to itself, with warning stickers all over it and one big red lever on the front.

The power box.

A box like that, Kit thought, always has a switch.

Kit reached up, took hold of the big red lever with both hands, and pulled it down.

CLUNK.

All across the Maze, every single vacuum sputtered. Coughed. Wheezed. And died.

The ugly hum stopped. The silence was so sudden that it rang.

And then, from out in the mist, came a sound like a hundred soft sighs. *Pfffff. Pfffff. Pfffff.* Every hose on every machine went limp. And out of every one of them, all at once, came the spores. All the stolen spores, every single one, puffing back out into the air in great glittering golden clouds. They went swirling up into the mist, and spreading out, and drifting back toward the mushrooms where they belonged.

Wherever they landed, the gray mushrooms began to glow again.

Out in the mist, nobody yelled.

That was the first thing Kit noticed, and it made the back of their neck go cold. There was no shouting. No crashing about. Just a pause, and then one voice cutting through the white, calm and clipped and much too close.

"Power's down. That's not a fault. That's a lever." Pell. "Junction box, south side. Drones up. Strand, take the east cables. Nobody leaves the clearing."

A lever, Kit thought, *can be pushed back up.*

Kit grabbed the big black cable where it plugged into the bottom of the box, braced one boot against the metal, and pulled with everything they had. It came loose with a fat *thunk*. Kit hauled it hand over hand and flung the end of it as far out into the mist as they could.

Then they heard it.

Click-click. Click-click.

A thin, dry buzzing, like a wasp in a jar. Coming slowly along the cables. Coming toward the box.

Kit pressed back against the cold side of the power box and didn't breathe. A shape floated out of the white: a hard white shell and two round wings shaped like little satellite dishes, swiveling, twitching, listening. The dishes turned one way. Then the other. Then, slowly, toward the box.

Toward the sound of Kit's heart, which was pounding so hard Kit was sure the whole Maze could hear it.

Sporix moved first. It leaned down off Kit's shoulder, and puffed.

Not a little puff. Every white spot on its cap opened at once, and a great soft cloud of glittering spores went rolling out into the mist, joining all the golden spores already swirling out of the dead

hoses. All at once the air was full of them, drifting and whispering and shimmering, thousands and thousands of tiny sounds.

The Skitterdrone's dishes jerked. Left. Right. Up. Left again. It was listening to everything at once, and it couldn't find anything at all.

Kit didn't wait. They crept backward into the white, one slow step at a time, one hand trailing along a cable so they wouldn't get lost, until the clicking faded behind them and Pell's voice was only a murmur and their legs finally gave out.

Kit sat down hard on the moss and started laughing, a shaky, breathless, can't-quite-believe-it laugh, with one hand clamped over their mouth to keep it quiet. Sporix bounced up and down on their shoulder, puffing out tiny happy golden sparkles.

"We did it," Kit whispered. "We actually did it. Just us."

Sporix bumped its cap against Kit's cheek one more time. *Told you.*

* * *

Meanwhile, Rook was very, very lost.

He had tried walking left. He had tried walking right. He had tried following Plazmo, who was trying very hard but was no better at mazes than Rook was. He had tried calling for Kit until the echoes made his head spin. Now the mist was so thick and so dark that even Plazmo's glow barely reached past his own hand. Zib was flashing his lights, trying to light the way, but the mist just swallowed them up.

Rook stopped. He leaned against a stalk. He took a deep breath.

Think first.

But there wasn't anything to think about. That was the problem. Everything looked the same. Every way was the wrong way.

Something soft bumped his leg.

Rook yelped and nearly jumped out of his boots. Plazmo flared up bright.

There, at his feet, blinking up at him, was a slug.

It was a big slug, as long as Rook's forearm, round and smooth and squishy-looking. And it was glowing. Its soft body glowed all over, from the inside, a bright, steady lime green, like a glow stick at a night fair. Over its back it wore a dark purple mantle, like a little cloak, dotted with spots that glowed green too, and the edges of its body curled out into slimy purple frills. Two long, wobbly eyestalks rose from the top of its head, with a round green eye at the end of each one. It looked up at Rook with them, and it seemed to be smiling.

"Oh," said Rook. His heart was still pounding. "Hi. You scared me."

The slug blinked. Then it turned around, very slowly, the way slugs do everything, and slid off a few feet into the mist. Then it stopped. And looked back at him.

"You want me to follow you?"

The slug's glow pulsed a little brighter.

Rook hesitated. Don't follow the echoes. But this wasn't an echo. This was a slug. And it was glowing. And it was the first thing in the whole Maze that seemed to know where it was going.

He followed.

The slug led him slowly through the mist. It went left, then right, then right again, then squeezed under a root that Rook had to crawl beneath. Everywhere it went, it lit up the way in its lime-green glow, and the mist seemed to part around it, just a little. It never hurried. It never stopped. And every so often, it looked back to make sure he was still there.

And as they went, the mist began to thin. The glow of the mushrooms got brighter. The air smelled sweeter. And then, quite suddenly, Rook stepped out of the last of the mist into a clearing full of soft golden light, and found himself on the bank of the channel, right next to Fenna's canoe.

He let out a breath so big it made his knees wobble.

The slug sat on the moss beside him, glowing quietly, looking pleased with itself.

"Thank you," Rook said. He knelt down. "Really. I'd still be wandering around in there if it weren't for you." He looked at the little glowing slug, so slow and so steady and so kind. "What are you?"

He held up his Linker. The screen lit up and showed him a picture. LUMISLUG. TOXIN-TYPE. GENTLE. ITS BRIGHT GLOW WARNS OTHERS TO KEEP THEIR DISTANCE, BUT IT MEANS NO HARM. FOUND IN MISTY SWAMPS AND DARK, DAMP PLACES. KNOWN TO LEAD LOST TRAVELERS HOME.

"Lumislug," Rook said. "That's a good name." He hesitated. "We're going on a really long journey. There are lots of dark places. Lots of places where people get lost. I don't suppose... would you want to come along? To light the way?"

The Lumislug looked at him for a long, slow moment.

Then it glowed brighter. Brighter than it had glowed all night. Bright as a little green moon.

Rook grinned and raised his Linker. The cyan beam, the swirl of sparkles, the sound of wind chimes. LUMISLUG. PARTNER CONFIRMED. And the Lumislug's warning glow softened, all at once, into a gentle shimmer, the way it would always glow from then on whenever Rook was near.

Rook had his first Lumislug.

* * *

But on his way out of the Maze, before he found the canoe, Rook had seen something else. He would think about it for a long time afterward.

It was at the very edge of the Helix camp, where the mist was just starting to thin. The floodlights were dark. Workers were moving between the dead machines with flashlights, quickly and quietly, checking hoses and following cables, and somewhere out in the white Rook could hear Pell's voice giving orders, never raised, never hurried. Over by the tents, a long hover-cart sat under a gray tarp, and under the edge of the tarp Rook could see the corners of little metal cages, stacked up and strapped down and ready to go.

One cage had been left behind. It sat off to one side, forgotten, with a Helix tag clipped to the front. And inside it was a tiny captured sporeling. A little round one with a leaf on its head, curled up in the corner, its glow almost gone.

And standing next to the cage, all alone, was Strand.

Rook had ducked behind a stalk and watched.

Strand looked toward the tents. He looked toward the dark. Nobody was watching. Then he knelt down, very quickly, and opened the cage door.

The little sporeling blinked up at him.

"Go on," Strand whispered. "Go home. Quickly."

The sporeling hopped out of the cage and vanished into the glowing mist.

The radio on Strand's shoulder crackled. "Strand. Status."

Strand touched it. "East cables clear," he said. "Cages secure." His voice didn't shake at all. Rook wondered how many times he had practiced saying things like that.

Strand stood up. He brushed off his knees. He pushed up his visor and rubbed his eyes. He turned around.

And he saw Rook, peeking out from behind the stalk.

They stared at each other. Rook didn't move. Strand didn't move. Rook could see his face clearly for the first time. He was older than Rook had thought, or maybe he just looked older, with round cheeks and worried eyes and a kind, tired face.

Rook waited for him to shout. One word into that radio, and Pell and the drones would be here in seconds. Strand's hand went to the radio.

And stayed there.

Then he took it away, and put one finger to his lips.

Shhhh.

"You didn't see that," he breathed. "And I didn't see you."

Then he pulled his visor back down and walked away toward the tents. Not hurrying. The way you walk when you don't want anybody to wonder where you've been.

* * *

Kit found Rook at the canoe an hour later, following the cables back. They hugged so hard they both nearly fell into the channel. Then they both started talking at once, and stopped, and laughed, and started again. Kit told Rook about the power box. Rook told Kit about the Lumislug, who was now riding on the front of the canoe like a little green headlight.

He told Kit about Strand, too.

Kit was quiet for a long time after that.

"Maybe," Kit said finally, "not everybody in Helix is the same."

They paddled out of the Maze together. Behind them, the mushrooms were glowing again, gold and green and violet, brighter than ever. The spores were back where they belonged,

drifting through the air in great slow golden clouds.

And then, all at once, they did something strange.

Every spore in the Maze flickered. Every one, all together, at exactly the same moment, as if someone had flipped a switch. Dark. Then bright. Then dark. Then bright.

On. Off. On. Off.

Like a heartbeat.

Rook stopped paddling. Kit stopped paddling. They sat very still in the canoe and watched the whole forest pulse around them, slow and steady and enormous.

On. Off. On. Off.

Then Rook felt something warm on top of his head. He looked up.

Zib was sitting on his cap. And Zib's lights were pulsing too. On. Off. On. Off. Exactly in time with the spores. Exactly in time with the whole glowing Maze.

And the strangest part, the part that made the back of Rook's neck prickle, was that Zib didn't seem to know he was doing it at all.

Chapter 14

Plazmet Ignites

The Sporeholm Relay Tower didn't look like a tower at all.

It looked like a mushroom. The biggest mushroom on the whole planet, bigger even than the ones in the Maze, rising up out of the middle of a wide, round lake. Its stalk was pale and smooth and enormous, wider than a house, and it went up and up and up, so high it disappeared into the glowing mist. And somewhere up there, at the very top, hidden inside its giant cap, Kit said, there would be a crystal. Just like on Ferrox.

"How do you know?" Rook asked.

Kit pointed. Carved around the bottom of the giant stalk, half hidden under moss, were the swirling marks.

Of course they were.

The lake around the tower was called the Spore Pools, and it was not really one lake at all. It was dozens of little round pools, all fitted together like the cells of a honeycomb, separated by narrow paths of soft springy moss. Each pool was a different color. Some glowed green. Some glowed violet. Some glowed a deep, rich gold. And the water in them was thick with spores, so thick that the pools looked less like water and more like liquid light, swirling slowly, as if something were stirring them from underneath.

They walked along the mossy paths between the pools. And Rook noticed that the spores in the water were pulsing. Just like in the Maze. On. Off. On. Off. Slow and steady.

He looked up at Zib. Zib's lights were blinking along with them.

Rook didn't say anything. But he put his hand up and touched Zib, gently, just to feel him there.

* * *

Inside the giant stalk of the tower was a laboratory.

It was round and tall and cool, with curving walls that glowed a soft, pale green. Spiral staircases wound up the inside of the stalk, and every level was covered with shelves and tables and glass jars. The jars were full of spores. Thousands of jars, each one labeled in tiny, neat handwriting, each one glowing a slightly different color. There were microscopes and notebooks and plants growing in pots everywhere, curling up the railings and hanging down from the ceiling. It was quiet in there. Peaceful. It smelled like rain.

In the middle of the floor, sitting cross-legged on a cushion with her eyes closed, was a woman.

She was tall and thin and very still. She had long, straight, dark hair with a single streak of silver in it, tied back in a low knot. She wore a lab coat, but not a white one. It had been white once, Rook thought, a long time ago. Now it was covered in moss. Soft, green, living moss, growing all over the shoulders and down the sleeves and along the hem, with tiny little white flowers blooming in it here and there.

She didn't open her eyes when they came in. She didn't move at all. She just kept breathing, slow and calm.

Rook waited. Then he waited some more. Then he started to fidget. Then he coughed.

"I heard you," the woman said, without opening her eyes. "I heard you come in. I heard you walk across the floor. I heard your partner sneeze on the stairs and the little one in your hat go bip." She opened her eyes. They were dark and calm and very sharp. "I

was waiting to see how long you could wait before you got impatient."

Rook went red.

"Forty-one seconds," she said. "Not bad. Most young trainers don't make it to ten." She stood up, unfolding herself gracefully, the moss on her coat swaying. "I'm Dr. Lysa Moor. I'm the Keeper of Sporeholm. And I study patience."

"Patience?" said Kit. "Like... waiting?"

"Like waiting," Dr. Moor agreed. "Mushrooms are patient. Moss is patient. Spores can wait for a hundred years for the right moment to grow. Everything on this world is patient." She looked at Rook. Her eyes were not unkind. But they were very, very sharp. "And I hear you are a boy who used to charge."

Rook blinked. "How did you—"

"Sporeholm is a small world," said Dr. Moor. "The spores talk. And everyone in Mirefen is talking about the boy who found Mother Willow's baby, and the engineer who turned off Helix's machines." Something that might have been a smile flickered across her face. "Thank you for that, by the way. Helix asked me for access to my tower last month. I said no. Two days later, I found a scratch on my crystal. Perfectly straight. As if someone had tried to cut it with a ruler."

Kit and Rook looked at each other. *Too straight,* Kit had said, about the crack on Ferrox.

"Now," said Dr. Moor, before they could ask. "I believe you came here to battle." She walked to the center of the floor, where a great circle was marked out in glowing moss. "Let's see if you have any patience."

* * *

Dr. Lysa Moor's Alienmon were Toxin-types.

Rook had never battled a Toxin-type before. He had only read about them. They were supposed to be rare, and strange, and tricky.

The first one oozed out of a jar on a high shelf and dripped down to the floor. *Splorp.* It was a blob of thick purple goo, like jam, with two lazy yellow eyes floating in it. It moved slowly. Very slowly. It barely seemed to be moving at all.

"Oozel," said Dr. Moor.

"Cactling!" said Rook. "Let's go!"

Cactling stomped out into the circle and threw a fistful of needles at the purple blob. They went straight into it. *Shlup. Shlup. Shlup.* And then they just... stayed there. Stuck in the goo, like spoons in pudding. The Oozel didn't seem to mind at all.

The Oozel oozed closer. Slowly. So slowly. Cactling threw more needles. *Shlup. Shlup.* The Oozel kept coming. It reached out one gooey purple tendril and touched Cactling, very gently, on the foot.

That was all. Just a touch.

But where it touched, a little purple mark appeared on Cactling's green skin. And Cactling winced. It hopped back, shaking its foot. It threw more needles. And slowly, the purple mark began to spread.

"Poison," Kit breathed. "Rook, it's poison. It doesn't have to hit hard. Every touch makes Cactling weaker."

Cactling did not care about poison. Cactling put its head down and charged, which was the most Cactling thing it could possibly have done, and punched the Oozel right between its lazy yellow eyes.

Its stubby fist sank in up to the shoulder. *SHLORP.*

And stuck.

The Oozel blinked. Then the whole blob heaved, like a wave rolling up a beach, and flung Cactling across the circle. *WHUMP.* Cactling bounced off the glowing moss border, rolled twice, and came up spitting, with a big purple splotch all down one arm.

Rook's stomach dropped. "Cactling, keep your distance! Needles from far away!"

Cactling fought bravely. It threw needles until its arms were shaking. It stomped and huffed and glared. But the Oozel just kept oozing, slow and patient, touching it once, and then again, and then again. *Tap. Tap. Tap.* And each touch left a mark. And each mark made Cactling a little slower. Its cream-colored spines started to bristle, stiff and ragged. The creamy flower in the middle of its body began to wilt, the petals curling in around its green eye like paper too close to a fire.

Finally, Cactling sat down hard in the middle of the circle. Its flower drooped. It was covered in purple spots, and it was breathing fast, and it could not get up. It planted one fist and pushed. Its arm buckled. It pushed again. It fell over sideways and lay there, still glaring at the Oozel with one squinted eye, as if glaring were the very last weapon it had left.

"Cactling!" Rook called it back into the Linker. "You were so brave. You were so, so brave."

He sent out Lumislug next. Lumislug was slow too, and gentle, and Rook thought maybe it could out-wait the Oozel. And for a while, it did. The two of them inched around and around the circle, glowing at each other. But then Dr. Moor called out her second Alienmon, a big, warty, grumpy-looking purple toad with spots that oozed green, called a Gloomtoad. It spat little bubbles of purple sludge that floated through the air and popped on whatever they touched. *Plip. Plip. Plip.* Lumislug's glow got dimmer

with every pop.

Then the Gloomtoad puffed its throat up huge and spat a big one.

KA-SPLAT.

It hit Lumislug side-on and knocked it right over onto its back. Lumislug lay there with its little foot waving in the air, its glow stuttering on and off like a flashlight with a dying battery. It rolled. It rolled again. It got itself the right way up, so slowly that Rook could hardly stand to watch, and it looked over at him, and it glowed, just once, as bright as it could.

Then Lumislug's glow went out, and it curled up in a little ball on the floor.

Rook called it back, with his throat tight. That was two down.

Now there was only Plazmo.

Plazmo floated out into the circle. He was already tired. He had been zipping in to help the others all battle long, bouncing off the walls, getting splashed by sludge. His flame was small and flickering, the size of a plum. There were purple spots on him too, dull little smudges in the orange, and every time he moved, he left a faint trail of purple smoke behind him.

"Spark Burst!" Rook shouted, before he could stop himself.

Plazmo flung a fireball. The Oozel slid right in front of the Gloomtoad and took it full in the middle.

FSSSSSHHH.

The fire went into the goo and went out. Just like that. Like a match dropped in a puddle. The Oozel jiggled. A little curl of steam rose off its top. That was all.

And then the Gloomtoad spat.

The sludge hit Plazmo dead center. *SPLAT. TSSSSSSSS.* His flame hissed and shrank and went dark purple at the edges, and he

dropped out of the air like a stone and hit the floor and skidded, trailing smoke, right into the Oozel's reach. A gooey tendril curled around him. Rook heard him crackle, high and thin, a sound like a fire trying to scream.

"PLAZMO!"

Plazmo thrashed. He flared. He tore himself free in a spray of sparks and wobbled up into the air, coughing little purple puffs, smaller than Rook had ever seen him. Smaller than a plum. Smaller than an egg.

Rook's hand was already on the Linker on his wrist. One button. Plazmo would be safe inside, and the poison would stop spreading, and it would be over. Nobody would blame him. Two Toxin-types against a kid who'd never even seen one. Everybody would understand.

Plazmo looked at him.

His flame was guttering. There was purple smoke drifting out of him. But his one big eye was fixed right on Rook, steady as anything, and he gave one small, hard shake, side to side. *No.* He wasn't asking to go back. He was asking what they were going to do.

Rook took his hand off the Linker.

And Rook felt it. The old feeling. Rising up in his chest like a wave.

ATTACK. That's what it said. *Attack, attack, ATTACK. Hit it with everything. Hit it NOW. Hit it as hard as you can, before it's too late, before you lose, before—*

He opened his mouth to shout it.

And then he closed it again.

Because he remembered. He remembered a dusty patch of ground behind his house, under two moons, one big and gold, one

small and silver. He remembered tossing pebbles, and pinecones, and wadded-up socks. He remembered lying on his back in the dirt with Plazmo on his chest like a little campfire, saying it out loud to the sky.

Think first. Then act.

Rook took a breath. He let it out slowly. His heart was slamming so hard his whole body shook with it. He let it shake.

"Plazmo," he said quietly. Not a shout. Barely louder than talking. "Watch her. Don't move until I say."

Plazmo's eye flicked to him. Then it went still.

And Plazmo floated in the middle of the circle, and did nothing at all.

On her cushion, Dr. Lysa Moor's eyebrows went up. Just a little.

The Gloomtoad spat a bubble of sludge.

"Dodge," said Rook. Plazmo dipped. The bubble sailed past and popped on the wall. *Plip.*

The Gloomtoad spat another. And another.

"Dodge. Dodge." Plazmo bobbed and dipped. He didn't attack. He didn't throw a single spark. He just watched, and moved, and waited.

Not every bubble missed. One clipped the edge of his flame, *TSST*, and he spun sideways, dimming, and Rook's breath stopped in his throat. Plazmo caught himself. He shook off a few sad sparks. He looked at Rook. Rook nodded, just barely, and Plazmo turned back to the toad and kept waiting. It was the hardest thing Rook had ever done. Harder than any battle. Standing there, saying *dodge* in a calm voice while his best friend got smaller and smaller, and not letting himself scream *ATTACK*.

The Gloomtoad was getting frustrated. Rook could see it. It puffed up its throat bigger and bigger. It spat faster and faster.

Plip-plip-plip-plip. The bubbles were flying everywhere now, popping on the walls, popping on the floor, sizzling holes in the moss, and none of them were hitting Plazmo. And every time the Gloomtoad spat, it had to puff up its throat first. And every time it puffed up its throat, it got a little more tired.

And the Oozel was coming too, slowly, slowly, creeping up from behind. Rook watched it. He watched it the whole time. He knew exactly where it was.

"Up," he said. Plazmo floated up, just as the Oozel's tendril reached for where he had been. It snapped shut on empty air. *Shlup.*

The Gloomtoad puffed up its throat one more time. Bigger than ever. It was huffing and wheezing now. It was so tired. Its puff took a long, long time. And for just a moment, just one single moment, it stopped. Mid-puff. Catching its breath. Its throat blown up like a balloon. Both its eyes squeezed shut.

Wide open.

"NOW!"

* * *

Plazmo blazed.

It was not a Spark Burst. It was not anything Rook had ever seen. It was as if everything Plazmo had been holding in, all battle long, all those dodges, all that waiting, every spark he hadn't thrown, came pouring out of him at once. His tiny, tired, battered flame exploded outward, bigger and bigger and brighter and brighter. Brighter than he had been at the Forge Gate. Brighter than he had been against Anvilox. Brighter than the Spore Pools outside, brighter than the whole glowing tower, brighter than anything.

VWOOOOOOOM.

A wave of heat rolled across the room. Jars rattled on every shelf, all the way up the spiral stairs. Papers flew. The moss on the floor flattened out in a ring, like grass under a helicopter. Rook threw his arm over his eyes. Kit dove behind a table. Dr. Moor sat perfectly still on her cushion, but her mouth was open, and the moss on her coat was blowing straight back.

Through his fingers, Rook could see Plazmo's shape changing. And he could see the purple spots. They were burning. Every last dull smudge of poison was glowing white-hot and shriveling away into smoke, like dry leaves in a bonfire.

He was stretching. Growing. The round ball of flame was pulling itself out long, longer, like a drop of honey being stretched between two spoons. One end of him became a head, bright and blazing and white-hot. The other end streamed out behind him into a tail, long and flowing and flickering, orange and gold and red, trailing sparks like a comet across the night sky. His two little spinning sparks had grown, too. They had stretched out and joined together into a ring. A glowing, spinning band of extra-hot plasma, white-gold and blazing, circling his middle like the rings around Glacia, humming with power.

And in the middle of it all, his one big eye opened. It was still Plazmo's eye. Rook would have known it anywhere. Curious and bright and fierce. But it was bigger now. And it was blazing.

The light faded.

Plazmo was gone.

In his place, hovering in the middle of the circle, his comet-tail rippling in the air behind him and his plasma ring spinning, was something new. Something magnificent.

Rook's Linker beeped on his wrist. He looked down at the screen, his hand shaking.

PLAZMET. PLASMA-TYPE. EVOLVED FORM.

"Plazmet," Rook whispered. And then, louder, so loud it echoed all the way up the inside of the giant mushroom: "PLAZMET! You EVOLVED!"

Plazmet turned his huge blazing eye toward Rook. And the eye crinkled up at the edges, exactly, exactly the way Plazmo's always had.

Rook grinned so hard his face hurt.

But the battle wasn't over.

The Gloomtoad's eyes snapped open. Its throat was still full, blown up huge, and it let all of it go at once. Not a bubble. A wave. A great rolling wall of purple sludge, roaring across the circle, *SPLOOOOSH*, as tall as Rook. And behind Plazmet, the Oozel reared up off the floor like a purple curtain, its tendrils spreading wide, ready to catch whatever came through.

Sludge in front. Goo behind. Nowhere to go.

If that wave hit him now, Rook thought, after everything, it would put him out. All the way out.

Think. There wasn't time to think. There was only time to trust.

"Okay, buddy," he said. "Let's see what you can do."

He didn't even need to name the move. Plazmet seemed to know. He pulled back, coiling his long blazing tail. His plasma ring spun faster and faster, humming higher and higher, until the whole tower was buzzing with it. And then he shot forward across the circle like a shooting star. Like a comet. A streak of white and gold and orange fire, so fast that he left a glowing line in the air behind him.

Comet Dash.

He went straight into the sludge wave.

TSSSSSSSSSSSSHHHHHHHH.

Steam exploded across the room, thick and white. Rook couldn't see anything. He couldn't see Plazmet, or the toad, or anything but steam and purple spatters and a glow somewhere in the middle of it all, a glow that was getting dimmer, dimmer, *dimmer*...

"PLAZMET!" Rook screamed. "GO! *GO!*"

The glow flared.

Plazmet burst out of the far side of the wave, smoking, streaming steam, his tail ragged, and he did not slow down. He struck the Gloomtoad right in its puffed-up middle. *WHOOOOOMPH!* The toad went tumbling backward, end over end, its throat deflating with a long *pfffffffffft*, like a balloon letting go. It rolled across the floor, slammed into the rearing Oozel, *SPLUDGE*, and the two of them collapsed in a heap, blinking, too dazed to move.

It was over.

The tower was very quiet. The steam drifted up the spiral stairs. Somewhere high above, a jar finished rattling and went still.

Plazmet hung in the air in the middle of the circle. Then his tail drooped. His plasma ring wobbled and slowed. And he sank, slowly, lower and lower, the way Plazmo used to when he was very tired, and Rook was already running. He skidded across the moss on his knees and caught him just before he touched the floor.

Rook reached out, very carefully, half afraid he might burn his fingers. But Plazmet's flame was warm, just warm, like a mug of hot cocoa, exactly like Plazmo had always been. He was panting little puffs of steam. His comet-tail was frayed at the end and sputtering. But his eye opened, and looked up at Rook, and

crinkled.

And he sneezed. *Pfft.* A tiny, happy spark.

Rook laughed, and it came out wet, and he held his partner against his chest, a lot bigger now and a lot harder to hold, and didn't care one bit.

Then Dr. Lysa Moor began to clap. Slowly. Calmly. Three claps. Then she stood up from her cushion, walked across the circle, and knelt down to check on her Gloomtoad and Oozel, who were tired and sticky and very surprised, but fine. She patted them both gently. Then she took a little green bottle from the pocket of her mossy coat, and without a word, she held out her hand for Rook's Linker. One drop of glowing green for Cactling. One drop for Lumislug. One drop, very carefully, on the end of Plazmet's tail, where the last purple spatter still clung. It hissed, and faded, and was gone.

"Spore tonic," she said. "They'll sleep it off by morning." Then she straightened up and looked at Rook.

"Forty-one seconds," she said, "when you came in." She tilted her head. "And just now, you waited for... I counted. Four minutes and twelve seconds. With your last Alienmon, poisoned and tired, and every reason in the world to panic." She smiled. It was a real smile this time, small and warm. "That's patience, Rook. That's real patience. Most grown-ups don't have it."

Plazmet lifted himself out of Rook's arms and floated up beside him, wobbly, but blazing proudly. Rook reached out and touched his partner's blazing head.

Some things change, Rook thought. *And some things don't.*

* * *

Dr. Moor handed Rook his second Signal Shard. It was a little different from the first. It glowed green instead of blue, like the

inside of a leaf held up to the sun. But it hummed the very same note. Rook held both Shards up together, one in each hand, and they sang to each other, a soft, sweet, two-part harmony that made the hair stand up on his arms.

Then Dr. Moor said, "Come with me. There's something you should see."

She led them out of the tower and across the mossy paths, to one particular pool at the very foot of the giant stalk. It was the biggest pool of all, and the brightest, and the spores in it were thick as honey, glowing pure gold.

And they were pulsing. On, off. On, off. On, off. Slow and strong.

Like a heartbeat.

"They've been doing this for weeks," Dr. Moor said quietly. She crouched down at the edge of the pool. "Every pool on the planet. Every mushroom. Every spore. All of them, all at once, pulsing in perfect time." She looked up at them. "I measured it. I measure everything. And I found that it matches a signal. A very faint signal, coming from very far away. From the Starfall Crater, back on Dustara."

Rook's breath caught.

"And it's been getting faster," Dr. Moor said. "A little faster every week." She looked down at the golden water, pulsing, pulsing. "I've studied a great many things in my life, children. And I don't know what this is. But I know what it feels like." She was quiet for a moment. "It feels like something out there is straining. Pushing. Like a door being pushed from the other side."

A door.

Rook remembered Strand's voice in the Maze. *They said Phase Three is something to do with a door.*

Kit had gone pale. Rook could tell they were remembering it too.

* * *

That was when Zib floated down off Rook's cap.

He drifted over to the new green Shard in Rook's hand, the same way he had drifted to the first one on Ferrox. Slowly. As if something were pulling him. And as he got closer, the Shard's hum grew louder, and the spores in the golden pool pulsed faster, and Zib's huge eye began to glow.

The beam of light shot up out of it, into the misty air over the pool.

And a picture appeared.

It was not a planet this time. It was a face.

It was a giant face, gentle and kind, and it was made of leaves and branches. Its skin was bark, smooth and silvery, like the bark of a birch tree. Its hair was a great, spreading tangle of branches, reaching up and out in every direction, covered in leaves that shimmered every color, green and gold and crystal-clear, like the crystal leaves of the forest in Rook's dream. Flowers grew in its hair. Vines curled around its cheeks. It looked like a great, ancient tree. And it looked like a mother.

She was smiling.

But it was the saddest smile Rook had ever seen. The kind of smile someone gives you when they are saying goodbye, and they don't want you to be scared, so they smile even though their heart is breaking.

And her eyes were closed.

Nobody moved. Nobody breathed. Even the spores in the pool seemed to stop pulsing for a moment.

Then the picture flickered, and faded, and was gone.

Zib's eye went dark. He sank down slowly, slowly, until he was hovering just above the golden water. His lights were barely glowing at all. Just a faint, soft blue, flickering, like a candle in a draft.

"Bip," he said softly.

It wasn't a happy bip. It wasn't a scared bip. It was a new kind. Rook had never heard it before. And somehow, he understood exactly what it meant, the way you understand a song in a language you don't speak.

It sounded like he missed her.

Rook knelt down and cupped Zib in both hands and held him against his chest, right over Nana Wren's badge, and didn't say anything at all. Sometimes there isn't anything to say. Sometimes you just hold on.

Kit sat down on one side of him. Plazmet settled on the other, his comet-tail curling around them both like a warm blanket.

Behind them, Dr. Lysa Moor was standing very, very still.

"That face," she said slowly. Her calm, patient voice had gone strange. "I've seen that face before."

Rook turned around. "Where?"

Dr. Moor was staring at the place where the picture had been.

"Carved in stone," she said. "On the old harbor gate. In Port Ember, on the Molten Frontier." She looked at the two Shards in Rook's hand, glowing blue and green, humming together. "The gate that's been asleep for twenty years."

Chapter 15

Port Ember

They said goodbye to Sporeholm the next morning.

Fenna came to see them off, along with what seemed like half of Mirefen. Mother Willow was there, wading at the edge of the swamp with her baby riding proudly on top of her shell, right in the middle of the little garden. The baby's one leaf was standing straight up like a flag. Grandmother Fern opened both of her ancient eyes, which Fenna said had never happened before, not once, not in a hundred years.

Fenna gave Kit a moss cloak, rolled up and tied with a vine. She gave Rook a little paper lantern, folded in the shape of a bird.

"For when you miss somebody," she said. "You write their name on it and float it on the water, and then they know."

Rook turned the lantern over in his hands. He thought about who he would write on it. He thought about it for a long time.

Then the old woman who had started the Choir song stepped forward and laid one wrinkled hand very gently on top of Zib.

"Sing to them, little one," she said, "wherever you find them."

Zib's lights went soft and gold.

The *Dandelion* lifted off with a cough and a rumble and a whistle from the kettle, and the glowing mushrooms of Sporeholm fell away beneath them, and the last thing Rook saw was a cloud of spores rising up into the sky behind the ship, glittering, like the whole planet was waving goodbye.

* * *

They flew back across the stars to Dustara. Back past Glacia and its glittering rings. Back past the giant spinning asteroid. Kit watched it the whole way, and didn't let go of the armrests until it was far behind them and there was nothing white and needle-shaped anywhere in the mirror. And then down, down, down through the smoky pink sky of the Molten Frontier, past the rivers of lava and the clouds of steam, to the turquoise sea.

Port Ember was a fishing village built on stilts.

The houses stood right out over the water on long wooden legs, dozens of them, crowded together like a flock of wading birds. They were painted every color: sunny yellow, cherry red, sky blue, mint green, with the paint peeling off in the salty air. Wooden docks and walkways ran between them every which way, zigzagging over the water, joined together by little rope ladders and hanging bridges. Fishing nets hung drying from every railing. Lanterns made of colored glass dangled from every roof, clinking in the breeze. Seagulls cried overhead. And everything smelled like salt and seaweed and frying fish and the faint, warm, smoky smell of the lava rivers far off on the shore.

The *Dandelion* landed on a big round wooden platform at the end of the longest dock, scattering a flock of seabirds and making an old fisherman drop his sandwich.

And before Rook had even opened the hatch, he heard the kids.

"WHEEEEEEE!"

He looked out. Out on the turquoise water, kids were racing. They were riding on top of big round bubbles. Huge, shimmering, see-through bubbles of air, as big as armchairs, bobbing and bouncing across the waves like beach balls. And inside each bubble, snug in the middle, sat a little round Alienmon no bigger than a cat, with two little flippers on its sides, a pair of big happy

eyes, a wide, cheerful mouth, and a pouch in its chest that puffed out more air whenever its bubble started to shrink. And each one had a kid sitting on top, holding onto a loop of rope, shrieking with laughter as they went bouncing over the swells. *Boing. Boing. Boing.*

"Bubbub!" Kit said, pressing their face against the glass. "I've only ever seen them in books! They're Hydro-types. They blow those bubbles out of a pouch in their chests, and they ride the waves inside them. They travel in big giggly groups, and they love giving rides. They'll carry you anywhere, as long as you don't pop them."

"Can you pop them?" Rook asked, alarmed.

"No," said Kit. "I just wanted to see your face."

* * *

Of course, they had to try.

A girl named Mina, who had a gap in her teeth and a fishing hook stuck in her hat for luck, lent them two Bubbub of their own. Rook's was called Splodge. Kit's was called Sir Wobbleton the Third. Rook climbed on top of Splodge, which was like trying to sit on a giant water balloon with a giggling Alienmon inside it. He slid off the left side. He climbed back on. He slid off the right side. He climbed back on and grabbed the rope and held on as tight as he could, and Splodge gave a happy gurgle and took off across the water like a rocket.

"WHOAAAAAAA!"

Boing. Boing. BOING.

Rook bounced. He bounced so high that for a second he could see the whole harbor spread out below him, all the colored houses and the docks and the steam rising from the lava cliffs far away. He came down with a splash. He bounced again. Salt spray hit him

in the face. The wind roared in his ears. Plazmet streaked along beside him, his comet-tail skimming the waves and sending up long hissing trails of steam, and Zib clung to Rook's cap going "BIP! BIP! BIIIIIP!" at the top of his tiny voice.

It was, Rook decided, the second-best thing he had ever done. The first was flying the *Dandelion*. It was very close.

Kit, meanwhile, had slid off Sir Wobbleton the Third eleven times, fallen into the sea twice, and gotten seaweed stuck in their goggles. On the twelfth try, Kit finally stayed on. Sir Wobbleton the Third went bouncing off across the waves with Kit clinging to the top, both arms and legs wrapped around the bubble, goggles crooked, screaming, and then laughing, and then laughing so hard that they nearly slid off again.

Cactling refused to try. Cactling sat on the dock with its arms folded and watched everyone with deep disapproval. Then, when it thought nobody was looking, it carefully dipped one stubby toe in the water, shivered all over, and went back to disapproving.

Sporix, wearing its mist bottle, rode on top of a very small Bubbub with a lot of seriousness and an expression of enormous joy.

When they finally climbed back onto the dock, dripping and sunburned and grinning, Mina was waiting with her hands on her hips.

"Not bad for landlubbers," she said. "Now. What are you really here for?"

* * *

What they were really here for was at the very end of the harbor.

Past the last stilt house and the last fishing boat, where the docks ended and the water went deep and dark, stood a gate.

It rose straight up out of the sea on two enormous stone pillars, with a great stone arch across the top. It was the same pale stone as the Forge Gate and the old bridge. But it was older-looking, somehow. Barnacles crusted the bottom of the pillars. Seaweed hung from the arch in long green ribbons. And the carvings that covered it were darker than the others, worn deep by a thousand years of salt and storms, so that they looked almost black.

And right in the middle of the arch, at the very top, was a face.

Rook stopped walking.

It was her. The face from Zib's memory. Carved in stone, with the barnacles growing on it and the salt wearing it smooth. A gentle face made of leaves and branches, with a great spreading crown of carved twigs. Her eyes were closed. And she was smiling that same sad, brave, goodbye smile.

Zib went very still on Rook's cap. His lights flickered.

"That's her," Kit breathed. "Rook. That's really her."

"Aye, that's her," said a voice. "The Lady of the Gate."

They turned around.

Sitting on an old upturned barrel at the end of the dock, puffing on a long curly pipe, was a squid.

It was a big squid. About as tall as Rook, if you counted the tentacles, which were draped over the barrel and the dock and a nearby coil of rope in a relaxed sort of way. It was a soft, rosy pink, with big round friendly eyes. It wore a small white sailor's hat, perched at a jaunty angle on top of its head, and a blue scarf knotted around where its neck would have been, if squids had necks. And the pipe it was smoking didn't make smoke. It made bubbles. Every time it puffed, a little stream of shining soap bubbles came drifting out of the pipe and floated off over the water.

Nobody else on the dock seemed to think this was strange at all. A fisherman walked right past and said, "Morning, Captain," and the squid tipped its hat with one tentacle and said, "Morning, Bill."

Rook stared. Kit stared. Plazmet stared so hard his plasma ring stopped spinning.

"You... you can talk?" said Rook.

The squid puffed out a long stream of bubbles. "Well, it'd be a bit difficult to run a ferry if I couldn't, wouldn't it, lad? Can't very well sell tickets in sign language. Not enough fingers. Well. Too many fingers. Same problem." It held out a tentacle. "Squid Sailor. Captain of the Deep Sea Ferry, these forty years."

Rook shook the tentacle. It was cool and soft and a little bit sticky, and it gave his hand a friendly squeeze.

"Deep Sea Ferry?" said Kit.

The Squid Sailor pointed with its pipe. Bobbing at the next dock over was the strangest boat Rook had ever seen. It was round, like a giant soap bubble, made almost entirely of thick clear glass held together with brass ribs. There was a little brass wheelhouse on top, and a little brass propeller on the back, and a sign hanging off the side that said DEEP SEA FERRY. DIVES DAILY. (NOT CURRENTLY DIVING.)

"Takes you down under the waves," said the Squid Sailor proudly. "Down where the light goes blue and the big ones swim. All the way to the old worlds at the bottom of the sea. Or it did, anyway." It puffed a sad little bubble. "Harbor Authority won't let her dive anymore. Too dangerous, they say, with the deeps acting up. Not till somebody comes along carrying four Signal Shards. Old rule. Older than me." It looked them up and down. "You wouldn't happen to have four Signal Shards, would you?"

"We've got two," said Rook.

The Squid Sailor's eyes went wide. Its pipe fell out of its mouth. It caught it with a different tentacle.

"Two?" it said. "Two. Well, now. Well, well, well." It turned and looked up at the great stone gate rising out of the sea, with the sad, smiling face at its top. "The harbor gate's been asleep for twenty years, lad. Ever since the night the stars fell. Folks round here say it only wakes for somebody carrying two Signal Shards." It looked back at Rook. "Never thought I'd live to see anybody try."

* * *

The whole harbor came to watch.

Word spread from dock to dock and house to house faster than a seagull can steal a sandwich. People came out of their stilt houses and lined the walkways. Fishermen stopped their boats. Kids paddled over on their Bubbub and bobbed in a big circle in the water. Mina sat on the end of the dock with her legs dangling over, chewing her nails. Even the seagulls went quiet and lined up along the railings to watch.

Rook walked to the very end of the very last dock, right up to the edge of the deep water. The gate towered above him, dark and silent and crusted with barnacles. Its stone face gazed down at him with its closed eyes.

He reached into his satchel and took out the two Signal Shards. The blue one from Ferrox. The green one from Sporeholm.

He held them up.

The moment they caught the sunlight, they began to hum. That soft, sweet, two-part harmony, high and clear. It rang out over the water. Every person on every dock heard it. Every Bubbub turned to look.

And the gate heard it too.

A deep rumble came up from somewhere under the sea. The water around the pillars began to shiver and ripple. Bubbles came streaming up from the dark depths. Then, at the very bottom of the left pillar, under the barnacles, one dark carving flickered.

Blue.

Then another. Then another. The light spread up the pillar, racing from carving to carving, burning through the barnacles and the salt and the seaweed, until every mark was glowing bright electric blue. It raced up and over the arch. It raced down the other side. The seaweed hanging off the stone glowed blue from the light behind it, like curtains in front of a window. And at the very top, the carved face lit up from inside, so that for one breathtaking moment the Lady of the Gate seemed to be glowing with life.

The rumble grew. The whole harbor shook. Lanterns swung. Stilt houses creaked. Somebody's laundry blew off a line.

And then, inside the great stone arch, the air began to swirl.

Blue light, spinning around and around, faster and faster, like water down a drain. The sea under it was rippling in a circle. And then, with a sound like a giant breath being let out, the swirl opened.

A doorway. Shimmering. Rippling. Blue as the inside of a wave.

And through it, Rook could see another world.

The whole harbor exploded into cheers.

* * *

Rook flew the *Dandelion* through the gate himself, very slowly and very carefully, with Kit gripping the back of his seat and everybody in Port Ember cheering from the docks. The Squid Sailor stood at the end of the pier waving its sailor's hat in one tentacle and its bubble pipe in another and blowing a whole

stream of farewell bubbles with a third.

There was the *whoosh*. The tingle all over. The flash of blue. The stomach-flip.

And then they were out the other side, and Rook had to stop the ship in midair, because he could not see where he was going through his own tears of surprise.

It was the most beautiful place he had ever seen.

It was a world made of sea. Turquoise sea, everywhere, in every direction, so clear and bright that he could see right down through it to white sand and coral far below, and schools of silver fish flashing like coins. Scattered across the water like pearls on a blanket were islands. Little round islands of pure white sand, each one with a few tall, skinny palm trees and a fringe of bright green jungle. Some were so small they only had room for one tree. Some were big enough for whole towns, with white houses and red roofs and lighthouses on the points.

And across the sky, arching from one horizon all the way to the other, were rings.

Enormous glittering rings. Not like Glacia's, which you had to fly to see. These were right overhead, huge and close and bright, sweeping across the blue sky in great silver-white bands, like a bridge made of diamonds. In the daylight they sparkled. Rook could only imagine what they would look like at night.

"Thalassa," Kit whispered. "Ocean world. Seventh ring." They had their face pressed so hard against the glass that their goggles had gone sideways. "Rook. Rook, look at it."

"I'm looking," Rook whispered back. "I'm looking."

Zib wasn't saying anything at all. He was floating in the middle of the bubble cockpit, turning slowly in a circle, his huge eye wide, taking in every bit of it. His lights were flashing a pale,

shimmering, rippling blue, exactly the color of the sea.

* * *

They landed on the biggest island, at the edge of a busy harbor town called Port Saltreach. It was bigger than Port Ember, with stone docks instead of wooden ones and big tall-masted ships with white sails. And on a rocky point at the edge of the harbor, overlooking the sea, rose a tower.

It was tall and white, like a lighthouse, with a spiral of blue tiles winding all the way up it like the stripe on a candy cane. And at the very top, instead of a lamp, there was a crystal, glowing a deep sea-blue against the bright sky.

As soon as Rook climbed down from the *Dandelion*, a woman came striding down the pier toward them.

She was tall, very tall, with broad shoulders and a sunburned face and short gray hair cut close to her head. She wore a long blue captain's coat with brass buttons and gold braid on the shoulders, and tall black boots that clomped on the stones. A brass spyglass hung from her belt. She walked like someone who was used to walking on the deck of a ship in a storm. Like nothing in the world could knock her over.

She stopped in front of Rook and looked down at him. Then she stuck out a hand.

"Captain Delia Marsh," she said. Her voice was low and rough, like waves on gravel. "I'm the Keeper here."

Rook shook her hand. Her grip was like an anchor. It nearly lifted him off the ground.

"I felt that gate wake up from all the way over here," Captain Marsh said. "Rattled every window on the island. So I thought, whoever's coming through that gate, I'd better have a look at them." She looked at Rook. She looked at Kit. She looked at

Plazmet and Zib and all the rest. Her eyes were gray and sharp, like a stormy sky. "You're young."

"Yes, ma'am," said Rook. "We're here to battle you. For a Signal Shard."

Captain Marsh didn't laugh. She didn't smile. She just looked out past him, at the sea, at the white sails, at the glittering rings across the sky. And her face went hard.

"Then I hope you're as tough as you look," she said. "Because we may have bigger problems."

She pulled the brass spyglass off her belt, snapped it open, and handed it to Rook.

"Out there," she said. "Past the last island. Have a look."

Rook put the spyglass to his eye. He saw the sea, blue and bright. He saw the islands. He saw the rings. And then, far, far out, near the horizon, he saw them.

Ships.

Not sailing ships. Starships. Three of them, long and sleek and white, hanging low over the water, circling slowly. Circling like sharks. On their sides was a shape Rook knew by now. An orange ring with a diagonal slash through it.

And behind them, bigger than the others, was a fourth ship. It was not white. It was black. Black, with bold yellow stripes down its sides, like a wasp.

"Helix ships have been circling my tower for a week," Captain Marsh said quietly. "Waiting for something. I don't know what." She took back her spyglass and snapped it shut. "And that black one showed up this morning."

She looked down at Rook.

"I've been sailing these waters for forty years, son. And I know what it looks like when a storm is about to hit."

Chapter 16

Ghost Ship

Night on Thalassa was even more beautiful than day.

Rook found that out the hard way, by lying on his back on the warm stone of the pier for so long staring up at the sky that he forgot to eat dinner. The great rings overhead didn't sparkle at night. They glowed. They glowed silver and pale blue and the faintest shimmering pink, arching across the whole dark sky like a bridge made of moonlight. And their light fell on the sea, so that the whole ocean glittered with long silver ripples, as far as he could see.

The water glowed too. Little creatures lived in it, Captain Marsh said, too small to see, that lit up when anything disturbed them. So every wave that broke on the shore broke in a flash of soft blue light. Every fish that jumped left a sparkling ring behind it. When Rook dangled his hand off the edge of the pier and swished it in the water, his fingers left glowing trails, like he was drawing with light.

Zib thought this was the best thing in the entire universe. He spent an hour skimming low over the waves, dipping the very bottom of his saucer in the water and then zooming up into the air to look at the glowing trail he'd made behind him. *Bip! Bip! Biiiiip!*

Kit sat beside Rook on the pier with their knees pulled up, eating a fish pie from a paper bag. Plazmet floated above them like a little campfire.

Sporix was asleep in Kit's lap, snoring tiny snores.

Captain Marsh had given them dinner at the tower, and a room with two hammocks, and a long, stern talking-to about not going anywhere near the Helix ships. Then she had gone up to the top of her tower to keep watch through her spyglass, the way she had every night for a week.

The harbor was quiet. The fishing boats were all tied up. The stilt houses had their lanterns turned down low. And out past the last island, the Helix ships still circled, slow and silent, their lights blinking red against the glowing rings.

That was when the other ship came.

* * *

Kit saw it first. They stopped chewing.

"Rook," they said, very quietly. "Look."

A ship was drifting into the bay.

It was not a starship. It was a sea ship, a big old cargo boat, long and low and dark, with a tall smokestack and two rusty cranes on its deck. It was coming in very slowly, sliding across the glowing water without a sound. No engine noise. No horn. No splash of oars.

And no lights.

Not one. Not on the deck, not in the portholes, not on the mast. It was completely, totally dark. The only light on it at all was the faint blue glow of the water lapping against its sides.

And there was nobody at the wheel.

Rook could see the wheelhouse clearly, up at the back of the deck. The windows were dark. The door was swinging open. And the big wooden wheel was turning slowly, all by itself, a little bit left, a little bit right, as the ship drifted wherever the tide wanted to take it.

It bumped gently into the end of the outermost dock with a long, low, wooden groan. *Creeeeeak.* And stopped.

Up and down the harbor, doors were opening. People were coming out onto their porches in their nightclothes, holding lanterns. An old fisherman with a white beard and a woolly hat came shuffling down the pier toward them, and stopped, and stared at the dark ship, and went pale.

"Ghost ship," he whispered.

"Ghost ship?" said Rook.

"Comes in on the tide sometimes. No crew. No lights. No name." The old fisherman made a funny sign with his fingers, like a little wave. "Bad luck, lad. Very bad luck. Nobody goes near a ghost ship." He backed away, shaking his head, still making the sign. "Nobody."

Rook watched him go. Then he looked at the ship.

Then he stood up.

"Rook," said Kit. "No."

"I just want to look."

"Nobody goes near a ghost ship. He literally just said that. He said it TWICE."

"I know. But think about it." Rook pointed. "That's a cargo ship. Cargo ships carry stuff. And it came in from out there, from the same direction as the Helix ships. What if it's theirs? What if there's something on it we need to know about?"

Kit opened their mouth to argue. Then they closed it again. Rook could see them thinking it through, the way they thought through a broken engine.

"...I hate it when you make sense," Kit muttered, and stood up too.

* * *

The ghost ship was much bigger up close.

Its sides rose up above them, dark and rusty and streaked with old salt, like a wall. A rope ladder hung down over the side, swaying gently. Rook grabbed it and started to climb. Kit came up after him, muttering under their breath with every rung. Plazmet floated up alongside them, glowing, and Zib rode on Rook's cap with his lights turned low and nervous.

They climbed over the rail and onto the deck.

It was very quiet.

The deck was empty. Ropes lay coiled where they had been dropped. A bucket lay on its side, rolling slowly back and forth as the ship rocked. *Clunk. Clunk.* A coat hung on a hook by the wheelhouse door, swinging. It looked like everybody had just stood up and walked away in the middle of whatever they had been doing.

The ship creaked. It creaked all over, from bow to stern, a long low groaning creak, as if it were alive and didn't like having visitors.

And then the lights came on.

All of them. All at once. Every lamp on the deck, every bulb in every porthole, blazing on with a *FZZT*.

Rook and Kit grabbed each other.

Then the lights went off again. Then on. Then off. On, off, on, off, flickering and buzzing and stuttering, so that the whole deck jumped in and out of the dark like pictures in a flip book.

"Old wiring," Kit said, in a voice that was trying very hard to sound like an engineer and not like a terrified person. "It's just old wiring. Salt gets in the connections. Happens all the time. Totally normal. Totally, totally normal."

The lights went off and stayed off.

And from somewhere deep below their feet, down in the belly of the ship, came a sound.

Hooooooooowwwwwwwwl.

It was long and high and wobbly and terrible. It went up and up and up, and then broke, and then wavered, and then went up again. It echoed through the whole ship, through the metal walls and the wooden deck and the soles of Rook's boots. It was the loneliest sound he had ever heard.

Kit grabbed Rook's arm so hard that it left fingerprints. Rook could see them in the morning: five little red marks, like a bracelet.

"That," whispered Kit, "is not old wiring."

Hooooooooowwwwwwwwl.

"It's coming from down there," said Rook. He pointed at a dark hatch in the middle of the deck, with a metal staircase going down into blackness.

"Great," said Kit. "Fantastic. Down into the dark. Where the howling is. Wonderful plan."

Rook looked at the dark hatch. His heart was going so fast he could hear it. Every bit of him wanted to turn around, climb back down the ladder, and run all the way back to Captain Marsh's tower and get into his hammock and pull the blanket over his head.

But he thought about the howl. How lonely it sounded.

And he thought about Sporix, alone in a capsule in the Observatory, waiting for somebody to look at it. And the little rusty Gleamgrub, alone in the scrap heap, guarding the Cogglets. And the baby Mossback, alone under the fern in the mist.

"That doesn't sound scary," he said slowly. "I mean, it does. But it doesn't sound like something that wants to scare us. It sounds

like something that's scared."

Kit looked at him for a long moment.

Then Kit took a deep breath, let go of his arm, and nodded at Rook's Linker.

"Lumislug," Kit said. "You'd better lead."

Rook let out Lumislug. It slid out onto the deck in a swirl of sparkles, blinked at them sleepily, and then lit up. Its soft lime-green nightlight glow spread out across the dark deck, steady and calm, and somehow everything seemed a little less frightening in its light.

It slid over to the edge of the hatch. It looked back at them, the way it had in the Mushroom Maze.

Then it started down the stairs.

* * *

They went down, down, down into the dark hold of the ghost ship.

The stairs were steep and metal and clanged under their boots. At the bottom was a long corridor, narrow and low, with pipes running along the ceiling that dripped cold water down the backs of their necks. Doors lined the walls, all of them closed. The air smelled like rust and old seawater and something else, something sharp, like the inside of a hospital.

Hoooooowwwwl.

Louder now. Closer.

They went down another set of stairs. And another. Lumislug led the way, slow and steady, its glow lighting up the walls around them. The ship creaked and groaned. Somewhere, something dripped. *Plink. Plink. Plink.* Plazmet kept his flame turned low so he wouldn't scare whatever was down there, and his long tail flickered nervously behind him.

HOOOOOWWWWWWL.

They turned the last corner.

The corridor opened up into a big dark room at the very bottom of the ship. The cargo hold. Lumislug slid forward into the middle of it and glowed as bright as it could, and its lime-green light swept across the floor and up the walls.

And there, in the middle of the floor, sitting all alone in a little pool of Lumislug's light, was the monster.

It was about the size of a grapefruit.

It was round and plump, with teal and hot-pink feathers all puffed up like a pom-pom. It had two tiny stubby wings sticking out of its sides, much too small for its body, with shiny chrome tips. It had two tiny chrome legs. On one side of its head was a little ear shaped exactly like a speaker. It had a beak shaped exactly like a megaphone. And it had two enormous, round, shiny black eyes, wet with tears.

It looked up at them. Its beak trembled. It pointed its tiny megaphone beak straight at them.

HOOOOOOOOOOWWWWWWWWWWWWL.

The sound that came out of it was so enormous that it made the pipes rattle. Rook and Kit both slapped their hands over their ears. Plazmet's tail stood straight up. Zib dove into Rook's collar.

Then the howl broke off into a hiccup, and the little bird sat there, sniffling, with its feathers all puffed up.

Rook slowly took his hands off his ears.

"Oh," he said.

Kit slowly took their hands off their ears too.

"Oh," Kit said. "Oh, you poor thing."

Kit's Linker beeped. They held it up, and the cracked screen flickered and showed a picture. CHIRPOD. SONIC-TYPE. VERY SMALL. VERY LOUD. COPIES ANY SOUND IT HEARS. HOWLS

WHEN SEPARATED FROM ITS FLOCK.

"It got left behind," Kit said. "It's just a baby. It got left behind when everyone else got off the ship, and it's been down here all alone in the dark, howling for somebody to come back."

The little Chirpod looked up at them with its huge wet eyes and hiccupped.

Kit knelt down slowly on the cold metal floor and held out both hands.

"Hey," Kit said softly. "Hey, little one. It's okay. We came. We heard you."

The Chirpod looked at Kit's hands. It looked at Kit's face. And then it hopped forward on its tiny chrome feet, one hop, two hops, three, right into Kit's hands. Kit scooped it up and held it against their chest, inside their jacket. The Chirpod burrowed in. It gave one last tiny hiccup.

And then it stopped howling, and snuggled down, and closed its eyes.

Zib peeked out of Rook's collar. "...Bip," he said, very softly, so as not to wake it.

Rook let out a breath he felt like he'd been holding since they climbed the ladder. He started to laugh, a shaky, relieved laugh. "A monster," he said. "The ghost ship monster. It's a pom-pom."

Kit was smiling down at the sleeping Chirpod. "The scariest pom-pom in the whole Kessler system."

Rook was still laughing when Lumislug moved.

It slid forward a little, deeper into the hold, and its light swept across the rest of the room. Across the far walls, where they hadn't been able to see before.

And Rook stopped laughing.

* * *

Cages.

The far walls of the hold were lined with cages. Rows and rows of them, stacked one on top of another, all the way up to the ceiling. Metal cages, with metal bars, and metal latches, and metal tags hanging off the front of each one. Big ones at the bottom. Small ones at the top. Rows of them going back into the darkness of the hold, farther than Lumislug's light could reach.

And every single one was empty.

The doors hung open. Inside a few of them, there were still things left behind. A food bowl, tipped over. A little scrap of blanket. A single loose feather. A puddle of something that glowed faintly green, like Sporeholm moss. And on the bars of one cage, low down, there were scratch marks. Little ones. As if something small had tried very, very hard to get out.

Nobody said anything. The ship creaked.

On a desk in the corner, under a single bare bulb, lay a big black book. A logbook. On its cover was a shape stamped in orange.

A ring, with a diagonal slash through it.

Rook walked over to it. His legs didn't feel like his own. He opened the book. The pages were filled with lists, in small, neat, careful handwriting. Dates and places and numbers. He turned to the last page that had writing on it.

He read it out loud. His voice sounded strange in the big dark room.

"'Final voyage. Cargo collected from Ferrox, Scrap Route. Sporeholm, Mushroom Maze. Thalassa, outer islands.'" He swallowed. "'Cargo delivered. All captured Alienmon transferred to the Station. Vessel to be abandoned.'" At the bottom of the page was a signature, sharp and spiky, written in purple ink.

"'Approved. Admin V.'"

Admin V.

Rook remembered Strand, in the Maze, shivering. *Don't say her name. People say she can hear through walls.*

Kit was standing very still in the middle of the hold, holding the sleeping Chirpod against their chest. They were looking at the cages. All of them. Up and up, row after row, back and back into the dark.

"How many?" Kit whispered. "How many did they take?"

Nobody answered.

Rook looked at the logbook. There were numbers on every page. Long columns of them. He started to try to add them up, and stopped, because the numbers were too big and his eyes had gone blurry.

Nobody knew.

* * *

There was one more thing.

Rook almost missed it. It was in the very last cage of the very last row, a small one, near the floor. The door was open like all the others. But inside, someone had left something.

A tiny folded blanket. A real one, knitted, a bit lumpy, made of soft yellow wool. And tucked into the blanket, a scrap of paper, folded in half.

Rook picked it up and unfolded it. The handwriting was big and round and wobbly, not at all like the neat handwriting in the logbook.

For the little one, so it's not cold on the trip. I'm sorry. I'm really sorry. —S.

Rook stared at the note for a long time.

Then he folded it up very carefully and put it in his pocket. He didn't know why. It just felt like something that shouldn't be left behind in the dark.

* * *

They climbed back up out of the ghost ship, with Lumislug lighting the way and the Chirpod asleep inside Kit's jacket. Nobody said much. When they got back to the pier, Captain Marsh was standing there in her long blue coat with her arms folded, waiting for them. She had clearly seen them go. She clearly had a lot to say about it.

But when she saw their faces, she didn't say any of it.

She just took the logbook out of Rook's hands and read the last page by the light of the glowing rings. Her face went hard. Harder than stone.

Then she put a big hand on each of their shoulders and steered them back to the tower, and made them cocoa, and sat with them in the kitchen until they were ready to go to sleep, which was not for a very long time.

* * *

The next morning, they set the little Chirpod free.

They took it down to the beach at sunrise, when the sky was pink and gold and the rings were fading to silver. Kit held it up in both hands. The Chirpod looked around, blinking, at the sand and the sea and the sky. Then it looked up, high up, at a flock of round teal-and-pink birds circling over the far end of the island.

Its whole body went stiff. Its feathers puffed out.

And then it opened its tiny beak and let out the loudest, happiest, most enormous howl Rook had ever heard. *HOOOOOOOOWWWWWWL!*

From far away, from the flock, came an answer. Dozens of howls, all at once, all together, rolling across the beach like music. *HOOOOWWWL! HOOOOWWWL!*

The Chirpod flapped its tiny, too-small wings. It flapped them so hard they blurred. And it lifted off Kit's hands, wobbling, dipping, nearly crashing into the sand, and then rising, rising, up into the pink morning sky, toward its family.

They watched until it was just a speck. Until it joined the flock. Until they couldn't tell which little teal-and-pink puff it was anymore.

"Good luck," Kit whispered. "Don't get left behind again."

Rook should have felt happy. And he did, a little. But mostly he couldn't stop thinking about the cages. All those empty cages, row after row, going back into the dark. All those food bowls and scraps of blanket and scratch marks. All those Alienmon who hadn't been left behind. Who had been taken somewhere.

The Station.

He was still thinking about it when the bells started.

They rang out from the top of Captain Marsh's tower, loud and clanging and urgent, the big brass harbor bells, the ones that only rang for storms. *CLANG-CLANG-CLANG-CLANG!* Then the bells from the other towers joined in, all across Port Saltreach, from every lighthouse and every steeple. Seabirds burst up off the beach in a white cloud. People came running out of their houses.

Rook spun around.

Out past the last island, the Helix ships weren't circling anymore.

They were coming in. Straight across the water, low and fast, all four of them, the three white ones and the big black one with the yellow stripes. Heading for the rocky point.

Heading for the tower.

Chapter 17

Harbor Under Siege

They ran.

They ran up the beach and across the sand and onto the stone streets of Port Saltreach, where everybody else was running too, but in the other direction. Fishermen were hauling their boats up out of the water. Mothers were scooping up kids. Shopkeepers were slamming their shutters. A man ran past carrying a goat. The bells clanged and clanged from every tower, so loud that Rook could feel them in his teeth.

CLANG-CLANG-CLANG-CLANG!

Overhead, the Helix ships roared past, so low that their shadows swept over the rooftops and the wind they made sent laundry flying off the lines. Three white ships. And the black one with the yellow stripes, bigger and louder than the others, its engines making a deep, angry *BZZZZZZZZZ*, like a giant wasp.

They were heading for the rocky point. For the tall white tower with the blue spiral stripe. For Captain Marsh's tower.

"The crystal!" Kit panted, running beside Rook with their toolbelt clanking. "Rook, the scratch on Dr. Moor's crystal, the crack on Dad's, they were TESTING. They were testing how to get them out. That's what they're here for!"

Rook didn't answer. He didn't have any breath left to answer with. He just ran faster.

Plazmet streaked ahead of them, his comet-tail blazing. Zib clung to Rook's cap with his lights flashing a frightened red.

They reached the bottom of the rocky point. The road up to the tower was steep and winding, cut into the cliff. And it was blocked.

Helix grunts held it. A dozen of them, in white jumpsuits and visors, spread across the road in two neat lines, the way people stand when they have practiced standing that way. Nobody was shouting. One of them was talking into a radio, calmly, reading out numbers. Above their heads hovered their Alienmon: buzzing bug-like fliers as big as dogs, each held up by two round wings shaped exactly like satellite dishes, which swiveled and twitched as they flew, listening to everything. Skitterdrones. They worked in pairs, sweeping back and forth above the road, clicking and buzzing to each other like a swarm passing messages.

And past them, halfway up the cliff road, Captain Delia Marsh was fighting her way up toward her tower.

She was alone. She had her long blue coat flying out behind her and her brass spyglass in one hand like a sword. Beside her, rolling up the road like a boulder, was the biggest Alienmon Rook had ever seen. It was old and huge and blue, a giant sea creature like a cross between a whale and a turtle, with flippers as wide as doors and a great heavy shell crusted all over with barnacles. It was shoving Helix grunts out of the way with its enormous head, gently but firmly, like someone moving furniture.

But there were so many grunts. Every time the old blue creature shoved one line back, the other line stepped up and closed the gap, calm and tidy, like a door swinging shut. And the Skitterdrones swarmed over its shell like ants, clicking, dish wings turning, pinning it down. Captain Marsh was barely moving forward at all.

She saw them. She shouted something over the bells. Rook couldn't hear it. But he saw her point. Not at the road. Up. At the

tower.

At the side of the tower, a long iron ladder ran up the cliff from the beach. A service ladder. For lighthouse keepers.

"She wants us to go up the back way," Kit breathed.

Rook was already running.

* * *

The ladder was slippery with sea spray and so steep that it leaned out over the waves. Rook climbed with his heart in his throat, not looking down, Zib clinging to his cap, Kit climbing right below him. Plazmet flew alongside, lighting the way. The bells clanged. The wind howled. The waves smashed against the rocks below, sending up great sprays of glowing blue foam.

At the top was a small round door. Rook shoved it open.

They tumbled inside, into the heart of the Harbor Tower.

It was a big round room, tall and white, with a spiral staircase winding up the walls toward the top. Blue tiles covered the floor in swirling patterns, like waves. Round windows looked out at the sea on every side. And in the middle of the room, running straight up through the ceiling like the trunk of a tree, was a great column of light.

It was the core. The crystal heart of the tower. It ran all the way from the floor up through the center of the tower to the crystal at the very top. It was made of the same glowing crystal as the Signal Shards, but huge, as thick as a tree trunk, and it was shining a deep, beautiful sea-blue. Rook could hear it humming. It was the same note as the Shards in his satchel. Deep and pure and steady.

And it was being taken apart.

Helix workers were swarming over it. They had built scaffolding around it, white metal scaffolding, and they were

standing on every level with tools. Big wrenches. Hissing cutters. Clamps and cables and pulleys. They were unbolting it. Rook could see it happening. They were unscrewing the huge brass bolts that held the core to the floor, one by one, and wrapping it in thick black straps, and hooking the straps to chains that ran up through the hole in the roof.

Up through the hole in the roof, Rook could see the belly of the black-and-yellow ship, hovering right over the tower. Waiting.

The core's hum was wavering. Getting fainter. Flickering, like the crystal on Ferrox had flickered.

Pell and Strand were there too. Rook spotted them at the edge of the room, beside a big crate. Pell had a glowing screen in one hand and was calling bolt numbers up to the scaffolding, crisp and steady, and the workers called back to him one by one as each bolt came free. Strand was at a winch by the wall, feeding chain up through the hole in the roof. Neither of them looked up. They were working the way people work when they have done a thing many times before. But they were both standing very straight. And every few seconds, Rook saw Pell's eyes flick toward the middle of the room, the way you keep checking on a dog that might bite.

Because standing in the middle of it all, in front of the core, was someone new.

She was tall and thin, and she stood with perfect posture, as if there were a string pulling her up from the top of her head. Her hair was cut sharp and short and asymmetrical, longer on one side than the other, and it was dyed a bright, startling teal, like the sea on a sunny day. She wore a sleek black uniform with silver buttons. And over her shoulders hung a cape. A long cape, down to her heels, striped black and yellow, black and yellow, like a wasp.

She had her back to them. She was looking up at the core, watching the workers, with her hands clasped behind her back.

She didn't turn around when they burst in. She didn't jump. She didn't even seem surprised.

"Ah," she said. Her voice was cool and smooth and bored, like someone reading a shopping list. "There you are."

Then she turned.

Her face was pale and sharp. Her mouth was a thin straight line. And her eyes were the palest blue Rook had ever seen, almost silver, almost white. They were as cold as ice. They looked at Rook the way you look at a bug on a windowsill.

"Admin Vex," she said. "And you are Rook. From Dustmere." The pale eyes moved to Kit. "And the engineer who switched off my harvest in the Maze." She said it the way someone reads a line off a page. "Field Agent Pell writes very thorough reports."

Across the room, Pell went still.

Rook remembered the radio crackling in the dark behind the asteroid. *Somebody a lot higher up than me is going to hear your name.* Pell had kept his promise. And now he was standing in the same room as the person he had made it to, and he didn't look proud at all. He looked like someone waiting to find out whether he was in trouble.

"Admin," Pell said. His voice was steady. "The boy's partner is an evolved Plasma-type. I'd recommend..."

"Twice, Pell." Admin Vex didn't look at him. "Twice you told me you would bring in the scout. And yet here it is. It walked in on its own."

A tiny pause.

"Yes, Admin."

"Keep the bolts moving."

Pell's jaw tightened. Then he turned back to the scaffolding and called out the next number, and his voice didn't shake at all. Over at the winch, Strand kept his eyes on the chain. But his hands, Rook noticed, had stopped moving.

* * *

Rook's heart was pounding so hard he could feel it in his ears. But he made himself stand up straight. He made himself look right into those cold, pale eyes.

"Give that core back!" he shouted. "That's not yours! It's Captain Marsh's! It's Thalassa's!"

Admin Vex looked at him for a long moment. Then she sighed. A small, tired, bored sigh, the kind of sigh you make when a fly is buzzing near your ear.

"It isn't anybody's," she said. "It's a crystal. A very old, very interesting crystal. And the Director needs it more than a fishing village does." Her pale eyes flicked up, just for a moment, to Rook's cap. To Zib. Something moved in them. Something hungry. "Hello, little scout."

Zib went rigid. His lights flashed red, red, red.

Rook stepped in front of him. "Don't you dare touch him."

"Touch him?" Vex almost smiled. Almost. "I wasn't going to. Not today." She tilted her head. "The Director says the scout will come to us on its own. When it's time." She turned away, back to the core, as if Rook had stopped being interesting. "Now run along. I'm working."

Rook's hands balled into fists.

"Plazmet!" he shouted. "Comet Dash! At the chains!"

Plazmet blazed. He coiled up, his plasma ring spinning, and shot across the room like a shooting star, straight at the thick black chains that ran from the core up to the ship.

Admin Vex didn't even look around.

She just snapped her fingers.

Something dropped down from the scaffolding. It landed on the tiled floor right in Plazmet's path with a heavy, wet *SPLAT*. Plazmet swerved, just in time, and went skidding off to one side in a shower of sparks.

And the something swung its tail.

WHAP. It caught Plazmet in midair, a long, heavy, dripping lash, and flung him sideways into the scaffolding. He hit a white metal pole with a *CLANNNG* that shook the whole frame. A wrench fell three floors and bounced off the tiles. Plazmet dropped to the floor in a heap of sputtering sparks, and where the dripping tail had touched him, his fire hissed and smoked and went a sick, dull orange.

"Plazmet!"

It was a serpent.

A long, thick, coiling serpent, longer than the room was wide, and it was purple. Deep, dark, glistening purple, the color of a bruise. It was covered in shiny scales that dripped. They dripped constantly, little drops of thick purple ooze that fell to the floor and hissed and smoked where they landed, leaving little burned marks on the blue tiles. It had a flat, wide head like a shovel, and two narrow yellow eyes. And all down its back ran a row of black-and-yellow striped spines.

It reared up. It hissed. The hiss sounded like a kettle full of acid.

"Hexcoil," said Admin Vex, still not turning around. "Deal with them."

Plazmet was already getting up. He shook the ooze off his comet-tail in a spatter of smoking drops, flared himself bright

again, and flew straight back at the serpent, low and fast. "Plazmet, wait..." Rook started. Too late. The Hexcoil didn't even turn its head. It just flicked its tail again, lazy, like someone swatting a fly. *WHAP.* Plazmet tumbled across the floor, over and over, and fetched up against the wall under a round window, his plasma ring wobbling, his flame flickering low.

Rook's mouth had gone dry. That was Plazmet. Plazmet had beaten the Iron Wall. Plazmet had evolved in a blaze bright enough to light a mushroom from the inside. And this thing had knocked him across the room twice without even looking at him.

The Hexcoil's yellow eyes swept across the room. They passed over Plazmet, smoking and struggling up by the wall. They passed over Rook. They passed over Zib.

And they stopped on Kit.

Kit had been edging along the wall toward the scaffolding, trying to get to one of the cutters, trying to fix things the way Kit always fixed things. Kit froze.

The Hexcoil smiled. Rook didn't know snakes could smile. This one could.

And it went for Kit.

It didn't go for Plazmet, who was the strongest. It didn't go for Rook, who was the one shouting. It went straight for the smallest, quietest person in the room. It slithered across the tiles so fast that it left a smoking purple trail behind it, a long hissing line of melted, bubbling tile, and it backed Kit into the corner, between the wall and a stack of crates, rearing up over them. Its dripping jaws opened wide. Purple ooze spattered on the floor at Kit's feet. *Hissss. Hissss.*

Kit pressed back against the wall. There was nowhere to go.

"KIT!" Rook yelled. He started running. Plazmet was already streaking across the room, trailing smoke, his fire still guttering. But they were too far away. Much too far.

And that was when Sporix jumped.

* * *

It leaped down off Kit's shoulders. It landed on the tiles right in front of Kit, right between Kit and the Hexcoil. It planted its tiny feet.

It was so small. So, so small. It barely came up to Kit's knee. The Hexcoil was as big as a tree. Its dripping purple head hung over Sporix like a storm cloud, its yellow eyes narrowing, its jaws dripping.

Sporix was shaking. Rook could see it from across the room. Its whole body was trembling. Its cap was quivering. Little puffs of frightened spores were popping out of the white spots on its cap with every shiver.

But it did not move.

The Hexcoil spat.

A gob of purple ooze hit Sporix square on top of its cap. *TSSSSSSS.* Smoke boiled up. Sporix squealed, a thin, high, terrible little sound, and was knocked flat on its back on the tiles, its feet kicking at the air. When it rolled over, there was a smoking, blackened spot on its red cap, right in the middle of the white spots, as big as a coin.

"Sporix!" Kit dropped to their knees and reached for it. "Sporix, no, come here, come back up here, *please*..."

Sporix got up.

It wobbled. Its cap was steaming. It was shaking so hard now that its little feet tapped on the tiles. But it stepped out of Kit's hands, and walked back to the exact same spot, and planted its

feet again.

It did not run. It did not hide. It did not pull its cap down over its eyes.

It stood there, between its person and the monster, shaking all over, and it did not move one inch.

Then, just once, it looked back over its shoulder. Up at Kit.

Rook saw Kit's face. He knew that face. It was the face he'd made against Anvilox, with his hand on the Linker and one button between his partner and safety. Kit's hand was already half out, reaching to scoop Sporix up and hide it away.

Kit's hand stopped.

"Okay," Kit whispered. Their voice wobbled all over the place. "Okay. I'm right here. I'm right behind you."

The Hexcoil hissed. It drew back its head to strike.

And Sporix began to glow.

It started under its cap. A soft green light, like the inside of a leaf held up to the sun. Then it spread, through its whole little body, brighter and brighter, until it was glowing like the mushrooms of Sporeholm, glowing like a lantern, glowing so bright that the Hexcoil flinched back and hissed and shielded its yellow eyes.

The light grew.

And Sporix grew with it.

Its body stretched up, tall and lanky, taller than Kit, taller than Rook, as tall as a grown-up. Its two stubby little legs stretched down into the floor and became roots, long strong twisting roots that dug into the cracks between the tiles and held on. Its two stubby little arms grew long, and longer, and became vines, thick pale twisting vines, all its soft cream fluff gone hard and woody and wound together like rope, that coiled and curled through the

air. And its mushroom cap, its little red cap with the white spots that it used to hide under, spread out. Wider and wider. Until it was as wide as an umbrella, as wide as a shield, red with white spots, its edges drooping and ragged, spreading out over Kit like a roof.

The light faded.

Where little Sporix had been, now stood something tall. Tall and strong and calm, like a young tree. Its body was pale and lanky and twisting, like a mushroom stalk wound out of woody rope. Its roots held fast to the floor. Its vines swayed slowly in the air. And its great spotted cap spread out over Kit's head like a shield, so that Kit was standing completely safe underneath it. There was still a dark, scorched spot right in the middle of it. It hadn't gone away. It had just grown with everything else.

It had the same eyes. The same big, gentle eyes. But they weren't shy anymore. Not one little bit.

Kit's homemade Linker beeped. The cracked screen flickered.

MYCELITH. BIO-TYPE. EVOLVED FORM.

"Mycelith," Kit whispered, looking up at it. "Oh. Oh, look at you."

The Hexcoil hissed again, louder, angrier. It lunged.

WHAM.

Its shovel head slammed into Mycelith's great cap like a battering ram. Mycelith's roots tore loose from the floor with a crackle of breaking tile, and it slid backward, *SKRRRRK*, a whole long step, until its stalk thumped against the wall right beside Kit. The cap held. Kit, underneath it, didn't get touched. But Mycelith let out a low, groaning creak, like a tree in a storm.

The Hexcoil didn't stop. It whipped its long body around and around Mycelith's stalk, coil after dripping coil, and squeezed.

Everywhere its scales touched, the ooze hissed. *TSSSS. TSSSS.* Smoke curled up off Mycelith's pale stalk. Its vines lashed at the serpent's head, *thwack, thwack*, and the serpent bit at them, and the vines came back smoking and singed at the tips. Mycelith's cap began to tilt. To sag. Lower. Lower. Its gentle eyes squeezed shut.

"Get off it!" Rook was almost there. "Plazmet, help it!"

Plazmet flung himself at the coils, and the Hexcoil's tail came round one more time and swatted him into a stack of crates, *KRUNCH*, and he didn't get up straight away. Rook's heart slammed so hard it hurt. Both of them. It was beating both of them at once.

But Kit wasn't looking at the snake.

Kit was looking at the floor.

Rook saw it a second later. The trail. The long, smoking purple trail the Hexcoil had left everywhere it had slithered, across the room, along the wall, around the crates, in loops and zigzags. The ooze hadn't just burned the tiles. It had eaten right *through* them. All along that trail, the blue tiles were melted into holes, and through the holes Rook could see the old dark stone of the tower underneath, cracked and crumbly and full of gaps.

The Hexcoil had drawn a map. And the map was everywhere it was lying right now.

"Mycelith!" Kit's voice cracked, and Kit didn't stop. "Don't pull at it! Go *down*! Under the floor! Follow the holes!"

Mycelith's eyes opened.

It didn't fight the coils anymore. It stood still inside them, sagging and smoking, and it pushed its roots straight down, deep into the cracks between the tiles, into the old stone underneath. Rook felt it through his sneakers. A rumble. A shiver, running out across the whole floor, under everything, like something

enormous waking up.

The Hexcoil felt it too. Its yellow eyes went wide. It squeezed harder. Mycelith's cap creaked and dipped almost all the way down onto Kit's head...

Then Mycelith lifted one long vine arm, calm and slow, and the floor exploded.

Roots burst up out of the blue tiles, all around the Hexcoil. Up out of every single hole the Hexcoil had burned. Huge roots, thick as Rook's arm, twisting and curling, shooting up out of the cracks in the floor. *KRAK-KRAK-KRAK-KRAK.* Tiles flew. The Hexcoil thrashed, uncoiled from Mycelith in a panic, and struck at Kit one last time, jaws wide, straight down at the cap, and Mycelith didn't dodge. It braced. It took the hit. *WHAM.* The whole great cap shuddered...

And the roots caught the Hexcoil in midair.

They wrapped around its long purple body. Once. Twice. Three times. Around and around and around, tight as a knot, until the Hexcoil was tied up like a parcel, its yellow eyes bulging, its dripping jaws snapping at nothing, hissing and thrashing and completely, totally stuck.

The room went silent. Every Helix worker on the scaffolding had stopped to stare.

Rook skidded to a stop. Plazmet came wobbling up out of the crates and stopped beside him, his fire low and smoky. They both stared at the tall, calm, spotted giant standing in the corner. Its stalk was streaked with burn marks. Its vines were singed. It was leaning against the wall, breathing in long, slow, creaking breaths. But its roots were still holding, and Kit was still safe underneath it.

And Admin Vex, finally, turned around.

She looked at the Hexcoil, tied up in roots. She looked at Mycelith. She looked at Kit, standing safe underneath the great spotted cap.

She raised one thin eyebrow.

"Interesting," she said.

That was all. Just one word. But she said it in the same voice you might use about a beetle under a microscope, and it made Rook's skin crawl.

Then she reached up and touched a small silver device on her collar. "Release the core," she said into it. "Lift."

"No!" Rook shouted.

But the last bolt had already come loose. The chains went taut with a great metallic *CLANK*. And the core, the great glowing crystal heart of the Harbor Tower, rose up off the floor. Slowly at first. Then faster. Up through the scaffolding, up through the hole in the roof, swinging on its black chains, its blue light flickering, flickering, getting fainter.

"Recall," said Vex, and the Hexcoil dissolved into purple sparkles and flowed into a sleek black Linker on her wrist, slipping out of Mycelith's roots like water through fingers. She swept toward a door at the side of the room, her black-and-yellow cape swirling behind her. Helix workers came down the scaffolding after her, quickly but in order, the top level first, as if they had practiced it. Pell stood by the door with his screen tucked under his arm and counted them out, one by one. He didn't look at Rook once.

At the door, Vex paused. She looked back over her shoulder. Not at Rook. At Zib.

"We already have what we came for," she said. "For now."

And she was gone.

Strand was the last one out. At the door, he stopped. He looked back at Rook, just for a second, with his worried, round-cheeked face. He looked like he wanted to say something. Something he wasn't supposed to say.

"Strand." Pell's hand closed on his arm. Not hard. Not a yank. Just enough. He said it low, but Rook heard. "She notices everything. *Everything.* Don't give her a reason."

Strand's mouth closed.

Pell looked past him, across the wrecked blue floor, at Rook. For a moment they just looked at each other, the boy and the field agent. Rook couldn't read anything in his face at all.

"I told you it wouldn't be easy," Pell said quietly.

Then he turned, and took Strand with him, and the door swung shut behind them.

* * *

The roar of the black-and-yellow ship's engines filled the whole sky. Rook ran up the spiral stairs and out onto the balcony at the top of the tower just in time to see it rise. It went up, and up, carrying the great blue crystal beneath it on its chains like an eagle carrying a fish. The three white ships fell in behind it. And together they shot away into the bright sky, past the glittering rings, smaller and smaller, until they were just four dots.

Then they were gone.

Rook stood on the balcony with his hands on the railing. Below him, the bells of Port Saltreach had stopped. The harbor was quiet. People were coming out of their houses again, slowly, looking up at the sky.

And behind him, the tower was dark.

The crystal at the very top, the one that had shone sea-blue over the harbor every night for longer than anyone could

remember, was gone. In its place was an empty brass cradle, and a hole, and the sky.

He heard footsteps on the stairs. Kit came out onto the balcony. Mycelith came out behind them, slowly, ducking its great spotted cap under the doorway. It moved stiffly, like someone who had been out in a storm all night. The burn marks on its stalk had faded to gray smudges, and the scorched spot on its cap had stopped smoking, but one singed vine still trailed along the floor behind it.

Kit didn't say anything. They just walked straight up to Mycelith and threw both arms around its long, twisting middle and held on tight. Mycelith's vines curled down around Kit's back, gently, the way you'd tuck a blanket around someone. Its great cap tilted down over both of them, like an umbrella in the rain.

"You protected me," Kit whispered into Mycelith's side. "You were so scared. I saw you shaking. And you did it anyway." Their voice broke. "You always protect me."

Mycelith made a soft, low, rustling sound, like wind through leaves.

Rook looked away to give them a moment. He looked out at the sea instead. And then he reached into his satchel and took out the two Signal Shards. The blue one and the green one.

They were flickering.

Not humming. Not singing their sweet two-part harmony. Flickering. Dimming and brightening, dimming and brightening, unsteadily, like a candle in a draft. Like they had felt something happen. Like something had hurt them.

Somewhere out there in the Kessler system, Rook thought, there were eight towers. Eight crystals, on eight different worlds, all shining together like the eight little lights on Dr. Vashti's map.

And now one of them was dark.

Chapter 18

Captain's Orders

Captain Delia Marsh came up the spiral stairs of her tower very slowly.

Rook heard her coming. Clomp. Clomp. Clomp. Her heavy black boots on the stone. She was not running anymore. She came out onto the balcony, and she stopped, and she looked up at the empty brass cradle where her crystal used to be.

She looked at it for a long, long time.

She had a cut on her cheek. Her long blue captain's coat was torn at the shoulder and spattered with purple ooze from the Skitterdrones. Her gray hair was full of sea spray. Behind her, down at the foot of the tower, the huge old blue sea creature with the barnacled shell was lying on the rocks, breathing slowly, resting. It lifted its great head and made a low, sad sound up at the dark tower. *Wooooooom.*

Captain Marsh didn't cry. Rook didn't think Captain Marsh had ever cried in her life. But her hands were gripping the railing so hard that her knuckles had gone white, and her jaw was clenched so tight that a muscle in her cheek was jumping.

"A hundred and twelve years," she said finally. Her voice was very quiet and very rough. "That crystal has lit this harbor every single night for a hundred and twelve years. Through storms. Through floods. Through the night the stars fell. Every fisherman who ever got lost out there in the dark found his way home by that light." She closed her eyes. "And they unbolted it like a

lightbulb."

Rook didn't know what to say. He held out the two flickering Shards, as if that might help.

Captain Marsh looked at them. Then she looked at Rook. And then her stormy gray eyes went hard, harder than Rook had ever seen anybody's eyes go.

"No battles," she said.

"What?"

"You heard me. No battles. No Signal Shards." She pushed herself off the railing and stood up straight. "Not until every last Helix grunt is off my docks. They ran in such a hurry they left half their people behind, and those people are still out there in my harbor, scaring my fishermen and breaking things and hiding in my sheds." She looked down at the harbor, at the boats and the stilt houses and the people standing in the streets, looking up at the dark tower. "A Keeper's job isn't to battle, son. Not really. A Keeper's job is to keep. To look after a place and the people in it." Her jaw tightened. "Today I didn't do that very well. So until I do, nobody battles anybody."

She turned and started down the stairs. Then she stopped and looked back over her shoulder.

"You can help," she said, "if you want to."

* * *

They wanted to.

It took the whole next day.

They started at dawn on the docks. Captain Marsh was right: the Helix ships had left in such a hurry that a dozen grunts had been left behind. Rook had always pictured Helix as one big thing, white and orange and organized, like a machine. But the people it had left behind weren't a machine. They were just people,

scattered all over Port Saltreach with their clicking, buzzing Skitterdrones, and every one of them was different. Some were trying to steal boats to get away. Some were hiding, scared, now that their ships were gone. And some were still angry.

The first group was on the fish market pier, trying to untie a fishing boat that very clearly did not belong to them.

"Excuse me," said Rook. "That's not yours."

The grunts turned around. There were three of them. They saw Rook. They saw Plazmet, blazing behind him with his comet-tail lashing. They saw Kit, and Mycelith, tall and calm under its wide, ragged red cap, looming over Kit's shoulder like a very large and very disapproving umbrella.

Two of them dropped the rope and put their hands up. Their Skitterdrones ducked behind their legs, dish-shaped wings folded tight. But the third one didn't. He was older than the others, with a hard, sunburned face and his visor shoved up on his forehead, and his hand stayed resting on the static-net launcher at his hip. His Skitterdrone rose up off the boards behind him, and its dish-wings swiveled, slowly, until they were pointing at Zib.

"We were just leaving," he said. His voice was flat. "Step aside, kid. You don't want to do this today."

"Not in that boat," said Kit.

The man looked at Kit. He looked at Plazmet, whose fire had gone white-hot at the edges. He looked down at his own boots, and at Mycelith's pale roots, which had spread out quietly across the wet boards all around them while nobody was watching.

"Brann," said one of the others, low. "Leave it. The ships are gone. Nobody's coming back for us."

For a long second, nobody moved. Then the man called Brann took his hand off the launcher, slowly, one finger at a time, and let

the rope drop into the water.

Captain Marsh had a big old cargo barge waiting at the end of the harbor, and anyone who wanted to leave Thalassa was welcome to take it, she said, as long as they took it straight back through the harbor gate and never, ever came back. Rook and Kit marched the grunts to it. Then they went back for more.

They found three grunts hiding in the lighthouse on Gull Rock, sitting on the floor in the dark with the door barricaded, who wouldn't come out until Captain Marsh herself stomped up the path and told them through the keyhole that nobody on her island was going to hurt them. They found two more trapped at the end of the sea wall by Mina, who was standing in front of them with a fishing net held out in both hands, and her Bubbub, Splodge, puffed up to twice its size beside her, and a look on her face that said she had been waiting all night for this. And they found one all by himself on a little beach on the far side of the island, sitting on a rock with his helmet off, looking out at the sea. He looked very young, not much older than the big kids at the Dustmere schoolhouse, and very miserable.

"I just wanted a job," he said, when they found him. He didn't get up. He didn't try to run. "There's no work back home. Helix came to our school with a brochure, with pictures of Alienmon on it, all smiling. They said it was research. They said we'd be helping Alienmon." He looked down at his Skitterdrone, which was nestled against his boot. "They gave me him on the first day. I named him Pip. You're not supposed to name them." He swallowed. "I didn't know about the cages. I swear I didn't know. Not until yesterday. Not until they made me carry one."

Rook thought about Strand, opening the cage in the Maze. Strand, leaving a yellow blanket in an empty cage. *I'm sorry. I'm*

really sorry. Helix was full of people who were sorry, Rook thought. And the cages kept filling up anyway.

"There's a barge," Rook said gently. "Captain Marsh says anyone can take it home."

The young grunt looked up at him. Then he nodded, and picked up his Skitterdrone, and walked with them back to the harbor without anyone having to march him at all. On the barge, he sat by himself at the very back, with Pip in his lap. When it went out through the harbor gate, he was the only one who looked back.

* * *

Around noon, Kit heard the crying.

It was coming from an old wooden shed at the back of the boatyard, behind a stack of lobster pots. A little whimpering, whining sound. Kit pressed their ear against the door. Then Kit's face went hard and angry, in a way Rook had only seen once before, on the Scrap Route on Ferrox, holding a crate stamped *dispose after use*.

The door was padlocked. Kit had it open in about four seconds with a hairpin and a tiny screwdriver.

Inside, in the dim, two Alienmon were tied to a post with rough rope.

One was a seahorse as big as a dog, with glittering green scales and a curly tail and long frilly fins like lace. The other was a crab, round and orange and about the size of a dinner plate, with one claw much bigger than the other. They had been tied up tight, so tight they could barely move. The seahorse's fins were drooping. The crab's eyes, on their little stalks, were pressed flat against its shell.

On the wall above them was a Helix label. COLLECTED. AWAITING TRANSFER.

"They were going to take them," Kit said. Their voice was shaking. "They just didn't have time."

Mycelith stepped forward. It reached out with its long, gentle arms of pale, woody fiber, twisted together like rope. And very, very carefully, it began to untie the knots. One by one. Slowly and patiently, the way you would untangle a necklace. Kit knelt down and helped. Rook held the lantern.

When the last rope fell away, the crab scuttled straight into the corner and hid. But the seahorse just stood there, trembling, staring at them with its huge, glittering eyes, as if it couldn't believe it was free.

Then Rook did the only thing he could think of. He took Nana Wren's badge off his satchel strap and held it out, so the seahorse could see the little brass cross, with the little brass bird.

"It's okay," he said. "You're safe now. We look after people. It's a promise."

He didn't know if the seahorse understood. But it stopped trembling. And after a moment, it swam forward through the air, slow and graceful, and pressed its long nose very gently against the badge.

They took both Alienmon down to the harbor and let them go in the turquoise water. The seahorse swam three circles around the dock, its lacy fins rippling, and then dove down into the glittering blue and was gone. The crab took a little longer. It sat on the edge of the dock and looked at the water for a while. Then it waved its big claw at them, once, and dropped in with a plop.

* * *

The whole afternoon, they helped the fishermen fix their nets.

The Helix grunts had torn half the nets in the harbor, trying to cut their way through to the boats. Now they lay in great tangled heaps on the docks, full of holes. The fishermen sat on upturned crates with big wooden needles, mending them, and they showed Rook and Kit how. You tied a knot. Then another knot. Then another knot. Over and over and over, hundreds of knots, until the hole was gone.

It was slow. It was boring. Rook's fingers got sore and his back got stiff and he got fishy-smelling twine stuck to everything.

But the fishermen told stories while they worked. Stories about storms and sea serpents and the time Old Barnaby, Captain Marsh's huge blue barnacled Alienmon, had carried an entire sinking ship back to harbor on its back. Stories about the Captain herself, who had come to Port Saltreach as a girl of fourteen with nothing but a rowboat and a stubborn streak a mile wide. And stories about the tower. About how its blue light had brought them home on dark nights, again and again and again, for as long as any of them could remember.

Mycelith turned out to be wonderful at fixing nets. Its long, rope-like fibers could tie knots faster than any fisherman on the dock. By the end of the afternoon, there was a small crowd of fishermen standing around it, watching, with their mouths open.

"I'd trade my boat for one of them," said one of them.

"Not for sale," said Kit, very fast.

Mycelith tied another knot, very pleased with itself.

* * *

By sunset, the docks were safe.

The last Helix grunt was on the barge, heading out through the harbor gate. The nets were mended and hanging up to dry. The fishing boats were tied up in neat rows. People were out in the

streets again, lighting their lanterns, talking in low voices, looking up at the dark tower with sad faces. But they were safe.

Captain Marsh walked down the pier toward Rook and Kit, who were sitting on the edge of the dock with their feet dangling over the glowing water, too tired to move. Her long blue coat had been mended. The cut on her cheek had a bandage on it. Old Barnaby swam alongside the pier beside her, his barnacled shell rising out of the water like a little island.

She stopped. She looked down at them for a long time. They were covered in fish scales and twine and sunburn and purple Skitterdrone goo.

Then, for the first time since Rook had met her, Captain Delia Marsh smiled.

It was a small smile. It crinkled up the corners of her stormy gray eyes. But it was real.

"Right," she said. "Now we battle."

* * *

They battled on the water.

Captain Marsh's arena wasn't in her tower. It was out in the harbor, in a wide circle of open sea marked out by floating buoys with little bells on them. The whole of Port Saltreach lined the docks to watch, holding their lanterns up. The glowing rings arched overhead. The sea glittered and glowed. Rook stood on one floating platform, Captain Marsh on another, with the open water between them.

And into that water swam Old Barnaby.

He was huge. Up close he was even bigger than Rook had thought, as big as a fishing boat, his great shell crusted with barnacles and seaweed, his flippers as wide as doors. His face was old and wrinkled and wise, with drooping whiskers like an old

man's mustache. He looked at Rook with one deep, calm, ancient eye. Rook's Linker beeped. BRINEBACK. HYDRO-TYPE. VERY OLD. VERY STRONG.

Rook swallowed.

Water beats fire. Everybody knew that. He thought about sending out Plazmet straight away, because Plazmet was his strongest. Then he stopped.

Think first.

"Cactling," he said. "You first."

The crowd murmured. Cactling stomped out onto the edge of Rook's platform. It looked at the sea. It looked at Old Barnaby. It looked back at Rook as if to say, *You want me to do WHAT?*

"Plants beat water," said Rook. "You've got the advantage, buddy. Just don't fall in."

Cactling huffed. Then it cracked its stubby knuckles and turned to face the enormous old Brineback.

It was a battle of waves and wind, and it went on and on.

Old Barnaby didn't move fast. He didn't need to. He swept one huge flipper through the water and a wave rose up, taller than a house, green and glowing and curling over at the top, and came crashing down over Rook's platform. *KA-SHOOOOM.* The platform plunged under. Rook went down on one knee with salt water up to his chest and the whole world roaring. When it bobbed back up, Cactling was still there, clinging to the edge with all four stubby limbs, dripping and furious.

"Needle Spray!"

Cactling threw needles. And they stuck. They stuck in the soft places between the barnacles, *thk-thk-thk*, and every one made Old Barnaby flinch. Plants beat water. The big Brineback grunted, and shook his great head, and Rook saw him start to slow down.

So Old Barnaby breathed in, and blew.

A howling wind came whipping across the harbor so hard that it nearly blew Rook's cap off. Zib had to hold onto his hair. The platform tipped up on its side like a door swinging open. And Cactling, who had been braced for water, not wind, lost its grip.

It went flying. Out over the edge, tumbling end over end, and into the sea with a tiny, awful *plip*.

"CACTLING!"

The crowd gasped. Rook threw himself flat on the tilting platform and stared at the dark water where it had gone in, and there was nothing, nothing, just ripples and foam and the glowing green sea. His heart stopped. Cactling couldn't swim. Cactling *hated* water. Cactling wouldn't even stand near a puddle.

Clang.

One of the buoys swung. Its little bell rang. And there was Cactling, hanging off the side of the buoy by one stubby arm, coughing up seawater, the creamy flower in the middle of its body plastered flat, its one green eye squinting out of the middle of it. It glared across the harbor at Old Barnaby with an expression of pure, outraged fury.

Then it climbed. Up the buoy. Along the rope. Hand over hand, dripping, its stubby legs kicking, while Old Barnaby's next wave rolled underneath it and nearly shook it off again. It flopped back onto the platform in a soggy heap, lay there for one second, and got up.

"You okay?" Rook breathed. "Buddy, are you..."

Cactling shook itself like a wet dog, spraying him all over. Then it turned around and faced the sea again.

Then Old Barnaby dove. He sank down under the glittering water, so deep that the waves closed over him and he disappeared

completely. The crowd went quiet. Rook watched the water. He watched it so hard his eyes stung. And then he saw it. A huge dark shape rising up underneath Cactling's platform, fast, faster...

"Cactling! JUMP!"

Cactling jumped. Old Barnaby burst up out of the sea right where it had been standing, in a tremendous explosion of spray, *KRA-BOOOOSH*, flipping the platform over like a pancake. Cactling landed on top of the old Brineback's barnacled shell. It blinked. Old Barnaby blinked.

Then Old Barnaby rolled. He bucked and twisted, trying to shake it off, and the barnacles scraped and the water churned white, and Cactling hung on with its stubby fists dug deep into the seaweed and its teeth gritted, getting dunked, coming up, getting dunked again.

On the third time up, it let go with one arm. And threw every needle it had left, straight down, from point-blank range.

Old Barnaby let out a long, rumbling groan, like a ship's horn. He sank back down into the water, slowly. When he came up again, he was floating on his back with his flippers out, breathing hard.

But he wasn't done. And neither was Cactling. Cactling was exhausted, soaked, and out of needles. It slid off the shell onto the bobbing wreck of the platform and sat there with its flower drooping, wheezing, half its needles gone, and it tried to stand up for more, and its legs folded. Rook leaned out and scooped it up in both arms, prickles and seawater and all. He called it back, telling it over and over how amazing it was, and Cactling flowed into the Linker looking extremely smug.

"Plazmet," said Rook. "Your turn. Remember the Spore Pools."

Plazmet blazed out over the water. His fire hissed where it touched the spray. Steam rose all around him. Old Barnaby rolled over and looked at him with that calm, ancient eye, and Rook could tell he was thinking: *Fire? Against me? On the open sea?*

Old Barnaby swept up another wave.

"Up," said Rook. Plazmet shot up, high over the wave, and it crashed harmlessly underneath him.

Old Barnaby blew another wind.

"Ride it," said Rook. Plazmet turned sideways and let the wind carry him, swooping around in a great arc like a seabird, his comet-tail streaming.

Old Barnaby dove again, down into the deep. Plazmet hovered over the water and waited. The crowd held its breath. Captain Marsh's eyes narrowed.

The sea under Plazmet went smooth. Too smooth. Like glass. And Rook realized, one second too late, that Old Barnaby wasn't coming up for air this time.

"Plazmet, MOVE..."

The water exploded straight up. Not Old Barnaby. A spout. A tower of seawater as thick as a tree trunk, shooting out of the sea like a fountain, *FWOOOOSSSHHH*, and it hit Plazmet from underneath and swallowed him whole.

For one horrible second there was no fire at all. Just a column of water and a huge, screaming cloud of steam, *TSSSSSSSSSSHHHHH*, rolling out across the harbor so thick that Rook couldn't see the buoys. The crowd went dead quiet.

Then something fell out of the bottom of the steam cloud.

It was Plazmet. Or what was left of him. His comet-tail was gone. His plasma ring had gone out. He was a tiny, sputtering, coal-red ember, smaller than he had been against Anvilox, smaller

than he'd ever been, and he was falling. Straight down. Toward the sea.

"PLAZMET!"

Rook's hand jumped toward the Linker, and stopped halfway. *Wait.*

The ember caught itself, an arm's length above the waves. It hovered there, flickering. Steam drifted up off it in thin gray wisps. And its one eye, very small now, turned and found Rook across the water.

It wasn't asking to come back. Rook knew that look by now. It was asking, *What do we do?*

Remember the Spore Pools. He'd said it himself, and then he'd forgotten it the second the battle got exciting. Plazmet didn't need to dodge everything. He needed to *wait*. And Rook needed to *watch*.

"Plazmet," he said. Quietly. Barely louder than talking. "Get small. Stay high. Rest. Don't do anything until I say."

Plazmet floated up, slowly, wobbling, until he was a tiny red dot high over the water. And he waited. He didn't throw a single spark. He just hung there, and breathed, and very slowly, little by little, his fire crept back from red to orange.

Rook waited. He waited and watched. Because he had seen something, during the battle with Cactling. Every time Old Barnaby came up from a dive, he had to stop at the surface for just a second. Just one second. To breathe. His great wrinkled head came out of the water, and his mouth opened, and he took a huge gulping breath of air. And in that second, he wasn't making waves. He wasn't making wind. He was just breathing.

Old Barnaby knew it too. That was why he'd used the spout. He'd stayed down so long, making it, that he had to be nearly out

of air now.

The water bulged. Rook's heart slammed against his ribs.

Old Barnaby's head broke the surface. His mouth opened. He breathed in.

"NOW!"

Plazmet dropped out of the sky like a falling star. Comet Dash. He flared as he fell, every bit of fire he'd saved up roaring back into him at once, his comet-tail whipping out behind him, his plasma ring sputtering back to life. And Old Barnaby saw him coming. The old Brineback snapped his mouth shut and swept up one last wave, fast, a wall of water rising straight into Plazmet's path...

Plazmet went through it.

Straight through. *TSSSSHHH.* Rook saw his fire shrink to almost nothing in the middle of the wave, and he screamed Plazmet's name, and then a white-hot point came punching out the other side, still falling, still burning, and struck the old Brineback right on the top of his great barnacled head, in a burst of fire and steam that lit up the whole harbor gold. *KA-WHOOOOOSH!*

When the steam cleared, Old Barnaby was floating peacefully on his back again. His flippers were spread out wide. His eyes were closed. And he was making a slow, contented, rumbling sound that sounded very much like laughter.

Plazmet came drifting back over the water toward Rook. He was sinking lower and lower, his tail just a wisp, and right before he touched the sea, Rook leaned out over the edge of the platform as far as he could and caught him in both cupped hands. He was barely warm. He was the size of a walnut. But his eye opened, and he sneezed, *pfft*, one tired little spark, right onto Rook's thumb.

The whole harbor went wild.

Captain Marsh walked across the floating platforms to Rook. She shook his hand with that grip like an anchor, careful not to jostle the little ember cupped in his other one. Then she pressed something into his palm.

It was a Signal Shard. Deep sea-blue, like the tower's crystal had been.

But it was flickering. Faint. Weak. Like a candle at the very end of its wick.

"Every Keeper keeps one piece of their tower's heart," Captain Marsh said quietly. "I chipped this one off the day I became Keeper, forty years ago. I've worn it on a chain around my neck every day since." She closed Rook's fingers over it with her own big rough hand. "It's the only piece of my tower they didn't take. You keep it safe, son. You hear me?"

"I will," said Rook. His voice came out thick. "I promise."

He had his third Signal Shard.

* * *

That evening, his Linker rang.

Rook was sitting on the pier with Kit, eating fish pie and watching the rings glow, when his wrist buzzed and a little picture popped up on the screen. A round face with flour on its nose.

"Mom!"

"Hi, sweetheart!" Mom's voice crackled out of the tiny speaker, warm and bright and so familiar that Rook's throat went tight. "Oh, look at you! You're sunburned! Are you wearing your hat? You're not wearing your hat. Rook, wear your hat."

"I'm wearing it, Mom, Zib's sitting on it."

"Bip!" said Zib, waving his lights at the screen.

"Oh, hello, Zib, darling! Oh, I miss you both so much." Behind Mom, in the little picture, Rook could see their kitchen. The stove.

The table. And standing by the counter, a tall brass shape with one glowing lamp-eye, holding what appeared to be a toaster.

"HELLO, ROOK," said DX-4. "YOUR MOTHER ASKED ME TO REPAIR THE TOASTER. I HAVE INSTEAD IMPROVED IT. IT NOW HAS ELEVEN SETTINGS."

"It used to have three," said Mom. "I just wanted it to have three."

"SETTING ELEVEN," said DX-4, "IS CALLED 'VOLCANO.' I DO NOT RECOMMEND IT."

Rook laughed so hard he nearly fell off the pier. He told Mom everything. Almost everything. He told her about Nurse Coral and the Forge Gate and Hank and the *Dandelion*, and Mom cried a little when he told her about Nana Wren's ship, and then cried a lot more when he told her about Plazmet. He told her about Kit and Sporix, and Kit waved shyly at the screen, and Mom said Kit was welcome for pancakes any time, forever. He didn't tell her about the cages. Or Admin Vex. He didn't want her to worry.

Then Mom's face changed. It went soft and a little bit sad.

"Guess who came by today?" she said. "Sola Reyes."

Rook sat up.

"She knocked on the door this morning. She'd come all the way back to Dustmere, just for the day. She was asking all sorts of questions about her dad. Where he used to go. Who he used to talk to. What he was like before he disappeared." Mom paused. "She asked a lot about Dr. Vashti, actually. Whether they were friends. Whether they used to go out to the crater together."

"What did you tell her?"

"The truth. That I didn't really know. That Teo Reyes was a kind man who always had his head in the stars." Mom was quiet for a moment. "She seemed so tired, honey. Tired all the way

through. Like she hadn't slept in a week. And so..." Mom searched for the word. "So alone."

Rook looked out at the dark sea. He didn't say anything for a long while.

He thought about the paper boat on the Lantern Marsh with *Dad* written on its side. He thought about Sola crying behind the paper moon. He thought about the glowing screen with the orange ring and slash in the corner. *They said they're closer to finding him than anyone's ever been.*

"Mom," he said slowly. "Did she say where she was going next?"

Mom frowned. "She did, actually. It was a bit strange. She said she was going to the Deep Sea Ferry dock, in Port Ember. Tomorrow night." Mom looked out of the screen at him, worried now. "She said somebody was meeting her there."

Chapter 19

Sola's Choice

They left Thalassa first thing in the morning.

Captain Marsh walked them down to the *Dandelion*. Old Barnaby swam alongside the pier, his barnacled shell glinting in the sun. Mina came too, with Splodge bouncing at her heels, and pressed a paper bag of salt-fish crackers into Kit's hands for the trip.

"Whoever she is," Captain Marsh said, when Rook had explained, "you go and get her." She looked up at her dark tower, and then back down at him. "I know a little something about people who get pulled out to sea by the wrong tide. Sometimes they just need somebody to throw them a rope."

Then she saluted him. A real captain's salute, sharp and proud.

Rook saluted back. He wasn't very good at it. But Captain Marsh nodded as if it had been perfect.

They flew back through the harbor gate, out of the turquoise sea and the glittering rings, through the *whoosh* and the tingle and the flash of blue, and into the smoky pink sky of the Molten Frontier. And as soon as they came out the other side, Rook pushed the *Dandelion* to Slightly Less Gentle and kept it there all the way across the steaming sea.

Nobody talked much. Kit fiddled with the engines and didn't really fix anything. Plazmet floated by the window, his flame turned low. Zib sat on top of the steering wheel, very still, watching the horizon.

They reached Port Ember just as the sun was going down.

* * *

The Deep Sea Ferry dock was at the far end of the harbor, past the stilt houses and the fishing boats, past the great stone gate with the Lady's face carved on its arch, now dark and asleep again. The round glass ferry was bobbing at its mooring with its sign hanging off the side. DEEP SEA FERRY. DIVES DAILY. (NOT CURRENTLY DIVING.) The Squid Sailor was nowhere to be seen. The dock was empty and quiet. The lanterns hadn't been lit yet. The sky was purple and orange and pink, all at once, and the turquoise sea had gone dark and still, like a sheet of glass.

And at the very end of the pier, all alone, sat Sola.

She was sitting with her feet hanging over the edge, above the water. Her father's big olive-green jacket was pulled tight around her, even though it wasn't cold. Her ponytail hung down her back. She wasn't looking at anything. She was just looking out at the sea.

Rook walked down the pier toward her. His footsteps sounded very loud on the boards. Kit came behind him, a few steps back. Plazmet and Mycelith hung back at the start of the pier, as if they understood.

Sola didn't turn around. But she knew they were there. Rook could tell by the way her shoulders went stiff.

"Your mom told you," she said, without looking up. "Didn't she."

"She was worried about you."

Sola let out a short laugh that didn't sound like a laugh at all. "Everybody's always worried about me. Poor Sola. Poor little Sola, whose dad got lost in a sandstorm." She kicked her heel against the post of the pier. "Nobody ever actually does anything. They just worry."

Rook sat down on the pier beside her, not too close, with his own feet hanging over the edge. The water below was dark. Little fish were nibbling at the seaweed on the posts.

For a while, neither of them said anything.

Then Sola said, very quietly, "Helix found it."

"Found what?"

"The signal. The one my dad was chasing." She pulled the glowing screen out of her pocket and turned it over and over in her hands. "They traced it. All the way back. They know where it's coming from. And they know where he was going when he went out to the crater that night." Her voice went small. "They said his last message, before he went quiet. It was just three words. *Found the door.*"

A shiver went right down Rook's back. *A door being pushed from the other side,* Dr. Moor had said. *Phase Three is something to do with a door,* Strand had said.

"They said if I come with them," Sola went on, "they'll take me right to it. Tonight. They'll take me to where he went. They said they think he might still be..." She stopped. She couldn't say it.

"Sola." Rook turned to face her. "Sola, listen to me. Helix put Alienmon in cages. We saw them. On a ship, on Thalassa. Hundreds of cages. Rows and rows of them, all the way up to the ceiling. They took the crystal right out of Captain Marsh's tower, while she was fighting to get to it. There's this woman, Admin Vex, she's got this snake that drips poison, and she looked at Zib like—"

"I don't care!"

Sola stood up so fast that the pier wobbled. She spun around to face him, and her eyes were blazing, and they were full of tears.

"I don't care what they did! I don't care about the cages, I don't care about crystals, I don't care about any of it! He's my DAD!" Her voice cracked right down the middle. "Do you know what it's like? Do you have any idea? Six years! Six years of everybody in Dustmere patting me on the head and saying he got lost! He didn't get lost! He knew that desert better than anyone! He went somewhere, on purpose, and nobody will tell me where!" She was shaking. "Dr. Vashti knows something. I KNOW she does. Every time I ask her, she changes the subject. Everybody changes the subject. And the only people in the whole Kessler system who have ever, ever actually tried to help me find him are Helix."

"Then let US help you!" Rook was on his feet now too. "Me and Kit! We'll help you look! We've got a ship, and Signal Shards, and Zib knows things, he shows us pictures, there's a planet and a lady made of trees and—"

"You?" Sola stared at him. "You lose every time we battle."

That stung. It stung so much that Rook couldn't say anything at all.

Sola wiped her face with her sleeve, fast. She took a deep breath. And when she spoke again, she was calm. Cold. The way she was at the Trading Post. The way she was in the Lantern Marsh.

"Battle me," she said. "Right here. If you win, I'll listen."

* * *

It was their third battle.

The first had been in the corral at the Trading Post, in front of half the town, the day after they got their partners. Rook had lost, badly, because he had charged in without thinking.

The second had been on the platform in the Lantern Marsh, surrounded by floating paper lanterns. Rook had lost again, but

only just, because he had started to watch and wait.

This was the third.

The sun had gone down. The lanterns along the dock flickered on, one by one, all on their own, glowing soft gold. The sea was dark and glassy. And Sola let out Tidaloid.

Tidaloid rose up out of the Linker in a swirl of blue light and unfolded itself on the end of the pier. Tall and graceful, it floated under its tall, speckled bell like a living lantern of seawater, the dome glowing, its long silky tentacles rippling in the evening air. Its quiet face peeked out from beneath the bell and looked at Rook with calm, ancient eyes. Then it looked at Sola, and something in its face went worried, as if it knew how upset she was.

Rook let out Plazmet.

Plazmet blazed out over the dark water, his comet-tail streaming, his plasma ring humming. His fire lit up the whole end of the pier, orange and gold, and reflected in the sea below like a second Plazmet swimming underneath.

Sola's eyes went wide. For just a second, she forgot to look cold.

"He evolved," she whispered.

"On Sporeholm," said Rook. "His name's Plazmet now."

Sola stared at Plazmet. Then she looked at Rook. Something passed over her face. It looked a lot like the face she'd made on the Lantern Marsh when Gloopa evolved. Amazed. Then she shut it away.

"Fire against water," she said. "Still loses. Tidaloid. Tidal Whip."

Tidaloid raised one long rippling arm and swung it. It cracked across the air like a whip made of ocean, fast as lightning. *KSSHHAK!*

Rook didn't shout. He didn't panic. He'd been watching Tidaloid's bell, the way it glowed brighter and drew a tentacle back before every swing.

"Under," he said quietly.

Plazmet dipped. The Tidal Whip sliced through the air where he'd been and smashed down on the pier, *WHAM*, so hard that a board split down the middle and salt water sprayed up over Rook's sneakers.

"Again!" said Sola.

Another whip. Then another. Then two at once, from both sides.

"Spin."

Plazmet spun, his long comet-tail whirling around him, and danced between the two whips like a comet through falling rain. The spray from the whips hit his fire and turned instantly to steam, so that soon the whole end of the pier was wrapped in soft white clouds, glowing gold from the inside.

"Tidaloid!" Sola's voice was sharp. "Don't swing at him. *Grab* him!"

Rook didn't see the arm coming. Nobody could have. It came low, out of the steam, from the wrong side, and it wrapped around Plazmet's comet-tail like a rope.

TSSSSSSSSS.

Plazmet screeched. Steam boiled off him in a white rush. He blazed, trying to burn his way loose, and the arm just squeezed tighter, hissing and steaming and not letting go. And then Tidaloid swung him. Up, over its glowing dome, around in a great whistling circle, and down.

Into the sea.

KSSSSHHHHHHHHHHH.

The water where Plazmet went in exploded into steam. A huge white cloud of it, hissing and roaring, billowing up over the end of the pier so thick that Rook couldn't see his own hands. Under it, the dark sea was bubbling. Boiling. And then it went still.

"PLAZMET!"

Rook was on his knees at the edge of the pier, leaning out over the black water, with no idea when he'd moved. There was nothing down there. No glow. No light. Just dark, flat water and a few last bubbles. His heart was slamming so hard it shook his whole body. His hand found the Linker on his wrist and clamped over it. One press. That was all. One press, and he'd be safe inside, wherever he was..

A bubble rose. And another. And then, like a coal pulled out of a bucket, a tiny, hissing, steaming red spark came bobbing up out of the sea.

Plazmet dragged himself into the air. He barely made it. His comet-tail was gone, nothing but a wisp of smoke. His plasma ring flickered, out, on, out. He was smaller than he had been since the night he evolved, small and dim and dripping, and every little drop of sea that fell off him hissed. He wobbled up to the level of the pier, and stopped there, panting, the way a fire pants when you've almost put it out.

And he looked at Rook.

His eye was tiny. But it was steady. And it wasn't saying *take me back*. Rook knew it like he knew his own name. It was saying, *I'm still here. What do we do?*

Rook took his hand off the Linker.

He wanted to yell. He wanted to yell *Comet Dash* and *Get her* and *Again, again, again*. It was right there in his throat. He swallowed it.

Think first.

"Stay out of reach," he said, and his voice was shaking, and he let it. "Don't fight. Just watch her. I'll tell you when."

Plazmet's eye narrowed. And he hung there, small and red and dripping, out at the very edge of Tidaloid's reach, and didn't throw a single spark.

Sola was breathing hard. "Tidaloid! Tidal Whip! Keep going! Don't stop!"

Tidaloid swung. Plazmet slid away from it, slow, barely moving, just far enough. *KSSHHAK.* Swung again. *KSSHHAK.* The whips were missing him by a hand's width. Then by a finger's. One clipped the very end of his wispy tail and he spun, and steamed, and nearly went down again, and caught himself.

And Rook realized something. Something that made his heart ache.

Sola was charging.

She was doing exactly what he had done at the Trading Post. Shouting the same thing over and over. Attack, attack, attack. Throwing everything she had, harder and harder, faster and faster, as if yelling louder would make it work. She wasn't watching. She wasn't waiting. She wasn't thinking. She was too upset to think. She was so full of sad and scared and angry that it was spilling out of her, and it was coming out as *again, again, again*.

And Tidaloid was getting tired.

Rook could see it. Its graceful arms were swinging slower. Its dome was dimming. Every whip was a little weaker than the last. The arm that had grabbed Plazmet was red and blistered along one side, from the heat, and Tidaloid kept holding it close. And between each swing, it had to stop. Just for a moment. Its arms

would drop, and its bubble heart would pulse, and it would draw in a long, shaky breath, catching it.

But Plazmet was tired too. More tired. Rook could see that just as clearly. His fire had crept back up from red to orange, but no further. He had one Comet Dash left in him. Maybe. If it missed, there wouldn't be another.

"Plazmet," Rook said softly. "Next time it stops to breathe. Go straight through the steam. Don't stop for anything."

Tidaloid swung. Plazmet dodged. Tidaloid swung again, slower. Plazmet dodged again.

Tidaloid's arms dropped. Its bubble heart pulsed. It drew in a breath.

"Now."

Plazmet struck. Comet Dash. He flared, everything he had left roaring out of him at once, his comet-tail snapping back out behind him long and gold. A streak of fire through the white steam, fast and clean and bright...

And Sola saw it. "Tidaloid! *UP!*"

Tidaloid's arm came up, tired and blistered and fast anyway, and swung, one last whip straight into Plazmet's path. *KSSHHAK.* It hit him. Rook saw it hit him. Saw the fire shrink, saw the steam burst out in a great white flower...

Plazmet didn't stop.

He went right through the water, hissing, and out the other side, and hit Tidaloid right on its glowing dome. *KA-WHOOOM.*

The flash lit up the whole end of the pier. Both of them went flying. Tidaloid staggered back across the boards, and Plazmet tumbled away the other way, end over end, a little red spark bouncing off the planks, *tok, tok, tok*, and rolled to a stop right against the toe of Rook's sneaker.

Tidaloid wobbled. Its long arms drooped. It swayed one way, and then the other.

And then, very slowly, very gently, the way a tired dancer sits down at the end of a long night, it sank down onto the boards of the pier and folded its silky arms around itself, and was still.

The steam drifted away across the dark water.

Rook knelt and cupped Plazmet in both hands. He was hot and damp and hissing faintly, and so dim that Rook could see the lines of his own palms through him. But he was there. His eye cracked open. And he sneezed, *pfft*, a single, soggy spark.

For the very first time, Rook had won.

* * *

He didn't cheer. He didn't jump up and down. He didn't feel the way he'd always imagined he would feel, beating Sola Reyes. He'd imagined it a hundred times. Fireworks. Shouting. Doing a little dance.

Instead, he just felt quiet.

Sola was staring at her partner. She didn't move for a long time. Then she knelt down on the boards beside Tidaloid, and very gently, the way Rook had picked up Plazmo in the corral at the Trading Post, she gathered up its long silky arms and held them.

"I'm sorry," she whispered to it. "I'm sorry. That was my fault. I wasn't thinking. I was just..." Her voice broke. "I'm sorry."

Tidaloid lifted one tired arm and touched her cheek.

Sola stayed there for a while, kneeling on the pier. Then she called Tidaloid back into her Linker, and stood up, and turned around, and looked at Rook.

Her eyes were shining. But she wasn't wiping them away this time. She just let them shine.

"You got good," she said quietly. "Really good."

"You said you'd listen," Rook said. "If I won."

"I am listening." She took a breath. "And I heard you. About the cages. And the crystals. And the snake lady. I heard all of it." She looked out at the sea. "And that's exactly why I have to do this alone."

"What? No! Sola, that doesn't make any—"

"If I bring you," Sola said, "you'll get hurt." She turned back to him, and her voice was steady, even though her chin was trembling. "You and Kit and Plazmet and that weird little saucer. Helix wants him. You said so yourself. If you come with me, you'll be walking right into the place where they want him most." She swallowed hard. "My dad walked out into the desert one night to find something, and he never came back. And I'm going to find out why. But I can't lose anybody else, Rook. I can't. I won't."

Rook opened his mouth. Nothing came out.

Sola reached into the big pocket of her father's jacket. She pulled out something small and white. It was the little paper boat from the Lantern Marsh. The one with *Dad* written on the side, in her neat, careful handwriting. It was a bit crumpled now, from being carried around.

She held it out to him.

"If I don't find him," she said, "float this for me. Somewhere nice."

Rook took the paper boat. His hands were shaking.

And from above them, out of the purple night sky, came a low, smooth, humming sound.

* * *

A white Helix shuttle came gliding down out of the dark. It came in low over the water, slow and careful, with its landing lights on, and touched down on the very end of the pier, right beside them,

as lightly as a gull settling on a post. Its engines sighed and went quiet. Painted on its side, bright under the dock lanterns, was an orange ring with a diagonal slash through it.

Its door slid open. Soft white light spilled out onto the boards.

Rook looked through the door. Inside, there was nobody but the pilot, sitting at the controls in a white jumpsuit with the visor up. It was Strand. Strand, with his round cheeks and his worried eyes. He looked out through the door at Rook. Then he looked away, fast, at the floor.

Rook waited for the rest of them. For Pell, tall and straight, with his net launcher. For the clicking of Skitterdrones out of the dark. Nobody came. There was only Strand, and the open door, and the soft white light.

Somehow that was worse. They hadn't sent anybody to fight. They hadn't needed to. Sola was walking in on her own.

Sola turned toward the shuttle.

"Sola," said Rook. "Don't."

She took a step.

"Sola, please. Please don't."

On his shoulder, Zib had gone wild. He was flashing every light he had, red and gold and blue and purple, all at once, so fast they blurred. "BIP! BIP-BIP! BIP-BIP-BIP-BIP!" And he lifted off Rook's shoulder and shot toward the shuttle. Toward Sola. As fast as he could fly. As if he wanted to go with her. As if he knew something terrible about where she was going and wanted to stop it, or follow it, or both.

Rook's hand shot out on its own. He caught Zib, in midair, in both hands. And held on.

"No, Zib!" he gasped. "No! That's where they WANT you!"

Zib struggled in his hands. He buzzed and whirred and flashed. "BIP! BIIIIIP!"

Inside the shuttle, Strand had half risen out of his seat, one hand reaching for a switch on the panel. Then he saw Zib caught safe in Rook's hands, and he sat back down, slowly, and took his hand away.

Sola stopped in the doorway of the shuttle. She looked back.

She looked at Rook, standing on the end of the pier, holding the paper boat in one hand and the struggling little saucer in the other. She looked at Kit, standing behind him, with Mycelith's great ragged red cap spread over them both. Kit stepped forward.

"We'll come for you," Kit said. Their voice was very small and very steady. "Wherever they take you. We'll come."

Sola looked at Kit for a long moment. Her mouth trembled. And for one second, just one, Rook thought she might come back. Might walk back down the pier. Might say, *Okay. Okay, let's do this together.*

Then she turned around and walked inside.

The door slid shut.

Through the little round window beside it, Rook saw Strand lean over and say something to her, and Sola nod without looking at him. Then Strand turned back to the controls. For one second his eyes came up and found Rook's through the glass, and this time he didn't look away. He gave one small shake of his head. It was so small that Rook couldn't tell if it meant *don't follow us*, or *I'm sorry*, or *I didn't want this either*.

The shuttle hummed. Its lights blinked. It rose up off the pier, smooth and quiet, and turned, and climbed up into the purple evening sky. Up, and up, past the first evening stars, smaller and smaller, until it was just one more light among all the others.

Then it disappeared.

* * *

Rook stood on the end of the pier for a long time.

Kit stood beside him. Nobody said anything. Plazmet floated close, his flame low and warm. Mycelith's cap tilted down over them both, like an umbrella, though there wasn't any rain.

After a while, Rook opened his hands.

Zib floated up out of them. He didn't fly back to Rook's shoulder. He didn't land on his cap. He drifted a few feet away and hung there in the air over the dark water, with his back to Rook. And his lights went dim. All of them. Dim and gray, like a lamp being turned down, until he was barely glowing at all.

"Zib," Rook said. His voice cracked. "Zib, I'm sorry. I had to. They would have taken you. They want you more than anything, and I couldn't let—"

Zib didn't turn around.

"Zib. Please."

Nothing. Just the slow gray flicker of his lights, and the lap of the dark water against the posts of the pier.

That night, Zib didn't curl up anywhere near Rook, the way he always did, close enough to hear him breathing. He slept on the windowsill of the *Dandelion*, as far from Rook's bunk as he could get, with his lights turned all the way down and his huge eye facing out at the stars.

He wouldn't look at Rook for the rest of the night.

And Rook lay awake in the dark, holding a crumpled paper boat with *Dad* written on its side, and stared up at the little brass bird swinging on its string, and wondered if he had just made the biggest mistake of his whole life.

Chapter 20

City of Lights

Rook woke up before the sun.

He lay in his bunk for a while, staring at the ceiling. Then he got up, very quietly, so as not to wake Kit, and dug through his satchel until he found it. The little paper lantern Fenna had given him on Sporeholm, folded into the shape of a bird. *For when you miss somebody.*

He found a pencil. He sat at the little table in the *Dandelion*'s kitchen, under the swinging brass bird. He thought for a long time.

Then he wrote a name on the lantern's wing, in his best handwriting.

Sola.

He went outside onto the dock. Port Ember was still asleep. The stilt houses were dark. The sea was gray and calm and smooth as glass, with just a faint pink glow beginning far off at the edge of the sky. Rook knelt at the end of the pier, where Sola had been sitting the night before, and set the paper bird down on the water.

It bobbed. It turned slowly in a circle. Then the tide caught it and began to carry it out, away from the dock, toward the open sea, its little paper wings catching the first light.

"We're going to find you," Rook whispered. "I promise. And when we do, I'm going to tell you you're wrong. You don't have to do it alone. Nobody does."

He heard a soft whirring behind him.

Zib had come out of the ship. He was floating a little way off, over the edge of the dock, watching the paper bird drift away. His lights were still dim. But they weren't gray anymore. They were a soft, quiet, thoughtful blue.

"I'm sorry," Rook said. "About last night. I know you wanted to go with her. I think... I think you wanted to protect her. Like you protect all of us." He swallowed. "But I couldn't lose you, Zib. I just couldn't. You're my friend. You're one of my best friends in the whole universe."

Zib floated there for a long moment, watching the little paper bird.

Then he drifted over, slowly. And landed, very lightly, on the brim of Rook's cap.

"...Bip," he said.

It was a small bip. A tired bip. But it was a bip, and it was for Rook, and Rook let out a breath he felt like he'd been holding all night.

They sat together on the end of the pier and watched the paper bird float out to sea until the sun came up.

* * *

It was DX-4's compass that told them where to go next.

Rook had almost forgotten about it. It was still hanging around his neck on its string, the little brass coin with the glass window that pointed at any signal matching Zib's frequency. Mostly, it pointed at Zib. But that morning, when Rook pulled it out, the needle was doing something new. It was swinging back and forth, back and forth, between Zib on his cap and somewhere else. Somewhere up. Somewhere past the pink sky, out among the stars.

Kit traced the direction on Dr. Vashti's map, the one with the purple ribbon. Their finger landed on a little planet in the ninth

ring, drawn in bright electric blue.

"Neonis," Kit said. "The city world. There's a Relay Tower there too. And a Keeper. DJ Static." Kit looked up. "Something on Neonis is broadcasting on Zib's frequency. Something big."

Rook looked at the map. He looked at the little planet, glowing blue.

"Then that's where we're going," he said.

* * *

Neonis was a city that never went dark.

They saw it from space first, and Rook nearly forgot to steer. The whole planet glowed. It wasn't green and blue like a normal world, or red like Dustara, or purple like Sporeholm. It was a ball of light. Every inch of it, from the north pole to the south, was covered in city. Streets and towers and bridges and lights, millions and millions of lights, pink and blue and electric yellow and acid green, all twinkling and flashing and racing along the streets in rivers, so bright that the whole planet seemed to fizz, like a sparkler held in the dark.

And as they got closer, it only got better.

The towers were so tall they scraped the clouds, all glass and steel, and every one of them was covered in pictures. Moving pictures. Holograms, huge and glowing, dancing across the sides of the buildings. A giant smiling cartoon fish swimming up the side of one tower, advertising sushi. A dancing robot, taller than a mountain, doing the same dance over and over on the side of another. A huge glowing Alienmon, a lightning-bird with crackling wings, swooping in loops around the very top of the tallest spire.

Trains floated between the towers. Not on tracks. On ribbons of light, glowing blue and pink, that curved and looped through the

air between the buildings like roller coasters. The trains themselves were sleek and silver and silent, and they went whooshing past the *Dandelion* so close that Rook could see people inside them, reading and eating and waving.

Music thumped from everywhere. From every window and every rooftop and every street corner, all different songs, all playing at once, so that the whole city seemed to be humming with one enormous, cheerful, slightly confusing tune.

And it was raining. A soft, light, warm rain, falling gently over everything. But even the rain was shiny. Every drop caught the lights of the city as it fell and glowed, pink and blue and gold, so that it looked like it was raining glitter.

"Whoa," said Rook.

"WHOA," said Kit.

"BIP!" said Zib. It was the first loud bip since Port Ember. His lights were flashing every color the city was flashing, pink, blue, yellow, green, as if he were trying to keep up with it all. Rook grinned. He had missed that.

* * *

They followed the compass.

They landed the *Dandelion* on a rooftop parking pad, between a sleek silver sports ship and a battered delivery van covered in stickers. They took a glass elevator down sixty floors, so fast their ears popped. They walked through streets so bright it was like walking through the middle of a firework, past noodle stands and arcades and shops selling glowing sneakers, past street performers with Alienmon that juggled balls of light, past a lady walking a fluffy pink Alienmon on a leash that floated along behind her like a balloon. And the compass needle swung and swung, leading them on.

It led them to a tall glass tower at the edge of a little park, where a fountain splashed and glowed purple in the middle of a square. The tower was old-fashioned compared to the others, without any holograms on it at all. And right at the very top, on the very highest floor, there was a light on in a round window. A warm, yellow, ordinary light.

And poking out of the round window, pointing up at the sky, was a big brass telescope.

Rook stopped dead.

He knew that telescope. He had grown up looking at that telescope. He had climbed one hundred and twelve stone steps to see it, more times than he could count.

He ran.

He burst through the tower doors and into the elevator and punched the top button so many times that Kit had to grab his hand. The elevator went up and up and up. The doors slid open. And there, in a round room full of bookshelves and star charts and jars of glowing things and brass gadgets that ticked and whirred on every table, standing in the middle of it all with a pencil in her mouth and two more stuck in her messy silver bun, was a familiar face.

"DR. VASHTI!"

She spun around. The pencil fell out of her mouth.

"Rook?" Her face lit up like a sunrise. "ROOK!"

Rook ran across the room and threw his arms around her, and she threw her arms around him, and her lab coat smelled exactly like the Observatory, like old books and dust and peppermint and the faint burnt smell of Plazmet's sneezes. She hugged him so hard his cap fell off. Zib, who had been sitting on it, had to zoom up into the air to avoid being squashed.

"Look at you," she said, holding him at arm's length. "Look at you! You've grown! You're taller! You're sunburned! You've got sea salt in your hair!" Then she saw Plazmet, floating behind him, with his comet-tail and his plasma ring, and she gasped and clapped both hands over her mouth. "Oh! Oh, Rook! He evolved! Plazmet! Oh, he's magnificent!"

Plazmet puffed up so proudly that his plasma ring spun faster.

"And who's this?" Dr. Vashti turned to Kit, who was standing awkwardly in the elevator doorway with Mycelith ducking behind them.

"This is Kit," said Rook. "Kit Briggs. Kit's my best friend. And that's Mycelith. It used to be Sporix. The Sporix from your Observatory."

Dr. Vashti's mouth fell open. She looked up at Mycelith, tall and calm on its twisting root legs, under its wide, ragged red cap. Mycelith looked down at her. Then it gave a slow, gentle bow, its great cap tipping forward, the way you would bow to someone you remembered.

"Oh, my goodness," Dr. Vashti whispered. Her eyes had gone wet. "Oh, my little one. You found somebody." She held out both hands to Kit. "Kit. Thank you. Thank you for looking at it."

Kit went bright pink and shook her hand and looked at the floor.

"But what are you DOING here?" Rook said. "In Neonis? I thought you never left the Observatory!"

"I didn't. Not for twenty years." Dr. Vashti went over to one of the big tables, where a strange machine sat humming. It was made of brass and glass, with dials and needles and a big round screen, and the screen showed a single wavy green line, going up and down, up and down, like a heartbeat. "But after you left, the

signal from the crater started to change. The one that made the bridge hum. It's been getting stronger, Rook. Much stronger. Every day. I couldn't measure it properly from Dustara anymore. It was too close. Too loud. I needed to listen to it from far away, from a quiet place with good equipment." She smiled a crooked smile. "Neonis isn't very quiet. But it has wonderful equipment."

That explained the compass. Her machine was listening to the signal so hard that it was humming on the very same frequency.

She looked at the green line, pulsing, pulsing. Up and down. Faster than Rook remembered it on Sporeholm.

Then she turned and noticed Zib.

He had come down from the ceiling and was floating a little way off, near the bookshelves, watching her with his huge eye. His lights were blinking softly.

Dr. Vashti's smile went a little wobbly at the edges.

"Hello, Zib," she said quietly.

"Bip," said Zib. It was a shy bip. A careful bip. The kind of bip you'd say to someone you weren't quite sure you knew.

Dr. Vashti looked at him for a long moment. Her hand moved, just slightly, toward the deepest pocket of her lab coat. The one she never let anybody see inside.

Then it stopped.

And just then, the whole city went *BZZZZZZZZZZT.*

* * *

Every light in the lab flickered.

The yellow lamps went blue, then pink, then off, then on. The humming machine on the table let out a squeal like a startled pig. Out the round window, the whole skyline of Neonis jumped and stuttered. The giant dancing robot on the side of the tower across the street froze, mid-dance, and then started dancing backwards.

The cartoon fish swam upside down. The lightning-bird hologram fell apart into a cloud of pixels.

The floating trains stopped. Just stopped. In midair. Hanging on their ribbons of light, with all the people inside them pressing their faces against the windows.

And from far below, from the street, came shouting. Not scared shouting, not yet. Startled, confused shouting, the kind people do when everything around them stops making sense all at once.

Rook ran to the window and looked down.

In the little park at the bottom of the tower, beside the purple fountain, a white Helix transport was sitting on the grass. It hadn't crashed. It had landed neatly, square in the middle of the park, as if it had every right to be there. On its side was an orange ring with a diagonal slash through it. Its big cargo door was wide open, and a ramp ran down onto the grass, and at the bottom of the ramp sat a stack of metal crates. The top one had burst open from the inside. Its lid was bent straight up, blackened and smoking at the edges.

And pouring out of it were bugs.

Dozens of them. Hundreds of them. Little bug-shaped Alienmon, each one about as big as a loaf of bread, stubby and striped yellow and black, with huge cyan eyes, two crackling antennae, and buzzing wings that seemed to break apart into pixels at the edges. They were streaming out of the broken crates in a great buzzing, crackling, sparking cloud, flying in every direction at once. And they crackled. Their whole bodies crackled with static, little blue zaps of electricity jumping off them like they had rubbed their feet on a carpet, and a fizzy electric haze leaking off them wherever they went.

And everywhere they landed, the electricity went haywire.

One landed on a streetlight, and the streetlight started flashing like a disco. One landed on a sign that said NOODLES, and the sign started saying SELDOON. One landed on the door of a shop, and the door started opening and shutting and opening and shutting, *whoosh-whoosh-whoosh-whoosh*, so fast the shopkeeper couldn't get out. A whole swarm of them landed on a hot dog stand, and the hot dog stand started playing opera music, very loudly, while hot dogs shot out of the top of it like fireworks.

"Glitchbugs," Kit breathed, pressing their face against the glass. "Volt and Swarm types. They scramble any screen they touch." Kit's voice dropped. "Helix had them packed in crates. That many, squashed in together, scared... their static must have built up until the locks blew."

And moving through the middle of it all, calm and unhurried, were four figures in white jumpsuits.

They weren't chasing anything. They were working. Two of them carried squat white static-net launchers, the same kind Pell had carried in the Sunset Tunnel, and every few seconds one of them raised it and fired. *Thoomp.* A crackling blue net snapped shut around a cluster of Glitchbugs and dropped them, twitching, onto the wet grass. The other two walked behind, picking up the nets and slinging them up the ramp into the transport like bags of laundry.

"They're hurting them," Kit whispered.

Then one of the grunts touched the side of his helmet, as if he were listening to someone. He raised one hand and drew a circle in the air. All four of them stopped at once. They didn't look at the swarm. They didn't look at the people shouting in the street, or the frozen trains, or the shopkeeper trapped behind his flapping door. They just walked back up the ramp, carrying whatever they had

already caught. The ramp folded up. The door slid shut. The transport lifted off the grass, smooth and quiet, turned once over the park, and climbed away between the towers.

It left the rest of the Glitchbugs behind. Hundreds of them. Scared and crackling and loose in the middle of the city.

Rook's hands had curled into fists on the windowsill. "They're just *leaving* them."

Behind them, Dr. Vashti had come to the window too. She watched the transport until it was gone, and her face was very hard. "They took what they needed," she said quietly. "Whatever's left over is somebody else's problem."

Rook looked at Kit. Kit looked at Rook.

"Well," said Kit, already pulling their goggles down. "Somebody's got to fix this."

* * *

It took all afternoon.

It was the hardest, silliest, most ridiculous afternoon of Rook's life. Glitchbugs were fast. Really fast. They zipped and zapped and darted in every direction. Every time Rook got close to one, it zapped him. Not hard. Just a little tingly zap, like a static shock off a doorknob. But it made his hair stand straight up, and after the first hour, it stayed standing straight up, and Kit couldn't look at him without laughing.

One Glitchbug was a joke. A hundred Glitchbugs, all scared and all crackling at once, were not.

They tried everything. Plazmet chased them, but they were too quick, and every time he got close, they zapped him and his flame flickered blue. Then a whole cloud of them turned on him at once. *ZZZZZRAKK!* It was like flying into a thunderstorm. A web of blue lightning wrapped around him, and his flame went from gold to

blue to a sputtering gray, and he dropped out of the air and hit the wet pavement with a *fssst*, rolling, smoking, his plasma ring wobbling crooked.

"Plazmet!" Rook skidded down beside him. His heart was going like a drum. Plazmet shook himself, hard, and a shower of blue sparks flew off him. He sneezed. A tiny puff of fire, very indignant. Then he floated back up, a little lopsided, and glared at the swarm.

"Okay," Rook breathed. "Okay. Careful. They're scared, not mean."

Cactling threw needles, but it felt bad about it and kept missing on purpose. Mycelith spread its long, rope-like fibers out wide like a net and caught dozens of them at once, which worked beautifully, until they all zapped it at the same time. *KRZZZT!* Mycelith's whole body went rigid. Its fibers jerked. It sank down onto one knee on the pavement, steaming gently in the rain, while Kit yelled its name, and its whole cap stood up on end like Rook's hair.

The swarm was getting bigger. Every light in the park was flashing. Every one of them was a little angrier than the last.

Then Kit had an idea.

"They're bugs," Kit said. "Bugs like light. Rook! Lumislug!"

Rook let out Lumislug. It slid out onto the wet pavement and blinked around at the chaos. Then, when Rook asked it to, it turned its glow all the way up. Brighter than it had ever glowed. Bright as a little lime-green moon, its dark spots blazing.

Every Glitchbug in the park stopped.

Their antennae swiveled. Their huge cyan eyes went even wider. And one by one, then ten by ten, then all at once, they came floating out of the streetlights and the signs and the hot dog stand, and drifted toward Lumislug's glow like moths to a porch light.

They landed all over it, all over its back and its eye-stalks, crackling happily, until Lumislug looked like a slug wearing a sparkly yellow-and-black coat.

Lumislug didn't seem to mind at all. It just kept glowing, calm and steady, while the Glitchbugs snuggled up against it.

"KIT," said Rook. "You are a GENIUS."

They walked Lumislug very, very slowly through the whole neighborhood, street by street, collecting Glitchbugs as they went. It was the slowest parade in the history of Neonis. But slowly, street by street, the lights went back to normal. The signs said NOODLES again. The hot dog stand stopped singing. The floating trains started floating again, and the people inside them burst into applause.

And as they went, somebody fell into step behind them.

Rook didn't notice at first. Then Zib's lights flicked to a sharp, warning red, and Rook turned around.

A man was standing at the mouth of an alley, a few steps back, out of the bright lights. He wasn't wearing a white jumpsuit. He was wearing a plain gray rain jacket with the hood up, like half the people in Neonis. But Rook knew the round cheeks under that hood. He knew those worried eyes.

"Strand," he said.

Kit stepped in front of Lumislug. Plazmet's flame flared up bright and hot, and the shiny rain hissed where it touched him.

Strand didn't reach for anything. He held his hands a little way out from his sides, open and empty, the way you would with a frightened animal. "I'm not here for him," he said. He didn't look at Zib. He seemed to be trying very hard not to. "I'm not here for anything. I saw your ship come in. I just..." He stopped. He looked past them, at the Glitchbugs riding on Lumislug's back. "I told

them the crates were too full," he said, very quietly. "Nobody listens to Second Class."

"Where is she?" Rook said. "Where's Sola?"

Strand looked at the ground for a long time.

"She's safe," he said finally. His voice was very low. "She's at the Station. They gave her a room with a big window. She's... she's safe." He swallowed. "For now."

"What does that mean? 'For now'?"

Strand opened his mouth. And on his wrist, under the gray sleeve, a Linker buzzed.

He glanced down at it. Rook caught a flash of orange on the little screen, the ring and the slash, and a name underneath. PELL.

Strand turned his wrist so the screen faced his arm. It stopped buzzing. Then, at once, it started again, and this time a voice came out of it, small and flat and perfectly calm.

"Strand. North pad. Four minutes." A pause. "Whatever you're doing, finish it."

Strand looked at Rook. His worried, round face looked even more worried than usual. It looked older, too.

"I'm sorry," he whispered. "I'm sorry. I can't."

And he turned and walked back into the alley, fast, with his head down, and the glittering rain closed behind him like a curtain.

* * *

They took the Glitchbugs to a place called the Grid Gardens, which was what the people of Neonis called the city's oldest power station. It was a huge, humming, crackling building full of giant coils and glowing wires and great sparking towers of electricity, and wild Glitchbugs had been living there happily for as long as anyone could remember, eating the extra sparks. It was, an old

engineer told them, exactly where these ones would have wanted to go, if Helix hadn't caught them in the first place.

One by one, the Glitchbugs drifted off Lumislug's back and floated up into the crackling towers and disappeared into the sparks, chirping happily.

All except one.

It was the littlest one. Smaller than the others, with a slightly crooked antenna and a mischievous gleam in its eye. All afternoon, it had been following Rook. Every time he turned around, there it was. And every time it got close, it zapped him. Right on the top of his cap. *Zzzt.* Not hard. Just enough to make Zib jump.

Now, while all the others floated away into the power station, it stayed. It hovered in front of Rook's face, its antennae crackling.

Rook narrowed his eyes. "Don't you dare."

Zzzt. Right on his cap.

"BIP!" said Zib, extremely offended, and his lights flashed red at it.

The little Glitchbug made a happy crackling sound, like popcorn, and did a loop.

Rook sighed. Then, slowly, he started to grin. Because the little Glitchbug wasn't flying away. It was just hovering there. Looking at him. Waiting. Its crooked antenna was twitching.

"You want to come with us," Rook said slowly. "Don't you? That's why you keep zapping me. You've been trying to get my attention all day."

The Glitchbug zapped him one more time. On purpose. And then made a happy, crackling, popcorn sound.

"I like this one," Rook said to Kit. He held up his Linker. "Want to join the team? You'll have to stop zapping Zib, though."

The Glitchbug considered this. Then it zapped Zib, very gently, on the edge of his saucer. Zib went "BIP!" and every light on him flashed at once.

Then the Glitchbug flew straight into the cyan beam.

GLITCHBUG. PARTNER CONFIRMED.

"Welcome to the team, Glitchbug," said Rook. His hair was still standing straight up.

"Bip," said Zib grumpily. But Rook noticed his lights were twinkling, just a little, at the edges. Like he was trying very hard not to laugh.

* * *

It was dark by the time they got back to Dr. Vashti's lab. The city was glowing outside the round window, pink and blue and gold, as bright as ever, with the shiny rain still falling.

Dr. Vashti was standing at the window with her back to them. She was very still.

"Dr. Vashti?" said Rook.

She didn't turn around. She just pointed out the window, at the tallest tower in the whole city. It was a great spiraling needle of glass and silver, so tall that its tip disappeared into the clouds. And at the top, Rook knew without being told, there would be a crystal.

"The Voltspire," Dr. Vashti said. "The Neonis Relay Tower."

As they watched, every screen on every building in the whole city flickered. Every hologram vanished. Every sign went blank. And then, on every single one of them, all at once, a face appeared. A face with big sparkly sunglasses and enormous headphones and hair that stood straight up like a lightning bolt.

A voice came booming out of every speaker in Neonis.

"GOOD EVENING, NEONIS! You're listening to the one, the only, the most illegal voice on the airwaves, DJ STATIC! And

tonight, my beautiful glowing city, I'm gonna tell you the truth about that pulse coming out of the Starfall Crater, and what Helix doesn't want you to—"

BZZZZT.

Every screen went black.

The silence was enormous.

In the window, Dr. Vashti's reflection had gone very pale.

"That was a Helix jammer," she said quietly. "They're cutting Static off." She turned to look at them, and her eyes were frightened in a way Rook had never seen them before. "Children, I think they're coming for this tower next."

Chapter 21

Pirate Radio

Everyone in Neonis listened to DJ Static.

Rook found that out the next morning, walking through the glowing streets with Kit and Dr. Vashti. The noodle seller was talking about DJ Static. The kids at the arcade were talking about DJ Static. Two old ladies on a floating train were arguing about DJ Static so loudly that their fluffy pink Alienmon covered its ears. And everywhere, people kept glancing up at the big screens on the sides of the buildings. The screens that had gone black the night before, right in the middle of a sentence.

"Static's the most famous voice on the whole planet," Kit explained, reading off a poster stuck to a lamppost. The poster showed a grinning face with big sparkly sunglasses, a pair of enormous headphones, and spiky hair that stood straight up like a lightning bolt. Underneath it said, in glowing letters: TUNE IN. TURN UP. FIND OUT. "Static's been on the radio every night for fifteen years. Music, news, battle results, all of it. And Static's the Keeper here, too. The Keeper of the Voltspire."

"And lately," said Dr. Vashti quietly, "Static is the only one on any channel in the whole Kessler system who's been talking about the pulse from the Starfall Crater."

Rook looked up at the tallest tower in the city. The Voltspire. A great spiral needle of glass and silver, so tall its tip vanished into the clouds. Somewhere up there, at the top, was a crystal. And somewhere up there, last night, Helix had reached out and

switched it off like a radio.

"So how do we find Static?" he asked.

Dr. Vashti smiled her crinkly smile. "Oh, that's easy," she said. "We let Static find us."

* * *

She was right.

They had only been walking for another ten minutes when a little round Alienmon came zooming down out of the sky and stopped in front of them, hovering at the height of Rook's nose. It looked like a tiny flying radio. It was square and silver, with a round speaker for a face and a long, wobbly antenna on top, and it crackled with static when it moved.

It looked at Rook. It looked at Zib. Then it beeped three times, very fast, and a voice came crackling out of its speaker-face.

"*Kshhh.* Hey there, little dudes. *Kshhh.* Heard about the Glitchbug parade yesterday. Heard about a kid with a fire-comet and a saucer on his hat. *Kshhh.* Follow the Squawkbox. And for the love of good music, don't let anybody see you."

The little flying radio spun around and zoomed off down a narrow alley.

They followed it.

It led them through the back streets of Neonis, where the lights were dimmer and the holograms were older and flickery. Down alleys. Up fire escapes. Through a laundromat where every single washing machine was playing a different song. Across a rooftop garden full of glowing plants. Up a rusty ladder. And finally, to a little metal shack perched on the very edge of a very tall rooftop, so close to the edge that it looked like it might fall off.

The shack was covered in antennas. Dozens of them. Big ones and small ones, bent ones and straight ones, all pointing in

different directions, all sprouting out of the roof like a bad haircut. Cables ran everywhere. A hand-painted sign on the door said: ON AIR. (OR SHOULD BE.)

The Squawkbox zoomed in through a round window. The door swung open.

"Well, come on in, then!" said a voice. "Don't just stand there! You're letting the quiet in!"

* * *

Inside, the shack was the most wonderful mess Rook had ever seen.

It was crammed from floor to ceiling with records. Thousands of records, in towering, tilting stacks, and in boxes, and in crates, and on shelves that sagged under their weight. There were speakers everywhere, big ones and small ones, some as tall as Rook. There were tangles of wire, and blinking control panels, and microphones on long bendy arms, and a whole wall covered in buttons and sliders and switches. Posters covered the ceiling. Fairy lights were strung across everything, flashing in time to a low, thumping beat that seemed to come up from the floor itself.

And in the middle of it all, sitting backwards on a spinning chair in front of a giant turntable, was DJ Static.

Static was exactly like the poster. Spiky hair, bleached white at the tips, standing straight up like a lightning bolt. Enormous headphones, slung around the neck. Sparkly sunglasses, even though it was dim inside. A jacket covered in patches and pins and little flashing lights. And a grin so wide and so bright that it seemed to light up the shack all by itself.

Static spun all the way around in the chair, twice, and stopped facing them.

"So YOU'RE the fire-comet kid," Static said, pointing at Rook with a drumstick. "And YOU'RE the engineer. And you" — the drumstick swung to Dr. Vashti — "are the famous Dr. Imogen Vashti, who never, ever leaves her Observatory, except apparently she does now." Static whistled. "Big week for surprises."

Then Static's eyes behind the sparkly sunglasses landed on Zib, sitting on Rook's cap. And the grin went still.

"And that," Static said softly, "must be the little guy who's been making my dishes sing."

"Your dishes?" said Rook.

Static jumped up off the chair, grabbed a giant record off the turntable, and spun it on one finger like a basketball.

"Let me tell you something, fire-comet kid. My show goes out to all fourteen worlds. All of them. Every night. You know how?" Static pointed up at the ceiling, at the forest of antennas on the roof. "Dishes. Hundreds of them. On every rooftop in this city. My own personal network. They catch my signal and bounce it from Neonis to everywhere." Static flipped the record and caught it. "And about three weeks ago, those dishes started catching something else. Something weird. A pulse. Coming from the Starfall Crater. And every once in a while, when it pulses, it sounds like..." Static paused, and looked at Zib. "Like a little bip."

Zib's lights flickered.

"So I started talking about it," said Static. "On the air. Every night. Because nobody else was. And that's when Helix started breaking my dishes."

Static dropped back into the spinning chair.

"They come at night. Little drones. They zap the dishes, cut the wires, bend the antennas. Every time I fix one, two more go dark. And last night they got the big ones. All the important ones. The

ones that connect to the Voltspire." Static's grin was gone now. "I've got a show to do tonight, and I've got no way to send it. They've shut me up." Static pulled off the sparkly sunglasses. Underneath, Static's eyes were tired and angry. "Nobody shuts me up."

Kit had been very quiet this whole time. Now Kit stepped forward. Their goggles were already pulled down. Their eyes behind them were shining.

"I can fix dishes," Kit said.

* * *

So they spent the whole night on the rooftops of Neonis.

It was the most exciting night of Rook's life, and that was saying something, considering the week he'd had.

Static gave them a map, scribbled on the back of a record sleeve, showing every broken dish in the city. There were twenty-three of them. They were scattered across the rooftops in a great zigzag, all the way from Static's shack to the foot of the Voltspire. Some were on tall towers. Some were on little buildings. Some were on rooftops so far apart that the only way to get between them was to jump.

So they jumped.

They jumped from rooftop to rooftop across the glowing city, with the shiny rain falling all around them and the neon lights blazing below. Kit went first, with the toolbelt clanking and the goggles down, leaping across gaps that made Rook's stomach flip. Rook came next, with Plazmet streaking along beside him like a torch. Dr. Vashti came last, in her lab coat, holding up the hem with one hand, puffing and laughing and saying "Oh, goodness! Oh, my goodness!" every time she jumped, and somehow never once falling.

At every broken dish, they all had a job.

Kit fixed. Kit tightened bolts and spliced wires and bent bent antennas back into shape. Kit's fingers flew. Gleamgrub crawled over every rusted bolt and ate the rust right off it, so it would turn. Kit worked faster and surer than Rook had ever seen, humming to themselves the whole time.

Rook and Plazmet guarded. Because Static was right. Helix drones came. Little white flying machines, round and humming, with one red eye and a long zapping arm, and an orange ring and slash stamped on every shell. They didn't buzz around like bugs. They came out of the dark in twos and threes, in straight, careful lines, always from the side Rook wasn't watching, always heading for whatever dish Kit was fixing. Somebody, somewhere, was steering them. Somebody who could see exactly where the kids were.

On the ninth rooftop, three of them came at once, and while Plazmet blocked two, the third got behind him. *KZZZAKK!* A red bolt hit him square. His flame went blue and ragged, and he spun down onto the wet rooftop and skidded, hissing, through a puddle. *TSSSSSS.*

"PLAZMET!" Rook's stomach dropped through his sneakers.

Plazmet looked up at him through the steam. Not asking to go back. Asking, *Which one?*

Think first. The drones had to stop and hover, just for a heartbeat, to aim. "Stay down," Rook said, his voice shaking. "Wait till they stop. Then go."

The drones drifted in. Slowed. Stopped. "NOW!"

Plazmet blazed up out of the puddle and Comet-Dashed them right out of the sky. *ZZZZAP-FWOOOM! KRUNCH!* The drones went spinning off into the night, sparking and smoking, and dropped,

dark and smoking, onto the gravel of the rooftop.

Plazmet sank onto Rook's shoulder, panting little puffs of steam, and sneezed. Rook cupped his hands around him to keep the rain off until he burned gold again. After that, every time the drones came, Plazmet waited for them to stop and aim. And every time, they went down. But more kept coming. Whoever was steering them had plenty to spare.

Mycelith held things steady. On the twelfth rooftop, an enormous antenna, tall as a tree, cracked at the base and started to fall. Toward the street, toward the floating trains, toward the people below. Mycelith stepped forward, wrapped its long, rope-like arms around the antenna, and held it. Held it upright, steady and calm, its roots gripping the rooftop, while Kit welded the base back together. When Kit was done, Mycelith let go, very slowly, and the antenna stood straight and tall all on its own.

And Glitchbug woke them up.

That was Rook's idea. When Kit finished fixing a dish, it still sat there cold and dead, because the power had been cut for so long. So Rook let Glitchbug out, and pointed at the dish. And Glitchbug zoomed straight over and zapped it. Right in the middle. *ZZZZT!* And the dish crackled, and sparked, and hummed, and came back to life. Its little red light blinked on. It swiveled around, all on its own, and pointed toward the Voltspire.

Glitchbug made a happy popcorn sound and zapped Rook's cap. Zib flashed red at it.

"That's twenty," Kit said, ticking it off on the map. "Twenty-one." Zap. "Twenty-two." Zap.

The night went on. The rain fell. The city glowed. Rook's legs ached from jumping and his hair was standing up from Glitchbug's zaps and his face was wet with shiny rain, and he

didn't think he had ever been so happy.

The twenty-third dish was the last one.

It was on the highest rooftop of all, the very last building before the Voltspire. Up here, the wind was strong and cold. The city was spread out below them like a carpet of jewels. And the Voltspire rose up right beside them, so close and so tall that it filled half the sky, its silver spiral glinting in the rain.

The dish was the biggest one yet. It was huge, as wide as the *Dandelion*, curved like a giant bowl, pointing straight at the top of the Voltspire. Helix had cut every single one of its wires.

Kit knelt down beside it and went to work.

Rook stood guard. Plazmet hovered in the wind, his flame flickering. Dr. Vashti sat on an air vent, catching her breath, with Zib sitting in her lap. Rook noticed that. Zib had never sat in Dr. Vashti's lap before.

Kit worked for a long time. Splicing. Twisting. Taping. Muttering. Then they stopped. They pulled their goggles up. And they held up one last wire.

"This is it," Kit said. "The last one. Ready?"

Rook nodded. Glitchbug crackled on his shoulder, ready to zap.

Kit plugged in the final wire.

* * *

The dish crackled to life.

Its red light blinked on. Its great bowl hummed. It swiveled, all on its own, with a long, low, mechanical groan. But it didn't swivel toward the Voltspire, the way all the others had.

It swiveled up.

Up, past the Voltspire. Up, past the clouds. Up, toward the stars.

And it caught something.

Out of the little speaker on its side came a sound. Not music. Not Static's voice. A hiss, a crackle, a whistle, like a radio tuning between stations. And then, through the hiss, voices. Far away. Faint. Like voices at the bottom of a well.

"...*kssshh*... Station control, this is Admin office... *kssh*... core from Thalassa installed in Bay Seven, holding stable... *ksshhhh*..."

Rook's skin went cold all over. Kit froze with their hand still on the wire.

"It's Helix," Kit breathed. "It's a Helix signal. It's coming from the Station."

The voices crackled and faded. Then another voice came through. A girl's voice. Very faint, very far away. It sounded tired.

"...*kssh*... is he there? You said if I came... *kssh*... you said you'd take me to him. Is my dad there?"

Rook's heart stopped.

"Sola," he whispered.

And then a man's voice answered her.

It was very calm. It was very quiet. It was the quietest voice Rook had ever heard, so quiet that he had to lean in close to the speaker to hear it. It wasn't angry. It wasn't loud. It wasn't mean. It was gentle, almost. Smooth and soft and patient, like someone talking to a sleepy child.

And it made every hair on Rook's arms stand straight up.

"Patience, Miss Reyes," the voice said. "You'll see him very soon. Everyone will." A pause. The hiss of static. And then, even quieter, as if the man had turned away to speak to someone else: "Tell Vex the timeline holds. Phase Three begins when the eighth tower cracks."

Then the signal went dead.

The dish whined. Its red light flickered and went out. It swung slowly back down and pointed at the Voltspire, as if nothing had happened.

Nobody moved.

The wind blew across the rooftop. The shiny rain kept falling. Far below, the city glowed and hummed and played its thousand songs, and nobody down there had heard a thing.

"Who was that?" Kit whispered finally. Their voice was shaking. "Rook. Who was that?"

Rook didn't know.

But Dr. Vashti did.

Rook turned around. She was still sitting on the air vent, with Zib in her lap. But she had gone white. Not pale. White. As white as her lab coat. As white as paper. Her hands were gripping Zib so tightly that he had gone still. Her eyes were wide and fixed on the dish, and they were full of something Rook had never seen in them before.

She was afraid.

"Dr. Vashti?"

She didn't answer for a long moment. When she did, her voice was very slow and very quiet.

"That," she said, "was Director Kael Thorne. The head of Helix."

* * *

They climbed back down to Static's shack in silence.

Static was waiting for them. All twenty-three dishes were glowing on the big control panel, and the shack was humming with power, and Static should have been happy. But when they played the recording, Static's grin went away again. Static took off the sparkly sunglasses and sat down very slowly in the spinning

chair and didn't spin it.

"The eighth tower," Static said quietly. "Cracks."

Kit was staring at their arm. At the drawing they had copied from the Forge Gate, all those days ago. It had mostly washed off by now. But Kit had traced it over and over again, every night, in pen, so it wouldn't disappear. A circle. And around it, eight smaller circles, all joined together with lines.

"Eight towers," Kit whispered. "Ferrox. Sporeholm. Thalassa. Here. And four more. And Helix is cracking them." They looked up. "Dad's crystal had a crack in it. A straight one. Dr. Moor's had a scratch. They took Captain Marsh's away completely. And now they're coming for this one." Kit's voice went small. "What happens when they crack all eight?"

Nobody answered.

Rook looked at Dr. Vashti. She was standing by the window, with her back to them, looking out at the glowing city. Very still. She hadn't said a word since the rooftop.

"Dr. Vashti," Rook said. "How did you know that was him? Director Thorne?"

She didn't turn around.

"Nobody knows what he sounds like," Rook went on. "Even Static had never heard it. He's never on the news. He never talks in public. Nobody's ever even seen his face. So how did you know his voice?"

For a long time, Dr. Vashti didn't answer.

Then, without turning around, she said, very softly, so softly Rook almost didn't hear it:

"Because I knew him, Rook. A long, long time ago."

And she reached into the deepest pocket of her lab coat. The one she never let anybody see inside. Rook watched her hand

close around something in there. Something flat and small.

But she didn't take it out.

She just stood at the window, holding it, looking out at the stars.

Chapter 22

Static on the Line

The next morning, DJ Static went back on the air.

Rook was asleep on a pile of beanbags in the corner of Static's shack when it happened. He woke up to the sound of every speaker in the room crackling on at once, and the floor thumping with a beat so loud his teeth rattled. And then Static's voice, booming out of every speaker in the shack, and every speaker on every rooftop, and every screen on every building in the whole glowing city.

"GOOOOOD MORNING, NEONIS! Did you miss me? I know you missed me! Somebody tried to switch me off last night, but guess what, my beautiful glowing city? NOBODY! SWITCHES! ME! OFF!"

Outside the round window, Rook could see people in the street below stopping and looking up at the screens. Somebody cheered. Then somebody else. Then a whole floating train full of people went past, and every single one of them was pressed against the windows, waving.

"And I've got some very special guests to thank for it," Static went on. "A fire-comet kid. A genius engineer. A professor who jumps rooftops in a lab coat. And a little saucer with a big secret. They fixed every dish in the city last night, folks. All twenty-three. With their bare hands and a very cheeky Glitchbug." A pause. "So tonight, to say thank you, we're throwing a party. Live from the top of the Voltspire, broadcasting to all fourteen worlds of the Kessler system for the first time in history. It's gonna be loud. It's

gonna be bright. And the main event..."

Static spun around in the spinning chair and pointed straight at Rook, who was sitting up on the beanbags with his hair sticking up in every direction.

"...is ME against HIM."

Rook's mouth fell open.

"LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, ALIENMON OF ALL AGES," Static roared into the microphone. "TONIGHT IS... BATTLE NIGHT!"

* * *

The Voltspire was even bigger on the inside.

That night, they rode a glass elevator up through the middle of it. It went up and up and up, so fast that Rook's ears popped three times, through floor after floor of glowing glass, until finally the doors slid open onto the very top.

And Rook stopped breathing.

The top of the Voltspire was an arena. A great round arena, open to the sky, with the clouds drifting past just below the edge and the stars blazing overhead. Stands climbed up the sides in great curving tiers, all the way around. And they were packed. Thousands of people. Tens of thousands, maybe. Waving glowsticks and banners and signs, stamping their feet, cheering so loud that the whole tower seemed to sway.

Strobe lights flashed. Lasers swept across the sky in great green and pink and blue beams. Giant screens hung over the stands, showing the crowd, the arena, the stars. Fireworks burst overhead. Music boomed out of speakers the size of houses, so loud that the floor shook, so loud that Rook could feel the beat in his chest, so loud that he couldn't hear himself think.

And right above the middle of it all, at the very peak of the Voltspire, floating inside a cage of silver bars that spiraled up into

the night sky, was the crystal.

It was enormous. Bigger than the one on Ferrox. Bigger than any of them. It was shaped like a huge icicle, pointing straight up at the stars, and it glowed with a fierce, fizzing, electric yellow, crackling with little forks of lightning that danced up and down its sides. Rook could hear it humming even over the music. The same note as the Shards in his satchel. Only louder. Much, much louder.

Dr. Vashti stood beside him, looking up at it with her mouth open.

"Oh," she said softly. "Oh, it's beautiful."

Kit was looking at it too. But Kit wasn't looking at how beautiful it was. Kit was looking at the silver bars around it, and the bolts that held it, and the little camera on a pole that watched it.

"Static's got it guarded," Kit said. "Cameras, sensors, alarms. The works." Kit's eyes narrowed. "Helix would have a really hard time getting to this one."

"Good," said Rook.

Kit didn't say anything. But they didn't look like they thought it was good enough.

* * *

In the middle of the arena, on a round stage that flashed with lights in time to the music, stood DJ Static.

Static had dressed up for the occasion. The jacket was gold now, covered in sequins that flashed every color under the strobe lights. The sunglasses were even sparklier. The hair was even spikier, and somehow, it was glowing. Static had a microphone in one hand and the other hand thrown up in the air, and the crowd was screaming.

"LADIES AND GENTLEMEN!" Static bellowed, and the voice came booming out of every speaker on the tower, and on every rooftop in the city, and, Rook realized with a jolt, out of every radio on every one of the fourteen worlds. "IT'S! BATTLE! NIGHT!"

The crowd roared.

Somewhere, Rook thought, Mom was listening. In her kitchen in Dustmere, with flour on her nose. And DX-4. And Old Dusty. And Hank, in his hangar on Ferrox. And Nurse Coral, and Fenna, and Captain Marsh.

And maybe, somewhere, in a room with a big window on a silver space station, Sola.

He walked out onto the stage.

* * *

Static's Alienmon was a speaker.

That was the only way to describe it. It came stomping out onto the stage on four huge, thick, stumpy legs, like an elephant's, and it was shaped like the biggest speaker Rook had ever seen. It was as tall as a house and as wide as a truck. Its body was a giant black box, covered in round speaker cones, big ones and small ones, all pulsing in and out in time to the music. It had two long tusks made of shining chrome, curving up from the bottom of its face like a mammoth. And on its front, right where a face would be, it had a big round dial, with a needle that swung back and forth, and two small glowing green lights for eyes.

Every step it took made the stage jump. *THOOM. THOOM.* Rook felt it come up through his feet and into his knees.

The crowd went absolutely bonkers.

Rook's Linker beeped. BOOMBASTADON. SONIC-TYPE. EXTREMELY LOUD.

"No kidding," Rook muttered. His mouth had gone dry.

"Fire-comet kid!" Static yelled across the stage, grinning. "Let's see what you've got!"

Rook sent out Plazmet.

Plazmet blazed out onto the stage, his comet-tail streaming, his plasma ring spinning, and the crowd went "OOOOOOOH." The screens all showed him in close-up, enormous, glowing.

The Boombastadon's dial swung all the way to the right. Its speaker cones all pulsed inward at once. And then it opened its mouth and let out a sound.

BOOM.

It wasn't just a sound. It was a wave. A shockwave. Rook saw it ripple out through the air, like a ripple on a pond, bending the laser beams, bending the rain, and it hit Plazmet head-on and knocked him clean across the stage. He went tumbling end over end, his flame flattening sideways like a candle in a gale, and crashed into the edge of the arena with a *CLANG* that dented the metal rail.

The crowd went "OOOOOH!" in a different way.

"Plazmet!"

Plazmet shook himself and flew back in. But the Boombastadon was ready.

BOOM. BOOM. BOOM.

Three shockwaves, one after another. Each one made Rook's ears ring. Each one made his teeth rattle and his eyeballs feel wobbly, and he was standing all the way back at the edge of the stage. Plazmet dodged the first one. The second one clipped his tail and spun him like a top. The third one hit him dead-on.

WHAMMM.

It folded his whole flame in half. It drove him down into the stage so hard that the glowing floor tiles cracked in a star around

him, and the lights under them sputtered out. For a second, all Rook could see was smoke.

Then Plazmet floated up out of it. Slowly. His plasma ring was wobbling. His comet-tail had shrunk to a stub.

Rook sent out Glitchbug to help. Glitchbug zoomed straight at the Boombastadon, crackling and zapping. The Boombastadon looked at it. Its dial twitched. It let out one small, polite boom. And Glitchbug went flying, end over end, straight off the stage and into the crowd.

"GLITCHBUG!"

In the third row, a big man with a beard caught Glitchbug in both hands, looked down at it in surprise, and then passed it to the lady next to him. She passed it to a kid. The kid passed it to his grandma. The grandma passed it forward. And Glitchbug went traveling back down through the crowd, hand over hand over hand, crackling dizzily the whole way and zapping everybody who touched it, until finally the man in the front row reached over the barrier and handed it back to Rook.

"Nice bug!" the man shouted, his hair standing straight up.

Glitchbug wobbled. Its crooked antenna was bent even more crooked now. But it zapped Rook's cap anyway, a little weaker than usual. It seemed to be having the time of its life.

* * *

Plazmet came back to Rook's side, his flame low. Glitchbug crackled on his shoulder. Across the stage, the Boombastadon stood calm and huge, its speaker cones pulsing, its dial ticking, waiting.

Then it stamped one huge foot and let out the biggest boom yet.

BA-DOOOOOOM.

Rook didn't even see it coming. One second Plazmet was beside him. The next, the wave had scooped Plazmet up and thrown him the whole length of the stage, and he hit the rail and dropped and lay there on the cracked tiles. His fire had shrunk to almost nothing. A small orange glow, flickering, flickering, like a match in the wind. The giant screens showed it in close-up, for all fourteen worlds to see.

The crowd went quiet.

"Plazmet!" Rook's voice cracked right down the middle. He ran. He slid onto his knees beside him. Plazmet was so small. Smaller than he'd been since he was Plazmo. His plasma ring had stopped spinning altogether.

Once, Rook's hand would have gone straight to the Linker. Not anymore. He just knelt there on the cracked floor with his hands on either side of that little flame, and he waited for Plazmet to tell him.

Plazmet opened his eye.

He looked right up at Rook. And then, very slowly, he pushed himself up off the floor, wobbling, and turned around, and faced the Boombastadon. His tiny flame stood up straight. And his plasma ring gave one stubborn little spin.

Not yet, that spin said. *Not yet.*

Rook stood up.

The music thumped. The crowd chanted. Static was grinning.

And Rook stopped.

He stood very still in the middle of the noise and the lights and the crowd, and he made himself think. Think first.

He couldn't beat the Boombastadon by being louder. Nothing in the whole Kessler system was louder than the Boombastadon. He couldn't beat it by being stronger. It was the size of a house. He

couldn't beat it with just Plazmet, or just Glitchbug, or just anybody.

But he didn't have just anybody.

He thought about the rooftops. About last night. About Kit fixing and Plazmet guarding and Mycelith holding and Glitchbug waking. About how not one of them could have fixed all twenty-three dishes alone. But together, they had done it in one night.

And he thought about the Boombastadon itself. How before every big boom, its dial swung right. How its two little green eyes watched everything. How all its speakers had to pulse together, in time, to make a shockwave. Like a band that had to play the same note at once.

"We can't win by being louder," Rook said, out loud, to his team. "We have to be smarter." He took a deep breath. "Everybody. Together."

He opened his Linker. And out came everyone.

Cactling stomped out onto the stage, cracking its stubby knuckles. Lumislug slid out beside it, blinking calmly. Glitchbug crackled on his shoulder. Plazmet floated up beside him, small and dim and absolutely refusing to sit down. And on his cap, Zib flashed every color at once.

The crowd went quiet. Then it went louder than ever.

Static's grin got wider.

"Okay," Rook said. "Here's the plan."

* * *

"Lumislug!" Rook called. "Brightest you've ever been!"

Lumislug glowed. It glowed and glowed and glowed. It glowed brighter than it had in the Mushroom Maze, brighter than in the streets of Neonis. It glowed until it was too bright to look at, a

blazing lime-green star in the middle of the stage, so bright that the strobes and the lasers looked dim beside it.

The Boombastadon's two little green eyes squeezed shut. It shook its huge head. It couldn't see.

So it fired at the light.

BOOM. The wave hit Lumislug and shoved it backward across the stage, squeaking along the tiles, leaving a long glowing smear behind it. Its eye-stalks flattened. Its glow shuddered, dimmed... and came right back up. Lumislug dug in and held on and kept glowing, slow and steady and stubborn, right in the Boombastadon's face.

"Hold on, Lumislug!" Rook yelled. "Cactling! The dial!"

The dial was already swinging right. Rook could see it. The next boom was coming.

Cactling wound up and threw. A single needle, straight and true, whistling across the stage. It hit the Boombastadon's big round dial right in the middle, right where the needle pivoted, and stuck there. The dial jammed. The needle couldn't swing.

But the boom had already started. *BWOMM.* Half a shockwave burst out and caught Cactling square, and it went bowling backward across the stage, needles snapping, and fetched up against Rook's shins in a grumpy, prickly heap. Its flower was squashed flat. It sat up anyway, and glared over at the Boombastadon as if to say, *That's all?*

The Boombastadon's speakers sputtered. *Bmmp. Bmp. Bmp.* It couldn't turn itself up.

"Glitchbug! The wires!"

Glitchbug shot off Rook's shoulder like a rocket. It zipped straight between the Boombastadon's stumpy legs. One huge foot came down, *THOOM*, right where it had been, and the tile under it

shattered. Glitchbug jinked left. Another foot. *THOOM.* Glitchbug jinked right. And then it was underneath, and it found the thick bundle of glowing wires on the Boombastadon's underside, and zapped them with everything it had. *ZZZZZZZZZT!*

The Boombastadon's beat skipped.

It actually skipped. The music coming out of its speakers stuttered and jumped and hiccupped. *Boom-boom-b-b-b-boom. Bm. Boom-ba-ba-boom.* It sounded like a record scratching. The Boombastadon shook its head in confusion. It stomped. Its speakers were all pulsing at different times now, all mixed up, all out of rhythm. It couldn't see. It couldn't turn itself up.

But it wasn't beaten. Not yet.

Its speaker cones shuddered. They pulled in. They pulled in further, every single one, straining, trying to find each other, trying to get back in time. *Boom... ba-boom... BOOM... BOOM...* Rook's stomach went cold. It was finding the beat again. One more shockwave like the last one, and nobody on this stage would be getting up.

And Plazmet was the only one left who could reach it. Plazmet, who was the size of a teacup.

Rook listened. Really listened, the way Dr. Vashti listened to her green wavy line. *Boom... ba-boom... BOOM...* And there it was. Every time the beat came around, it stumbled, just once, in the same place. A hiccup. A gap. One tiny heartbeat where every speaker on that giant body was empty, and nothing at all was coming out.

"Plazmet," Rook said, very quietly. His heart was slamming so hard he could hear it over the crowd. "Not on the beat. On the gap. You'll only get one try. Wait for it."

Plazmet coiled back. His plasma ring spun faster and faster, humming higher and higher, the way it hadn't been able to all night. He drew in every last scrap of fire he had. He went from orange to gold to white.

Boom... ba-boom... BOOM...

The Boombastadon's cones pulled all the way in. All of them. Together. The big one was coming.

"Wait for it..."

...BOOM... ba...

"NOW!"

Plazmet streaked across the stage in a blazing line of gold and white fire.

Comet Dash.

He went into the gap like a key into a lock. The boom came a split second behind him. It caught the very end of his tail and tore it to sparks, and his flame went thin as a thread, and for one horrible second Rook couldn't see him at all.

Then he hit the Boombastadon right in the middle of its big black speaker-chest.

KA-WHAMMMM.

Fire burst across every speaker cone at once. The whole stage jumped. The Boombastadon rocked back on its stumpy legs, and its chrome tusks scraped sparks off the floor.

The Boombastadon swayed. Its speakers let out one last, long, low, wobbly sound.

BWAAAAAAAAAAMP.

And then it sat down. Right in the middle of the stage. Like a dog sitting down when it's told to. Its legs splayed out. Its dial unjammed and swung lazily back to zero. Its green eyes blinked open, and it looked around, a bit dazed, and then it let out a small,

contented *bmp*, like a burp.

For one second, there was total silence on top of the Voltspire.

Then a tiny spark drifted down out of the smoke, sinking lower and lower, and Rook dove across the cracked tiles and caught it in both hands.

Plazmet was barely there. A warm flicker in Rook's palms, so faint he could see his own fingers through it. But his eye opened a crack and looked up at Rook. And Plazmet sneezed. *Pfft.* One tiny, proud spark.

Rook laughed, and it came out wet. Cactling limped over and leaned against his knee. Lumislug slid up on his other side, its glow turned down soft and tired. Glitchbug landed on his shoulder and, very gently for once, didn't zap anybody. And on his cap, Zib flashed gold.

Then the crowd went WILD.

They screamed. They stamped. They jumped up and down so hard that the whole tower actually did sway, just a little. Glowsticks flew through the air. Fireworks burst overhead in great showers of gold and green. The giant screens showed Rook's face, enormous, with his hair sticking straight up and his mouth hanging open and Plazmet cupped against his chest. In the front row, the man with the beard was crying.

DJ Static walked slowly across the stage. Static knelt down beside the Boombastadon and patted it on its big chrome tusk, and the Boombastadon let out a low, tired hum, like a fridge settling down for the night. Then Static stood up, and pulled off those sparkly sunglasses, and looked at Rook with tired, bright, grinning eyes.

"Now THAT," Static said, into the microphone, so that all fourteen worlds could hear it, "is teamwork, kid."

Then Static handed Rook his fourth Signal Shard.

* * *

It was yellow. Electric yellow, like the crystal at the top of the Voltspire, crackling with tiny forks of lightning that tickled Rook's palm. It hummed so loudly that he could hear it over the crowd. And when he took the other three Shards out of his satchel, the blue and the green and the faint, flickering sea-blue, they all began to hum together. A four-part chord. Rich and deep and beautiful, like a choir.

The crowd went quiet. They could hear it too.

And then Zib floated down off Rook's cap.

He floated down slowly, the way he had on Ferrox, and on Sporeholm. As if something was pulling him. Down to the four Shards in Rook's hands. And as he got closer, they hummed louder. The crystal at the top of the Voltspire began to hum too, louder and louder, until the whole tower was singing. Every light in the arena flickered. Every screen went white.

And Zib's eye began to glow.

It glowed brighter than it ever had before. So bright that Rook had to squint. The beam of light shot up out of it, straight up, up past the crystal, up into the night sky over the Voltspire. And there, enormous, floating over the heads of all those thousands of people, so big that the whole crowd tipped their heads back and gasped, a picture appeared.

It was the Kessler system.

The whole thing, seen from far, far above. The sun in the middle, gold and round and blazing. And around it, in great looping circles, all fourteen worlds. Rook could see Dustara, red and dusty. Ferrox, gray and gleaming. Sporeholm, green and purple. Thalassa, with its glittering rings. Neonis, fizzing with

light.

And on eight of those worlds, there were towers.

They lit up one by one. A spark of light on Ferrox. A spark on Sporeholm. A spark on Thalassa, though that one was faint and flickering, much dimmer than the others. A spark on Neonis, blazing yellow, right where they were standing. And then four more, on four worlds Rook didn't know yet, one after another, around and around the sun.

And then lines of light shot out between them.

From tower to tower to tower, all the way around, joining all eight of them together. And from every tower, a line shot inward, to the very middle, to the sun. Until the whole picture was one great glowing shape, hanging in the sky over the Voltspire.

A circle. With eight points around it. All joined together.

It was the drawing on Kit's arm.

And it looked, Rook realized, with a cold feeling creeping up the back of his neck, exactly like a lock.

Like the face of a giant lock. The kind with a dial. The kind you spin around and around until it clicks.

Nobody in the arena made a sound. Not one person in all those thousands.

Then Kit spoke. Kit was standing at the edge of the stage, staring up at the picture, with their goggles pushed up on their forehead and their face lit up in the glow.

"The towers," Kit breathed. "They're not just towers."

Rook looked at Kit.

"They're holding something shut," Kit said. Their voice was barely more than a whisper. But the microphone was close, and it carried, out over the stands, out over the city, out to all fourteen worlds. "All eight of them. Together. They're not towers. They're a

seal."

The picture hung in the sky. On Thalassa, the faint, flickering light pulsed weakly. One line of the great lock was dimmer than all the others. Like a crack.

And in Rook's head, he heard a voice. A calm voice. A quiet voice. The quietest voice he had ever heard.

Phase Three begins when the eighth tower cracks.

The picture faded. Zib's eye went dark. The arena lights came back on, and the screens flickered back to life, and the crowd let out a long, shaky breath, all together, all at once, and then started to whisper.

Rook turned around to look for Dr. Vashti.

She was standing in the corner of the stage, by the elevator. Her face was in shadow. She had both hands pressed flat over her mouth. And she was looking up at the empty sky, where the picture had been, with an expression on her face that Rook had never seen on anybody before.

She didn't say a word. Not then. Not on the long ride down in the glass elevator. Not on the walk back through the glowing streets. Not at dinner, when Static ordered noodles for everybody and Kit and Rook were too tired and too worried to eat them.

She didn't say a word for the rest of the night.

* * *

Late that night, Rook woke up in the dark.

He was on the beanbags in Static's shack again. Kit was asleep next to him, snoring softly, with Mycelith curled around them like a cozy tree. Plazmet was floating over the record player, dimmed down to a soft orange glow. Static was asleep in the spinning chair with the headphones on.

And Zib was gone.

Rook sat up. His heart started to pound. Then he saw a thin line of light under the door to the little back room. And he heard a voice. Very quiet.

He crept over and looked through the crack in the door.

Dr. Vashti was sitting on an upturned record crate in the little back room, under a single dim bulb. Zib was sitting in her lap, very still. And she was holding something in her hand. Something flat and small and faded.

A photograph.

Rook couldn't see what was in it. Her thumb was covering most of it. But he could see that her shoulders were shaking. And he could hear what she was whispering, over and over, so softly that it was barely a sound at all.

"I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. I should have told them. I should have told them years ago."

Zib's lights pulsed, soft and gold, against her lab coat.

Rook backed away from the door very quietly. He went back to the beanbags and lay down. He didn't sleep.

He lay there in the dark, holding his satchel against his chest. Inside it, four Signal Shards were humming softly. Blue and green and yellow and faint, flickering sea-blue.

Four Shards.

And somewhere, back on the Molten Frontier, a pink squid in a sailor's hat was waiting at the end of a dock, beside a round glass ferry with a sign hanging off its side. A ferry that hadn't been allowed to dive in twenty years.

Not until somebody came along carrying four Signal Shards.

Chapter 23

The Deep Sea Ferry

Dr. Vashti didn't come with them.

"Somebody has to keep listening," she said in the morning, standing at the window of her lab with a cup of tea she wasn't drinking. Her eyes were red around the edges. She looked like she hadn't slept at all. "The signal is getting faster, Rook. If anything changes, I need to be here to hear it."

Rook wanted to ask her about the photograph. About the whispering in the back room. *I should have told them.* Told who? Told what?

But every time he opened his mouth to ask, she looked so tired and so sad that he closed it again.

She hugged him goodbye at the door. She hugged him for a long time. Then she hugged Kit, which surprised Kit so much that their goggles fell off. Then she knelt down in front of Zib, who was floating at the height of her knees, and looked at him for a long moment.

"Be careful, little one," she said softly. "Wherever you're taking them."

"Bip," said Zib. And he bumped his saucer very gently against her cheek.

* * *

They flew back across the stars to the Molten Frontier one more time. And when they landed on the round wooden platform at the

end of the longest dock in Port Ember, the Squid Sailor was already there.

It was sitting on its upturned barrel, exactly where they had left it, puffing on its bubble pipe. As the *Dandelion*'s hatch swung open, it took the pipe out of its mouth and pointed it at them.

"Heard you on the radio," it said. "Battle Night. All fourteen worlds. Very loud. Very impressive." It puffed a stream of bubbles. "Heard something else, too." Its big round eyes went to Rook's satchel. "Heard there were four Shards humming together at the end."

Rook reached into his satchel and took them out. The blue one from Ferrox. The green one from Sporeholm. The faint, flickering sea-blue one from Thalassa. And the crackling yellow one from Neonis.

He held them up.

They hummed. That four-part chord, deep and rich and beautiful. All along the docks of Port Ember, people stopped what they were doing and turned to listen. The Bubbub in the harbor bobbed up out of the water. Mina, sitting on a dock post with Splodge, nearly fell off.

The Squid Sailor's pipe fell out of its mouth. It caught it with a tentacle. Then it caught its hat with another tentacle, because its hat had fallen off too.

"Four," it whispered. "Four. Forty years I've been waiting for somebody to say that."

It slid down off its barrel. It straightened its blue scarf. It put its sailor's hat back on its head, very carefully, at exactly the right jaunty angle. And then it reached over to the sign hanging off the side of the round glass ferry. DEEP SEA FERRY. DIVES DAILY. (NOT CURRENTLY DIVING.)

It took hold of the bottom part of the sign, the part that said *(NOT CURRENTLY DIVING.)*, and tore it right off.

All down the docks, people cheered.

"All aboard!" bellowed the Squid Sailor, in a voice that was suddenly much bigger and much more sailor-ish than before. "All aboard the Deep Sea Ferry! Next stop, the bottom of the world!"

* * *

The Deep Sea Ferry was a big glass bubble.

Up close and inside, it was even more wonderful than it had looked from the dock. The whole thing was made of thick, clear, curved glass, held together with gleaming brass ribs, so that you could see out in every direction. Up. Down. Sideways. Even under your feet. There were brass benches around the edges with red velvet cushions. There was a little brass wheelhouse at the top, where the Squid Sailor stood at a big brass wheel, with tentacles on all eight of its controls at once. There was a little brass bell that it rang twice, *ding-ding*, for luck.

Rook sat on a bench with Plazmet floating beside him. Kit sat next to him with Mycelith ducking its huge cap under the curved glass ceiling. Zib floated in the very middle of the bubble, turning slowly in a circle, his eye wide.

"Hold onto your hats," said the Squid Sailor. "Or your caps. Or your saucers." It pulled a lever.

The ferry sank.

It didn't plunge. It didn't drop. It sank slowly, gently, the way a feather sinks through honey. The turquoise water rose up the outside of the glass, past their feet, past their knees, past their shoulders, past the top of the bubble. And then they were underneath.

The light went blue.

It was a soft, deep, glowing blue, like being inside a sapphire. The sunlight came down from above in long, wavering beams, like curtains swaying in a breeze. And the water was so clear that Rook could see for miles.

They sank deeper.

Schools of silver fish swirled past the glass, thousands of them, all turning at exactly the same time, flashing like a shower of coins. A big orange fish with fins like silk scarves drifted by and looked at Rook with one big curious eye. Little round puffer-shaped Alienmon bobbed past, inflating and deflating as they went, like breathing balloons. A long, thin, glowing eel twisted through the water in loops, leaving a trail of sparkles behind it.

Deeper.

The blue got darker. The sunbeams faded. And then the water started to glow from inside. Little lights appeared everywhere. Tiny creatures, too small to see, lighting up as the ferry passed through them, so that the whole ocean around them sparkled like a night sky full of stars.

And then the jellyfish came.

They were enormous. Bigger than the ferry, some of them. Great domes of soft, glowing light, pink and violet and pale gold, drifting slowly through the dark water with their long, trailing tentacles rippling behind them like streamers. They pulsed as they swam, opening and closing, opening and closing, like slow heartbeats. They lit up the water all around them. They looked like floating lamps. Like lanterns on the Lantern Marsh. Like huge, gentle, glowing ghosts.

Rook pressed his hands against the glass.

"They look like Tidaloid," Kit whispered beside him.

They did. They looked exactly like Tidaloid. Rook felt a sharp little pain in his chest, and he wondered where Sola was right now, and whether she was looking out of her big window at the stars, and whether she was scared.

Deeper.

And then something moved beneath them.

Rook felt it before he saw it. A shifting in the water. A slow, deep, gentle swell that rocked the ferry, just slightly, like a cradle. He looked down through the glass floor.

Something was swimming under them.

Something enormous.

It was so big that Rook couldn't see the whole of it at once. It was just a great dark shape, sliding slowly through the deep water beneath the ferry. A long, smooth, gray back, wider than the Port Ember harbor. A fin, huge as a sail, moving lazily up and down. And all along its side, rows and rows of soft glowing spots, pale blue, pulsing slowly, like the windows of a sleeping city.

It was so big. And it was so gentle. It didn't hurry. It didn't notice them at all, Rook thought, the way you wouldn't notice a ladybug on your shoulder. It just swam, slow and peaceful, through the dark, humming to itself. Rook could hear it. A deep, deep, low humming, so low that he felt it in his bones more than heard it.

Zib came drifting down from the middle of the bubble. He pressed himself against the glass floor, his huge eye looking down at the great shape gliding beneath them.

"Bip," he said. Very, very softly. "Bip... bip... bip..."

He said it so quietly. As if he were trying not to wake it up.

Nobody else said anything at all. They just watched, in total silence, as the great gentle giant swam on beneath them, and

away, and down into the deep dark, its blue lights fading, until it was gone.

"What... was that?" Rook whispered finally.

In the wheelhouse, the Squid Sailor had taken off its sailor's hat and was holding it over its heart with one tentacle.

"That," it said quietly, "was the Old One. Nobody knows what kind. Nobody knows how old. I've seen her three times in forty years." It put its hat back on. "Count yourselves lucky, mateys."

* * *

And then, deep down at the very bottom of the sea, they came to the gate.

Rook saw it glowing in the darkness long before they reached it. A ring of blue light, far below them, standing on its edge on the sandy seabed. As they sank closer, he could see that it was made of the same pale stone as all the others. The bridge in Dustmere. The Forge Gate. The harbor gate. It was covered in barnacles and coral and waving sea-grass. Little fish swam in and out of its carvings. And every single one of its carvings was glowing.

"The Sunken Gate," said the Squid Sailor. "Older than all the rest, they say. Only opens for the Ferry. Only opens for four Shards."

Rook held them up against the glass. They hummed. The gate hummed back.

And in the middle of the stone ring, the water began to swirl.

The ferry sailed straight into it.

There was the *whoosh*, and the tingle, and the flash of blue, all at once, much stronger than any gate before. Rook's ears popped. His stomach flipped three times. The water outside the glass turned white, then gold, then blue again.

And then the ferry was rising. Up, and up, and up, faster now, through water that was getting lighter and brighter and warmer, until golden sunlight came pouring down through the surface above them in great shimmering beams.

The ferry burst up out of the sea in a great splash of white foam and bobbed there, rocking gently, in the sunshine.

They were in a new world.

* * *

Glyphos.

That was the name of it. Rook knew it before the Squid Sailor said it, because it was carved on a great stone tablet half-sunk in the water right in front of them, in letters as tall as he was. GLYPHOS. And under it, a swirl of those strange swirling marks.

It was a world of ruins.

Everywhere Rook looked, there were temples. Huge stone temples, gray and gold and ancient, rising up out of a calm, green, glassy sea. Some of them were standing tall, with great columns and steps and roofs carved like waves. Some of them were half-sunk, leaning sideways, with the sea lapping at their windows. Some of them had fallen down completely, so that only the tops of their pillars poked up out of the water, like the fingers of giants. Great stone pillars leaned against each other in pairs, like tired old friends.

And everything was carved. Every wall. Every pillar. Every step. Carved all over with those swirling marks, so old and so worn that the edges had gone soft. And in among the swirls, inlaid in the stone, there were lines of gold. Real gold, glinting in the sunshine. Glowing.

On a wide, flat island of sand in the middle of it all, someone had set up camp. Rook could see canvas tents, white and tan, with

little flags fluttering on top. Lanterns hanging from poles. Tables covered in maps and notebooks and tools. And people. Dozens of people, in wide hats and dusty clothes, kneeling on the old stone steps of the temples. They were brushing the stones very carefully with tiny brushes, like paintbrushes. Measuring things with string. Writing in notebooks. Holding magnifying glasses up to the carvings.

"Archaeologists," said Kit. "People who dig up old stuff and figure out what it means."

The Squid Sailor steered the ferry up to a little wooden jetty at the edge of the camp, and they climbed out onto the warm sand.

And a voice said, "Well, well, well. Look who's wearing his Linker the right way up."

Rook spun around.

Sitting on a flat stone at the edge of the camp, eating an apple, was an old woman. She had skin as brown and wrinkled as a walnut, and a wide straw hat with a feather in it, and a vest absolutely covered in patches. Patches with mountains on them, and waves, and a gear, and a mushroom.

And one that just showed a big question mark.

"TAMSIN!"

Rook ran across the sand. Tamsin stood up, laughing her big warm laugh that made the feather on her hat bounce, and caught him in a hug that smelled like apples and dust and sea salt.

"Look at you!" she said, holding him at arm's length. "Look at you, look at you! I heard you on the radio! Fourteen worlds, they said! The fire-comet kid!" She looked past him. At Plazmet, blazing. At Kit, and Mycelith, towering behind them. Her eyes went wide. "And you found friends. I told you you'd need all the friends you could get."

Then her eyes landed on Zib.

Zib had floated up off Rook's cap and was hovering over Tamsin's shoulder. He was staring at her vest. At one patch in particular. The question mark. Just like he had in the Cactus Gardens, back on Dustara, what felt like a hundred years ago.

"Bip," he said.

Tamsin smiled. It was a different smile from her laughing one. Softer.

"Still like that one, eh?" She touched the patch with one finger. "The world I never found. The one they all came from. I've been looking for it for forty years." She looked up at the great gray and gold temples rising out of the sea. "And I think, little one, this is the closest I've ever been."

"What are you doing here?" Rook asked.

"Same as everyone else. Trying to figure out what all this is." Tamsin waved her apple at the temples. "These ruins are older than anything in the Kessler system. Older than the towers. Older than the gates. Older than people. Nobody knows who built them." She tapped a carving on the stone she'd been sitting on. "And these marks. Same as the bridge in Dustmere. Same as every gate. Same language. We've been trying to read it for years. Can't make heads or tails of it." She sighed. "It's like trying to read a book when you don't even know which way is up."

Rook looked at the carvings. The swirls and loops. He'd seen them on every gate and every tower, all across the Kessler system. And every time, they had glowed for Zib.

As if they recognized him.

* * *

The biggest temple stood in the middle of all the others.

It rose up out of the green sea like a mountain made of steps. Great wide stone stairs, climbing up and up and up, each one carved and gilded, to a huge dark doorway at the very top. On either side of the doorway stood two tall columns carved like the trunks of trees, with stone branches spreading out across the top. And the whole front of the temple, every inch of it, was covered in gold. Gold lines, gold swirls, gold patterns, all winding and spiraling together, so that the temple glittered in the sun like a crown.

Tamsin walked them to the bottom of the stairs.

"The Temple of Voices," she said. "That's what the old maps call it. Nobody's ever got further than the front door. It's sealed. Always has been." She shrugged. "We've tried everything."

Zib was floating forward, all by himself.

Rook watched him go. He drifted up the steps, slowly. As if something were pulling him. His lights were flickering every color, faster and faster. He floated past the first step, the second, the tenth, the twentieth, all the way up to the great dark doorway at the top, and stopped right in front of it.

And set into the stone wall beside the door, there was a crystal.

It was small. About the size of Rook's hand. Clear as water, and old, and dusty, like it hadn't been touched in a thousand years. Rook hadn't even noticed it.

But as Zib floated in front of it, it began to glow.

Soft white light, coming from somewhere deep inside it. Then brighter. Then it was blazing, so bright that every archaeologist in the camp stopped working and stood up and stared. The gold lines on the temple wall began to glow too. They lit up one by one, spreading out from the crystal in every direction, racing across the stone, until the whole front of the temple was blazing with golden

light.

And from the crystal, a voice spoke.

It was soft. It was clear. It was chiming, like a bell made of glass, or wind chimes in a summer breeze, or the sound a Linker made when an Alienmon flowed into it. It didn't sound like a person's voice. It didn't sound like an Alienmon's. It sounded like light would sound, if light could talk.

And it said:

"*Little scout. You came back.*"

Zib's lights went wild. Every color he had, flashing all at once, red and blue and green and gold and purple, so fast and so bright that he looked like a firework. He spun around and around in front of the crystal. "BIP! BIP-BIP! BIP-BIP-BIP-BIIIIIIIP!"

At the bottom of the steps, nobody moved. Tamsin had dropped her apple. Kit had both hands over their mouth. Plazmet's plasma ring had stopped spinning.

Rook climbed the steps. All of them. He didn't feel his legs. He didn't feel anything except his heart, hammering in his chest. He stopped at the top, beside Zib, in front of the glowing crystal.

"Who..." His voice came out as a croak. He tried again. "Who are you?"

The crystal pulsed, soft and warm.

"*I am Liss,*" said the voice. "*An echo. A memory of those who came before. I have been waiting here a very long time.*" The light shimmered, as if it were looking at each of them in turn. Rook. Kit. Plazmet. Mycelith. Tamsin, standing frozen at the bottom of the steps. And Zib, spinning in delight. "*And you have brought him home.*"

"Home?" Rook whispered. "Is this... is this where Zib comes from?"

"*No, child,*" said Liss gently. "*Not this place. This place is only a memory of his home. A story, carved in stone, so that it would never be forgotten.*" The light pulsed. "*Listen, children. The temple has a story to tell you. It is a long story, and a sad one, and an important one. It is the story of where the Alienmon came from. And why.*"

Behind them, the great dark doorway of the Temple of Voices rumbled. Dust trickled down from the stone above it. But it didn't open.

"*But first,*" said Liss, "*you must open its doors.*"

Chapter 24

Temple of Voices

The great dark doorway of the Temple of Voices didn't swing open. It didn't slide. It didn't creak.

It sank.

The huge slab of stone that had blocked it for a thousand years slowly lowered itself down into the floor with a deep, grinding rumble, like a giant clearing its throat. Dust poured off it in clouds. Little stones skittered and bounced down the steps. And when it had sunk all the way down, so that its top was level with the ground, there was a dark, open doorway, and a long stone hallway beyond it, going down into shadow.

"*Enter,*" said Liss's chiming voice, from the crystal in the wall. "*And be brave. The temple will test you.*"

At the bottom of the steps, Tamsin let out a whoop so loud that every archaeologist in the camp jumped. "FORTY YEARS!" she yelled. "FORTY YEARS I've been waiting to see the inside of this thing!" She came charging up the steps two at a time, faster than Rook would have believed an old woman could move, her feather bouncing, her vest flapping, her walking stick clacking on the stone.

She stopped beside them at the top, puffing. She looked into the dark doorway. She looked at Rook.

"Well?" she said. "What are we waiting for?"

* * *

The Temple of Voices was a maze.

Not a maze of mushroom stalks, like the one on Sporeholm. A maze of stone. Long, tall, echoing hallways, with walls that went up so high that Rook couldn't see the ceiling. Narrow corridors that twisted and turned. Staircases that went up, and then down, and then up again. Secret doors that slid open in walls that looked completely solid, and then slid shut again behind them.

And it echoed.

Every footstep. Every breath. Every word. It bounced off the stone walls and came back, again and again and again, softer and softer, until it faded away. When Kit sneezed, the sneeze came back nine times. When Plazmet's flame crackled, the crackle came back from every direction at once, like a crowd of tiny fires all whispering.

"It's called the Temple of Voices," Tamsin whispered. Her voice whispered back. *Voices... voices... voices.* "Now I know why."

Lumislug led the way, glowing its gentle lime green. Plazmet floated beside it, lighting up the walls. And everywhere the light fell, there were carvings. Swirls and loops, and gold lines that caught the light and glowed. Every so often, they passed another small crystal set into the wall, just like the one by the front door. And every time Zib floated past one, it lit up, soft and white, and Liss's voice spoke from it.

"*Left,*" it would say. Or "*Down the stairs.*" Or "*Not that way, little ones. That way is only a very long fall.*"

Rook was very glad of Liss.

They went deeper and deeper into the temple. Down and down and down. The air got cooler. The echoes got softer. And then the hallway opened up, all at once, into a vast round room.

Rook stopped. Everyone stopped.

It was the biggest room he had ever been in. Bigger than the arena at the top of the Voltspire. Bigger than Hank's tower. Its walls were made of pale, smooth stone, curving up and up into a great dome high above. And set into the walls, all the way around, were mirrors. Dozens and dozens of round mirrors, made of polished silver, each one in a carved stone frame, each one tilted at a slightly different angle.

Far, far above, in the very top of the dome, was a single small hole. And through it came one thin, perfect beam of sunlight. It shone straight down, through the dusty air, like a golden string, and landed on the floor in a bright little circle in the very middle of the room.

On the far side of the room was a door. A huge, round, stone door, taller than three houses. In the very center of it was set a large crystal, clear and dark.

And standing in front of the door, side by side, were three standing stones.

* * *

At first, Rook thought they were statues.

They were small. No taller than Rook's chest. Each one was a single slab of carved brown stone, standing upright on the floor, its edges worn smooth by a thousand years. They had no arms. No legs. No mouths. No noses. No ears. But around each one, three small pebbles hung perfectly still in the air, each on its own thin ring of pink light, like tiny moons that had forgotten how to move.

And down the middle of each smooth stone face ran one long, jagged crack. All three cracks were dark.

Rook took one step into the room.

The three cracks lit up.

They glowed. A deep, burning violet, like the sky just after sunset. The pebbles around them began to move, sliding along their pink rings, faster and faster, circling and circling. And with a deep, grinding, rumbling sound, like mountains turning over in their sleep, the three standing stones turned on the spot, all together, and faced him.

Rook's Linker beeped. MONOLET. GRAVITY/PSI-TYPE. 140 KILOGRAMS EACH. ANCIENT GUARDIAN.

"Oh," said Kit, in a very small voice.

The Monolets spoke. All three together. Their voices weren't voices. They weren't even sounds. They were rumbles, deep and slow, that didn't come through the air at all. They landed right inside Rook's head, so deep that he felt them behind his eyes. And they echoed in there, again and again and again.

"*ONLY... THE WORTHY... MAY PASS.*"

Pass... pass... pass...

The three Monolets shuffled forward into a perfectly straight row, edge to edge, neat as soldiers. The floor shook. *THOOM.* Their pebbles whirled faster and faster, humming on their rings of pink light.

Rook swallowed. He looked at the Monolets. He looked at the huge round door behind them, with the dark crystal in its middle. He looked at the mirrors on the walls, and the thin beam of sunlight shining down on the floor.

Think first.

The Monolets were guarding the door. But the door was closed. It didn't matter if he beat them. Even if all three of them fell down, the door would still be closed. So beating them wasn't the point. The point was the door.

And the door had a crystal in it. And the crystal was dark.

And there was a beam of light shining down from the roof. And mirrors all around the walls.

Rook turned to Kit. Kit was already staring at the mirrors. Their goggles were pulled down. Their lips were moving silently, as if they were counting. Rook knew that look. It was the same look Kit had in the Mushroom Maze when they found the cable. The same look Kit had under the console on the Forge Gate.

"Kit," said Rook. "Can you figure out the door?"

"It's a light puzzle," Kit said, without looking at him. Their voice was fast and excited. "See? The beam comes down from the hole in the roof. It hits the floor. But if you put a mirror in the right place, you could bounce it. And then bounce it again. And again. All the way around the room, from mirror to mirror to mirror." Kit pointed at the round door. "Until it hits that crystal. That's the lock. The light is the key."

"Can you do it?"

Kit looked at all the mirrors. Dozens and dozens of them, all at different angles. Their face went a bit pale.

"I... I think so," Kit said. "But it'll take time. And I'll have to get to every mirror. And they're..." Kit's eyes went to the three standing stones. "They're kind of in the way."

"Then I'll handle the Monolets," said Rook. He grinned at Kit. Kit grinned back, a shaky, nervous, excited grin. "You figure out the doors."

"And I," said Tamsin, rolling up her sleeves, "will help the genius."

* * *

The Monolets came shuffling forward in their neat straight row. *THOOM. THOOM. THOOM.*

Every shuffle shook the floor. Little chips of stone jumped and rattled on the tiles. Up in the dome, the mirrors trembled in their frames, and the thin golden beam of sunlight shivered like a plucked string.

Rook sent out everybody. Plazmet blazed out in front, his comet-tail streaming. Cactling stomped out beside him, cracking its knuckles. Lumislug slid forward, glowing. Glitchbug crackled on Rook's shoulder.

"Okay, team," Rook said. "Here's the thing. We are NOT trying to beat them."

Plazmet's eye swiveled toward him in surprise.

"They're guardians," Rook said. "They've been standing here for a thousand years, guarding this door. They're not bad guys. They're just doing their job." He took a deep breath. "So we're not going to hurt them. We're just going to keep them busy. Keep them looking at us. Keep them away from Kit. That's it."

Cactling gave him a long, flat look, as if to say, *You want me to do WHAT?*

The first Monolet's three pebbles stopped circling. They hung in the air for one heartbeat. Then they flew.

"Dodge!"

Plazmet and Cactling dodged. The pebbles hit the floor where they had been standing with a *KRAKOOOM* that made the whole room shake. They were only little stones. But they hit like falling boulders. The tiles split in a star of cracks. Dust rained down from the dome. A chunk of stone the size of Rook's head bounced past his boots, and he felt the wind of it. Then the pebbles leapt up off the floor and zipped back onto their pink rings, circling as if nothing had happened.

Those pebbles had missed Cactling by about the width of a needle.

The second Monolet's crack flared violet, and all at once the air around Rook went heavy, so heavy his knees buckled and his satchel dragged at his shoulder like a sack of bricks. The third one sent all three of its pebbles skimming across the floor in a line, low and fast and heavy as a falling wall.

"Jump!"

Cactling jumped. The pebbles whooshed underneath it so close they shaved the tips off two of its needles. Lumislug... did not jump, because it was a slug, but it was very low to the ground, and the pebbles skimmed right over the top of it with a sound like a passing train. Lumislug blinked, and kept glowing.

Rook let out a breath he hadn't known he was holding. His hands were already shaking.

And behind them, Kit ran to the first mirror.

* * *

It was the hardest thing Rook had ever done.

Not because the Monolets were strong, though they were. Not because they were big, though they were huge. It was hard because every bit of him wanted to fight back. Every time a stone came screaming in, he wanted to shout *Spark Burst! Comet Dash! Needle Spray!* He wanted to hit back. Hard.

But he didn't.

"Dodge. Dodge. Plazmet, swing around the left one, make it turn. Good! Cactling, run past the middle one. Make it chase you. Lumislug, glow brighter, make them look at you."

Then the Monolets stopped throwing wildly. All three of their violet cracks flared together, slow and cold, and Rook felt his stomach drop. They weren't just smashing anymore. They were

learning.

The middle one shuffled left. The left one shuffled right. And Cactling, running flat out between them, looked up and saw stone closing in on both sides.

"Cactling, OUT of there!"

Too late. The left Monolet's crack blazed, and the air beside Cactling went heavy and hard, like a giant invisible hand coming down flat to swat a fly. It caught Cactling side-on.

WHUMP.

Cactling flew. It skidded across the floor, needles screeching on the stone, and slammed into the base of a pillar with a *CRACK* that echoed nine times around the dome. It lay there in the dust. The creamy flower in the middle of its body was bent right over.

"Cactling!"

Cactling's arm twitched. It rolled over, slowly, and got one stubby arm under itself, and pushed. It wobbled up onto its feet. It turned around and glared at the Monolet with one squinted, furious eye, and Rook knew exactly what that glare meant. It meant, *Let me hit it. Just once. Please.*

"No," Rook said. His voice cracked. "No needles. I know. I know. Just keep moving."

The middle Monolet turned toward Plazmet.

Plazmet was fast. He looped up and over its top, and three whirling pebbles punched through the air where he had just been. He dropped low. Rook started to grin...

And the third Monolet, the one nobody was watching, shuffled out of the dust. Its crack blazed. And the air on both sides of Plazmet slammed together.

BOOOOM.

Plazmet was right between them.

The sound was like two mountains meeting. The dust went up in a ring. It was a crushing pull, from every side at once, squeezing inward, harder and harder. And when it finally let go, something tiny and orange dropped out of the empty air and fell, and fell, and hit the floor, and rolled.

Plazmet's fire had gone down to almost nothing. His plasma ring was flickering, on, off, on. He lay on the cracked tiles, a little gray wisp of smoke curling up off him, and he didn't move.

"PLAZMET!"

Rook was running before he knew it. He skidded to his knees beside him. Plazmet's flame was making a tiny, ragged sound. *Fff. Fff.* Like a candle in a draft.

Above them, the Monolet's pebbles drew back on their rings again.

Something hot and furious roared up in Rook's chest, so fast and so big that it frightened him. *They hurt him.* All he had to do was say two words. *Comet Dash.* Every bit of Rook wanted to scream it.

Plazmet looked up at him.

He was so small. He was the size of a match flame. But his one eye found Rook's face and held it, steady as anything. It was asking. *Is that really what we do?*

Rook closed his mouth on the words.

Think first.

They were guardians. They weren't being cruel. They were doing the one job they'd been given, a thousand years ago, and they were doing it with everything they had. If he hit them now, he would be just another kid with strong fists and no patience. And Kit wasn't done yet.

"Not yet," Rook whispered to Plazmet. "We don't hit them. We just don't let them win either. Okay? Can you get up?"

Plazmet's flame shivered. Then, with a sound like a match striking, *fsssht*, it flared. He floated up off the floor, wobbling, half his size, and turned to face the Monolet.

The pebbles came down. Rook grabbed Plazmet out of the air and threw himself sideways. *KRAKOOOM.* The tile where they had been kneeling exploded into gravel.

"Lumislug! Brighter! As bright as you can! Right in their faces! Glitchbug, zip around them. Don't zap them. Just buzz."

Lumislug scrunched up its whole squishy body, and glowed. It glowed so bright the room went green. All three Monolets flinched, their violet cracks flickering in the glare, and their pebbles flew wide.

And Glitchbug buzzed. It zoomed in circles around the third Monolet's smooth stone face, crackling, so close to its glowing crack that the Monolet kept turning around and around, trying to follow it. It spun in a slow circle on the spot. Then another. Then it got so dizzy that it tipped over, very slowly, like a falling tree, and landed flat on its back.

THOOOM. The whole room jumped.

Rook laughed out loud. It came out shaky. He couldn't help it.

And all the while, on the other side of the room, Kit was turning mirrors.

Click.

Kit grabbed the edge of a big silver mirror in its stone frame and turned it, just a little. The beam of sunlight hit it, and bounced off, and shot across the room in a straight golden line, and hit the wall.

"No," Kit muttered. "Left. Little more left."

Click.

The beam bounced off and hit another mirror. That mirror bounced it up, to another mirror high on the wall.

"Yes! Tamsin! That one up there! Can you reach it?"

Tamsin used her walking stick. She hooked it around the edge of the high mirror and pulled. Click. The beam bounced off it and zigzagged across the room again.

"YES!" Kit was running now, from mirror to mirror. Click. Click. The golden line of light zigzagged across the room. From mirror to mirror to mirror. Up and down and side to side. Like a laser. Like a spider's web made of sunshine.

Click. Click. Click.

A Monolet's pebble came hurtling straight at Kit. Mycelith was there in an instant, its wide, ragged red cap spreading out like a shield over Kit's head. *WHAMMM.* The pebble bounced off the cap. The floor under Mycelith's root-legs cracked in a ring. Mycelith didn't even flinch.

"Thanks," Kit gasped, and kept turning.

Click.

"One more!" Kit yelled. "Rook! I need one more! But it's behind the middle one!"

Rook looked. The last mirror was right behind the biggest Monolet, the one in the middle, set into the wall just above the door. The Monolet was standing directly in front of it, violet crack turned toward Rook.

And Rook's whole team was hurt. Cactling was limping. Lumislug's glow had gone dim and patchy from shining so hard. And Plazmet, floating at his shoulder, was still only half his size.

"Plazmet," Rook said. His voice shook. He let it. "I need you to lead it away. Right up close to its face, close enough that it only

looks at you. No fire. No hitting. Just make it follow you." He swallowed. "It's going to fight. You can't hit back. Can you do that?"

Plazmet's flame went still for a moment. Then he bobbed, once, firmly.

He floated forward, right in front of the middle Monolet's face. Close. Very close. Its violet crack flared, fixed on him. And then Plazmet backed away. Slowly. Teasingly. Like a cat with a piece of string. And the Monolet shuffled after him. One step. Two steps. Three. Away from the door.

Then it threw.

WHOOOSH. Plazmet dipped. The pebbles missed him by a whisker, and the wind of it blew his little flame sideways and nearly out. He steadied, and backed away again. Four steps. Five.

"Hold on," Rook whispered. He didn't even know he was saying it. "Hold on, hold on, hold on..."

Kit ran. They ran behind the Monolet and scrambled right up onto its flat stone top, as if it were a step stool, ducking under its whirling pebbles, which made the Monolet go "*HRRMMMM?*" in confusion, deep inside everybody's heads. It stopped. It started to turn around. If it turned, Kit would go flying, right into the path of those pebbles.

"PLAZMET! NOW! As bright as you've EVER been!"

Plazmet blazed. Not at the Monolet. Just blazed, all the fire he had left, flaring up big and white and gold right in front of that glowing crack, like a sunrise in a dark room. The Monolet froze, dazzled, its pebbles wobbling on their rings.

Kit reached up from its top, grabbed the edge of the last mirror, and turned it.

CLICK.

The beam of sunlight bounced off the last mirror. It shot down in a perfect straight golden line.

And it hit the crystal in the center of the great round door.

* * *

The crystal blazed.

It lit up from inside, bright gold, like the sun itself was trapped inside it. The light poured out of it in every direction, all across the door, along the carved lines, until the whole enormous stone door was glowing with golden light, every swirl and loop shining.

And the Monolets stopped.

All three of them, all at once. They froze, mid-shuffle. The one chasing Plazmet stopped with its three pebbles hanging frozen in the air. The one with Kit on top went perfectly still. The one lying dizzy on its back stopped rocking.

In the sudden quiet, a tiny spark drifted down out of the air in front of Rook. Plazmet had spent every bit of fire he had. Rook held out both hands and caught him. He was barely a flicker, warm and light as a feather, but his eye opened a crack and looked up at Rook. And Plazmet sneezed. *Pfft.* One tiny spark.

Rook laughed. It came out wobbly. He held Plazmet against his chest. Cactling limped over and leaned its whole prickly side against his leg, and Rook didn't even mind the needles.

Then, slowly, with a deep grinding sound, the one on its back floated itself upright, and the three Monolets shuffled into a neat straight row and turned to face Rook and Kit. Their glowing cracks weren't cold anymore. They were warm. Soft gold, like the light from the door.

And all three of them tipped forward, together, in a slow, deep bow. Their pebbles dipped low on their rings.

The one with Kit on top tilted itself very, very carefully, until Kit could slide down off it onto the floor.

"BRAINS," the Monolets rumbled, deep inside Rook's head. They looked at Kit. "AND HEART." They looked at Rook. "TOGETHER."

Together... together... together...

"YOU DID NOT STRIKE US," the middle one said, its deep voice rumbling through the inside of Rook's skull. "YOU COULD HAVE. YOU DID NOT. MANY HAVE COME TO THIS DOOR, LONG AGO, WITH STRONG FISTS AND NO PATIENCE. THEY DID NOT PASS." Its glowing crack turned toward Rook, and then at the little flicker in his hands. "YOU ARE WORTHY."

Rook felt something warm and bright spread through his whole chest, all the way out to the tips of his fingers. And in his cupped hands, Plazmet's flame grew, just a little, as if he felt it too.

Kit ran over and grabbed his arm, laughing and shaking. Tamsin threw her hat in the air.

And the great round door began to move.

It rumbled. It shook. Dust poured down. It began to roll to the side, slowly, slowly, like a giant stone wheel.

And then it stopped.

It had opened just a crack. A thin dark crack, barely wide enough to slip a hand through. And no matter how much it rumbled and shook, it wouldn't open any further.

The golden light on the door flickered.

* * *

"What?" said Rook. "Why did it stop?"

Kit was already at the door, pressing their ear against the stone. Their eyes were closed. They were listening.

"There's something missing," Kit said slowly. "The light worked. The lock's open. But it's like... it's like the door is waiting for something else." They frowned. "There are little holes. All along the edges of the door. Hundreds of them. Like a flute. Or an organ. It's supposed to make a sound." Kit pulled back and looked up at the huge door. "It's supposed to sing. That's how it opens all the way. But nothing's singing. The temple's broken."

Tamsin leaned on her walking stick and looked around the vast, silent room. "The Temple of Voices," she said quietly. "And it's lost its voice."

Zib floated over to the crack in the door. He looked into it, his huge eye glowing. He tried humming. The Spore Choir song. *Hmm-mm-mmm.* It echoed around the room, soft and sweet. But the door didn't move.

"*It needs a pure note,*" said Liss's voice, chiming out of a crystal high in the wall. "*One single, perfect, ringing note. Long ago, the temple keepers had one. But it has been a very long time since anyone rang it.*"

And from behind a pillar at the edge of the room, something peeked out.

It was small. About as tall as Rook's knee. It was shaped like a little bell, round at the top and flared at the bottom, made of polished silver that gleamed in the dim light. Beneath its rim was a tiny smiling face, shy and round-eyed. Long teal ribbons flowed off it like streamers in a breeze. And hanging below it, like a skirt, was a ring of thin glass chime tubes that clinked very softly whenever it moved. It was floating, just slightly off the ground, peeking around the edge of the stone pillar.

It had been hiding there, Rook realized. It had been hiding there the whole time. Watching the battle. Watching Kit turn the

mirrors. Too scared to come out.

Rook's Linker beeped, very softly. CHIMELET. SONIC/CRYSTAL-TYPE. ITS NOTE CAN WAKE ANCIENT THINGS.

Rook didn't move. Kit didn't move. Nobody wanted to scare it.

The little bell looked at them. It looked at the great door, open just a crack. It looked at the three Monolets, still bowing. And then it looked at Zib.

Zib looked back at it. His lights went soft and gold. And very, very quietly, he went: "...Bip."

The Chimelet came out from behind the pillar.

It floated slowly across the great round room, past Rook, past Kit, past the Monolets, until it was hanging in the air in the very middle of the room, right in the center of the golden beam of sunlight. The light glinted off its silver sides and sparkled through its glass tubes, so bright that it looked like a little sun.

It took a breath. Rook didn't know bells could take breaths. This one did.

And then it swung itself gently from side to side, once, its teal ribbons fluttering and its glass tubes shivering, and rang.

Dinnnnnnnnng.

It was the purest sound Rook had ever heard. Pure and clear and perfect, like a single drop of water falling into a still pond. It rang out through the vast round room. It rang up into the dome. It rang down the long dark hallways, and through the maze, and out to the very edges of the temple.

And the whole temple sang back.

Every wall hummed. Every crystal chimed. The hundreds of little holes along the edges of the great door all began to sing at once, like a giant pipe organ, like a choir, like the Spore Choir on Sporeholm and the four Shards humming together and the howl

of the Chirpods all at once. The sound swelled and swelled until Rook could feel it in his bones, in his teeth, in his heart. The golden light blazed brighter and brighter. The Monolets' violet cracks shone, and their pebbles whirled on their pink rings. Mycelith's cap trembled. Plazmet's plasma ring spun so fast it whistled. Zib was flashing every color he had, spinning in circles beside the Chimelet, going "BIP! BIP! BIIIIIP!" along with the song.

And the great round door rolled open.

All the way. Slowly. Grandly. With a deep, rumbling, joyful sound, like the whole temple letting out a breath it had been holding for a thousand years.

The song faded. The echoes faded. The Chimelet floated gently back down to the floor, glowing with pride.

And beyond the door, there was a hall.

It was dark. It was so big that Rook couldn't see the end of it, or the ceiling, or the walls. It just stretched away into shadow, vast and silent and waiting. But something in there was glowing. Faintly. Softly. All along the walls, as far as he could see.

Pictures.

"*Come,*" said Liss gently. "*Come and see where you came from, little scout.*"

Zib floated forward, into the doorway. He stopped there. His lights flickered. Then he looked back over his shoulder at Rook, with his huge round eye, and Rook could have sworn he looked scared.

Rook walked forward and stood beside him. He held out his hand. Zib floated down into it.

"Together," Rook said.

And they walked into the dark.

Chapter 25

Murals of Ystra

The hall beyond the door was so big that it didn't feel like being inside at all.

It felt like standing outside at night, under a sky with no stars. Rook couldn't see the ceiling. He couldn't see the far end. He could only just see the walls on either side, and only because they were glowing. Faintly. Softly. The way the drift grass in the Cactus Gardens glowed at the tips. The way the mushrooms of Sporeholm glowed from deep inside.

The walls were covered in paintings.

They went up and up, higher than Rook could see, and on and on, farther than he could see. Huge paintings, each one as big as the side of a house, painted right onto the stone. They were old. Very old. The colors had faded. Some of the paint had flaked away, and in places there were long cracks running through the pictures, like wrinkles on an old face. But they were still glowing. Every line and every color, shimmering softly in the dark, like someone had mixed starlight into the paint.

Nobody spoke. Nobody could.

Tamsin had taken off her hat. She was holding it against her chest with both hands, the way people do in very old churches. Her eyes were wet. Kit had pushed their goggles all the way up on their head and was turning around and around in a slow circle, mouth open. Plazmet had turned his flame down to the softest glow he could, as if he were afraid of hurting the paintings with

too much light. Mycelith had bowed its wide, ragged red cap low.

Zib was sitting in Rook's hands. Very still. His lights were off. All of them. Rook had never seen that before. Not ever. Not even when Zib was asleep.

And then, from the dark all around them, Liss spoke.

Its voice didn't come from a crystal this time. It came from everywhere at once. From the walls. From the floor. From the paintings themselves. Soft and chiming and very, very sad.

"*This is our story,*" said Liss. "*The story of Ystra.*"

* * *

The first painting began to glow brighter.

It lit up from inside, slowly, the way the sun comes up in the morning. The colors came back to it. Rook could see every line.

It was a world.

A beautiful world, round and shining, hanging in the dark of space. It was covered in forests. But not forests of wood and leaves. Forests of crystal. Trees made of glass, tall and thin as church spires, with branches hung with glittering crystal leaves that caught the light and threw it back in rainbows. The ground under the trees was soft and blue and glowing, like moss. Rivers of clear water ran between them. Mountains of white stone rose up in the distance. And everywhere, among the crystal trees, there were Alienmon. Thousands of them. Every shape and color. Floating and flying and running and swimming, playing in the rivers, sleeping in the branches.

And above it all hung a sun. A big, round, red sun. Far too big and far too red. It looked tired. The way a campfire looks tired near the end of the night, when the flames have gone low and orange and the coals just pulse.

Rook's breath caught in his throat. His knees went wobbly.

"That's my dream," he whispered.

Kit turned to look at him.

"That's my DREAM!" Rook said, louder. His voice echoed through the hall. *Dream... dream... dream.* "From my birthday! The morning I met Plazmo! I dreamed I was standing in a forest made of glass, and the trees were singing, and there was a big red sun, and someone said..." He stopped. His throat had gone tight. "Someone whispered in my ear. They said, 'Find the one who listens.'"

The hall was very quiet.

"*Ystra called out,*" said Liss softly. "*At the very end, she called out across the stars, as loud as she could. She called for someone, anyone, who might hear. Someone who would listen.*" The light pulsed, warm and gentle. "*It seems, child, that someone did.*"

Rook stared up at the crystal forest, at the tired red sun, and couldn't say anything at all.

* * *

The second painting lit up.

It was the same world. The same crystal forests, the same red sun. But now there was something else in the sky.

A shadow.

It was spreading across the stars. It had no shape. No edges. No face. It was just dark. A darkness darker than the night sky behind it, darker than anything, so dark that it seemed to pull the light out of the painting around it. It spread the way ink spreads through water, slowly, curling, reaching. And where it went, the stars went out. One by one. Little points of light, swallowed up, gone.

It was hungry. Rook didn't know how a painting could look hungry. But this one did.

It was already touching the edge of the red sun.

Kit had grabbed Rook's arm. Tamsin had gone very pale. In Rook's hands, Zib was trembling. A tiny, fast, frightened trembling, like a bird's heartbeat.

"*It came from very far away,*" said Liss. "*From the darkest place between the stars. We never knew its name. We never knew what it wanted. Only that it was hungry, and that it never stopped. It ate the light. It ate the stars. And it was coming for Ystra.*"

Rook remembered the dream. The shadow on the horizon, eating the edge of the sky. Stars going out. He'd thought it was just a dream.

He held Zib a little tighter.

* * *

The third painting lit up.

And there she was.

The face from Zib's memory on Sporeholm. The face carved into the harbor gate at Port Ember. But here, she wasn't just a face. Here, she was all of herself.

She was a tree. The biggest tree Rook had ever seen or ever imagined, rising up out of the middle of the crystal forest, so tall that her branches brushed the stars. Her trunk was silver bark, smooth and shining. Her roots went down and down and down, deep into the heart of the world. Her branches spread out wide in every direction, covered in crystal leaves, every color, glittering like rainbows. And in the middle of her trunk was her face. Gentle and kind and wise and so, so old.

She was a mother. Rook could see that. Every Alienmon in the forest was gathered around her roots, looking up at her. The way kids look up at their mom.

And she was holding out her branches.

On every branch, there were seedpods. Huge, round, glowing seedpods, gold and violet and green. Hundreds of them. Thousands of them. And one by one, she was letting them go. Lifting her branches and sending them up, up, up, away from the world, away from the red sun, away from the shadow. Out into the stars. Like dandelion fluff blown from a stem. Like sparks rising from a fire.

It was the picture from Zib's memory on Ferrox. The little glowing seeds, flying away from the red planet. Rook understood it now.

And she was smiling. That sad, brave, goodbye smile. The kind of smile someone gives you when they are saying goodbye, and they don't want you to be scared.

Her eyes were closed. Because she was staying behind.

"*She sent her children away,*" said Liss, very softly, "*to save them.*"

The hall was silent.

"*She could not run. She was too old, and too big, and her roots went too deep. So she gave everything she had left to the seeds. All her strength. All her light. And she sent them out across the dark, as far as they could go, to find somewhere new. Somewhere safe. Somewhere the shadow could not follow.*" The light pulsed. "*We called her the Seedmother. Every Alienmon you know came from her seeds.*"

Rook looked at Plazmet, blazing softly beside him. At Mycelith, tall and calm. At Cactling and Lumislug and Glitchbug, peeking out of his Linker.

Every single one.

Kit's voice was very quiet.

"So the Alienmon," Kit said. "They're not just... from somewhere else." Kit swallowed. "They're refugees. They ran away from home. Because something was eating it."

Nobody answered. Nobody needed to.

Tamsin was crying. Openly, the tears running down the wrinkles of her face. She was touching the question-mark patch on her vest.

"Ystra," she whispered. "Forty years. Forty years I've been looking for you. And you've got a name."

* * *

In Rook's hands, Zib's lights came back on.

But they weren't flashing. They weren't twinkling. They were pulsing. Slow and soft and sad. A deep, dim blue. On. Off. On. Off. Like a heartbeat. Like a heart that hurt.

Rook looked down at him. And he finally understood. All of it. Why Zib had gone so quiet when they looked at Ferrox's Shard. Why he had missed the tree-mother on Sporeholm. Why he wanted so badly to follow Sola onto that shuttle, to stop somebody else from losing someone they loved.

Zib had been here. Zib had been one of those seeds. Zib had watched his home go dark.

Rook lifted his hands, very gently, and held Zib up against his chest, right over Nana Wren's badge, right over his heart.

"It's okay, buddy," he whispered. "It's okay. You've got a home now."

Zib's lights flickered.

"You've got Dustmere," Rook said. "And my mom, who makes too many pancakes. And DX-4. And Dr. Vashti. And Kit, and Plazmet, and Mycelith, and everybody. And me." His voice cracked. "You've got us. And we're not going anywhere. I

promise."

Zib pressed himself against Rook's chest. Hard. His whole little saucer body, pressed right against Nana Wren's badge.

And very quietly, he went:

"...Bip."

Kit came and stood on Rook's other side. Then Plazmet floated close, his comet-tail curling around them, warm. Then Mycelith bent down, slowly, and spread its wide, ragged red cap over all of them like a roof. And then Tamsin came, and put one old, wrinkled, warm hand on Rook's shoulder, and the other on Kit's.

They stood like that for a long time, all together, under the painting of the tree-mother with her eyes closed.

* * *

There were more paintings.

They walked along the hall slowly, and Liss told them about each one. A painting of the seedpods flying through the dark, for years and years and years, across distances too big to imagine. A painting of a seedpod landing on a strange new world, and something small and frightened climbing out. A painting of tiny saucers, palm-sized, with one big eye each, flying ahead of the seeds, in front of all the others, searching.

"*Scouts,*" said Liss. "*Sent ahead, to find the way. To find a place where the seeds could land safely. To listen for a world that would welcome them.*"

Rook looked down at Zib, sitting in his hands. *Little scout,* Liss had called him.

And then there was a painting that made Kit stop walking.

It showed a door.

Not a door like the one they had just come through. A great, round, dark door, painted in the middle of nowhere, floating in

empty space between the stars. It was shut. And around it, spaced out evenly, holding it shut, were eight bright points of light. Eight stars. All joined together with lines. A circle with eight points.

The drawing on Kit's arm.

Kit held up their arm next to the painting. They matched exactly.

"The seal," Kit breathed.

Under the painted door, there were words. A short line of those swirling, looping marks, carved into the stone and filled with gold. They were glowing brighter than anything else on the wall.

"What does it say?" Rook asked. "Liss? What do those words say?"

The light in the hall flickered. For a long moment, Liss didn't answer.

"*Those words,*" Liss said at last, slowly, "*are not mine to speak. They were carried here, long ago, inside the very first seed. Written on stone, so that whoever found it would read them first, before anything else.*" The light dimmed. "*The ones who found that seed can tell you what it says. Ask them.*"

"But we don't know who found it!" said Rook.

Liss didn't answer.

* * *

It was Kit who found the last painting.

It was at the very end of the hall. Kit had wandered ahead with Lumislug while Rook was staring at the door. And suddenly Kit's voice came echoing back through the dark, high and strange.

"Rook. ROOK. Come here. Come look at this."

Rook ran.

The last painting was different from all the others. It wasn't old. Not as old, anyway. The paint was brighter, the lines sharper,

as if someone had added it much, much later. It wasn't glowing as much as the others either. It was smaller. Simpler. As if whoever painted it had been in a hurry, or had been very young.

It showed a crater.

A big round bowl in the ground, in a red desert, under a dark night sky full of stars. Rook knew that crater. He had seen it every single day of his life, glowing faintly purple on the horizon from the Observatory steps.

The Starfall Crater.

And in the middle of the crater, there was a seedpod. A big one, cracked open like an egg, glowing purple and gold. And something was inside it. Something small and round and silver, with one big eye.

And standing around the seedpod, looking down into it, were four small figures.

Four human figures. Four kids.

Twenty years ago.

Rook stared at it. His heart was pounding so hard he could feel it in his ears.

"Dusty's story," he whispered. "The four kids who walked out to the crater. Who found the very first star-seed. Glowing. Warm as a heartbeat." His voice shook. "It was real. It was all real."

Kit was leaning close to the painting, holding Lumislug up to get a better look. "Rook," Kit said slowly. "Look at them. Look at their faces."

Rook looked.

They were painted small and simple, but you could still make them out. A tall boy, standing a little apart from the others, with sharp eyes and his hands behind his back. A girl with long dark braids. A boy with a big wide grin and a jacket that was much too

big for him, olive-green, with the sleeves rolled up.

And a girl with round glasses and a messy bun.

Rook's whole body went cold.

He'd seen that girl before. Not in a painting. He'd seen her grown up. He'd seen her every week of his life. Standing at the top of one hundred and twelve stone steps, in a lab coat with too many pockets, with pencils stuck in her silver hair.

"That's..." Kit's voice had gone very small. "Rook, is that...?"

Rook didn't answer. He was already turning around.

"Tamsin," he said. "Do you have paper? Big paper? And charcoal?"

Tamsin blinked. Then she grinned, and wiped her eyes, and reached into the biggest pocket of her patched-up vest, and pulled out a whole roll of thick brown paper and a fistful of charcoal sticks.

"Child," she said, "I'm an archaeologist. I never go anywhere without them."

* * *

They made rubbings of every mural.

It took hours. They pressed the big sheets of paper flat against the stone, and rubbed over them with the charcoal, gently, the way you rub a pencil over a coin to see the picture come through. Tamsin showed them how. Mycelith held the big sheets up high with its long, rope-like fibers, so they could reach the tops of the paintings. Plazmet floated close and gave them light. And one by one, the paintings appeared on the paper, in soft gray lines. The crystal forest. The shadow. The tree-mother. The scouts. The door, with its eight stars and its golden words.

And the last one. The crater. The seedpod. The four kids.

Rook did that one himself. He rubbed the charcoal over it very carefully, very slowly, so he wouldn't miss anything. When it was done, he held it up and looked at it for a long time. At the girl with the round glasses and the messy bun.

Then he rolled up all the rubbings and tied them with the purple ribbon from Dr. Vashti's map, and put them in his satchel, next to the four humming Shards.

"*Go,*" said Liss softly, from the walls all around them. "*Go and ask your questions, little ones. The answers are waiting.*" A pause. "*And come back to me, scout. When it is time.*"

Zib's lights flickered once, gold.

Then Rook turned around, and grabbed Kit's hand, and ran.

They ran back through the great hall, past the glowing paintings. Through the round door. Past the three Monolets, who tipped forward in a bow as they passed, their pebbles dipping on their rings, and the little Chimelet, who rang a soft *ding* goodbye. Up through the echoing maze, with Liss whispering *left, right, up the stairs* from every crystal. Out of the dark doorway at the top of the temple, into blinding golden sunlight. Down all the steps, two at a time, three at a time. Across the sand. Past the tents and the archaeologists, who all stood up and stared.

To the little wooden jetty, where the Squid Sailor was sitting on its barrel, puffing its bubble pipe.

"Back so soon?" it said. "Find what you were looking for?"

"We need to go back," Rook gasped. "Right now. As fast as the ferry can go."

The Squid Sailor looked at his face. Then it took the pipe out of its mouth and stood up.

"Where to, matey?"

Rook looked down at the satchel against his chest. At the rolled-up rubbings tied with purple ribbon. At the girl with the round glasses, hidden inside them.

"Neonis," he said. "There's someone we need to talk to."

Chapter 26

The Crater Four

Dr. Vashti was in her Neonis lab when they burst through the door.

She was sitting at her humming machine, the one with the round green screen and the wavy green line. It was pulsing so fast now that it was almost a blur. Up, down. Up, down. Up, down. She had her chin in her hands and a pencil in her mouth and dark circles under her eyes, and she jumped so hard when the elevator doors slid open that the pencil flew across the room.

"Rook! Kit! Goodness, you're back already? You've only been gone two days! What happened? What did you—"

She stopped.

She was looking at their faces. And whatever she saw there made her go very still.

Rook didn't say anything. He walked across the lab, past the bookshelves and the star charts and the jars of glowing things. He took the roll of rubbings out of his satchel and untied the purple ribbon, the one that had come from her own map. And he began to lay them out on her desk.

One by one.

The crystal forest under the tired red sun. Dr. Vashti made a small sound in her throat.

The shadow, eating the stars. Her hand went to her mouth.

The tree-mother, sending her children away. Dr. Vashti's eyes filled with tears.

The scouts. The door, with its eight stars and its line of golden words. She stared at that one for a long time. Her face had gone pale.

And then the last one.

Rook laid it down very slowly. He smoothed it flat with both hands. The crater, in the red desert, under the stars. The seedpod, cracked open, glowing. The little silver shape inside it, with one big eye.

And the four figures, standing around it.

A tall boy with sharp eyes. A girl with long dark braids. A grinning boy in a jacket much too big for him.

And a girl with round glasses and a messy bun.

The lab was very quiet. The only sound was the humming of the machine, and the soft thumping of the city's music, far away below the window.

Rook looked up.

"You were there," he said. "Weren't you?"

* * *

Dr. Vashti looked at the drawing for a long, long time.

She didn't say anything. She didn't move. She just looked at the four little figures in the charcoal rubbing, the way you might look at an old photograph of a house you used to live in.

Then, very slowly, she reached up and took off her round glasses. She folded them. She set them down on the desk, very carefully, right next to the drawing of the girl who was wearing them.

And she sat down. Not in her chair. On the floor. Right where she was standing. As if her legs had simply stopped working.

"Yes," she said. "I was there."

Kit sat down on the floor too, across from her. After a moment, so did Rook. Plazmet settled beside them, his flame low and warm. Mycelith knelt down behind Kit, its great cap spreading over them all. And Zib floated down from the ceiling, slowly, and settled on the floor between Rook and Dr. Vashti, his lights soft and quiet, his huge eye fixed on her face.

"There were four of us," Dr. Vashti said. Her voice was very quiet and very far away. "Four kids from Dustmere. Thirteen years old, all of us, with brand-new Linkers that didn't work properly yet because there weren't any Alienmon to use them on." A small, sad smile. "We were best friends. We did everything together. We climbed every canyon and dared each other to walk across the old bridge at night. And we never once made it all the way."

She touched the drawing of the girl with the round glasses.

"Me," she said.

She touched the drawing of the girl with the long dark braids.

"A girl named Orra Venn. She was the bravest of us. She could climb anything." Something passed over Dr. Vashti's face. "She went far away, after. A long way. We lost touch."

She touched the drawing of the tall boy with the sharp eyes, standing a little apart from the others, with his hands behind his back. Her finger stopped on it. It stayed there for a long moment. It was trembling.

"A boy named Kael Thorne," she said.

Kit's breath caught. Rook felt it too, a cold drop in his stomach, like missing a step in the dark. *Director Kael Thorne. The head of Helix.*

"He was the cleverest person I ever met," Dr. Vashti said quietly. "Cleverer than me. Cleverer than anybody. Quiet. Always thinking. Always asking questions. What's this, what's that, how

does it work, what's on the other side." She shook her head slowly. "He always wanted to know what was on the other side of things."

And then she touched the last drawing. The boy with the big wide grin, in the jacket much too big for him, olive-green, with the sleeves rolled up.

Her voice cracked right down the middle.

"And Teo," she said. "Teo Reyes."

Kit gasped out loud. "Sola's DAD!"

Rook couldn't breathe.

He stared at the little charcoal boy with the grin and the too-big jacket. The olive-green jacket. With the sleeves rolled up. He had seen that jacket every single day since his birthday. Walking out of the Observatory without saying goodbye. Wiping tears away in the corral at the Trading Post. Pulled tight on the end of a dark pier.

"It was his father's jacket," Dr. Vashti said softly, as if she knew exactly what he was thinking. "Even then. He wore it everywhere. It was too big for him when he was thirteen. And then it was too big for Sola." She wiped her eyes. "Teo always said he'd grow into it."

* * *

She told them everything.

She told them about the night the stars fell. Four kids standing in the plaza in their nightclothes, watching the sky come down. She told them about the next morning, packing sandwiches, sneaking out of town before anyone was awake, walking all the way across the desert to the Starfall Crater. Hours and hours, in the heat, singing songs to keep their spirits up. Teo carrying everyone's water. Orra climbing down into the crater first, because she was the bravest. Kael right behind her.

"And at the bottom," said Dr. Vashti, "we found the first seedpod. The very first one that ever fell. It was the biggest of all. It was glowing. And it was warm." She closed her eyes. "Warm as a heartbeat."

Old Dusty's words. Rook had heard them by the Bonfire, a hundred years ago.

"It was cracked open," said Dr. Vashti. "And inside it, sleeping, curled up in a little nest of glowing threads, was..."

She opened her eyes. And she looked at Zib.

Zib looked back at her. His lights flickered.

"You," Dr. Vashti whispered. "It was you, little one. You were so small. Your light was flickering. You'd come down so hard. You were hurt." Her voice shook. "I'd know you anywhere. I knew you the moment you flew into my Observatory. After twenty years."

Hello again, little one. Rook remembered that, suddenly. Something he hadn't even seen. Something he had only half-heard, as he ran down the hundred and twelve steps that morning, with Zib on his cap. Her voice, alone in the lab. *After twenty years.*

"We didn't know what to do," Dr. Vashti went on. "We'd never seen anything like you. So we wrapped you up in Teo's jacket and carried you all the way back across the desert. All the way back to Dustmere. To the only person we could think of who might be able to help." She looked at Rook. "To the Recovery Bay."

Rook's heart stopped.

"To your grandmother," said Dr. Vashti. "To Nana Wren."

Rook couldn't speak.

"She sat up with you," Dr. Vashti said to Zib, very softly. "Three whole nights. She held you, and talked to you, and sang to you. And she never once let you be alone. And on the fourth morning..."

She smiled through her tears. "On the fourth morning, your light came back on. And you looked at all of us, one by one. And then you flew straight up out of the window, up into the sky, and away. And we never saw you again."

Zib had gone perfectly still.

Rook reached up and touched the badge on his satchel strap. The little brass cross. The little brass bird. Recovery Bay, Number One.

Did you know she healed the very first Alienmon that ever fell from the sky? Nurse Coral had said. *It was scared and hurt and all alone.*

It had been Zib. All this time. It had been Zib.

Zib floated up off the floor, very slowly. He drifted over to Rook. And he pressed himself, very gently, against Nana Wren's badge. And held there.

And his lights glowed soft and warm and gold, the color of a candle in a window, the color of someone keeping watch all night.

* * *

"There was something else in the seedpod," said Dr. Vashti.

She was looking at the rubbing of the door now. The great round door floating between the stars, with eight bright points around it. And the line of golden words underneath.

"A stone tablet," she said. "Flat and smooth as glass, about as big as a book. Lying right beside you, in the nest. And on it, there was writing. In those same swirling marks. The ones on the bridge, and the gates, and the towers." She traced the golden words on the rubbing with one finger. "These ones."

"Liss wouldn't tell us what they said," Kit said. "Liss said to ask the ones who found it."

Dr. Vashti nodded slowly.

"It took us years to read it," she said. "Years and years. Kael and I, mostly. Comparing it to the bridge, and the gates. Working it out one mark at a time. We were sixteen before we read the first word. Eighteen before we read the last." She was quiet for a moment. "It was only four words. That's all. Four words, carried across the whole dark of space, inside the very first seed, so that whoever found it would read them before anything else."

She looked up at them.

"*Never open the door.*"

The words hung in the air of the lab.

The machine on the table hummed. The green line pulsed. Up, down. Up, down. Faster than ever.

"Teo and Orra and I, we understood," said Dr. Vashti. "Whatever was behind that door, it was what Ystra's children had run from. It was why they ran. And the towers, and the gates, and the bridge... the Alienmon who came before, the very first ones, long, long ago, they had built them. To hold it shut. Forever." She closed her eyes. "But Kael..."

She stopped.

"Kael didn't listen," she said quietly. "Kael always wanted to know what was on the other side of things. He said, what if it's not a monster? What if it's power? What if it's the greatest discovery anyone ever made? He said we were cowards for being scared of it." Her voice was very small. "He made a copy of the tablet. Secretly. And he kept it. And one day, he just... left Dustmere. Without saying goodbye. And I didn't hear his name again for years. Not until I heard it on the news. Director Kael Thorne. The founder of the Helix Directive."

Kit had gone very pale. Their eyes were wide behind their goggles.

"Phase Three," Kit whispered. "Phase Three begins when the eighth tower cracks." Kit's hands were shaking. "The towers are the seal. They're holding the door shut. If he cracks all eight..."

"Then the door opens," said Rook.

Nobody said anything.

"And whatever ate Ystra," Kit whispered, "comes through."

* * *

"And Teo," said Rook. His voice came out rough. "What happened to Teo?"

Dr. Vashti put her face in her hands.

"Everyone thinks he got lost," she said through her fingers. "In a sandstorm. That's what they told Sola. That's what I let them tell her." She lifted her head. Her eyes were red. "But Teo didn't get lost. Teo never got lost in his life. He knew that desert better than anyone."

She took a shaky breath.

"He went looking. On purpose. For the Alienmon's home. For Ystra. He wanted to understand what they were running from, so that he could help protect them. So that he could stop Kael, if it came to that." She swallowed. "He found something. Out past the crater. He sent me one last message, the night he left. Just three words."

"*Found the door,*" Rook said quietly.

Dr. Vashti stared at him.

"Sola told me," Rook said. "Helix told her. That's what they used to get her to come."

Dr. Vashti made a sound like something breaking. She pressed both hands over her mouth.

"And he never came back," she whispered. "Six years. He never came back." Tears were running down her face now, and she

wasn't trying to stop them. "I should have told Sola. Years ago. The very first time she asked. She came to me again and again, and every time I changed the subject. Every time. Because I was scared. Scared of Kael. Scared of the door. Scared of what she'd do if she knew." She shook her head. "So she went and found the only people who would tell her anything. And now she's out there. With Kael. On his station. Because of me."

She bent her head.

"It's my fault," she whispered. "All of it. It's my fault."

* * *

For a long moment, nobody said anything.

The machine hummed. The green line pulsed. The city's music thumped on and on, far below the window, cheerful and loud and not knowing anything at all.

Then Rook got up.

He walked over to Dr. Vashti, sitting on the floor of her lab with her face in her hands. He knelt down beside her. And he put his hand on her shoulder.

He thought about Sola on the pier. *I can't lose anybody else.* He thought about Captain Marsh. *Sometimes they just need somebody to throw them a rope.* He thought about Nana Wren, sitting up for three whole nights with a little hurt saucer whose light was going out. *Never give up on anybody.*

"Then we'll go find her," Rook said.

Dr. Vashti lifted her head.

"We'll go find Sola," Rook said. His voice was steady. Steadier than he felt. "Wherever she is. However far. And when we find her, we'll tell her the truth. All of it. About her dad, and the tablet, and the door, and everything." He took a breath. "And then we'll stop Director Thorne. Together."

Dr. Vashti stared at him.

And behind him, Kit stood up. "Together," Kit said, and nodded, once, firmly. Their goggles were crooked and their eyes were red, but their chin was up.

Plazmet blazed. His flame burst up bright and gold, his comet-tail streaming, his plasma ring spinning fast and strong, lighting up the whole lab.

Mycelith rose to its full height behind Kit, tall and calm and strong, its wide, ragged red cap spreading out over all of them, like a shield. Like a promise.

And Zib floated up off Rook's badge.

He drifted across to Dr. Vashti, slowly. He stopped right in front of her face. He looked at her with his huge, round, shining eye. The same eye that had looked up at four frightened kids from the bottom of a crater, twenty years ago. The same eye that had looked at Nana Wren on the fourth morning.

And then he bumped his little saucer against her cheek. Gently. Once. Twice. The way Sporix used to bump Kit, in the Mushroom Maze, when Kit was scared.

It's okay, the bump seemed to say. *We forgive you.*

Dr. Vashti let out a long, shaking breath. She lifted her hand, very slowly, and cupped it around Zib, and held him against her cheek. And she closed her eyes.

"Thank you," she whispered. "Thank you, little one."

Then she reached into the deepest pocket of her lab coat. The one she never let anybody see inside. And this time, she took it out.

It was an old, faded photograph. Soft at the corners from years and years of being held. It showed four children standing in the desert at night, grinning at the camera, their faces lit by a soft

purple glow from something just out of the picture. A girl with round glasses and a messy bun. A girl with long dark braids. A tall boy with sharp eyes, his hands behind his back, not quite smiling. And a boy with a big wide grin, in an olive-green jacket three sizes too big for him, with the sleeves rolled up four times.

She held it out to Rook.

"For Sola," she said. "When you find her. She should have her father's face."

* * *

Far, far away from Neonis, far away from every world in the Kessler system, a huge silver space station hung alone among the stars.

It was enormous. It was shaped like a twisting ladder, two great curving arms of silver spiraling around each other, with lights blinking all along them. Ships came and went from it like bees around a hive, and on every one of them, and on the station's great silver flank, glowed an orange ring with a diagonal slash through it. Inside it, in rooms nobody ever saw, one great crystal was glowing. Deep sea-blue, from Thalassa, dim and flickering, wrapped in black chains. And beside it, in a long row, seven empty cradles. Waiting.

And at the very top of the station, in a room with a huge round window full of stars, a girl stood alone.

She was wearing an olive-green jacket three sizes too big for her, with the sleeves rolled up four times. Her ponytail hung down her back. She had her hands pressed flat against the glass. She was looking out at the stars, at the thousands and thousands of them, as if she were trying to find one in particular.

She didn't hear the door slide open behind her.

A tall man in a long white coat came and stood beside her at the window. He had silver at his temples and sharp eyes and a calm, still face. He stood with his hands clasped behind his back. He was quiet for a long moment, looking out at the stars with her.

Then he reached out and rested one gloved hand on her shoulder.

She didn't move away.

Below them, through a wide floor of glass, stretched a hall so long that its far end was lost in shadow. It was full of cages. Row after row after row of them, neat and white and humming. And in every single cage sat an Alienmon. No two the same. A little tag hung from each cage door, with a name and a number on it, like a label in a museum. Over the entrance to the hall, in tall silver letters, were two words. PROJECT UNITY.

Sola didn't say anything. But her hands, pressed flat against the glass, slowly curled into fists.

Then he turned back to the stars. When he spoke, his voice was very calm. Very quiet. The quietest voice in the whole Kessler system.

"Begin Phase Three."

* * *

And back in Dr. Vashti's lab, on Neonis, while Rook was tucking the old photograph very carefully into his satchel, next to the four humming Shards and the paper boat with *Dad* written on its side, Zib's eye gave one strange flicker.

Nobody saw it. It was too quick. Just a flash, and then gone.

For just a moment, his huge round shining eye reflected something. Something out among the stars. Something far, far away, past the edge of the Kessler system, in the darkest place between the stars, where no light had ever been.

A giant dark eye.
Slowly opening.

* * *

THE END

Rook, Kit and Zib will return in
Alienmon Book 2: The Eighth Tower.

Xenodex

Alienmon	Type	What it's like	Who has it
Plazmo / Plazmet	Plasma	A swirl of orange and gold flame with one round eye, growing into a comet with a ring of white-hot plasma	Rook
Gloopa / Tidaloid	Hydro	A giggly bubble jelly with curly tentacles, growing into a tall speckled bell of living seawater	Sola
Sporix / Mycelith	Bio	A round mushroom in cream fluff with a spotted red cap, growing into a lanky Root Walker	Kit
Zib	Volt?	A palm-sized saucer scout with a clear dome, one big eye and a ring of blinking lights. Says only "Bip!"	Rook's friend
Cactling	Bio	A stout cactus with cream spines and a creamy flower around its one green eye	Rook
Gleamgrub	Toxin / Alloy	A rust slug in a riveted shell whose glowing slime rusts metal	Kit
Lumislug	Toxin	A gentle slug whose lime-green warning glow lights the way home	Rook
Glitchbug	Volt / Swarm	A stubby yellow-and-black flier with pixel wings that scrambles screens	Rook
Cogglet*	Alloy	A gear with one eye in the middle; loves sorting screws	Ferrox
Rumbler*	Magma	An angry boulder of rock and lava with legs	Forge Miner Dax
Girderon*	Alloy	An iron beam with a hammer head	Hank Briggs
Anvilox	Magma / Alloy	The Anvil Hound: lava-seamed armor and an anvil plate on its brow; it drinks heat	Hank Briggs
Mossback*	Bio	An ancient turtle with a garden on its shell	Sporeholm
Oozel*	Toxin	A slow blob of purple goo	Dr. Lysa Moor
Gloomtoad*	Toxin	A warty toad that spits sludge bubbles	Dr. Lysa Moor

Alienmon	Type	What it's like	Who has it
Bubbub	Hydro	A bouncy wave-rider in a bubble of air it blows from its chest	Port Ember
Brineback*	Hydro	A giant whale-turtle covered in barnacles	Captain Marsh
Hexcoil*	Toxin	A huge dripping serpent with wasp-striped spines	Admin Vex
Skitterdrone	Swarm	A dog-sized flier with two dish-shaped wings that swivel and listen	Helix
Chirpod	Sonic	A teal-and-pink bird with a megaphone beak that copies any sound	Set free
Boombastadon*	Sonic	A house-sized walking speaker with chrome tusks	DJ Static
Monolet	Gravity / Psi	A small standing stone with a violet crack and three orbiting pebbles	Temple of Voices
Chimelet	Sonic / Crystal	A silver bell with a smiling face and a skirt of glass chimes	Temple of Voices

** Seen only in the books so far. Every species, with art, stats and habitats, is in the official Xenodex at alienmon.com/xenodex.*